GNAMMA RESEARCH · PRIMARY TEXTS

نهاية الحكمة

Nihāyat al-Ḥikma

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Reading edition

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INTRODUCTION

Author’s Introduction

مدخل الكتاب

INTRODUCTION

Remarks Serving as an Introduction to This Discipline

كلام بمنزلة المدخل لهذه الصناعة

In the name of God, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful.

Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, and blessings and peace be upon our master Muhammad and his pure family.

We human beings are things that really exist. Alongside us are other existent things that may act upon us or be affected by us, just as we act upon them or are affected by them.

There is air that we breathe, food that nourishes us, dwellings that we inhabit, earth upon which we move, a sun by whose light we see, stars by which we find our way, animals, plants, and other things.

There are things that we see, others that we hear, others that we smell, others that we taste, and still others of various kinds.

There are things that we pursue or flee from; things that we love or hate; things that we hope for or fear; things that our natures desire or recoil from; and things that we want in order to remain in a place, to move from or to a place, to obtain pleasure, to avoid pain, to escape something unwelcome, or to accomplish other purposes.

All these things of which we are aware—and perhaps others of which we are not aware—are no mere nullity, for they really exist and are established in reality.

Nothing pursues anything except because it is an external entity and a real existent, or leads to one, rather than a mirage-like illusion.

We therefore cannot doubt that existence is there, or deny reality absolutely, unless we obstinately oppose the truth by denying it or professing doubt about it. If anything of this sort occurs, it occurs in words alone.

Each of us, like every existent that lives through knowledge and awareness, constantly regards himself as a real existent with real effects. He encounters nothing other than himself except insofar as it has some share in reality.

Yet, just as we do not doubt this, we also do not doubt that we sometimes err, taking what does not exist to exist, or the reverse. Early human beings affirmed things and held views that we deny today, while we hold their contradictories; one of the two views must be mistaken. There are also errors that afflict us every day: we affirm existence of what does not exist and deny it of what really does exist, and then discover that our judgment was mistaken. Hence the need arises to investigate existent things and distinguish them, through the established properties of existence, from what does not exist. This investigation must remove doubt and yield certainty, for it is this kind of investigation that guides us to real things themselves insofar as they are real.

In other words, it must be an investigation in which we restrict ourselves to demonstration. Among syllogisms, the demonstrative syllogism is the one that yields a certain conclusion, just as, among beliefs, certainty is the belief that discloses reality as it is.

If we undertake this kind of investigation, we can conclude through it that such-and-such exists and such-and-such does not exist.

But investigating particulars lies beyond our capacity. Moreover, demonstration does not apply to the particular insofar as it changes and passes away.

For this very reason, in this kind of inquiry we turn to investigating the condition of the existent universally, and thereby learn the conditions of the existent without qualification insofar as it is universal.

Since it is impossible for an existent to be characterized by conditions that do not exist, these conditions are confined to determinations coextensive with the existent insofar as it is existent—such as unrestricted externality, general unity, and universal actuality, which are coextensive with the existent without qualification—or to conditions narrower than the existent without qualification, but which, taken together with their opposites, are coextensive with it. Examples are our statements, “The existent is either external or mental,” “The existent is either one or many,” and “The existent is either actual or potential.” As you see, none of these lies outside existence without qualification.

The totality of these inquiries is what we call “philosophy.”

What has preceded makes the following points clear.

First, philosophy is the most general of all sciences because its subject is the most general of subjects: the existent, which embraces everything.

Thus all the sciences depend upon it for establishing their subjects.

Philosophy, however, depends upon none of the sciences for establishing its own subject. Its subject is the existent in general, of which we have a primary conception and whose existence we likewise affirm primarily, because existence is its very self.

Second, since its subject is the most general of things, and nothing outside it has any established reality, the predicates affirmed in philosophy are either identical with the subject—as when we say, “Every existent, insofar as it is existent, is one,” or “is actual”—or are narrower than the subject without being other than it. Although the one differs conceptually from the existent, it is identical with it in instance; if it were other than it, it would be null in itself and could not be established of the existent. The same holds of the actual. An example of the second kind is our statement, “The cause exists.” Although the cause is narrower than the existent, causality is not an aspect outside existence in general, for otherwise it would be null.

Such propositions, together with their opposites, return to propositions with a disjunctive predicate whose alternatives are coextensive with existence in general, as when we say, “Every existent is either actual or potential.” Most philosophical questions therefore proceed by division: dividing the existent into necessary and contingent; dividing the contingent into substance and accident; dividing substance into immaterial and material; dividing the immaterial into intellect and soul; and so forth.

Third, the propositions of philosophy are formulated by reversing the direction of predication. Our statements, “The necessary exists” and “The contingent exists,” mean, “Existence is sometimes necessary and sometimes contingent.” Our statement, “Necessity is either intrinsic or through another,” means, “The necessary existent is divided into what is necessary in itself and what is necessary through another.”

Fourth, since this discipline has the most general subject of all disciplines, and nothing whatsoever falls outside its subject and the predicates that refer back to it, no end external to it can be conceived for whose sake the discipline is pursued.

Knowledge of philosophy is therefore sought for its own sake. It is not sought for the sake of something else, serving as an instrument for reaching another end in the manner of the instrumental disciplines. Nevertheless, benefits do follow from it.

Fifth, the fact that its subject is the most general of things entails that it cannot be the effect of anything outside it, since there is nothing outside it. It therefore has no cause.

The demonstrations employed in philosophy are consequently not demonstrations of the reason why.

As for demonstration of the fact, it has been established in the Book of Demonstration in logic that proceeding from an effect to its cause does not yield certainty. Philosophical inquiry is therefore left only with that kind of demonstration of the fact which relies upon general concomitances, proceeding from one of two general concomitants to the other.

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1. **translation:** “Demonstration of the reason why” renders burhān al-limm; “demonstration of the fact” renders burhān al-inn. The latter here includes inference through general concomitances, not only inference from effect to cause.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 7–10 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=7&type=c_fbook

STAGE I

The General Properties of Existence

المرحلة الأُولى — في أحكام الوجود الكلّيّة

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One: Existence Is Shared in Meaning

الفصل الأوّل — في أنّ الوجود مشتركٌ معنويٌّ

Existence, as a concept, is shared in meaning: it is predicated with one meaning of everything of which it is predicated.

This is evident when we consult the mind as we predicate it of things or deny it of things, as in our statements, “The human being exists,” “The plant exists,” “The sun exists,” “The conjunction of contradictories does not exist,” and “The conjunction of contraries does not exist.”

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—put it well when he said, “That the concept of existence is shared among quiddities is close to being a primary truth.”

Thus the statement of some people that “existence is shared only as a word, and in each quiddity of which it is predicated it means that quiddity” is an absurd assertion.

It is refuted by the consequence that all simple existential propositions would lose their informative value: for example, “The Necessary exists,” “The contingent exists,” “Substance exists,” and “Accident exists.”

Moreover, one may be uncertain whether a thing exists or does not exist while knowing its quiddity and meaning, as when we ask, “Does coincidence exist or not?”

Likewise, one may be uncertain of a thing’s quiddity while being certain of its existence, as when we ask, “Is the existing human soul a substance or an accident?” Uncertainty about one of two things, together with certainty about the other, establishes that they are different.

Equally absurd is the view attributed to some that “the concept of existence is shared only as a word between the necessary and the contingent.”

This has been refuted as follows. Either we intend a meaning by the existence that we predicate of the Necessary, or we do not. The second alternative entails the suspension of any meaningful affirmation. On the first alternative, either we mean what we mean when we predicate existence of contingent things, or we mean its contradictory. On the second of these alternatives, we would be denying existence of Him when affirming existence of Him—exalted is He above that. On the first, what was required is established: the concept of existence is shared in meaning.

The truth, as some investigators have stated, is that the claim that existence is shared only as a word arises from confusing the concept with the instance. The judgment of difference applies to the instance, not to the concept.

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1. **translation:** “Shared in meaning” renders mushtarak maʿnawī: the concept has one meaning across its predications. This does not by itself assert that its external instances are identical in every respect.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 12–14 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=12&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Chapter Two: The Primacy of Existence and the Derivative Character of Quiddity

الفصل الثاني — في أصالة الوجود وإعتباريّة الماهيّة

Existence is primary, rather than quiddity: it is the concrete reality that we affirm as a matter of necessity.

Once we have settled the basic issue of doubt and sophistry and affirmed that which is primary—the reality of things—our first return to things reveals them as different and distinct, each negated of the others, while they all agree in excluding the unreality that the sophist had entertained. Thus we find among them an existent human being, an existent horse, an existent tree, an existent element, an existent sun, and so forth. They have quiddities predicated of them, through which they differ from one another, and existence predicated of them, with one meaning shared among them.

Quiddity differs from existence, since what is peculiar to each differs from what is shared. Moreover, quiddity in itself does not refuse either the predication or the negation of existence. Were it identical with existence, existence could not be negated of it, since a thing cannot be negated of itself. The aspect of quiddity that we find in things therefore differs from the aspect of existence that we find in them. Since each of these things has only one reality, one of these two aspects—quiddity and existence—corresponds to its reality and actuality. This is what is meant by primacy. The other aspect is intellectually derived from the primary aspect, and reality is attributed to it incidentally.

Since each thing attains reality only when existence is predicated of it and it is qualified by existence, existence is that which corresponds to the reality of things.

Quiddity, however, has reality when qualified by existence and is null in its essence when existence is negated of it. In itself, therefore, it is not primary; it acquires actuality only incidentally to existence.

We have thus established that existence is primary and quiddity derivative, as the Peripatetics maintained. That is, existence exists intrinsically, and quiddity exists through it.

This disposes of the following objection to the primacy of existence: if existence were realized among concrete things, it would be existent, since realization is existence. Existence would therefore have an existence; transferring the discussion to that existence, and so on, would produce an infinite regress.

The reply is that existence is existent, but intrinsically, not through an additional existence. Existence is, in other words, identical with being existent. Quiddity differs in that the aspect of its essence differs from the aspect of its existence.

As for the claim that, in customary linguistic usage, “existent” is applied only to something possessing an essence that serves as the subject of existence—and that existence itself consequently is not existent—even if correct, this is a matter of linguistic convention or prevalent usage. Realities do not follow the usage of words. As already explained, existence has a concrete reality that is itself established for itself.

Bahmanyār says in al-Taḥṣīl: “In sum, the reality of existence is nothing other than that it is among concrete things. How could that whose reality is this fail to be among concrete things?” End of quotation.

The following difficulty is also disposed of: if existence is existent intrinsically, contingent existences must be necessary in themselves. For existence being existent intrinsically entails that it cannot be negated of itself, since a thing cannot be negated of itself; and by the necessary in itself we mean only that whose nonexistence is impossible on account of itself.

The reply is that the criterion for a thing's being necessary in itself is not that its existence is its very essence. Rather, it is that its existence is required by its essence without need of anything else. Every contingent existence, while existent in itself, needs something else and is bestowed by it. It is like a particle's relational meaning: it is itself, yet it becomes a complete concept only through subsisting in another.

This will be explained further in the discussions to come.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn says in al-Asfār: “The meaning of the Necessary's existence through itself is that it is required by its essence without need of an agent or a recipient. The meaning of existence being realized through itself is that, once it occurs—whether through itself, as in the Necessary, or through an agent—its realization does not require a further existence through which it subsists, unlike what is other than existence.” End of quotation.

Another objection is also disposed of: if existence is existent intrinsically, whereas quiddity is existent through something else, namely existence, the concept of existence would be shared between what exists through itself and what exists through another. The argument's assumption that existence is shared in meaning among existents, rather than merely shared in name, would then not hold.

The reply is that this confuses concept with instance. The difference mentioned is a difference of instances, not of concept.

What has preceded shows the falsity of the view that quiddity is primary, a view attributed to the Illuminationists.

According to them, quiddity is primary when it is such that existence can be abstracted from it, although in itself it is derivative, and the existence abstracted from it is derivative as well.

The answer is that a derivative quiddity's becoming primary and possessing a concrete reality through the abstraction of a derivative concept of existence would be a transformation of its very nature, which is necessarily impossible.

Also shown to be false is the position that existence is primary in the Necessary and quiddity primary in the contingent. Al-Dawwānī adopted this position, explaining that, as the insight of the metaphysical sages requires, existence is one individual concrete reality, namely the Necessary, exalted is He, and contingent quiddities acquire actuality through a certain relation to it. “Existent” is thus applied to Him, exalted is He, in the sense that He is existence itself, and to contingent quiddities in the sense that they are related to existence, which is the Necessary.

The reply is that if this relation entails the supervening of a concrete reality upon quiddities, that reality is existence. For an actualized quiddity has only the two aspects of quiddity and existence; if primacy is not attributed to quiddity, it belongs to existence. If the relation entails nothing, and quiddity's condition is the same before and after the relation, its acquiring actuality through that relation would be an impossible transformation of its nature.

The primacy of existence and the derivative character of quiddity have the following consequences.

First, whatever is predicated of the aspect of quiddity is predicated only through existence.

Existence is a qualifying aspect in every quiddative predication. For quiddity in itself is null and perishing, possessing nothing; its essence and essential constituents are therefore established for it through existence.

When the intellect considers quiddity as such, it is indeed nothing but itself, neither existent nor nonexistent. Yet existence's exclusion from it under this consideration—meaning that existence is not included in its definition—does not prevent existence from being predicated of it outside its definition and as supervening upon it. It therefore has some establishment however it is supposed.

Likewise, the concomitants of its essence—the concomitants of quiddity, such as the concept of quiddity that supervenes upon every quiddity and the evenness that supervenes upon the quiddity of four—are established for it through existence, not through its essence.

This makes clear that a concomitant of quiddity is in truth a concomitant of both external and mental existence, as al-Dawwānī maintained.

Likewise, the concomitants of mental existence, such as being a species in the case of the human; the concomitants of external existence, such as coldness in the case of snow; and predicates that are not concomitants, such as writing in the case of the human: all of these are through existence.

This also shows that existence is among the concomitants of quiddity that lie outside its essence.

Second, existence is not qualified by any of the determinations of quiddity, such as universality and particularity; being a genus, species, differentia, proprium, or common accident; or substantiality, quantity, quality, and the other accidental categories. All these determinations supervene upon quiddity either insofar as it applies to and is true of something—as “human” applies to and is true of Zayd, ʿAmr, and the other individuals—or insofar as something falls under it, as individuals fall under species and species under genera. Existence, which is intrinsically concrete reality, admits neither application to something nor inclusion under something, neither truth of something nor predication, nor anything resembling these meanings. The concept of existence does, however, admit being true of many and being shared, like other concepts.

It follows that existence is coextensive with individuality.

It also follows that existence has no like. For a thing's like is what shares its specific quiddity, and existence has no specific quiddity.

It further follows that existence has no contrary. As will be explained, two contraries are two positive things that succeed one another in a single subject, fall under one proximate genus, and differ to the utmost degree. Existence has neither a subject nor a genus, nor does it stand in contrariety to anything.

Third, existence cannot be part of something. For if the other part and the whole composed of the two are existence itself, a thing's being part of itself has no meaning. If one or both are other than existence, they are null in themselves, since nothing other than existence is primary; there is therefore no composition.

The same argument establishes that existence has no parts, and also shows that existence is simple in its essence.

Fourth, the attributes and predicates that truly attach to existence are not outside its essence. Were they outside it, they would be null.

Fifth, the existent, insofar as it is qualified by existence, admits a kind of division into what is existent intrinsically and what is existent incidentally. Existence is existent intrinsically in the sense that it is identical with itself. Quiddity is existent incidentally: it is not qualified by existence when considered solely in respect of its own essence, although it truly exists through existence, in contrast to that which does not exist through existence.

Sixth, existence supervenes upon quiddity. This means that the intellect can strip quiddity of existence and understand it by itself, without considering its existence. Existence is therefore neither identical with it nor part of it. Evidence for this includes the possibility of negating existence of quiddity, the need for proof that it is qualified by existence, and its equal relation in itself to existence and nonexistence. Were existence identical with quiddity or a part of it, none of these would be correct.

As you have learned, this difference is intellectual; it does not conflict with the unity of quiddity and existence externally and mentally. There is only one reality, namely existence, because existence is primary and quiddity derivative. Different quiddities differentiate existence in a certain way, without anything being added to existence. This is the meaning of their statement, “Quiddities are modes of existence.” The distinction, separation, and difference in effects among existent quiddities reduce to this difference; this is the meaning of their statement, “Quiddities are the limits of existence.” The essence of each existent quiddity is a limit that its existence does not exceed. This entails negations equal in number to the existent quiddities outside it. The existent

quiddity of a human, for example, is a limit of that human's existence, which does not pass beyond it to another: the human is not a horse, not a cow, not a tree, not a stone, and so on through the existent quiddities distinct from the human.

Seventh, the establishment of each thing—whatever kind of establishment is supposed—is due solely to an external existence there that intrinsically excludes nonexistence. Thus judgments true in the order of things themselves, which have no corresponding object either externally or mentally, have a corresponding object established with a certain derivative establishment, following real existents.

To explain: some true judgments have a corresponding object externally, such as “The human exists” and “The human writes.” Others have a corresponding object mentally, such as “The human is a species” and “Animal is a genus.” Still others have a corresponding object to which they conform, but it exists neither externally nor mentally. Examples are “The nonexistence of the cause is a cause of the nonexistence of the effect” and “Nonexistence is null in itself.” Nonexistence has no realization externally or mentally, nor do its determinations or effects. Propositions of this kind are considered to conform to the order of things themselves, nafs al-amr. For when the intellect affirms that the existence of the cause is a cause of the existence of the effect, it must affirm that the effect ceases if its cause ceases. This is the nonexistence of the cause's being a cause of the nonexistence of the effect. Yet nonexistence has no realized instance externally or mentally, since whatever occurs in either has existence.

In light of the preceding discussions, what should be said is that the primary is real existence: it is existence, and every real determination belongs to it.

Then, since quiddities are manifestations of existence to minds, the intellect necessarily extends its consideration by considering existence as belonging to them and predicating it of them. The concept of existence and establishment thereby comes to be predicated of existence, quiddity, and the determinations of both.

The intellect then necessarily makes a second extension, predicating establishment and realization without qualification of every concept that it must consider in consequence of existence or quiddity—such as the concepts of nonexistence, quiddity, potentiality, and actuality—and then affirming their determinations.

The domain that the intellect supposes for establishment and realization without qualification in this last sense is what we call “the order of things themselves.” It encompasses true mental and external propositions and what the intellect affirms without a corresponding object mentally or

externally. Matters belonging to this order are, however, intellectual concomitants of quiddities, established through their establishment.

A continuation of this discussion will come before you, God willing.

It has been said that “the order” in “the order of things themselves” means the world of command, a universal intellect containing the forms of all intelligibles. A proposition's conformity to the order of things themselves would then mean its conformity to the intelligible form present in that intellect.

The difficulty is that the discussion is transferred to the intelligible form present in it. That form too is an intelligible form requiring a corresponding object beyond itself to which it conforms.

It has also been said that “the thing itself” is what is meant, the explicit noun being put in place of a pronoun. For example, nonexistence's being null in itself in the order of things themselves would mean its being so in itself.

The difficulty is that what has no corresponding object externally or mentally has no selfhood to which it and its determinations could conform.

Eighth, thingness is coextensive with existence. What has no existence has no thingness; the nonexistent, insofar as it is nonexistent, is not a thing.

The Muʿtazilites are reported to hold that nonexistent contingent quiddities have thingness in nonexistence, and that between existence and nonexistence there is an intermediary that they call a “state.” They define it as an attribute of an existent that is neither existent nor nonexistent, such as being capable of laughter or writing in the case of the human. They deny, however, an intermediary between negation and affirmation: the negated is the impossible, while the affirmed comprises the necessary, the existent contingent, and the nonexistent contingent. A state is that which is neither existent nor nonexistent.

These are claims rejected by plain reason. They resemble terminological stipulations more than scientific considerations, and it is better to pass over their discussion.

Ninth, the reality of existence, insofar as it is the reality of existence, has no cause beyond itself. Its concrete identity, intrinsically primary, existent, and excluding nonexistence, does not depend for its realization on anything outside this reality, whether as a complete or a partial cause. This is because it is primary and whatever lies beyond it is null. There is no objection, however, to some degrees of this reality depending on others, as contingent existence depends on necessary existence

and some contingents depend on others. From this it becomes clear that demonstration of the reason why has no application in divine philosophy, which investigates the determinations of the existent as existent.

Tenth, since the reality of existence is identical with the aspect through which effects follow, it is identical with externality. It therefore cannot enter the mind and become mental, with its effects no longer following, since that would entail an impossible transformation of its nature.

As for mental existence, which will be established, God willing: insofar as it excludes nonexistence from itself, it is an external existence upon which effects follow. It is counted as mental, without the effects following, only in comparison with the external instance corresponding to it.

It is thus clear that the reality of existence has no intellectual form, unlike quiddities existing externally, which do have intellectual forms.

It is also clear that the relation of the concept of existence to external existences is not the relation of a universal quiddity to its external individuals.

What has preceded also shows that a concept is a quiddity only if it has an external individual that it constitutes and upon which its effects follow.

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1. **translation:** Iʿtibārī is rendered “derivative” where quiddity is contrasted with primary existence; the text does not thereby deny that quiddities truly exist through existence. “The order of things themselves” renders nafs al-amr, whose scope the author explains in the seventh consequence.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 14–23 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=14&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Chapter Three: Existence Is a Graded Reality

الفصل الثالث — في أنّ الوجود حقيقة مشكّكة

There is no doubt that concrete external identities are characterized by multiplicity: sometimes because this is a human being, that is a horse, and another is a tree, and so forth; and sometimes because this is actual and that is potential, this is one and that is many, this is originated and that is eternal, this is contingent and that is necessary, and so on.

What we presented in the preceding chapter established that multiplicity in the first respect—quiddative multiplicity—exists externally incidentally through existence, while existence is characterized by it incidentally through quiddity, because existence is primary and quiddity is derivative.

Multiplicity in the second respect, however, is what belongs to existence through the divisions that occur in existence itself, such as its division into necessary and contingent, one and many, actual and potential, and the like. It was established in the preceding chapter that existence is simple and that there is nothing other than it.

It follows that this multiplicity is constitutive of existence, in the sense that it is within existence and does not stand outside it. Otherwise it would be a part of existence, whereas existence has no part, or a reality outside existence, whereas there is nothing outside existence.

Existence therefore has multiplicity within itself. Is there, then, an aspect of unity to which this multiplicity returns without being abolished by returning to it, so that the reality of existence is many while being one, and one while being many? In other words, is it a graded reality with different degrees, in each of which that by which it is distinguished returns to that which it shares with the others, as has been attributed to the ancient Persian sages? Or does it have no aspect of unity, so that existence amounts to realities entirely disparate in their essences, each distinguished from the others by its entire simple essence, rather than by a part or by something external, as has been attributed to the Peripatetics?

The truth is that it is one reality while being many. For we abstract from all its degrees and instances the single, self-evident, general concept of existence; and it is impossible to abstract one concept from many instances insofar as they are many and do not return to any unity.

This makes clear that existence is a graded reality with different degrees. The example used for it is the reality of light, as understood by ordinary understanding: a single reality possessing degrees that differ in intensity and weakness. There is, for example, strong, intermediate, and weak light. The strong degree is not light together with something additional to luminosity, nor does the weak degree lack anything of the reality of light or mix with darkness, which is the absence of light. None of its differing degrees adds anything to the shared reality of light or lacks anything of it. Each is simply light in a particular, simple degree, neither composed of parts nor joined by any addition; and it is distinguished from the others by its very essence, which is the luminosity they share.

Light is thus one simple reality, multiple in its very unity and unified in its very multiplicity. Likewise, existence is one reality possessing degrees that differ in intensity and weakness, priority and posteriority, height and lowness, and other such respects.

Several matters follow from what has preceded.

First: one degree of existence is distinguished from another only by its very simple essence, in which that which is shared is identical with that by which it is distinguished. This does not prevent the intellect from attributing existential distinction to the aspect of multiplicity in existence rather than to the aspect of unity, or from attributing what is shared and the affinity between them to the aspect of unity.

Second: the degrees of existence possess absoluteness and restriction relative to one another, because they differ in intensity and weakness and the like. If we suppose two degrees of existence, one weak and one intense, a comparison and relation between them necessarily arises. The weak degree, by its character, does not include some of the perfection possessed by the intense degree; but there is no perfection in the weak degree that the intense degree does not possess. The weak degree is therefore as though composed of possession and lack: its essence is restricted by the absence of some of the perfection in the intense degree. You may, if you wish, say that it is "limited." The essence of the intense degree, however, is absolute and unlimited in relation to the weak degree.

If we suppose another degree above the intense one, the relation of the intense degree to this degree supposed above it is like the relation of the degree below it to itself. The intense degree becomes limited in relation to what is above it, just as it was absolute in relation to what is below it. The same applies to the degrees proceeding upward, until one stops at a degree above which there is no degree. This is absolute, without being limited except in that it has no limit.

The reverse applies when we take a weak degree and consider it in relation to what is weaker than itself, and so on, until we arrive at a degree of perfection and actuality that possesses no actuality except the actuality of having no actuality.

Third: everything that has preceded makes clear that the ordered degrees of existence have limits, except for the highest degree, which is limited in that it has no limit.

It is evident that these limits, inseparable from the negations, nonexistences, and lacks that we affirm of the degrees of existence even though those degrees are primary and simple, arise only from the inadequacy of expression. Otherwise, nonexistence is the contradictory of existence, and it is impossible for it to penetrate the degrees of its contradictory.

This meaning—the entry of nonexistences into the limited degrees of existence, and their non-entry, which amounts to sheer existence—is a kind of simplicity and composition in existence different from the simplicity and composition spoken of technically elsewhere, namely simplicity and composition with respect to external, intellectual, or imagined parts.

Fourth: the further a degree descends, the more numerous its limits become and the narrower its existence; and the further it ascends and approaches the highest degree, the fewer its limits and the broader its existence. At the highest degree, it includes every existential perfection without limitation and is absolute without end.

Fifth: existence has two extremes in respect of intensity and weakness. This is what follows from saying that existence is a graded reality.

Sixth: existence, with the breadth and expansiveness belonging to its reality, is specified by its simple concrete reality; it is specified by a degree among its differing simple degrees, in which that by which it is distinguished returns to that which it shares with the others; and it is specified by the quiddities that arise from it and delimit it. It is evident that specification in either of the first two ways belongs to existence intrinsically, whereas specification in the third way belongs to it incidentally through quiddities.

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1. **translation:** “Graded reality” renders ḥaqīqa mushakkaka: the degrees share the very reality by which they differ. The “ancient Persian sages” are the Fahlawiyyūn named in the Arabic.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 23–27 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=23&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Chapter Four: Some Judgments Concerning Nonexistence

الفصل الرابع — في شطر من أحكام العدم

It has already been explained that nonexistence has no thinghood: it is sheer perishing and nullity.

It follows that there is no differentiation in nonexistence. For two things differ either through their entire essences, as do two species under two different categories; through a part of their essences, as do two species under one category; or through something that occurs to their essences, as do two individuals of one species. Nonexistence, however, has no essence.

Nevertheless, nonexistence is sometimes related to existence, thereby acquiring a share of existence, which is accompanied by a kind of differentiation. Thus the nonexistence of sight, which is blindness, differs from the nonexistence of hearing, which is deafness; and the nonexistence of Zayd differs from the nonexistence of ʿAmr.

In this way the intellect attributes causality and being an effect to nonexistence, corresponding to what existence possesses in this respect. Thus it is said, “The nonexistence of the cause is a cause of the nonexistence of the effect.” Here nonexistence is related to the cause and the effect, and the two nonexistences become differentiated. The nonexistence of the effect is then made dependent

on the nonexistence of the cause, just as the existence of the effect depended on the existence of the cause. This is a kind of figurative expression whose actual significance is to indicate the dependence obtaining between the two existences.

Nonexistence qualified by any qualification—such as essential nonexistence, temporal nonexistence, and eternal nonexistence—is analogous to relational nonexistence. In all these cases the concept of nonexistence is conceived, and an instance is posited for it just as for other concepts. The concept is then qualified, so that the instance becomes differentiated; and a judgment appropriate to it is made concerning that instance on the basis of its supposed subsistence. One example is considering the nonexistence of nonexistence in opposition to nonexistence, just as the nonexistence opposed to existence is considered in opposition to existence.

This resolves the objection concerning the consideration of the nonexistence of nonexistence: nonexistence related to nonexistence is a species of nonexistence, yet, insofar as it removes the nonexistence to which it is related, it stands opposed to that nonexistence by the opposition of contradiction; and being a species and being an opposite can never go together.

The resolution, as Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may God have mercy on him—explained, is that the respects differ. Insofar as the nonexistence of nonexistence is a concept more specific than unrestricted nonexistence, with nonexistence included in it, it is a species of nonexistence. But insofar as the nonexistence to which it is related has a supposed subsistence, which the related nonexistence removes as one contradictory removes the other, the related nonexistence stands opposed to it.

The same consideration resolves an objection raised against their statement, “Nothing can be asserted of the absolutely nonexistent.” The objection is that the proposition contradicts itself: it indicates that nothing can be asserted of the absolutely nonexistent, yet this itself is an assertion about it.

The answer is that nothing can be asserted of the absolutely nonexistent insofar as it is sheer nullity in reality. But insofar as its concept has a certain mental subsistence, it can be asserted of it that nothing can be asserted of it. The respects are therefore different.

In other words, nothing can be asserted of what is absolutely nonexistent by common predication; but of what is absolutely nonexistent by primary predication it can be asserted that nothing can be asserted of it.

The foregoing also removes the suspicion of contradiction from several other propositions. For example, we say, “The particular is particular,” whereas it is itself a universal that applies to many things. We say, “The conjunction of contradictories is impossible,” whereas it is itself possible and exists in the mind. And we say, “A thing either subsists in the mind or does not subsist in it,” whereas what does not subsist in the mind does subsist in it, since it is something understood and exists with a mental existence.

The particular is particular by primary predication, and a universal applying to many things by common predication. The conjunction of contradictories is possible by primary predication and impossible by common predication. What does not subsist in the mind does not subsist in it by primary predication, and does subsist in it by common predication.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 28–30 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=28&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Chapter Five: There Is No Repetition in Existence

الفصل الخامس — في أنّه لا تكرُّرَ في الوجود

The concrete identity of every concrete existent is its existence, in accordance with what has already been established concerning the primacy of existence. A concrete identity by its very essence refuses to apply to many things; this is individuation. Individuality therefore belongs to existence intrinsically.

If two existences were posited for one existent, its one concrete identity would be many while being one. This is impossible.

A similar argument shows that it is impossible for two things exactly alike in every respect to exist. Positing two like things necessarily entails a distinction between them, whereas positing likeness in every respect entails the absence of any distinction between them. This involves the conjunction of contradictories, which is impossible.

In general, it is impossible for one existent to exist with more than one existence, whether the two existences, for example, occur at one time with no intervening nonexistence, or are separate with nonexistence intervening between them. The difficulty—the necessary identity together with the supposed duality—is the same in both cases.

It may be said: “The second existence differs from the first because it is preceded by nonexistence after existence, whereas the first is not. This suffices to establish duality without impairing identity, since the distinction is through nonexistence.”

This is rejected because nonexistence is sheer nullity, in which there is neither multiplicity nor differentiation. There is no essence within it characterized by nonexistence to which existence subsequently attaches after that characterization has ceased.

It has already been explained that all this is an intellectual consideration aided by the estimative faculty, which relates nonexistence to a positive possession, so that nonexistence becomes numbered and multiplied as those positive possessions multiply.

The real meaning of a thing's existence being preceded and followed by nonexistence—in general, of nonexistence surrounding it before and after—is that its existence is confined to one circumstance of reality and falls short of extending over the other concrete circumstances. It does not mean that the thing has a real existence in one circumstance of reality while nonexistence has an actual subsistence extending over the other circumstances, sometimes coming upon existence, driving it out of its abode, and occupying that abode itself. This would confer primacy on nonexistence and entail the conjunction of contradictories.

The result is that the distinction of the second existence is a distinction made by the estimative faculty and does not entail a real distinction. If it did, it would entail separation between the two existences and identity would be abolished.

It may be said: “Why should it not be possible for an agent that gives existence to bring something into existence, after which it ceases to exist, while an intelligible form of it in its individuality remains with that agent or with some of the higher principles? The thing could then exist a second time in accordance with what was known, with the intelligible form preserving unity and identity between the two existences.” The answer is that the second existence, however it is posited, is an existence after an existence. Its otherness and separation from the first existence, insofar as it is after that existence, are necessary; and identity and otherness can never go together.

This established impossibility of the repetition of a thing's existence with intervening nonexistence is what is meant by their statement, “Restoring the nonexistent as numerically the same thing is impossible.” The Shaykh regarded the impossibility of restoring the nonexistent as numerically the same thing as self-evident.

They have put forward arguments for this which, if the issue is self-evident, serve as reminders.

One is that, if an existent at one time could cease to exist for a time and then exist as numerically the same thing at another time, nonexistence would have to intervene between the thing and itself. This is impossible, since it entails the existence of the thing at two times with nonexistence intervening between them.

Another is that, if a thing could be restored as numerically the same thing after ceasing to exist, it would be possible to bring into existence initially something like it in every respect. This is impossible.

The entailment holds because the thing restored as numerically the same thing and what is like it in every respect are two like things, and like things have the same ruling concerning what is and is not possible. If it were possible to bring it into existence as numerically the same thing a second time by restoration, it would be possible to bring its like into existence initially.

The consequent is impossible because the coexistence of two like things in existence entails the absence of any distinction between them, whereas they are two distinct things.

Another argument is that restoring the nonexistent as numerically the same thing entails that the restored thing is the initial thing. For the supposition of numerical identity entails that the restored thing is the initial thing in essence and in all its individuating characteristics, including time. Thus the restored thing becomes initial, and the respect of restoration is identical with the respect of initial origination.

Another is that, if restoration were possible, the number of returns would reach no determinate limit at which it stopped. There is no difference between the first return, the second, the third, and so on without end, just as there would be no difference between what is restored and what is initially originated. Yet a determinate number is one of the necessary concomitants of the existence of an individuated thing.

A group of theologians held restoration to be possible, on the grounds that the resurrection proclaimed by the true revealed laws is a restoration of the nonexistent.

They argued that, if restoring the nonexistent as numerically the same thing were impossible, this would be due either to its quiddity, or to something necessarily accompanying its quiddity—in which case it would not have existed initially—or to something separable, in which case the impossibility would cease when that thing ceased.

The reply is that the impossibility is due to something necessarily accompanying its existence, not its quiddity.

As for what the true revealed laws proclaim, gathering and resurrection are a passage from one mode of being to another, not an act of bringing into existence after annihilation.

1. **translation:** “Numerically the same” renders bi-ʿaynihi: the question concerns the restoration of an individual in its very identity, rather than the production of something qualitatively similar.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 30–33 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=30&type=c_fbook

STAGE II

Independent and Linking Existence

المرحلة الثانية — في الوجود المستقلّ والرابط

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One: The Division of Existence into Independent and Connective Existence

الفصل الأوّل — في انقسام الوجود إلى المستقل والرابط

An existent is divided into that whose existence is in itself, which we call “independent,” “predicative,” or “self-standing existence,” and that whose existence is in another, which we call “connective existence” (al-wujūd al-rābiṭ).

This is because there are propositions about external reality whose subjects and predicates apply to external reality, such as “Zayd is standing” and “The human being laughs.” There are also qualifying compounds drawn from these propositions, such as “Zayd’s standing” and “the human being’s laughter.” Between their terms we find something that we call a relation or connection. We do not find it in the subject alone, in the predicate alone, between the subject and something other than the predicate, or between the predicate and something other than the subject. There is, therefore, something existent in addition to the subject and predicate.

It does not have an essence separate from the two terms, such that it would be a third alongside them and separate from them as each is separate from the other. Otherwise it would need one connection linking it to the subject and another linking it to the predicate. What was supposed to be three would then be five; these five would need four further connections, becoming nine; and so on. The parts of the proposition or compound would thus regress without end, although they are confined between two limits. This is impossible.

It is therefore existent in the two terms and subsists through them: it is not outside them, without being identical with them, a part of them, identical with either one, or a part of either one; nor is it separate from them. The two terms in which it exists are otherwise than it in this respect.

It has thus been established that some existents have existence in themselves—these are independent—and some have existence in another—these are connective.

From what has been said, it has become clear that for the relation to mediate between the two terms means that its existence subsists through the two terms and connects them.

Several points follow.

First, the domain in which connective existence is realized is the domain in which the existence of its two terms is realized, whether that domain is external reality or the mind. This follows from the nature of connective existence, which is not outside the existence of its two terms. The domain of the existence of each of them is precisely the domain of its existence. An external relation is realized only between two external terms, and a mental relation only between two mental terms.

The rule is that the existence of the two terms is of the same order as the existence of the relation obtaining between them, and conversely.

Second, the realization of connective existence between two terms entails a kind of existential unity between them. This is because it is realized in them, is not distinct from them in essence, and is not outside them. Its individual unity therefore calls for a kind of unity between them, whether there is predication, as in propositions, or no predication, as in other compounds. None of these cases is without a manner of unity.

Third, propositions involving primary predication, such as “The human being is a human being,” have a connection only through mental consideration.

The same holds for simple existential propositions, such as “The human being exists,” since it makes no sense for a connecting relation to be realized between a thing and itself.

Fourth, no connection is realized from nonexistence, since it has no thinghood and contains no distinction.

It follows that affirmative propositions in which one or both terms are nonexistence, such as “Zayd is nonexistent” and “A partner of the Creator is nonexistent,” contain no connective nonexistence. It makes no sense for a nonexistence to subsist through two nonexistences, or through an existence and a nonexistence, when it has no thinghood and contains no distinction—except, of course, through mental consideration.

Negative propositions, such as “The human being is not a stone,” are similar: they contain no connective nonexistence except through mental consideration.

Fifth, connective existences have no quiddity. Quiddities are what is said in answer to “What is it?” and are therefore independent in their conceptual content, whereas connective existences have no concept that is independent in its conceptual content.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 37–39 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=37&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Chapter Two: How Connective and Independent Existence Differ

الفصل الثاني — في كيفيّة اختلاف الوجود الرابط والمستقلّ

Is the difference between independent and connective existence a difference in kind, or is it not? That is, can connective existence, which has a dependent meaning, shed this character and become an independent meaning when attention is directed to it independently, after having had the meaning of a particle, or can it not? The correct position is the latter alternative: the difference is not one of kind. For, as will be explained in the discussions of cause and effect, an effect's need for its cause is rooted in its very essence. This entails that it is need itself and that its essence subsists through the existence of the cause, having no independence apart from it in any respect. It follows that the existence of every effect—whether it is a substance or an accident existing in itself—is connective when considered in relation to its cause, although, when considered in itself and when such effects are compared with one another, it is a substance or an accident existing in itself. Thus the difference between connective and independent existence is not a difference in kind such that the nonindependent concept abstracted from the connective could not be transformed into the independent concept abstracted from the independent.

Several points follow from the foregoing.

First, a concept's independence or nonindependence in its conceptual content follows the existence from which it is abstracted. In itself, it has only indeterminacy.

Thus the determinations of substances and accidents are substantial and accidental quiddities when compared with one another and considered in themselves; when compared with the First Principle —blessed and exalted is He—they are existential connections. Considered in themselves, apart from their existence, they are neither independent nor connective.

Second, some connective existences subsist through a single term, such as the existence of an effect in relation to its cause, just as some subsist through two terms, such as the existences of other relations and correlations.

Third, the order of existence contains only one independent existence, namely the Necessary Existent—exalted is His name. The rest are connections, relations, and correlations.

1. **translation:** The Arabic "the latter" is read with the chapter's initial question and its explicit conclusion: the distinction is not a difference in kind. "The meaning of a particle" refers to a meaning dependent on its terms, like that of a grammatical particle, rather than an independently apprehended concept.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 39–40 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=39&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Chapter Three: The Division of Existence in Itself into Existence for Itself and Existence for Another

الفصل الثالث — في إنقسام الوجود في نفسه إلى ما لنفسه وما لغيره

An existent in itself is divided into that whose existence is for itself and that whose existence is for another.

By a thing’s existence being for another, we mean that its existence in itself—the existence that excludes nonexistence from its quiddity—is itself also what excludes nonexistence from something else. It does not exclude the nonexistence of that other thing’s quiddity and essence, for otherwise a single existent would have two quiddities, which is impossible. Rather, it excludes a nonexistence additional to that other thing’s quiddity and essence and having a certain concomitance with it. Knowledge, for example, by its existence excludes nonexistence from its own quiddity, while that very same existence excludes ignorance, which is a certain nonexistence, from its subject.

The proof that this division, namely existence for another, is realized is provided by the existences of accidents. Each, just as it excludes nonexistence from its own quiddity, excludes from its subject a certain nonexistence additional to the subject’s essence.

The same applies to immanent specific forms. They have a certain presence in their matters through which they exclude from those matters, not the nonexistence of their essence, but a substantial deficiency whose exclusion perfects them. This is what is meant by a thing’s existence being for another and being attributive.

Opposed to this is that whose existence excludes nonexistence only from its own quiddity. This is existence for itself, as in complete substantial species, such as the human being, the horse, and others.

It has thus been established that existence in itself is divided into that whose existence is for itself and that whose existence is for another. This was what was required.

What has been said also makes clear that the existence of accidents belongs to the modes of the existence of the substances that are their subjects. Likewise, the existence of immanent forms is not separate from the existence of their matters.

It also makes clear that the concepts abstracted from attributive existences, which are attributes of their subjects, are quiddities neither of those existences nor of their subjects. A concept abstracted from an existence is its quiddity only if the existence from which it is abstracted excludes

nonexistence from that concept itself; attributive existence does not exclude nonexistence from the very concept abstracted from it. For example, the existence of blackness in itself excludes nonexistence from blackness itself, so blackness is its quiddity. But this existence, insofar as it makes a body black, excludes a nonexistence neither from blackness in itself nor from the quiddity of the body characterized by it. Rather, it excludes it from an attribute with which the body is characterized and which lies outside its essence.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 40–41 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=40&type=c_fbook

STAGE III

Mental and External Existence

المرحلة الثالثة — في انقسام الوجود الى ذهنيّ وخارجيّ

CHAPTER 1

Chapter: The Division of Existence into Mental and External Existence

فصل — في انقسام الوجود إلى ذهنيّ وخارجيّ

The well-known position of the philosophers is that these quiddities which exist externally and upon which their effects follow have another existence in which those very external effects do not follow upon them, although other effects, different from their external effects, do follow upon them.

This kind of existence is what we call “mental existence.” It is our knowledge of the quiddities of things.

Some have denied mental existence. Some of them hold that knowledge is only a kind of relation between the soul and the external object known. Others hold—and this view has been attributed to the ancients—that what is present in the mind when things are known consists of likenesses representing them, as a statue represents that of which it is a statue, although the two differ in quiddity. Yet others affirm likenesses which differ from their objects without representing them. On this view the soul makes an error, but an orderly error which does not disrupt human life: as if a person were supposed always to see redness as greenness and always to assign the effects of redness to what he sees as greenness.

The demonstration of mental existence is that we conceive these things which exist externally—such as a human being and a horse—with the characteristics of universality and purity, and judge them to have these characteristics. We have no doubt that what we thus conceive has some established presence within the sphere of our awareness and that we judge it to have these characteristics. It therefore exists with some existence. Since it does not exist externally with these characteristics, for externally it has the characteristics of individuality and admixture, it exists in another sphere in which its external effects do not follow upon it. We call this sphere “the mind.”

We also conceive privative things which do not exist externally, such as absolute nonexistence, the absolutely nonexistent, the conjunction of contradictories, and the other impossibilities. They have some established presence for us, since they are characterized by positive judgments: they are distinguished from other things, they become present to us after having been absent from us, and so forth. Since this is not an external established presence, for they are nonexistent externally, it is in the mind.

We have no doubt that everything we apprehend intellectually is of one kind. Thus, just as things have an external existence possessing external effects, they have an existence in the mind in which those external effects do not follow upon them, although effects other than their particular external effects do follow upon them.

If what we apprehend intellectually of things were identical with what is external, as the proponent of the relational theory holds, it would be impossible to apprehend intellectually what is not external, such as nonexistence and the nonexistent, and no error would occur in knowledge.

If what exists in the mind were a likeness of the external thing, related to it as a statue is to that of which it is a statue, identity in quiddity would be lost and sophistry would follow, since our cognitions would become instances of ignorance. Moreover, actually passing from a representation to what it represents depends upon prior knowledge of what is represented, whereas knowledge of what is represented is supposed to depend upon the representation.

If every cognition were mistaken in disclosing what lies beyond it, sophistry would follow, and this would lead to contradiction. For the claim that every cognition is mistaken also requires this universal cognition itself to be mistaken and therefore false. Its contradictory would then be true: some cognition is correct.

It has therefore been established that quiddities have a mental existence in which their effects do not follow upon them, just as they have an external existence in which their effects follow upon them. This makes clear the division of the existent into external and mental.

Several matters become clear from what has preceded.

First: a mental quiddity does not fall under, and is not included in, the category under which it fell when it was external and its effects followed upon it. It has only the concept of that category. Thus, although the mental human being is a substance, a body, growing, sentient, moving by will, and rational, it is not, insofar as it is a substance, a quiddity existing without being in a subject, nor, insofar as it is a body, something possessing three dimensions. The same applies to the other parts of the definition of the human being. It possesses only the concepts of the genera and differentiae in its definition, without the external effects following upon it—by which effects we mean first and

second perfections. Falling under and being included in a category means nothing other than that its external effects follow upon the thing. Otherwise, if the mere applicability of a category's concept to something were sufficient for its inclusion under it, the category itself would be included under itself because it is predicated of itself, and it would be an individual of itself. This is the meaning of their statement: “Mental substance is substance by primary predication, not by common predication.”

The logicians' division of individuals into mental and external individuals is based upon a loose manner of speaking intended to facilitate instruction.

What has preceded resolves an objection raised against the doctrine of mental existence. According to this doctrine, essential constituents are preserved. Thus, when we apprehend substance intellectually, it is substance in view of the preservation of its essential constituents. Yet the very same thing is an accident, since it subsists in the soul as an accident subsists in its subject. It would therefore be, in itself, both substance and accident; and the impossibility of this is evident.

The resolution is that what is impossible is for one thing to be both substance and accident by common predication. Intellectually apprehended substance is substance by primary predication and accident by common predication. There is therefore no impossibility.

A second objection is that the doctrine of mental existence requires intellectually apprehended substance to be substance, in view of the preservation of its essential constituents, while knowledge, according to the philosophers, belongs to the qualities of the soul. What is intellectually apprehended of substance would therefore be included both under the category of substance and under the category of quality. This is impossible, since it would make its essence contradictory, the categories being distinct in their entire essences. Likewise, if we apprehend quantity intellectually, for example, the intelligible form would be included under both the category of quantity and the category of quality, which is impossible. Likewise, if we apprehend a visible quality intellectually, for example, it would be included under two species of the category of quality: sensible quality and quality of the soul.

The resolution is that it is a quality of the soul by common predication and is therefore included under that category. The other categories or their species, however, are predicated of it by primary predication, and this does not constitute inclusion under them at all.

A third objection is that the doctrine of mental existence requires the soul to be hot and cold together, square and triangular together, and similarly with other opposites, when it conceives these things. For by something hot, cold, square, or triangular we mean only that in which these meanings—which exist for another and qualify it—have occurred.

The resolution is that the criterion for a thing's existence being for another and for its qualifying that other is common predication. What exists in the mind of coldness, heat, and the like is such by primary predication, rather than common predication.

A fourth objection is that this doctrine requires one thing to be both universal and particular, which is evidently false. The implication is explained as follows. An intellectually apprehended human being, for example, is universal insofar as the intellect permits it to be true of many. The very same thing is particular insofar as it is an existent subsisting in one individual soul, through which it is distinguished from other things. It is therefore both universal and particular.

The resolution is that the respects differ. An intellectually apprehended human being, for example, is universal insofar as it is considered in relation to the external world, and particular insofar as it is a quality of the soul, subsisting in the soul without being considered in relation to the external world.

A fifth objection is that we conceive intrinsic impossibilities, such as a partner to the Creator, the negation of a thing of itself, and the conjunction of contradictories or the absence of both of them. If things themselves were present in the mind, this would entail the established presence of intrinsic impossibilities.

The resolution is that what is established in the mind consists only of their concepts by primary predication, not their instances by common predication. What is conceived of a partner to the Creator is a partner to the Creator by primary predication. By common predication, however, it is a possible existent and a quality of the soul, caused and created by the Creator.

Second: since mental existence is, in itself, considered in relation to the external world, it is intrinsically representative of what lies beyond it. It is therefore impossible for a thing to have a mental existence without having an external existence, either actual—as with real quiddities abstracted from external existence—or posited—as with concepts which are not quiddities and which the mind fashions by drawing in some way upon its intelligibles. It conceives the concept of nonexistence, for example, and posits for it some established presence, which it represents through the concept it has conceived. In general, the function of mental existence is to represent what lies beyond it, without the effects of what is represented following upon the representation.

This does not conflict with the occurrence of the representation's own particular effects insofar as it has the quiddity of quality. Nor does it conflict with what will be explained later: that cognitive forms are, without exception, immaterial. For the occurrence of the effects of a quality of the soul, and likewise immateriality, are judgments concerning cognitive forms in themselves.

Representation and the absence of the effects, however, are judgments concerning them in relation to the external world and insofar as they constitute the mental existence of a certain external quiddity.

This resolves an objection raised against the proponents of mental existence: we conceive the earth in its vastness, with its plains, deserts, and mountains, and the sky surrounding it, with its distant reaches, and the stars and planets, with their enormous distances. The presence of these immense magnitudes in the mind—that is, their being imprinted in a part of a nerve or a part of the brain—would be the imprinting of something large in something small, which is impossible. The proposed reply that “the substrate in which the forms are imprinted is divisible without end” is of no avail. A palm cannot contain a mountain, even if it is divisible without end.

The resolution is that the truth, as will be explained later, is that particular cognitive forms are not material. They are instead immaterial with an imaginal immateriality in which the effects of matter—dimensions, colors, and shapes—are present, without matter itself. Being imprinted is a property of matter, and there is no imprinting in what is immaterial.

This also resolves another objection. Sensation and imagination, as natural scientists have explained, occur through the presence in the sensitive organs of the forms of bodies, with their external relations and particular characteristics, and through their transmission to the brain. These organs also modify the forms in accordance with their own particular natures. A human being arrives at the particular characteristics of their magnitudes, dimensions, and shapes through a kind of comparison among the parts of the form present to him, as they have explained in detail in its proper place. It is clear that these forms, present and imprinted with their particular characteristics in a material substrate, differ from the external quiddities. There would therefore be no justification for affirming mental existence and the presence of the external quiddities themselves in minds.

The resolution is that their account of material action and affection when knowledge of particulars occurs is correct in its own domain. These imprinted forms, however, are not what is known in itself. They are material things which prepare the soul and dispose it for the presence to it of external quiddities in immaterial imaginal forms. This follows from what will become clear concerning the immateriality of knowledge without exception. You have also learned that the claim that the forms in sensation and imagination differ from the very things whose forms they are in the external world cannot be separated from sophistry.

Third: since the real quiddities upon which their effects follow externally are the very ones that enter minds without their external effects following upon them, suppose there were something the very character of whose essence was identical with its being external and with the occurrence of

effects—as is the case with concrete existence itself and its attributes subsisting in it, such as potentiality and actuality, unity and multiplicity, and the like. Its presence itself in the mind would be impossible. Likewise, if we suppose something the very character of whose posited essence is nullity and the absence of effects—as is the case with absolute nonexistence and what reduces to it—its entry into the mind would be impossible.

Thus, the reality of existence and everything whose essential character is that of existence, and likewise absolute nonexistence and everything whose posited essential character is that of nonexistence, cannot enter the mind in the way real quiddities enter it. This is what their statement means: “Intrinsic impossibilities have no correct form in minds.”

How the concept of existence and of that by which it is characterized, and the concept of nonexistence and of what reduces to it, are abstracted will be explained, God willing, in the discussions of intellect, the intellective subject, and the intelligible.

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1. **translation:** “Imaginal” renders mithālī: possessing such features as dimensions and shapes while being free of matter, as the author explains here.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 45–52 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=45&type=c_fbook

STAGE IV

The Modalities of Propositions

المرحلة الرابعة — في موادّ القضايا

CHAPTER 0

Stage IV: Necessity, Impossibility, and Possibility, and Their Restriction to Three

مدخل المرحلة

The primary aim here is to explain the division of the existent into the necessary and the possible, and to examine the properties of each. The examination of the impossible and its properties is subsidiary and intended only secondarily.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 53–53 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=53&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One: Every Concept Is Either Necessary, Possible, or Impossible

الفصل الأوّل — في أنّ كلّ مفهوم إمّا واجب وإمّا ممكن وإمّا ممتنع

Whatever concept we suppose and then relate existence to, either existence belongs to it necessarily, which is necessity; or existence is necessarily excluded from it—that is, nonexistence belongs to it necessarily—which is impossibility; or neither existence nor nonexistence belongs to it necessarily, which is possibility.

As for the supposition that existence and nonexistence might both belong to it necessarily, the slightest attention dismisses it. Every supposed concept, then, is either necessary, impossible, or possible.

This is a genuine disjunctive proposition, obtained from two divisions each turning upon affirmation and negation. We say: “For every supposed concept, either existence belongs to it necessarily or it does not. In the latter case, either nonexistence belongs to it necessarily or it does not. The first is the necessary, the second the impossible, and the third the possible.”

The definition of the three modal statuses supplied by this division is that a thing's necessity consists in its existence belonging to it necessarily; its impossibility consists in its nonexistence belonging to it necessarily; and its possibility consists in the negation of both necessities in its regard. The necessary is that whose existence is necessary; the impossible is that whose nonexistence is necessary; and the possible is that whose existence and nonexistence are neither of them necessary.

These are all verbal definitions, explanations of a name that serve to draw attention to its meaning, rather than real definitions. Necessity and nonnecessity are clear, self-evident meanings that are impressed upon the soul primitively: they are known through themselves, and other things are known through them. For this reason, anyone who has tried to give them a real definition has produced circular definitions: defining the possible as "that which is not impossible"; defining the necessary as "that from the supposition of whose nonexistence an impossibility follows," or "that whose nonexistence is impossible to suppose"; defining the impossible as "that which must not be"; and so on.

Of these three modal statuses, those primarily investigated in this discipline, which investigates the existent insofar as it is existent, are necessity and possibility, as was indicated earlier. These are two attributes by which the existent is divided in a primary division, with regard to the relation of its existence to itself.

This disposes of an objection to taking possibility as an established attribute of the possible, corresponding to necessity as an established attribute of the necessary. The objection runs as follows. As the preceding division has shown, possibility is the negation of necessary existence and the negation of necessary nonexistence. These are two negations, even if they are expressed in such a phrase as "the negation of the two necessities." How, then, can possibility be a single attribute qualifying the possible? Granted that it amounts to the negation of the two necessities and is a single negation, it is nevertheless, as the division shows, a simple negation, not an affirmation with a negative predicate. What, then, does it mean for the possible to be qualified by it externally, when qualification requires the predicate to be made negative? Thus, when they begin to explain the properties of possibility—such as its inseparability from quiddity, its being the cause of the need for a cause, and so forth—they are obliged to express it as the nonnecessity of existence and nonexistence, or as the equal relation of quiddity to existence and nonexistence.

The answer is that a proposition with a negative predicate is equivalent to a simply negative proposition when the subject exists. The subject exists in our statements, "Some existents are neither necessary in existence nor necessary in nonexistence," and, likewise, "Quiddity as such is

neither necessary in existence nor necessary in nonexistence.” Accordingly, affirmation with a negative predicate and simple negation are equivalent in the case of possibility.

Furthermore, this negation has a relation to necessity and to its subject, of which the two necessities are denied. Through this relation it is distinguished from other negations and becomes a relative nonexistence, possessing a share of existence and effects consequent upon it. This holds even though the intellect first apprehends it in the form of simple negation, just as it first apprehends blindness, which is a relative nonexistence, in that form.

Several matters follow from the foregoing.

First: the subject of possibility is quiddity. A thing can be qualified by the nonnecessity of existence and nonexistence only if, in itself, it is devoid of both existence and nonexistence. This is nothing other than quiddity as such. Every possible thing, therefore, has a quiddity. This clarifies the meaning of their statement: “Every possible thing is a composite pair: it has a quiddity and an existence.”

Calling existence other than that of the intrinsically necessary “possible,” and naming it “possible existence,” belongs to another technical usage of possibility and necessity. In this usage, possibility and necessity mean intrinsic poverty and intrinsic self-sufficiency. What is meant is not the negation of the two necessities or an equal relation to existence and nonexistence, since that is inconceivable with regard to existence itself.

Second: possibility is inseparable from quiddity. If it were not inseparable from it, quiddity could be devoid of it and would then be necessary or impossible. It would thus be, in itself, existent or nonexistent. Yet quiddity as such is neither existent nor nonexistent.

Its being inseparable from quiddity means that merely supposing quiddity as such suffices for its qualification by possibility, without the need for anything additional. What is meant is not inseparability in the technical sense, in which the thing from which a concomitant is inseparable is a cause requiring that concomitant to be realized and to belong to it. At the level of quiddity as such there is no requirement, whether affirmative or negative.

It should not be objected: “For the negation of the two necessities to hold at the level of quiddity’s very essence entails that possibility enters into the essence of the thing, and this is plainly false.” We reply that a predicate enters into the essence only if its predication is primary predication, whose criterion is conceptual identity, rather than common predication, whose criterion is identity in existence. The predication of possibility and the other concomitants of quiddities of quiddity as such is common predication, not primary predication.

Third: possibility exists among concrete things through the existence of its subject. It is neither a purely intellectual consideration with no form among concrete things, as some have maintained, nor something existing externally through a separate, independent existence, as others have maintained.

That it exists among concrete things through the existence of its subject follows from its being, in the division, a counterpart of the necessary, whose necessity of existence is among concrete things. The absence of necessity, which is possibility, is therefore also among concrete things. Since it is posited in a division requiring the thing divided to be qualified by each of the divisions, it has the sense of a positive attribute by which its subject is qualified. It is thus a negative meaning possessing a share of existence, and quiddity is qualified by it among concrete things.

Since quiddity is qualified by it among concrete things, it has existence among them in the manner of relative nonexistences: negative attributes qualifying the things to which they belong and existing through their existence. In truth, the effects consequent upon possibility are the absence of the effects of necessity, such as the purity of existence, simplicity of essence, self-sufficiency with respect to another, and so forth.

This explanation makes clear the falsity of the view that “possibility is one of the purely intellectual considerations having no form either externally or mentally.” For it is clear that the necessity of an existent’s existence is something whose domain is external reality, and that it has positive external effects.

The view that “possibility has a separate, independent existence externally” is likewise false. For it is clear that possibility is one negative meaning shared by quiddities and established through their being established in themselves: the negation of the two necessities. There is no sense in nonexistences existing through a separate, independent existence. Moreover, if possibility existed among concrete things through a separate, independent existence, it would be either intrinsically necessary, which is self-evidently false, or possible. In the latter case, its establishment would lie beyond the establishment of quiddity and would not be sufficiently accounted for by quiddity’s being established in itself. It would therefore be through another; and the impossibility of possibility through another will be explained.

They have offered several arguments for that view. The most plausible is that, if the possible were not possible among concrete things, it would be either necessary or impossible among them. The possible would thus be necessarily existent or necessarily nonexistent, and this is absurd.

The answer is that qualification by an attribute among concrete things does not require that attribute to be realized among them through a separate, independent existence. It is enough for it to exist through the existence of what it qualifies. Possibility is one of the secondary philosophical intelligibles: its occurrence as a predicate is in the mind, while qualification by it is external, and such intelligibles exist externally through the existence of their subjects.

It is evident from the foregoing that possibility is one shared meaning, like the concept of existence.

A further point: the divisions of necessity

Necessity is divided into eternal necessity, in which the predicate belongs to the subject necessarily on account of its essence, without any restriction or condition, even that of existence. This is confined to the case in which the subject's essence is sheer self-subsisting existence, unmixed with nonexistence and unlimited by quiddity. This is necessary existence—exalted and holy is He—with regard to the attributes by which He is qualified and which are identical with His essence.

Another division is essential necessity, in which the predicate belongs to the subject necessarily on account of its essence, with existence but not through existence. For example, we say, "Every human being is necessarily an animal." Animality is essential to the human being and belongs to the human being necessarily so long as the human being exists, and with existence. Without existence, the essence would be null: there would be neither human being nor animal.

Another is descriptive necessity, in which the predicate belongs to the subject necessarily on account of a description of the subject. For example: "Every writer necessarily moves their fingers so long as they are writing." Another is temporal necessity, which in one respect reduces to descriptive necessity.

Another further point: the divisions of possibility

The meaning of possibility explained above is the one investigated in these discussions. It is one of the three modalities, one of which is present in every proposition.

In ordinary usage, possibility was employed to mean the negation of necessity on the opposite side, which entails the negation of impossibility on the corresponding side. In an affirmative proposition it is true where the corresponding side is necessary, as in "A writer possibly moves their fingers," or where necessity is denied of it, as in "A human being possibly moves their fingers." In a negative proposition it is true where the corresponding affirmative side is impossible, as in "A writer is possibly not motionless in their fingers," or where necessity is denied of it, as in "A human being is possibly not motionless in their fingers."

Possibility in this sense is broader in its range of cases than possibility in the preceding sense—that is, the negation of the two necessities—and than either necessity or impossibility. It is not broader conceptually, since there is no common concept uniting the modalities. The philosophers then transferred the term specifically to the negation of necessity on both sides. They called this "special possibility" or "possibility in the special sense," and called ordinary usage "general possibility" or "possibility in the general sense."

Sometimes "possibility" is used to mean the negation of essential, descriptive, and temporal necessities. This is narrower than special possibility and is therefore called "more special possibility." An example is "A human being is possibly a writer." Human quiddity does not require writing, whether on account of its essence, on account of a description, or at a time specified in the proposition.

Sometimes "possibility" is used to mean the negation of all necessities, even necessity conditional upon the predicate. This concerns future matters in which neither affirmation nor negation has become determinate. Necessity is denied of them even with regard to the predicate, affirmatively and negatively. This consideration belongs to the simple, ordinary outlook, which is characteristically ignorant of future events because it does not encompass their causes and grounds. Otherwise, every supposed matter, in its own circumstances, has either existence and necessity, or nonexistence and impossibility.

Sometimes "possibility" is used to mean dispositional possibility. This is an existential attribute belonging to the qualities that subsist in matter, through which matter receives different actualities. It differs from special possibility in being an existential attribute that admits of strength and weakness, and of proximity to and remoteness from actuality. Its subject is existing matter, and it disappears from matter with the existence of that for which the matter was disposed. Special possibility, by contrast, is an intellectual meaning admitting neither strength and weakness nor proximity and remoteness. Its subject is quiddity as such, and it never departs from quiddity, whether quiddity exists or does not exist.

Sometimes "possibility" is used to mean that a thing is such that supposing its occurrence entails no impossibility. This is called "possibility of occurrence."

Sometimes "possibility" is used to mean the dependence of the existence of an effect upon the existence of its cause, and its constitution through that existence—specifically, the intrinsic poverty of possible existence in relation to necessary existence, majestic and exalted is He. This is called "possibility as poverty" and "existential possibility," in contrast to quiddative possibility.

Another further point

The three modalities mentioned are not restricted to propositions whose predicate is existence. One of them intervenes between any supposed predicate and any supposed subject to which it is related. Philosophy, however, treats them only insofar as they intervene between existence and its essential accidents, since its subject is the existent insofar as it is existent.

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1. **translation:** “Simple negation” renders salb taḥṣīlī; “affirmation with a negative predicate” renders ījāb ʿudūlī. The distinction is between denying a predicate and affirming a predicate that itself contains negation. “Special possibility” means the absence of necessity on both the affirmative and negative sides.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 55–62 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=55&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Chapter Two: The Division of Each of the Three Modalities into What Is Intrinsic, What Is Through Another, and What Is Relative to Another, with an Exception for Possibility

الفصل الثاني — في انقسام كلٍّ من الموادّ الثلاث إلى ما بالذات — وما بالغير وما بالقياس إلى الغير ، إلاّ الإمكان

Each of these three modalities is divided into what is intrinsic, what is through another, and what is relative to another, with an exception for possibility: there is no possibility through another.

By “intrinsic” is meant that positing the essence, while disregarding everything other than it, suffices for its characterization by the modality. “Through another” means that positing it in this way does not suffice; rather, the characterization depends on another’s bestowal and necessitation. “Relative to another” means that the characterization is considered in relation to another, in virtue of a requirement on its part, “requirement” here being broader than causal necessitation.

Intrinsic necessity is exemplified by the necessity of existence belonging to the essence of the Necessary Existent—exalted is He—for His essence through His essence. Necessity through another is exemplified by the necessity of existence that accrues to a possible being from its complete cause. Intrinsic impossibility is exemplified by the necessity of nonexistence belonging to intrinsically impossible things that, owing to their supposed essences, cannot admit existence: for example, the conjunction of contradictories, their joint exclusion, and the negation of a thing of itself. Impossibility through another is exemplified by the necessity of nonexistence that accrues to a possible being from the absence of its cause. Intrinsic possibility is a thing’s being such that, in itself and disregarding everything other than it, both the necessity of existence and the necessity of nonexistence are denied of it.

Possibility through another, however, is impossible, as was indicated earlier. For if possibility through another accrued to a thing from an external cause that necessitated it, the thing considered in itself, disregarding everything else, would be either intrinsically necessary, intrinsically impossible, or intrinsically possible, since, as established, the division into these three is exhaustive. On either of the first two alternatives, the accession of possibility from outside would entail a transformation of its intrinsic status. On the third alternative, namely, its being intrinsically possible, either it would be such that, if we supposed the external cause to be removed, the thing would remain in its former state of possibility, or it would not. In the former case, the other would have no effect on it, since the other's existence and nonexistence would be alike in this respect, although it was supposed to have an effect. This is a contradiction. If it did not remain possible, it would not be intrinsically possible, although it was supposed to be so. This too is a contradiction.

This is so if what is intrinsic and what is through another are one possibility that is both intrinsic and through another. If they are supposed to be two possibilities, one intrinsic and one through another, then one thing, in one and the same respect, would have two possibilities for a single existence. This is plainly untenable, just as the realization of two existences for one thing is untenable.

Moreover, the supposition of possibility through another supposes an external cause that necessitates possibility, and this amounts to the joint exclusion of contradictories. For the other that confers possibility—which is the nonnecessity of existence and nonexistence—can confer it only by removing the cause that necessitates existence and removing the cause that necessitates nonexistence, the latter being the absence of the cause that necessitates existence. Its conferral of possibility is thus complete only if it removes both the existence and the nonexistence of the cause that necessitates existence. This involves the joint exclusion of contradictories.

Necessity relative to another is exemplified by the necessity of a cause when it is considered relative to its effect, owing to a requirement on the effect's part: by existing, the effect permits nothing other than that its cause should exist. It is also exemplified by the necessity of an effect when it is considered relative to its complete cause, owing to causal necessitation on the cause's part: by existing, the cause permits nothing other than that its effect should exist. Another example is the necessity of either of two correlatives when it is considered relative to the existence of the other.

The general criterion is that the two things compared should stand in the relation of cause and effect, or should be effects of one cause. Without a causal connection between them, neither would depend on the other, and the establishment of one would not require the establishment of the other.

Impossibility relative to another is exemplified by the impossibility of the complete cause's existence when it is considered relative to the nonexistence of its effect, owing to a requirement; by the impossibility of the effect's existence when it is considered relative to the nonexistence of its cause, owing to causal necessitation; and by the impossibility of the existence of either of two correlatives when considered relative to the nonexistence of the other, or of its nonexistence when considered relative to the other's existence.

Possibility relative to another is the condition of a thing when it is considered relative to something that requires neither its existence nor its nonexistence.

The general criterion is that the two should neither stand in the relation of cause and effect nor be effects of a third thing.

There is no possibility relative to another between two existing beings. For the thing compared is either the intrinsically Necessary Existent considered relative to a possible being, or the reverse, and these stand in the relation of cause and effect; or it is a possible being considered relative to another possible being, and both ultimately terminate in the intrinsically Necessary Existent.

The intrinsically Necessary Existent does, however, have possibility relative to another when considered relative to another supposed Necessary Existent, or to the effects created by that other. For the two do not stand in the relation of cause and effect, nor are they effects of a third thing.

Analogous to two supposed intrinsically necessary beings are two intrinsically impossible things when either is considered relative to the other, or relative to what the other entails.

There is likewise possibility relative to another between the intrinsically Necessary Existent and a possible being that does not exist because some of the conditions of its existence are absent. Its nonexistence is an effect of the absence of its complete cause; on this supposition, the intrinsically Necessary Existent is one of that cause's components and does not necessitate the supposed possible being. The intrinsically Necessary Existent therefore has possibility relative to it, and conversely.

What has preceded establishes, first, that the intrinsically necessary cannot be necessary through another or impossible through another. Likewise, the intrinsically impossible cannot be impossible through another or necessary through another.

It also establishes that everything necessary through another is possible, and likewise that everything impossible through another is possible.

Second, if two intrinsically necessary beings were supposed, no relation of entailment would obtain between them. Such a relation obtains only between two things of which one is the cause of the other, or which are both effects of a third cause. Being an effect has no place in an intrinsically necessary being.

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1. **translation:** “Requirement” renders istidʿāʾ, which the author expressly distinguishes from the narrower causal necessitation, iqtiḍāʾ. “Relative to another” renders bi-l-qiyās ilā al-ghayr and is distinct from “through another,” bi-l-ghayr.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 63–66 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=63&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Chapter Three: The Quiddity of the Intrinsically Necessary Existent Is Its Existence

الفصل الثالث — في أنّ واجب الوجود بالذات ماهيّته إنّيّته

The quiddity of the intrinsically necessary existent is its existence: that is, it has no quiddity beyond the existence proper to it.

The proposition is evident in light of what was established previously, that possibility is inseparable from quiddity. Every quiddity is therefore possible. By contraposition, whatever is not possible has no quiddity. Accordingly, what is intrinsically necessary has no quiddity beyond its necessary existence.

Nevertheless, they have also offered arguments for this.

The strongest is that, if what is intrinsically necessary had a quiddity beyond the existence proper to it, its existence would be additional to that quiddity and accidental to it. Everything accidental has a cause. Its existence would therefore be caused either by its quiddity or by something else. The second alternative—being caused by another—contradicts intrinsic necessity of existence. The first—being caused by its quiddity—requires its quiddity to precede its existence in existence, because a cause must necessarily precede its effect in existence. If this prior existence were identical with the subsequent existence, a thing would precede itself, which is impossible. If it were other than it, one quiddity would exist through more than one existence, the impossibility of which has already been established. Moreover, we can transfer the discussion to the prior existence, and an infinite regress follows.

It has been objected that its quiddity might be a cause necessitating its existence, preceding it by quiddity, just as the parts of a quiddity are causes of its constitution and precede it by quiddity, rather than by existence.

The reply is that an effect necessarily depends, in its mode of existence, on the existence of its cause. The cause's priority is therefore in the very mode in which the effect is established, except that the cause has it more intensely. If the effect is established externally, its cause precedes it in external existence; and if it is established mentally, the same applies.

Since the existence of what is necessary through itself is real and external, if it had a quiddity that was a cause necessitating its existence, its quiddity would have to precede it in external existence, rather than in quidditative establishment. The difficulty thus remains.

Another argument: considering any quiddity in itself, the intellect allows that it may have, beyond the individuals of it that exist, further individuals without end.

Any individual that has not been realized is therefore impossible through another. If it were intrinsically impossible, no individual of that quiddity would ever be realized.

If, then, this thing possessing a quiddity is supposed to be intrinsically necessary, its quiddity will be a universal having, beyond its individuals that exist externally, nonexistent individuals whose existence is admissible when the quiddity itself is considered. They are impossible only through another. It is known that impossibility through another cannot coexist with intrinsic necessity. It has already been established that everything necessary through another or impossible through another is possible. Thus the intrinsically necessary existent has no quiddity beyond its proper existence.

It has been objected: why may the intrinsically necessary existent not have an existential reality that is not additional to its essence but identical with it, which the intellect then analyzes into existence and a particular, individual, nonuniversal subject of that existence, this subject being its quiddity?

The reply is that the argument rests on the true position that individuation is through existence alone, as will be explained in the discussions of quiddity.

The foregoing has thus shown that what is intrinsically necessary is an existential reality without any quiddity to delimit it. It is necessary in existence through its very essence, without needing an additional causal or qualifying aspect. This is eternal necessity.

It was established in the first stage that existence is an objective, graded reality with different degrees. Each of its degrees possesses the existential perfection belonging to what is below it, sustains what is below it, and is sustained by what is above it, while lacking some of the latter's

perfection. This is deficiency and need. The exception is the highest of the degrees, which possesses every perfection and lacks none, by which every degree is sustained, and which is not sustained by anything beyond its own essence.

On the doctrine of gradation, the necessary reality thus corresponds to the highest degree: beyond it there is no degree to delimit it; there is no perfection in existence that it lacks; no deficiency or nonexistence mingles with its essence; and no need restricts it. The negative attributes inseparable from it reduce to the negation of negation and the absence of deficiency and need, which is affirmation.

This disposes of several objections that have been raised against denying quiddity to what is intrinsically necessary.

One is that the reality of what is intrinsically necessary does not equal the reality of anything else, because the reality of anything else entails possibility, whereas its reality excludes it. Its existence, however, equals the existence of the possible in being existence. Its reality must therefore differ from its existence; otherwise the existence of every possible thing would be necessary.

Another is that, if the existence of what is intrinsically necessary were devoid of quiddity, this description would belong to it either through itself or through another. If through itself, the existence of every possible thing would be necessary, because existence is shared, and this is impossible. If through another, it would need another, entailing possibility, contrary to the supposition.

Another is that what is intrinsically necessary is the principle of possible things. If it is devoid of quiddity, then, if it is a principle through itself, every existence must likewise be a principle. Every possible thing would consequently be a cause of itself and its causes, which is plainly impossible. If it is a principle through its existence together with the qualification of being devoid of quiddity, the first principle must be composite; indeed, it must be nonexistent, because one of its two parts —being devoid of quiddity—is privative. If it is a principle on condition of being devoid of quiddity, every existence could be the principle of every existence, although this judgment fails to apply to it because it lacks the condition, namely, being devoid of quiddity.

Another is that, if what is necessary through its essence is being in concrete reality itself—that is, unrestricted being—every existent must be necessary. If it is being together with the qualification of being devoid of quiddity, the necessary existent must be composite, although that qualification is a privative meaning and cannot be a part of the necessary existent. If it is being on condition of being devoid of quiddity, the intrinsically necessary existent will not be necessary through its essence. If it is other than being in concrete reality, then, if it is without being, it must not be

existent, since an existence without being is inconceivable. If being is internal to it, composition follows. All the preceding consequences are plainly false. If being is external to it, its existence is external to its reality, which is what was to be proved. These are among the objections.

The reason they fail is that the existence taken in them is either the general, self-evident concept, which is an intellectually considered meaning distinct from necessary existence, the latter being an objective reality proper to the necessary existent; or it is a shared, univocal universal nature whose instances are equal. Objective existence, however, is a graded reality with different degrees, the highest of which is the existence proper to what is intrinsically necessary.

Moreover, being devoid of quiddity is not a privative description. It means the negation of a limit, which is a negation of negation and returns to affirmation.

It has also become clear that the necessity of existence belonging to what is intrinsically necessary is eternal necessity, rather than essential or descriptive necessity. For one kind of necessity is eternal: the necessity of a predicate's belonging to a subject through the subject itself, without any qualification or condition, as in our statement, "The necessary existent necessarily exists."

Another kind is essential necessity: the necessity of a predicate's belonging to the essence of a subject with existence, rather than through existence. This holds whether the subject's essence causes the predicate, as in our statement, "Every triangle necessarily has its three angles equal to two right angles," for the quiddity of the triangle causes this equality when it exists; or whether the subject's essence does not cause the predicate's belonging to it, as in our statement, "Every human is necessarily human," or "necessarily animal," or "necessarily rational." For the necessity of a thing's belonging to itself means its inseparability from itself while it exists, without its essence being a cause of itself.

Another kind is descriptive necessity: the necessity of a predicate's belonging to a subject by virtue of its description, with existence, rather than through existence, as in our statement, "Every writer necessarily moves his fingers for as long as he is writing." This has already been indicated.

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1. **translation:** In the chapter heading, inniyya denotes existence or the fact of being. "Essential necessity" (ḍarūra dhātiyya), as a classification of propositions, is distinguished here from the eternal necessity of the intrinsically necessary existent.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 66–70 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=66&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Chapter Four: What Is Intrinsically Necessary in Existence Is Necessary in Existence in Every Respect

الفصل الرابع — في أنّ واجب الوجود بالذّات واجب الوجود — من جميع الجهات

What is intrinsically necessary in existence is necessary in existence in every respect.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn, may God have mercy upon him, said: “What is meant by this is that there is no aspect of possibility in the Necessary Existent. Everything that is possible for it in the sense of general possibility is necessary for it.

“One consequence of this property is that it has no state awaiting realization: the former is a principle from which this latter judgment follows.

“The latter is not identical with the former, as many people have supposed. It is the former that is counted among the properties peculiar to the intrinsically Necessary Existent, rather than the latter, for the luminous separate beings also possess the latter property. If a separate being had a state of perfection awaiting realization that could come to be in it, this would entail the realization of dispositional possibility in it and its being affected by the world of motion and bodily configurations. That would necessitate its becoming corporeal and turbid, despite its being immaterial and luminous. This is a contradiction.” End of quotation.

The proof is as follows. If what is intrinsically necessary in existence, and free of quiddity, had an aspect of possibility in relation to some perfection among existential perfections, its essence in itself would lack that perfection, and the absence of that perfection would be established in it. It would therefore be composed of existence and nonexistence. This entails composition in the essence; composition entails need; and need entails possibility. Yet its necessity has been assumed. This is a contradiction.

Another proof: if the essence of the intrinsically Necessary Existent were not sufficient for the necessity of some attribute of perfection that it could possess, it would need another with respect to that attribute. Let us then consider the intrinsically necessary essence in itself, setting aside the existence and nonexistence of that other. If it is necessary together with the existence of that attribute, the causality of the other becomes redundant, though the other has been assumed to be a cause. This is a contradiction. If it is necessary together with the absence of that attribute, a contradiction likewise follows.

It has been objected that the intellect’s not taking the cause into consideration does not conflict with its being realized in reality. Likewise, considering a quiddity insofar as it is itself, and its being free under this consideration of existence, nonexistence, and the cause necessitating either, does not conflict with its possessing one of the two externally and with the occurrence of its cause.

The reply is that this is an analogy between different cases. The aspect of quiddity insofar as it is itself differs from the aspect of actuality. The intellect may therefore consider a quiddity and restrict its attention to it insofar as it is itself, without attending to anything else—existence, nonexistence, or their cause.

External existence is different. The aspect of its essence is identical with the aspect of actuality and the very substance of realization. It therefore cannot be considered without taking into account everything connected with it, whether cause or condition.

The proof can be formulated in another way. The essence's being insufficient for the necessity of one of its attributes of perfection calls for its needing another for that attribute's necessity. That other is thus the necessitating cause. This entails that what is intrinsically necessary in existence possesses necessity through another, whose impossibility has already been established.

An objection has been raised against the thesis itself: it is contradicted by the relations and connections that accrue to the necessary essence from its acts pertaining to its possible, originated effects. Relations and connections subsist through their terms and follow those terms in possibility —for example, creating, providing sustenance, giving life, causing death, and the rest.

This is answered by noting that these relations and connections, and the attributes derived from them, are meanings abstracted from the level of action rather than the level of essence, as will be explained.

Certainly, the existence of these relations and connections has a real connection with Him, exalted is He; and the attributes derived from them for the essence are necessary through the necessity of the essence. His being such as to create, His being such as to provide sustenance, and so forth are therefore necessary attributes. They ultimately refer to the illuminative relation. A detailed account of this will be given later, God willing.

From the foregoing, the following have become clear.

First, necessary existence is pure existence, having no quiddity and accompanied by no nonexistence. It therefore possesses every perfection in existence.

Second, it is one with the unity of purity, which is called "true unity." This means that anything you suppose to be a second to it must necessarily differ from it by some perfection absent from it. Its essence would thus be composed of existence and nonexistence and would cease to be sheer and pure existence, although it has been assumed to be pure. This is a contradiction. In its sheer essence, then, it is such that whenever you suppose a second to it, that second returns to being the first.

This is what is meant by their saying: “It is one, but not numerically.”

Third, it is simple and has no part, either intellectually or externally. Otherwise, it would cease to be pure existence, although it has been assumed to be pure. This is a contradiction.

Fourth, that from which its necessity is abstracted is precisely that from which its existence is abstracted. It follows that each of its attributes—all of which are necessary—is identical with every other attribute, and all are identical with the exalted essence.

Fifth, necessity, like unity, is among the aspects of necessary existence and does not fall outside its essence. It is the firmness of existence, which ultimately consists in its explicit contradiction of absolute nonexistence and its exclusion of it. Nonexistence therefore cannot befall it.

Possible existence, too, contradicts and excludes nonexistence. But it is connective in relation to its cause, which is the intrinsically Necessary Existent, either immediately or through an intermediary; it subsists through that cause and is in no way independent of it. Consequently, no judgment applies to it in itself except with its cause conjoined to it. It is therefore necessary through the necessitation of its cause, the intrinsically Necessary Existent, and resists and excludes nonexistence with that cause conjoined to it.

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1. **translation:** “A state awaiting realization” renders ḥāla muntaẓara: an unrealized state or perfection still capable of being acquired. “The illuminative relation” renders al-iḍāfa al-ishrāqiyya.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 70–74 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=70&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Chapter Five: A Thing Does Not Exist Unless It Becomes Necessary, and the Refutation of the Doctrine of Priority

الفصل الخامس — الشيء ما لم يجب لم يوجَد ، وفيه بطلان القول بالأولويّة

It has already been explained that quiddity, at the level of its essence, is nothing but itself: neither existent nor nonexistent, nor anything else. Both the necessity of existence and the necessity of nonexistence are denied of it by simple negation; this is possibility. In the intellect, therefore, it stands in an equal relation to existence and nonexistence. The intellect has no doubt that its being qualified by either existence or nonexistence cannot derive from the quiddity itself, since its relation to the two is equal, and that neither can this occur without a cause. Rather, it depends on something beyond the quiddity that takes it out of this state of equality and gives preponderance to existence or nonexistence for it. This is the cause.

The cause's giving preponderance to the side of existence can only be its making existence necessary. Without this necessitation, existence would not be determined for the quiddity: either alternative would remain admissible, and the question would remain, “Why did it become existent when nonexistence was admissible for it?” A cause's bringing something into existence is therefore not complete unless it first makes existence necessary for the effect.

The account of the cause of nonexistence and its imparting impossibility to its effect is analogous to the account of the cause of existence and its imparting necessity.

Thus a cause of existence is not a complete cause unless it necessitates, and a cause of nonexistence is not a complete cause unless it is such as to impart impossibility to its effect. A thing does not exist unless it becomes necessary, and it does not become nonexistent unless it becomes impossible.

Some have said: “The necessity of the effect's existence entails that the cause, without qualification, is compelled—mūjab, with the jīm vocalized with a fatḥa—and is not free in its choice. It therefore entails that the Necessary Existent, exalted is He, is compelled in His act and is not free in His choice, which is impossible.”

This is answered as follows. The necessity with which the effect is qualified is necessity through another. The effect's necessity is abstracted from its existence and does not extend beyond it. It is impossible for an effect to influence the existence of its cause, when the effect follows upon the cause, is posterior to it, and subsists through it.

What has preceded makes clear the invalidity of the doctrine of priority in all its forms.

To explain: some theologians supposed that to say that a possible thing is qualified by necessity when either existence or nonexistence acquires preponderance for it entails that the Necessary Existent, in being the source of bringing things into existence, is an agent who is compelled—mūjab, with the jīm vocalized with a fatḥa; exalted and holy is He above that. They therefore held that either alternative acquires preponderance for the possible thing when the quiddity leaves its state of equality and tends toward one of the two sides, so that existence has priority for it, or nonexistence has priority for it, without either side reaching the point at which it takes the quiddity beyond the limit of possibility. Thus, among quiddities, those that exist have acquired preponderance through existence having priority for them without necessity, and those that do not exist through nonexistence having priority for them without necessity.

They divided priority into intrinsic priority, which the quiddity demands through its essence or from which it is inseparable, and nonintrinsic priority, which an external cause imparts. Each of these two kinds is either sufficient for the effect to occur or insufficient.

It is reported of some of the ancients that they recognized a priority of existence in some existents, the consequence of which is that they exist more frequently, that their existence is more intense and stronger, or that fewer conditions are required for their occurrence. They recognized a priority of nonexistence in some others, the consequence of which is that they exist less frequently, that their existence is weaker, or that more conditions are required for their occurrence.

It is reported of some that they recognized priority only on the side of nonexistence, and only in relation to one group of existents.

It is reported of some that they recognized a priority of nonexistence in relation to all possible existents, on the ground that nonexistence occurs more easily.

These are their various positions.

What has preceded makes clear that the doctrine of priority is unsound at its root. The attainment of priority on either the side of existence or that of nonexistence does not eliminate the admissibility of the other alternative's occurrence.

The question of why the alternative possessing priority becomes determined, while the other alternative remains admissible, is still in place—even if priorities proceed without end—until one reaches something through which the alternative possessing priority becomes determined and the admissibility of the other alternative is eliminated. That is necessity.

Moreover, the doctrine of priority invalidates the necessary truth that possible quiddities depend on a cause for their existence and nonexistence. On this doctrine, the less preponderant alternative may occur even though priority has been attained by the other alternative and its complete cause is present.

It has already been explained that, in that case, the cause of the less preponderant alternative that occurs cannot be realized. Its occurrence would thus not depend on a cause. This is contrary to the supposition.

There are other arguments with which they have refuted these positions and clarified their unsoundness. We have refrained from presenting them, since the matter is already clear from what has preceded.

As for the claim that necessity through another—that is, the effect's being made necessary by its cause—entails that the cause is compelled, mūjab with the jīm vocalized with a fatḥa, its unsoundness is clear, as explained earlier. This necessity is an intellectual abstraction from the

effect's existence and is not something added to that existence. In its entire reality, the effect is something derivative from its cause, subsisting in its very essence through the cause, and posterior to it. Something whose condition is this cannot intelligibly influence the cause and act upon it.

One consequence of this issue is that propositions whose modality is priority are not demonstrative propositions, since there is no modality other than necessity and possibility—unless, indeed, the meaning comes down to a kind of gradation.

A clarification

The necessity of existence for quiddity discussed above is necessity through another. It is prior to the quiddity's existence and is abstracted from that existence. There is also another, posterior necessity that attaches to an existent quiddity, called necessity conditional upon the predicate. For if it were possible for a quiddity qualified by existence, while it remains so qualified, to be overtaken by the nonexistence that opposes and excludes that existence, this would amount to the possibility of two contradictories being conjoined, which is impossible. It follows that existence cannot be separated from the quiddity so long as it is qualified by existence, and insofar as it is so qualified. This is the necessity of existence in this respect.

An analogous account applies to the posterior impossibility that attaches to a nonexistent quiddity.

An existent quiddity is thus encompassed by two necessities, and a nonexistent quiddity by two impossibilities.

It should be understood that this posterior necessity is necessity through another, just as the prior necessity is necessity through another. This is because the posterior necessity is abstracted from the quiddity's existence insofar as the quiddity is qualified by it, whereas the prior necessity is abstracted from that existence insofar as it is related to the cause that bestows it.

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1. **translation:** “Priority” translates awlawiyya: a preponderance of one alternative that, in the doctrine under criticism, falls short of making that alternative necessary. It does not mean temporal precedence or desirability.
2. **translation:** The argument distinguishes mūjib, “necessitating,” from mūjab, “compelled.” The sentence stating when a cause of existence becomes complete is read in the active sense required by the argument, despite the passive vocalization in the supplied Arabic transcription.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 74–78 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=74&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Chapter Six: The Possible Existent’s Need for a Cause, and Why Possibility, Rather Than Origination, Is the Ground of That Need

الفصل السادس — في حاجة الممكن إلى العلّه وأنّ علّة حاجته إلى — العلّة هو الإمكان دون الحدوث

The possible existent’s need for something beyond its quiddity—that is, its dependence upon such a thing in acquiring existence or nonexistence—is among the primary self-evident truths. Assent to it requires no more than conceiving its subject and predicate. For when we conceive a quiddity as possible, equally related to existence and nonexistence, and conceive the preponderance of either side for it and its acquisition of that side as dependent upon something beyond the quiddity, we assent to this without delay. Thus, the possible existent’s being characterized by either of the two attributes, existence and nonexistence, depends upon something beyond itself, which we call the “cause.” No sound intellect doubts this.

To allow that it may be characterized by either side, while it is possible and equally related to both, neither through itself nor through something beyond itself, is to depart from the natural disposition of human understanding.

Is the ground of its need for a cause its possibility or its origination?

A group of theologians have maintained the second position.

The truth is the first, which is the position maintained by the philosophers. They argue for it as follows. A quiddity, considered with its existence, necessarily exists, and, considered with its nonexistence, necessarily does not exist. These are two necessities conditional upon the predicate, and necessity is the ground of independence from a cause or reason. Origination is a thing’s existence after its nonexistence. If you wish, say that it is the succession of one of these two necessities after the other. Necessity, as you have learned, is the ground of independence from a cause. Unless, therefore, the quiddity is considered in respect of its possibility, independence is not removed and need is not established. Need is established only through its ground, and it has no ground other than possibility.

Another argument: origination, namely existence’s being preceded by nonexistence, is an attribute of a particular existence. It is therefore preceded by the effect’s existence, since that which is qualified precedes its attribute. Existence is preceded by the cause’s bestowal of existence; the bestowal of existence is preceded by the effect’s necessity; and its necessity is preceded by the cause’s necessitation, as explained earlier. The cause’s necessitation is preceded by the effect’s need, and the effect’s need is preceded by its possibility. For if it were not possible, it would be

either necessary or impossible, and necessity and impossibility are grounds of independence from a cause. Consequently, if origination were the ground of need—and a cause necessarily precedes its effect—it would precede itself by several degrees, which is impossible.

The ground is therefore possibility, since nothing else capable of being its ground precedes need, and need is present or absent together with possibility.

This argument rules out origination's being something on which need depends under every possible version of the claim: that origination alone is the ground; that possibility and origination together are the ground; that origination is the ground and possibility a condition; or that possibility is the ground and origination a condition, or the absence of origination an impediment.

They have argued against possibility alone being the ground of need as follows. If the ground of need for a cause were possibility without origination, it would be permissible for something beginningless in time to exist—that is, something not preceded by temporal nonexistence. But this is impossible. Because its existence is perpetual, nonexistence has no access to it such that removing that nonexistence would require a cause to bestow existence upon it. The perpetuity of its existence therefore makes it independent of a cause.

The reply is that the subject of need is the quiddity insofar as it is possible, rather than the quiddity insofar as it exists. The quiddity with the attribute of possibility is retained with perpetual existence just as it is retained with any other existence. A quiddity whose existence is beginningless therefore needs a cause insofar as it is possible, just as does a quiddity whose existence originates; and perpetual existence is bestowed upon it just as originated existence is. As for the existent quiddity insofar as it exists, it has necessity conditional upon the predicate. Necessity is the ground of independence from a cause in the sense that what exists, insofar as it exists, does not need another existingness to supervene upon it.

Moreover, by the origination they require as a condition of need, they mean temporal origination: existence's being preceded by temporal nonexistence. Their claim is therefore contradicted by time itself, since time's being preceded by temporal nonexistence has no meaning.

Furthermore, affirming time before every possible quiddity affirms the motion that traces out time; this affirms something moving in which the motion subsists; and this affirms a moving body, matter, and form. Thus, whenever existence is supposed for a possible quiddity, there is an interval of time before it, and whenever an interval of time is supposed, a possible quiddity accompanies it. Time, then, is not preceded by temporal nonexistence.

Some have replied to the counterexample that time is an intellectually considered, imagined affair, to which there is no harm in ascribing beginninglessness, since it has no reality beyond imagination.

The difficulty is that this destroys the position they have built by grounding the possible existent's need in its temporal origination, since on this account what is originated and what is beginningless become one and the same.

Others have replied that time is abstracted from the existence of the Necessary Existent, exalted is He, and so belongs to the domain of the First Principle, exalted is He; there is therefore no harm in its being beginningless.

It has been objected that time is intrinsically changing, and abstracting it from the essence of the Intrinsically Necessary Existent would entail change entering His essence, exalted and sanctified is He.

This has been answered by saying that it is permissible for an abstracted meaning not to correspond in every respect to the instance from which it is abstracted, and thus to differ from it.

The difficulty is that permitting the abstracted concept to differ from that from which it is abstracted is sophistry. For if a concept could differ from its instance, the edifice of cognitive assent would be destroyed at its foundation.

A clarification

It was explained in the discussions of nonexistence that nonexistence is sheer nullity: it has no thinghood, and there is no differentiation within it. Nevertheless, the intellect sometimes relates it to existence, so that it gains a certain mental establishment and a certain share of existence. One nonexistence is thereby distinguished from another: the nonexistence of sight from the nonexistence of hearing, for example, and the nonexistence of a human being from the nonexistence of a horse. The intellect then assigns to it the necessary judgments it apprehends, which in truth amount to establishing the corresponding judgments concerning existence.

Of this kind is the intellect's judgment that the possible quiddity, in acquiring nonexistence, needs a cause, namely the nonexistence of the cause of existence.

When the intellect conceives the quiddity as such, devoid of both realization and nonrealization, and then compares existence and nonexistence to it, it necessarily finds that the quiddity's realization through existence depends upon an existent cause. It follows that if the cause of its existence does not exist, the caused quiddity does not exist. The judgment is thus completed: because of its possibility, the possible quiddity needs a determining factor for its being

characterized by either existence or nonexistence, to make that side preponderate. The determining factor for existence is the existence of the cause, and the determining factor for nonexistence is its nonexistence. That is, if the cause bestowing existence is absent, the caused quiddity does not exist. The reality of this is that the possible quiddity's existence depends upon the existence of its cause.

1. **translation:** Ḥudūth is rendered "origination"; where the text specifies ḥudūth zamānī, it means temporal origination. Qidam zamānī is rendered "beginninglessness in time," rather than the broader and potentially ambiguous "eternity."
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 78–83 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=78&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Chapter Seven: The Possible Existent Needs a Cause in Its Continuance Just as It Needs One in Its Origination

الفصل السابع — الممكن محتاج إلى العلّة بقاءً كما أنّه محتاج إليها حدوثاً

This is because the ground of its need for a cause is its possibility, which is inseparable from its quiddity, as explained earlier. The quiddity remains with it in its continuance just as it is present with it in its origination. It therefore needs the cause that bestows its existence both in origination and in continuance, which is what was to be shown.

Another argument: the concrete identity of each thing is its own particular existence, while quiddity is derivative and abstracted from it, as explained earlier. The existence of the possible effect is a connective existence, dependent in its very essence upon its cause and constituted through it. It has no independence apart from the cause and never sheds this condition, as will be explained, God willing. Its condition with respect to needing a cause is therefore the same in origination and continuance, and need is inseparable from it.

The difference between the two arguments is that the first establishes the conclusion through quidditative possibility, meaning the equal relation of the quiddity to existence and nonexistence; the second establishes it through existential possibility, meaning the existential poverty constituted through the cause's independence.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 83–83 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=83&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Chapter Eight: Some Judgments Concerning What Is Intrinsically Impossible

Since intrinsic impossibility is the necessity of nonexistence when the supposed essence of a thing is considered, it stands opposite to intrinsic necessity, which is the necessity of existence when the actual essence of a thing is considered. Judgments corresponding to the opposites of those concerning intrinsic necessity therefore apply to it.

In the Asfār, after explaining that just as the intellect cannot comprehend the reality of the intrinsically Necessary Existent because of His supreme glory and the infinitude of His greatness and majesty, so too it cannot conceive the intrinsically impossible, precisely as intrinsically impossible, because of its extreme deficiency, its sheer nullity, and its being no thing, he says:

“Just as it has been established that what is intrinsically necessary cannot be necessary through another, so too what is intrinsically impossible cannot be impossible through another, by a corresponding argument. And just as a single thing cannot have two necessities, one intrinsic and one through another, or both intrinsic, or both through another, so a single thing cannot have two impossibilities in these ways.

“It has therefore become clear that whatever is characterized by necessity or impossibility through another is intrinsically possible.

“Whatever entails the intrinsically impossible is inevitably impossible in the respect in which it entails the impossible, even if it has another respect in which it is possible. Its entailment of the impossible, however, is only in its respect of impossibility. For example, a body’s being unlimited in its dimensions entails something intrinsically impossible: that what is bounded should be unbounded. This ultimately amounts to a thing’s being other than itself while being identical with itself. One of these is intrinsically impossible, and the other is impossible through another. The latter is therefore necessarily possible under a consideration other than that of its connection with the intrinsically impossible. This corresponds to what you have learned about a thing’s entailing the intrinsically Necessary Existent: it does so, not in respect of its possible quiddity, but in respect of the necessity of its existence as a possible existent.

“In general, just as entailment in existence between two things requires a relation of cause and effect between the things connected by entailment, so too entailment in nonexistence and impossibility between two things cannot be separated from a connection between them.

“Just as two necessary existents, were we to suppose them, would not be connected by entailment but would merely accompany one another by chance and coincidence, so entailment in the technical sense cannot obtain between two intrinsically impossible things. It obtains instead

between something intrinsically impossible and something impossible through another; and the latter is inevitably intrinsically possible, as has already been stated.

“This distinguishes an implicative conditional from a coincidental conditional. In the first, the consequent, whether affirmative or negative, is judged true on the supposition that the antecedent, whether affirmative or negative, is true, because of an intrinsic connection between them.

“In the second, the same judgment is made without a connection of entailment, merely because the antecedent and consequent happen to coincide.

“During debate, when an impossible supposition is made in order to establish the impossibility of some matter by a reductio or a direct argument, it has become common among dialecticians to say: ‘Your supposition is impossible. It may therefore entail the contradictory of what you claimed it entails, since one impossibility may follow from another.’ The error of this is evident. An impossibility does not entail just any impossibility whatsoever. It entails an impossibility such that, if the two were supposed to exist, a relation of cause and effect would obtain between them.” End of quotation.

If it is said: “The intrinsically impossible is simply what the intellect supposes and reports to be intrinsically impossible. What, then, does its inability to comprehend it mean?”

The answer is: What is meant is that it has no actual reality to which knowledge could attach. Indeed, that which we suppose to be intrinsically impossible and judge accordingly is intrinsically impossible by primary predication, and is judged to be impossible; by common predication, however, it is a possible, existent cognitive form.

This resembles the response given to the apparent contradiction in our statement, “Nothing can be asserted of the absolutely nonexistent.” This indicates the denial of assertion concerning the absolutely nonexistent, while itself being an assertion concerning it. The response is that assertion is denied of the absolutely nonexistent by common predication, since it has no thinghood such that something could be asserted of it. This very statement, however, is an assertion concerning what is absolutely nonexistent by primary predication, which is a possible mental existent.

If it is said: “The claim that two intrinsically impossible things can only accompany one another coincidentally is inadmissible. For the meanings that the intellect establishes to be impossible for the intrinsically Necessary Existent—such as a partner, a quiddity, composition, and so on—must be attributes intrinsically impossible for Him. Were they impossible through another, they would be intrinsically possible for Him, as stated above.

“Yet no possible attribute belongs to Him, exalted is He, since it has been demonstrated that what is intrinsically necessary in existence is necessary in existence in every respect.

“Moreover, as was indicated at the beginning of the book, the arguments establishing the denial of these impossible attributes are demonstrations from concomitants that proceed by way of general relations of entailment.

“The conclusions, namely the impossibility of these attributes, thus stand in a relation of entailment to the premises. They are consequently all effects of something beyond themselves and impossible through another. But it has been demonstrated that they are intrinsically impossible. This is a contradiction.”

The answer is: The impossible attributes that demonstrations from concomitants deny of the intrinsically Necessary Existent all ultimately amount to the denial of intrinsic necessity, which is identical with the intrinsically Necessary Existent. They are therefore one with respect to their supposed instance, although multiple in concept, just as the affirmative attributes of the intrinsically Necessary Existent are identical in instance with pure necessary existence, although multiple in concept.

The inseparability of these attributes and the demonstrative passage from some of them to others are due to their unity with respect to their supposed instance, even though, at the level of concepts, this takes the form of a relation of entailment between them. The same is true of the affirmative attributes. This is expressed by saying that essential attributes, such as intrinsic necessity, belong intrinsically and through a necessitation by the essence. Yet no necessitation or causality obtains between a thing and itself.

This is the meaning of the statement: “The proof of the existence of the True Originator can only take the form of an exposition resembling a demonstration from the cause.”

For example, the impossibility of a quiddity, which we establish by way of the impossibility of possibility for Him, exalted is He, and the impossibility of possibility itself both ultimately amount to the nullification of intrinsic necessity, which is impossible for Him. The intellect has brought this nullification before itself in conjunction with the intrinsic necessity abstracted from the very essence.

Know also that, just as entailment between two intrinsically impossible things is impossible, so too it is impossible for the possible to entail something intrinsically impossible. For if the possible antecedent can be realized while the consequent is intrinsically impossible, and entailment between them has been supposed, this requires the realization of the antecedent without the consequent. That denies the entailment, and is a contradiction.

An objection has been raised: The nonexistence of the first effect, which is possible, entails the nonexistence of the intrinsically Necessary Existent, which is intrinsically impossible.

“It is therefore permissible for the possible to entail something intrinsically impossible, just as the reverse is permissible: for example, the nonexistence of the Necessary Existent entails the nonexistence of the first effect.”

The objection is answered as follows. What is meant by “the possible” is a quiddity equally related to the two sides of existence and nonexistence.

It is known that, in its essence, it has no connection with anything beyond its own essence, which is affirmed of itself by primary predication. Thus no connection obtains between the quiddity of the first effect and the intrinsically Necessary Existent.

Its existence, however, is connected with His existence and necessary through His necessity; its nonexistence is intellectually connected with His nonexistence and impossible through the impossibility of His nonexistence. Neither of these is possible in the sense of being equally related to existence and nonexistence.

As for their counting the existence of the possible existent as possible, possibility here means the poverty and intrinsic dependence of the quiddity’s existence upon the cause’s existence. It does not mean possibility as an equal relation to existence and nonexistence. The objection thus contains a fallacy in which existential possibility is substituted for quidditative possibility.

Conclusion

The preceding discussions have made clear that necessity, possibility, and impossibility are modes of the relations in propositions, and that no proposition is without one of them. They have also made clear that necessity and possibility are existential matters, because propositions qualified by these modalities correspond completely to external reality precisely insofar as they are qualified by them.

The two therefore exist externally, but through the existence of their subjects, rather than through a distinct, independent existence. They are among the existential aspects belonging to the existent without qualification, like unity, multiplicity, origination, beginninglessness, and the other philosophical meanings examined in philosophy. This means that things are characterized by them externally, while their presentation as predicates occurs in the mind. These are called “philosophical secondary intelligibles.”

Impossibility, however, is a privative matter.

All this is from the standpoint of the intellect’s taking quiddities and concepts as the subjects of judgments.

From the standpoint that actual existence is their subject in truth because existence is primary, necessity is existence’s utmost intensity, inseparable from its subsisting through itself and being independent through itself. Possibility is existence’s poverty in itself and dependence upon another, such that it is not intrinsically independent of that other, as is the case with the existence of possible quiddities. The two are therefore aspects subsisting in existence and lying nowhere outside it.

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1. **translation:** “Demonstration from concomitants” renders burhān innī here, where the author explicitly speaks of proceeding through general entailments; “demonstration from the cause” renders burhān limmī. The discussion preserves the text’s causal conception of entailment.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 84–88 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=84&type=c_fbook

STAGE V

Quiddity and Its Properties

المرحلة الخامسة — في الماهيّة وأحكامها

CHAPTER 1

Chapter One: Quiddity in Its Own Essence Is Neither Existent Nor Nonexistent

الفصل الأوّل — في أنّ الماهيّة في حدّ ذاتها لا موجودة ولا لا موجودة

Quiddity (māhiyya), which is “what is said in answer to the question ‘What is it?’,” does not, considered as such and with regard to its own essence, preclude being characterized as existent or nonexistent. It is therefore, in its own essence, neither existent nor nonexistent. This means that neither existence nor nonexistence is included in its own essence, whether as identical with it or as a part of it, although in reality it is invariably characterized by one of them, in the manner of being characterized by an attribute extrinsic to the essence. In other words, quiddity is neither existent nor nonexistent by primary predication, although by common predication it is either existent or nonexistent. This is what they mean when they say: “The exclusion of existence and nonexistence from quiddity considered as such is the exclusion of two contradictories from a particular level. This is not impossible; what is impossible is their exclusion from reality absolutely and at all its levels.” Their meaning is that the contradictory of existence included in the essence is not nonexistence included in the essence. Rather, it is the negation of existence included in the essence: “included in the essence,” which specifies the level, qualifies the existence, not its negation. That is, it is the negation of what is qualified, not a qualified negation.

For this reason they say: “If a question is asked about quiddity considered as such in terms of the two sides of a contradiction, both sides must be denied in the answer, with the negation placed before the qualification ‘considered as such,’ so that the answer expresses the negation of what is qualified, not a qualified negation.

“Thus, if one asks, ‘Is quiddity considered as such existent, or is it not existent?,’ the answer is: ‘It is not the case that quiddity considered as such is existent, nor that it is nonexistent.’ This expresses the fact that neither existence nor nonexistence is included in quiddity’s own essence.”

All other opposed meanings that have the force of contradictories resemble existence and nonexistence in being extrinsic to quiddity considered as such, even those counted among the inseparable concomitants of quiddities. Thus quiddity considered as such is neither one nor many, neither universal nor particular, nor either member of any other such pair of opposites. Four considered as such is neither even nor odd.

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1. **translation:** “In its own essence” renders fī ḥadd dhātihā. The passage distinguishes denying that a predicate belongs to that essential level from denying the predicate absolutely; the placement of negation in the translated answer makes this scope explicit.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 91–92 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=91&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Chapter Two: The Ways in Which Quiddity Is Considered

الفصل الثاني — في إعتبارات الماهية

Quiddity admits of three ways of being considered in relation to the particular features that accompany it: it may be taken subject to the condition of something, subject to the condition of exclusion, or without condition. This division is exhaustive.

The first consists in taking quiddity as accompanied by the particular features that attach to it, so that it is true of the whole. An example is taking the quiddity of human being subject to its being together with Zayd’s particular features, so that it is true of him.

The second consists in taking it alone. This is done in two ways. In one, consideration is confined to its essence, disregarding everything else. This is what is meant by “subject to the condition of exclusion” in discussions of quiddity. In the other, it is taken alone in such a way that whatever accompaniment is supposed to accompany it will be additional to it and will not enter into it. It will thus be a subject for the supposed accompaniment and will not be predicated of it.

The third consists in stipulating neither accompaniment nor nonaccompaniment. Rather, quiddity is taken without qualification, unrestricted by either negation or affirmation.

Quiddity subject to the condition of something is called “mixed”; quiddity subject to the condition of exclusion is called “abstracted”; and quiddity without condition is called “unrestricted.”

What is divided into these three divisions is quiddity itself. It is the natural universal and is called “the unconditioned as the subject of division.” It exists externally, since some of its divisions, such as the mixed, exist externally.

What exists of the universal in each individual is numerically different from what exists of it in another individual.

If what existed of it in the external individuals were numerically one, the very same one would be many, which is impossible; and the one would possess opposed attributes, which is impossible.

This is the meaning of their statement: “The relation of quiddity to its individuals is like the relation of many fathers to their children, rather than the relation of one father to his many children.”

Quiddity is therefore multiple externally through the multiplicity of its individuals. In the mind, however, it is one under the description of universality and commonality, as will be explained.

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1. **translation:** The three considerations are bi-sharṭ shayʾ, bi-sharṭ lā, and lā bi-sharṭ. The last must be distinguished from lā bi-sharṭ maqsamī, the unconditioned quiddity that is itself the subject divided into all three considerations.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 92–94 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=92&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Chapter Three: The Universal and the Particular

الفصل الثالث — في الكلّيّ والجزئي

There is no doubt that a quiddity with many individuals is true of each of its individuals and is predicated of it. This means that whenever an individual of the quiddity occurs in the mind and is presented to the quiddity there, the quiddity is united with it and is that individual. This property is called universality, and it is what is meant by the individuals’ sharing the quiddity. Considering quiddity in itself, the intellect does not refuse to allow it to be true of many, whether or not it has many individuals externally.

Universality is thus a mental property that accrues to quiddity in the mind. External, concrete existence is coextensive with individuality and precludes being shared. Universality is therefore among the concomitants of the mental existence of quiddity, just as particularity and individuality are among the concomitants of its external existence.

It has been said: “Universality and particularity concern the manner of apprehension. Through the strength of its apprehension, sense grasps a thing completely, so that it is distinguished absolutely from everything else and is individuated. Through the weakness of its apprehension, the intellect grasps it faintly, so that what it grasps is indeterminate among several things and can apply to many. It is like a figure seen from afar that is not distinguished completely, so that it is uncertain, for example, whether it is Zayd, ʿAmr, a piece of wood set upright, or something else, although it is only one of these possibilities. It is also like a worn dirham that is indeterminate among different dirhams, although it is only one of them.”

This is unsound. If things were so, the instance of quiddity would in reality be only one of its individuals, and universal propositions would be false, such as “Every possible existent has a cause,” “Every four is even,” and “Every multiplicity is composed of units.” Self-evident judgment rejects this. The truth, then, is that universality and particularity are concomitants of the existence of quiddities: universality belongs to their mental existence, and particularity to their external existence.

It has likewise been said: “The quiddity existing in the mind is particular and individual, just like the quiddity existing externally, since it exists in a particular mind and subsists in a particular soul. Thus the human quiddity existing in Zayd’s mind, for example, differs from the human quiddity existing in ʿAmr’s mind; and what exists of it in Zayd’s mind today differs from what existed in his mind yesterday; and so on.”

This too is unsound. Under the aspect mentioned—that is, its subsisting in and qualifying a particular soul, and likewise its being one of the soul’s qualities and a perfection of it—the intelligible quiddity is one of the external existents that fall outside our discussion. We are discussing quiddity with its mental existence, in which its external effects do not follow from it. Under this aspect, it does not resist being true of many.

Things that share a universal meaning are distinguished from one another in one of three ways. If they share only an accidental feature that lies outside their essence, they are distinguished by their entire essence, as are two species belonging to two different accidental categories that share the property of being accidents. If they share an essential feature, then, if they share part of the essence—which must be the genus—they are distinguished by another part, namely the differentia. An example is human being and horse, which share animality and are distinguished by rationality and neighing. If they share the entire essence, they are distinguished by a separable accidental feature. For if it were inseparable, no individual would lack it, since a concomitant of the species is a concomitant of all its individuals.

Some have added to these three divisions a fourth: distinction through completeness and deficiency, intensity and weakness, within the very nature that is shared. This is gradation. The truth is that quiddity as such does not admit of gradation; gradation pertains only to existence.

All of this concerns universality and its being a mental property of quiddity. As for particularity, which is the impossibility of a thing’s being shared and is also called individuality, the truth is that it is through existence, as al-Fārābī—may God have mercy on him—held, and as Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may God have mercy on him—held after him.

He says in the Asfār: “The truth is that a thing’s individuation—in the sense that, by the very conception of it, it cannot be shared—is only through something additional to quiddity that, by its own essence, precludes the conception of its being shared.

“What individuates a thing—in the sense of that through which it becomes incapable of being shared—is in reality nothing other than that thing’s existence itself, as the Second Teacher held. Every existence is individuated through its own essence. If the particular mode of a thing’s existence is disregarded, the intellect does not refuse to allow it to be shared, even if a thousand specifying features are added to it. For distinction in reality differs from individuation: the former belongs to a thing in comparison with those things that share something general with it, whereas the latter belongs to it considered in itself. Indeed, if it had nothing sharing something with it, it would not need an additional distinguishing feature, even though it would possess individuation in itself. It is not implausible that distinction should bring about a thing’s preparedness for individuation. For, in the case of a material species dispersed among individuals, unless matter has acquired a disposition specifically for one of them, that individual’s existence does not emanate from the highest principle.” End of quotation.

From this it becomes clear, first, that the individuating accidents to which they have attributed individuation are signs and concomitants of individuation. These accidents are all accidents, as some people’s words apparently indicate; specifically position, when, and where, as others have expressly stated; or specifically time, as still others have maintained. The same applies to the view that matter individuates.

Second, there is some correctness in the statement of some that “What individuates a thing is its proximate agent, which bestows its existence”; in the statement of others that “What individuates is the agent of all things, namely the Necessary Existent—exalted is He—who bestows every existence”; and in the statement of others that “An accident is individuated through its subject.”

Nevertheless, this is an attribution to a remote cause. The proximate cause on which individuation depends is the existence of the thing itself. For a thing’s concrete existence, insofar as it is concrete existence, cannot be shared. It is thus individuated through its own essence, and quiddity is individuated through it. The agent or subject has a role in individuation insofar as each is among the causes of existence, but the nearest cause is the existence of the thing itself, as you have learned.

Third, the particularity of an object known through sensation does not arise from the object itself insofar as it is a mental concept. It arises, rather, from sensory contact with what is external and from the person’s knowledge that this is a kind of being affected by the external concrete thing.

Likewise, the particularity of an image in imagination arises from its connection with sense: for example, when someone brings to mind an image stored from sensation, or combines the stored sensory images that he possesses into an image of an imaginary individual. Understand this.

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1. **translation:** “When” and “where” render the technical category names matā and ayna; “position” renders waḍʿ. The quoted “Second Teacher” is al-Fārābī, whose position the preceding sentence identifies.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 94–98 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=94&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Chapter Four: Essential and Accidental Predicates

الفصل الرابع — في الذّاتيّ والعرضيّ

The concepts taken into account in quiddities—those included in their definitions, with whose removal the quiddities themselves are removed—are called “essential predicates.”

Other concepts predicated of them, which fall outside their definitions, such as “writer” in relation to the human being and “walking” in relation to animal, are called “accidental predicates.”

An accidental predicate is of two kinds. If its abstraction and predication depend upon the conjunction of something with the subject, as the abstraction of “hot” and its predication of a body depend upon the conjunction of heat with that body, it is called “a predicate through an added attribute” (maḥmūl bi-l-ḍamīma). If they do not depend upon the conjunction of anything with the subject, it is called “an extrinsic predicate” (al-khārij al-maḥmūl), such as “higher” and “lower.”

This is the well-known account. It has already been established that an accident is one of the degrees of the existence of substance.

An essential predicate is distinguished from what is not essential by its properties, which are consequences of its being essential. These are that it necessarily belongs to that of which it is an essential predicate, because a thing necessarily belongs to itself; that it has no need of a cause, since the cause that brings into existence that of which it is an essential predicate is itself the cause that brings the essential predicate into existence, owing to their identity; and that it precedes that of which it is an essential predicate by priority in substantial constitution, as will be explained, God willing.

It is clear from what has preceded that the predication between an essence and its essential parts is primary predication.

This removes the objection to the priority of the parts of a quiddity over the quiddity itself: the sum of the parts is identical with the whole, so the priority of the sum over the whole would be the priority of a thing over itself, which is impossible.

The reason is that an essential predicate, whether more general, namely the genus, or more specific, namely the differentia, is identical with the essence, and the predication between them is primary predication. It is called a “part” only because it occurs as a part of the definition.

Moreover, the objection to the priority of the parts over the whole is answered by saying that the priority belongs to all the parts, considered severally, over the whole; the two considerations are different.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 98–99 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=98&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Chapter Five: Genus, Differentia, Species, and Some Related Matters

الفصل الخامس — في الجنس والفصل والنوع وبعض ما يلحق بذلك

A complete quiddity having its own real effects is called a “species” insofar as it is such, for example, human being, horse, and sheep.

It has been explained in logic that some of the essential meanings of species included in their definitions are shared by more than one species, such as animal, which is shared by human being, horse, and others. Other such meanings belong exclusively to one species, such as rational, which belongs exclusively to human being. The shared part is called a “genus,” and the exclusive part is called a “differentia.”

Genus and differentia are divided into proximate and remote. Genus and species are also divided into highest, intermediate, and lowest. All of this is explained in its proper place.

Now, if we take, for example, the meaning of animal found in more than one species and conceive it as a substance that is a body, grows, senses, and moves voluntarily, we may conceive it on its own, so that every meaning accompanying it, such as rational, is additional to it and outside its essence. The meaning we have conceived will then be different from the combination of it and its accompaniment, and will not be predicated of that combination, just as it will not be predicated of the accompaniment.

Thus the conceived concept of animal is other than the concept of rational animal and other than the concept of rational. The meaning conceived in this way is matter in relation to the additional meaning accompanying it, and a material cause in relation to the combination of it and its

accompaniment.

We may also conceive it in relation to a number of species that share it. For example, we may conceive the meaning of animal just mentioned as the animal that is either a human being, a horse, a sheep, or some other species of animal. The meaning conceived in this way will be an incomplete quiddity, lacking determination until the differentia exclusive to one of those species is conjoined with it and determines it as a complete quiddity, so that it becomes that very species. Thus, for example, the human differentia, rational, may be conjoined with animal, so that animal is identical with rational, and is the human species. The shared essential meaning taken under this consideration is called a “genus,” and that which determines it is called a “differentia.”

The two considerations just mentioned that apply to the shared part—taking it with the condition of exclusion and taking it without a condition—also apply to the exclusive part.

Under the first consideration, it is a form for the other, accompanying part, and a formal cause of the combination; it is not predicated of any of these. Under the second consideration, it is a differentia that determines the genus and completes the species, and is predicated of the species by primary predication.

It follows that the more general part in quiddities, namely the genus, is constituted by the more specific part, namely the differentia, according to intellectual analysis.

On the manner in which a genus is constituted by a differentia, the Asfār states: “This constitution is not in external existence, since the two are united in existence, and when two things are united within a given domain, one cannot constitute the other in existence there. Rather, it is according to the intellect’s analysis of the specific quiddity into two intellectual parts and its judgment that one is a cause of the other. For the parts of a single quiddity necessarily need one another, and the part needed, which is the cause, can only be the differentia. It is impossible for the generic part to be a cause of the existence of the differential part; otherwise opposed differentiae would be its concomitants, so that one and the same thing would be diverse and opposed to itself. This is impossible.

“It therefore remains that the differential part is a cause of the existence of the generic part. It divides the unrestricted generic nature, is a cause of the portion that constitutes the species’ share of that nature, and is a part of the combination resulting from that portion and from what distinguishes it from other things.” Here the quotation ends.

If it is said: “If the differentia is a cause of the unrestricted genus, it does not divide it. But if it is a cause of the share within its own species, which belongs exclusively to that species, the specialization must first be supposed, so that the differentia can be a cause of that specialized

share. Yet once it has become specialized, it has entered existence and thereby has no further need of a cause.”

The reply is that the specificity by which the indeterminate genus becomes a share exclusive to the species is one of the features of its existential determination, which comes to it from its cause, namely the differentia. A cause precedes its effect in existence. The specialization is therefore obtained through the differentia, and through it the genus, which lacks such specialization in itself, is divided.

There is no difficulty in several differentiae being causes of a single generic quiddity, owing to the weakness of its unity.

If it is said: “The determination by which a genus enters existence is its determination through individual existence. Until it is invested with external existence, it is not complete and has none of the features of existence. What, then, is meant by counting the differentia as a cause of it?”

The reply is that its determination through the differentia means its establishment in intellectual conception and its becoming a complete specific quiddity. What it acquires through individual existence is the realization of that complete quiddity in such a way that external effects follow from it.

What the differentia confers, therefore, is the determination of the indeterminate generic quiddity and its becoming a complete specific quiddity. What individual existence confers is the determination of the complete quiddity and its becoming an external reality from which effects follow.

The foregoing makes the following points clear.

First, the genus is the species in an indeterminate manner, and the differentia is the species in a determinate manner. The species is the complete quiddity, without regard to indeterminacy or determination.

Second, both the genus and the differentia are predicated of the species by primary predication. As for the relation between the genus and the differentia themselves, the genus is a general accident of the differentia, and the differentia is a specific property of the genus. Predication between them is common predication.

Third, it is impossible for more than one genus to be realized at the same level in a single specific quiddity, or for more than one differentia to be realized at the same level in a single specific quiddity. This would entail that one and the same thing is many, which is impossible.

Fourth, genus and matter are identical in essence and differ in consideration. When matter is taken without a condition, it is a “genus”; when a genus is taken with the condition of exclusion, it is “matter.” Likewise, differentia and form are identical in essence and differ in consideration. A differentia taken with the condition of exclusion is a form, just as a form taken without a condition is a differentia.

This is evident in composite material substances. Matter and form exist externally in them, and from these the meanings of matter and form are taken. These meanings are then taken without a condition and become genus and differentia.

Accidents, however, are externally simple and are not composed of matter and form. That by which they share something in common is identical with that by which they are distinguished.

But the intellect finds common and exclusive features in them and considers these as their genera and differentiae. It then considers them with the condition of exclusion, whereupon they become their intellectual matters and forms.

The same account also applies to immaterial substances.

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1. **translation:** “With the condition of exclusion” renders bi-sharṭ lā, and “without a condition” renders lā bi-sharṭ. Here “specific” means pertaining to a species; the “specific property” (khāṣṣa) is the logical proprium.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 99–103 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=99&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Chapter Six: Some Matters Concerning the Differentia

الفصل السادس — في بعض ما يرجع إلى الفصل

The philosophers use the term “differentia” in two senses.

The first is the most specific and best known of the concomitants that accrue to a species. Such a concomitant is counted as a differentia and placed in definitions in the position of real differentiae only because it is difficult to obtain the real differentiae that constitute species, or because the language contains no name that denotes them by complete correspondence. An example is “rational” (nāṭiq), taken as the differentia of the human being. What is meant by nuṭq is either speaking, which in one respect belongs to audible qualities, or apprehending universals, which they class among qualities of the soul. Quality of whatever kind is an accident, and accidents do not constitute substances. This is called a “logical differentia.”

The second is that which really constitutes the species and determines the genus. It is the principle of the logical differentia, as when the human being's possessing a rational soul is taken as the differentia of the human species. This is called a "derivational differentia."

Now, the ultimate differentia is the entire reality of the species, for it determines the genus, making it determinate and completing it as a species. Whatever is included indeterminately in its genera and its other differentiae is included determinately in it.

It follows that the species remains the same species through its differentia, even if some of its genera change. For this reason, in material composites, if its form—which is the differentia taken with the condition of exclusion—becomes separate from matter—which is the genus taken with the condition of exclusion—the reality of the species is preserved through the form. An example is the human being, whose soul becomes immaterial and separates from the body.

Furthermore, the differentia does not fall under the genus that it determines: that is, the genus is not included in its definition as a genus is included in a species. Thus the differentiae of substances are not substances.

For if a differentia fell under its genus, it would need a differentia to constitute it. We would then transfer the argument to that differentia, and a regress would follow through a series of infinitely many differentiae. Infinitely many species would be realized in each differentia, and the genus would be repeated as many times as there are differentiae. Clear reason rejects this.

Moreover, the relation between genus and differentia would become identity, and predication between them would be primary predication. It would cease to be the case that the genus is a general accident of the differentia and that the differentia is a specific property of the genus.

This does not conflict with the occurrence of predication between a genus and the differentia that divides it, as when we say, "Every rational being is an animal," and, "Some animal is rational." This is common predication between a specific property and a general accident, as was indicated earlier. What we have denied is primary predication.

For example, substance is true of the differentiae that divide it, without their falling under it in such a way that it becomes part of their quiddity.

If you say: "The foregoing denial that the differentia of a species falls under its genus conflicts with the philosophers' statement, when dividing substance into intellect, soul, prime matter, corporeal form, and body, that corporeal form and soul are two species of substance. A thing's being a species of a category entails its being subsumed and included under that category.

“It is well known that corporeal form is the differentia of body taken with the condition of exclusion. Its being a species of substance therefore involves a substantial differentia’s falling under the genus substance, and substance’s being included in its definition.

“A similar account applies to their counting the soul as a species of substance. Moreover, they have demonstrated that the human soul is an immaterial substance that remains after separation from the body. The rational soul is the form of the human being; and this very same soul, taken without a condition, is the differentia of human quiddity.”

I reply: The judgment concerning concepts differs with the intellectual consideration applied to them. In the discussion of existence for itself and existence for another, it was explained that existence in itself is that from which a thing’s quiddity is abstracted.

But from considering its existence for something, no quiddity is abstracted, even though its existence for another is identical with its existence in itself.

The differentia is a concept relative to the genus. Its aspect is that it is an essential distinguishing principle of the species, whose existence is for the genus. It therefore has no quiddity insofar as it is a differentia.

This is the meaning of their statement: “That the genus is a general accident of the differentia, and the differentia a specific property of it, entails that the differentiae of substances are not substances in the sense of falling under the meaning of substance as species fall under their genus. Rather, they fall under it as things having a concomitant fall under that concomitant, which does not enter into their quiddity.”

As for form insofar as it is a form constituting matter, since it is taken with the condition of exclusion in relation to matter, there is no primary predication between them. It therefore does not fall under the genus. Otherwise, it would be a species between which and the genus there is identity and primary predication. This contradicts the supposition. Nevertheless, there is common predication between it and matter, on the view that the composition of matter and form is a composition by union.

Certainly, since form is the entire quiddity of the species—as they define it, that through which a thing is actually what it is—the differentiae of substances are substances, because they are identical with the reality and actuality of the species. But this does not require their falling under the genus substance in such a way that substance is included in their definition and there is primary predication between it and them.

It is thus clear from the foregoing that differentiae insofar as they are differentiae are simple, not composed of genus and differentia. They are purely essential distinguishing principles. Likewise, material forms, which are material in their essence and exist for matter, are externally simple, not composed of matter and form, and intellectually simple, not composed of genus and differentia. Otherwise, each one would be an infinite series of species, as was indicated earlier.

As for the immaterial soul, insofar as it is a differentia of the species, its aspect is that of attributive existence. You have learned that attributive existence has no quiddity. But insofar as the soul is immaterial in its essence, its immateriality makes possible its existence for itself, just as it exists in itself. It is the entire reality of the species, and substance is therefore true of it. It is thus the substantial species of which it was a formal part, and it is not a form. This does not conflict with its existence also being for matter: that dependence belongs only to the level of action, not to the essence. It is material in its action, not in its essence.

This is according to the view that the immaterial soul is spiritual in its origination and its subsistence, as the Peripatetics maintain. According to the view that it is corporeal in its origination and spiritual in its subsistence, it first becomes immaterial in its essence while still being connected with matter in its action. It then becomes separate from matter in its action as well, through separation from the body.

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1. **translation:** Nāṭiq is conventionally translated as “rational,” but the argument here explicitly considers both senses of nuṭq: articulate speech and the apprehension of universals. “Derivational differentia” translates faṣl ishtiqāqī, the author’s term here for the real constitutive principle distinguished from the logical differentia.
2. **translation:** “Complete correspondence” renders muṭābaqa, a term for a word’s signifying the whole of the meaning for which it is assigned. “With the condition of exclusion” and “without a condition” retain the renderings of bi-sharṭ lā and lā bi-sharṭ used in the preceding chapter.
3. **translation:** In the sentence about substance’s being true of its differentiae, the negative scope includes the consequence expressed by fa-yakūna: the differentiae are not subsumed under substance in the manner that would make substance a constituent of their quiddity. The later objection and reply explicitly distinguish this from substance’s being truly predicated of them.
4. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 103–107 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=103&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Chapter Seven: Some Properties of Species

الفصل السابع — في بعض أحكام النوع

A species is a complete quiddity that has its own effects in existence.

It is divided into that whose effects follow from it upon nothing further than the external existence that individuates it as an individual, such as the human being. This is called a “real species.” The other division is that whose effects follow from it only upon the addition of a differentia or differentiae. It is therefore a genus in relation to species below it, although it is a species when considered with regard to its complete quiddity. Such are the highest and intermediate species:

body, for example, which is a higher species of substance and then a genus of vegetable and mineral species; and animal, which is an intermediate species of substance and a genus of the human being and the other animal species. This is called a “relative species.”

Now, the parts of a specific quiddity exist externally through one existence, namely the existence of the species. For the predication between each of them and the species is primary predication, and the species exists through one existence. In the mind, however, they differ through indeterminacy and determination. For this reason, each of genus and differentia is accidental to the other, as has been explained.

Hence their statement that, in real composites—that is, material species—there must be poverty and need among the parts, some needing others, so that they become connected and united as one reality. They have counted this as self-evident.

A real composite is distinguished from other composites by real unity. Through the composition of its parts, something else arises beyond them, having a new, distinctive effect beyond the effects of the parts. It is unlike composites existing only by consideration, which have no effect beyond the effects of their parts, such as an army composed of individuals or a house composed of bricks, plaster, and other things.

Hence the preferable view is that the composition of matter and form is a composition by union, not by conjunction, as will be explained, God willing.

Furthermore, some specific quiddities have many individuals, such as species that have some connection with matter: an element, for example, or the human being. Others are confined to a single individual, such as a species immaterial in both essence and action, namely an intellect.

For multiplicity must be either the whole essence of the specific quiddity, a part of that essence, or outside it as either an inseparable or a separable attribute.

On the first three suppositions, it would be impossible for an individual of that quiddity to be realized. Whatever is supposed to be an individual of it would necessarily be multiple. Every multiplicity is composed of units, yet every supposed unit would necessarily be multiple, and every multiplicity is composed of units, and so on. The matter would proceed without end and never reach a unit. No unit would therefore be realized, and so no individual of the quiddity would be realized. Yet it has been supposed to have many individuals. This contradicts the supposition.

On the fourth supposition, multiplicity would be through a separable accident that accrues to the species. Multiplicity is realized through the contrast between its being conjoined with the species and its not being so conjoined. The occurrence of every separable accident depends upon a prior

possibility whose bearer is matter. The species would therefore necessarily be material.

Thus every species having many individuals is material. By contraposition, this becomes: every immaterial species is confined to a single individual. This was what was required.

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1. **translation:** “Specific” means pertaining to a species. “Composition by union” renders tarkīb ittiḥādī, contrasted with tarkīb inḍimāmī, “composition by conjunction.” The distinction concerns real unity, not merely the spatial arrangement of parts.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 107–108 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=107&type=c_fbook

STAGE VI

The Ten Categories

المرحلة السادسة — في المقولات العشر

CHAPTER 0

Stage VI: The Ten Categories — Introduction

مدخل المرحلة

These are the highest genera to which quiddities ultimately resolve through analysis.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 109–109 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=109&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 1

The categories and their number

الفصل الأوّل — في المقولات وعددها

There is no doubt that a contingent existent has a quiddity: its essence, whose relation to existence and nonexistence is equal, and which is stated in answer to “What is it?” Nor is there doubt that these quiddities have common and distinctive constituents—genera and differentiae—and that some genera are more general and others more specific. They may, that is, form an ascending order from the more specific to the more general. This series must therefore terminate in a genus above which there is no further genus. Its proceeding to infinity is impossible, since this would entail that a contingent thing's essence consisted of infinitely many parts. None of these quiddities could then be understood through all its essential constituents. Moreover, considered on condition of exclusion, these genera are external or intellectual matters. Matter is among the causes of constitution, and these are finite, as will be explained, God willing.

It follows that there are highest genera above which no genus stands. These are called “categories.”

From this the following become clear. First, the categories are simple, not composed of genus and differentia. Otherwise there would be a genus higher than them, contrary to the hypothesis.

Second, they differ from one another in the entirety of their simple essences. Otherwise they would share an essential constituent, namely a genus; a genus would then stand above them, contrary to the hypothesis.

Third, a single quiddity cannot fall under more than one category. One and the same thing cannot be both substance and quantity, or both quantity and quality, and similarly in other cases. It follows that any meaning found in more than one category does not itself fall under a category. If it fell under what it is predicated of, it would belong to two mutually disparate genera, or to several such genera, which is impossible. The same holds of concepts predicated of both the Necessary and the contingent, as was indicated earlier.

Fourth, simple quiddities, such as substantial differentiae and an isolated species—if there is such a thing—fall outside the categories. This was explained in the stage on quiddity.

Fifth, the Necessary and the impossible fall outside the categories, since they have no quiddities, whereas categories are generic quiddities.

Most Peripatetics maintain that there are ten categories: substance, quantity, quality, position, where, when, possession, relation, acting, and being acted upon. Their account relies on induction. No demonstration has been established that there is no category above these which is more general than all of them, or more general than some of them.

As for the concepts of quiddity, thing, existent, and the like, which apply to all ten; the concepts of accident, configuration, and state, which apply to the nine other than substance; and relational configuration, which applies to the last seven, called relational accidents: these are general concepts abstracted from their mode of existence and do not belong to the order of quiddity.

A thing's quiddity is its essence, predicated of it in answer to “What is it?” There is no identity except that of an existing thing; a thing's thinghood is its being existent, and what does not exist has no thinghood. A thing's accidentality consists in its existence subsisting in another; its being a configuration or a state is close to this. A thing's relational character consists in its existence being in another, without standing outside that other's existence.

These, then, are concepts abstracted from the mode of existence and predicated of more than one category. They are therefore not categories, as explained above.

Some maintain that there are four categories, reducing the relational categories to one: substance, quantity, quality, and relation. This is refuted by what has already been explained: relation is a nonquiddative concept abstracted from the mode of existence. If the mere generality of a concept

sufficed to make it a category, the categories should be reduced to two, substance and accident, because the concept of accident applies to every category other than substance—or indeed to one category, quiddity or thing.

The Master of Illumination maintains that there are five categories: substance, quantity, quality, relation, and motion. The objection to the preceding view also applies to his. In addition, motion too is a concept abstracted from a mode of existence, namely flowing existence which does not remain fixed and stable. There is therefore no basis for including it among the categories.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 111–114 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=111&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The definition of substance and its being a genus of the quiddities beneath it

الفصل الثاني — في تعريف الجوهر وأنّه جنس لما تحته من الماهيّات

Quiddity divides primarily into a quiddity which, when it exists externally, exists not in a subject independent of it—this is the quiddity of substance—and a quiddity which, when it exists externally, exists in a subject independent of it—these are the nine accidental categories.

Substance, then, is a quiddity which, when it exists externally, exists not in a subject independent of it. This defines substance by an attribute inseparable from its existence; it is not an essential definition composed of genus and differentia, for such a definition has no meaning in the case of a highest genus. Likewise, defining accident as a quiddity which, when it exists externally, exists in a subject independent of it defines the nine accidental categories by an inseparable attribute of their existence; it is not an essential definition at all.

Although not an essential definition, this definition includes everything it should and excludes everything else. “Quiddity” includes quiddities generally and excludes what is necessary in itself, since it is pure existence with no quiddity. The qualification “when it exists externally” indicates that we are defining the quiddity of substance that is substance by common predication. Unless a concept is realized in external existence, it is not a real quiddity with its real effects. This excludes mental substances, which are substances by primary predication. A concept's being predicated of itself is primary predication and does not entail that the concept falls under itself. Qualifying the subject as “independent of it” indicates the definition of a subject through its inseparable attribute: it subsists through itself, that is, exists for itself. Substance therefore exists not in a subject: its existence is not for another, as that of accidents is, but for itself.

It has been said that the qualification of independence is intended to include substantial forms inhering in matter. Although they exist in a subject, their subject is not independent of them but needs them. The objection is that substantial forms are in fact simple quiddities which do not fall under the category of substance and have no genus, as was indicated in the stage on quiddity.

That both divisions—substance and accident—exist externally is, in general, self-evident. Whoever denies the existence of substance unwittingly asserts the substantiality of accidents. Some accidents, such as relational accidents, are unquestionably accidental.

Substance is a genus of the specific quiddities to which it applies, constitutes them, and enters into their definitions. For the dependence of accidental quiddities, in their external existence, upon a subject independent of them entails the existence of a quiddity which is in itself their subject and independent of them. Otherwise the series of dependence would proceed to infinity, and no quiddity would become established. This is evident.

The following argument has also been offered for substance's being a genus of what falls beneath it. That the existence of substance is not in a subject is one attribute common to substantial quiddities, belonging to them inseparably without regard to anything extrinsic. If substance were not their genus, but merely an inseparable attribute of their existence while they were quiddities disparate in their entire essences, a single concept would have to be abstracted from many disparate instances precisely as disparate. This is impossible. These many disparate quiddities must therefore possess one common quiddative constituent whose existential concomitant is their existence not being in a subject.

The objection is that the attribute in question is a meaning abstracted from the kind of existence these substantial quiddities have, not from the quiddities themselves. Likewise, existence in a subject—one attribute inseparable from the nine accidental categories—is one meaning abstracted from the kind of existence all accidents have. If the unity of the attribute abstracted from substances entailed one common quiddative constituent in substantial quiddities, the unity of the attribute abstracted from the accidental categories would likewise entail one common quiddative constituent in them, serving as their genus. Quiddities would then terminate in two categories, substance and accident.

What establishes substance's being a genus of the quiddities beneath it is therefore the earlier argument: an accident's need for a subject in which to subsist entails a quiddity subsisting through itself.

It follows from the foregoing that a single thing cannot be both substance and accident. It suffices to observe that substance exists not in a subject, while accident exists in a subject. These two attributes plainly cannot combine in one thing.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 114–117 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=114&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The primary divisions of substance

الفصل الثالث — في أقسام الجوهر الأوّليّة

They say: substance either is in a substrate or is not. What is in a substrate is material form. What is not in a substrate either is a substrate for something subsisting in it or is not. The former is prime matter. The latter either is composed of prime matter and form or is not. The former is body. The latter either has, in some respect, a receptive connection with body or has none. The former is soul, the latter intellect. The primary divisions of substance are therefore five: material form, prime matter, body, soul, and intellect.

This is not an intellectual division turning upon affirmation and negation. A substance composed of an inhering substance and a substance serving as substrate is not, as a matter of intellectual possibility, confined to body. It is possible that existence includes a material substance composed of matter and a form other than corporeal form. Their restriction of the primary material species to body rests instead upon their induction. Moreover, you have already learned that substantial form does not fall under the category of substance, although “substance” applies to it as an extrinsic concomitant.

After referring to this division, the author of the Asfār says: “The better way to state the division is this: if substance admits the three dimensions, it is body. Otherwise, if it is a part of body through which body is actual, whether in its genus or in its species, it is form, either dimensional or natural. If it is a part through which body is potential, it is matter. If it is not a part of body, then, if it directly governs body, it is soul; otherwise it is intellect.”

He then indicates why this division is better: “This is because it will emerge throughout our investigations that human psychic substance is matter for the cognitive form through which it becomes another, actually perfected substance, belonging to determinate species with another mode of existence than the natural existence belonging to these determinate natural species.” End of quotation.

The objection to the former division applies equally to this one. Moreover, coordinating natural forms—which are subsequent to body's specific constitution—with dimensional form does not fit the division's being primary.

In any event, what concerns us here is to investigate the reality of body and of its two parts, matter and corporeal form. A complete investigation of soul belongs to psychology. Its reality will become partially clear in the two stages on potentiality and actuality, and on intellect and intelligible. The reality of intellect is discussed in theology in the narrower sense. It too will become partially clear in the stages on potentiality and actuality, and on intellect and intelligible, God willing.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 117–118 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=117&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The quiddity of body

الفصل الرابع — في ماهيّة الجسم

There is no doubt that body exists, in the sense of a substance in which three lines intersecting at right angles can be posited, even if they are not actually present in it, as in a sphere or a cylinder.

Although our senses, to which our knowledge ultimately leads, include none that apprehends a substantial existent, and apprehend only the states and accidental attributes of bodies, the various kinds of experience guide us conclusively to the fact that what lies between the surfaces and limits of bodies is, in general, filled: it is not empty of a substance extended in its three dimensions.

What sense finds of this substance extended in three dimensions, it finds as a single continuum capable of division into actual parts, not as a collection of actual parts separated by gaps. This is how matters stand for sense. As to how they stand in reality, different views have been maintained.

The first holds that body is composed of parts that have position but are altogether indivisible: they cannot be divided externally, in imagination, or intellectually. These parts are finite in number. This is the position of the majority of the theologians.

The second holds, like the first, that body is composite, but that its parts are infinite in number. It is attributed to al-Naẓẓām.

The third holds that body is composed of actual, finite, small, solid parts. Their smallness and solidity prevent external division, although they admit division in imagination and intellect. This is attributed to Democritus.

The fourth holds that body is a single continuum, as it appears to sense, and admits division into a finite number of parts. This is attributed to al-Shahrastānī.

The fifth holds that body is a simple substance consisting in substantial continuity and extension, which admits division externally, in imagination, and intellectually. This is attributed to the divine Plato.

The sixth holds that body is composed of a substance and an accident: substance and mathematical corporeality, which is quantitative extension in three dimensions. This is attributed to the Master of Illumination.

The seventh holds that body is a substance composed of two substances. One is matter, which is the potentiality for every actuality; the other is substantial continuity, which is its form. The form is a substantial continuity and extension admitting division into infinitely many parts in the sense that division never comes to a halt. A difference between two accidents divides it, and a cutting instrument likewise divides it by cutting. When the instrument becomes ineffective owing to the smallness or solidity of the part, imagination takes up the division; when imagination becomes unable to continue because of the extreme smallness of the part, intellect divides it in a universal manner: whenever it is divided into parts, the new part has a volume, with one side distinct from another, and admits division without this process coming to a halt. Thus the occurrence of division does not annihilate body. This is the position of Aristotle and the great masters among the philosophers of Islam.

These are the views that have reached us concerning the quiddity of the substance called body. Each has one or more weaknesses, to which we shall point as far as possible.

As for the first view, attributed to the theologians—that body is composed of altogether indivisible parts, finite in number and capable of being indicated by sense, with a cutting instrument passing through the gaps between them—the objection is this. If the supposed part has volume, it necessarily has one side distinct from another, and intellectual division applies to it, even if its extreme smallness makes division externally or in imagination impossible. If it has no volume, its combination with other such parts cannot produce a body possessing volume.

Again, let us suppose an indivisible part between two other such parts. If it prevents the two outer parts from touching, it is divisible, since each outer part meets something of it other than what the other meets. If it does not prevent them from touching, the middle part's existence and nonexistence are equivalent. The same applies to any middle part that may be supposed. Nothing would then obstruct anything else, which is self-evidently false.

Again, let us suppose an indivisible part above two such parts and over their meeting point. If, with all or some of itself, it meets the whole of both, it is divided. If its whole meets only the whole of one of them, it is not over their meeting point, though it was supposed to be there. If, with all or some of itself, it meets something of each, it is divided and both of them are divided as well. Many forms of demonstration against the indivisible part have been presented and are recorded in the philosophers' books.

The second view, attributed to al-Naẓẓām, holds that body is composed of infinitely many indivisible parts. It is subject to the objections directed against the first view, with the additional objection that, if the parts have volume, their infinite number necessarily makes the body formed by their combination infinite in volume. Self-evidence rules this out.

The third view, attributed to Democritus, holds that body is composed of small, solid parts that cannot be divided externally, although division in imagination and intellect is possible. But these parts must be substances with volume, and hence bodies possessing substantial continuity, from which sensible bodies are composed. What this view establishes is therefore that there are primary bodies which are the principles of these sensible bodies. Moreover, it does not establish the denial of prime matter or invalidate body's composition from prime matter and corporeal form. Prime matter will be established in the next chapter. This view thus amounts to establishing corporeal form for the primary bodies which are the principles of sensible bodies and into which the latter ultimately resolve by division.

The fourth view, attributed to al-Shahrastānī, holds that body is a single continuum, as it appears to sense, and admits division into a finite number of parts. It entails that intellectual division comes to a halt, which is self-evidently false.

The fifth view, attributed to Plato, holds that body is a simple substance consisting in substantial continuity and admitting division without end. We deny that body is simple, in view of the forthcoming demonstration of prime matter in body. Furthermore, that body's substantial continuity is precisely what sense apprehends in sensible bodies is itself a question, to be discussed, God willing.

The sixth view, attributed to the Master of Illumination, holds that body is composed of a substance and an accident: matter and mathematical body, which is a species of continuous quantity. First, it is meaningless for an accident to constitute a substance. It also entails the composition of a real quiddity from two categories, substance and quantity, although the categories differ in their entire essences.

Second, quantity is an accident that requires a subject wherever it occurs. The measured extension by which a body's length, breadth, and depth are determined is a quantity requiring a subject in which to inhere. Unless its subject possessed some continuity capable of being qualified by determination, quantity would neither accrue to it nor inhere in it. If we take a quantity of wax and shape it into a sphere, then a cylinder, then a cone, then a cube, and so forth, we find that the shapes change and replace one another, while a continuity of the wax remains preserved through these different, successive shapes.

There are, then, two continuities: an indeterminate continuity not determined in itself, without which there would be no wax; and a determinate continuity and extension whose disappearance does not entail the disappearance of the body of wax. The first is the body's form; the second is an accident that accrues to body. Division accrues to body through this accident. In respect of its intrinsic indeterminate continuity, however, body admits the positing of three dimensions in it.

The Shaykh says in the Healing: “Corporeality in truth is the form of continuity which admits what we have mentioned—the positing of three dimensions. This meaning is other than magnitude and other than mathematical corporeality. Inasmuch as this body has this form, it does not differ from another body by being larger or smaller, nor is it related to it by being equal to it, measured by it, a measure of it, commensurable with it, or incommensurable with it. These belong to body only insofar as it has magnitude and insofar as a part of it measures it. This consideration is other than the consideration of corporeality we have mentioned.” End of quotation.

In general, incorporating accidental quantitative extension into the quiddity of substance—apart from its own invalidity—confuses substantial continuity with the accidental extension that is mathematical body.

The seventh view, attributed to Aristotle, holds that body is composed of prime matter and corporeal form. This form is substantial continuity as apprehended by sense: the character of a thing in which three extensions intersecting at right angles can be posited, admitting division into infinitely many parts. Prime matter will be established below, while corporeal form, which is continuity, has already been explained.

There is no objection to body's being composed of matter and a substantial continuity that admits division without end. There is, however, no demonstration that body's continuity is as sense presents it, for sense is not immune from error.

After precise technical experiments, natural scientists have recently discovered that bodies are composed of atomic parts which possess bulk, with intervals between them many times greater than the extension of their own bulk. Let this view, therefore, be applied to the atomic bodies they

have discovered, which are the principles from which sensible bodies are formed; and let the existence of body in this sense serve as a postulate for us.

If, however, we accept the assertion that “matter”—by which they mean the primary atomic bodies—“can be transformed into energy and is a collection of accumulated quanta of energy,” philosophical investigation would have to take energy as a higher species ordered beneath substance and before body, and then arrange the derivative discussions in a manner appropriate to this arrangement. Let this be pondered.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 119–126 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=119&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The quiddity of matter and the demonstration of its existence

الفصل الخامس — في ماهية المادّة وإثبات وجودها

There is no doubt that body, insofar as it is a substance in which the three dimensions can be posited, is something actual. Insofar as other primary perfections called specific forms, which perfect its substance, and secondary perfections consisting of accidents outside its substance can exist in it, it is something potential.

The aspect of actuality differs from the aspect of potentiality, since actuality is realized only through possession, whereas potentiality accompanies lack.

That which, by its own nature, receives these primary and secondary perfections possible for it and becomes united with them is therefore something other than the continuous form through which it is actual. Substantial continuity, considered precisely as such, is nothing but substantial continuity. The aspect of the potentiality and possibility of subsequent perfections is something outside this continuity and different from it. Besides substantial continuity, then, body has another part whose very nature is the reception of subsequent forms and accidents. This is the part called “hyle” or “matter.”

It has thus become clear that body is a substance composed of two substantial parts: matter, whose being consists in receiving forms having some kind of attachment to body and the accidents attached to them, and corporeal form. Matter is a substance receptive to corporeal forms and accidents, and substantial extension is its form.

It should not be objected: There is no doubt that the forms and accidents that arise subsequently in bodies are preceded by a possibility in their substrate and by its preparedness and readiness for them. The closer the possible thing comes to occurring, the more specific and intense the

preparedness becomes, until, when its preparedness is complete, the possible thing exists through an effusion from the agent. What, then, prevents us from attributing reception to body—that is, substantial continuity—by means of a preparedness inhering in it as an accident, without needing a substantial preparedness and reception that we establish as a part of body? Furthermore, reception and preparedness are accidental concepts subsisting in another and cannot therefore constitute a substantial reality. Moreover, it is self-evident that preparedness ceases when that for which something is prepared becomes actual. If there were a prime matter that was substantial preparedness and reception and a part of body, it would cease with the realization of the possible thing for which it was prepared. Body would then cease with the cessation of its part and be annihilated through its annihilation, contrary to what is self-evident.

The reply is that the difference between body, insofar as it is nothing but substantial continuity, and each specific form prevents it from being the subject of reception and preparedness for that form. Another thing is needed that does not resist being united with each subsequent form. It must be receptive in its own nature to each of them, while the specific preparednesses mediating between it and possible forms are various determinations of the receptivity that belongs to it in its own nature. The relation of these diverse, determinate preparednesses to matter's intrinsically indeterminate preparedness is like that of mathematical bodies and quantitative extensions, which are determinations of substantial extension and continuity, to substantial continuity itself.

If body, insofar as it is substantial continuity, were the subject of preparedness, then, since body is among the things that originate and are preceded by possibility, it would carry the possibility of itself. It would consequently precede itself in time.

As for the claim that the concept of reception is an accidental meaning subsisting in another, and that it therefore makes no sense to call matter reception in its very essence, thereby making reception a substance: the answer is that this is an inquiry into reality. In inquiries into reality we follow demonstration, not words with their lexical concepts and customary meanings.

Nor is there any difficulty in preparedness ceasing when that for which something is prepared and has potentiality actually comes to be. Matter is, in its own nature, the potentiality for everything without any one of those things being determined. The determination of this potentiality, which entails a determination of its object, is an accident whose subject is matter. When the possible object of potentiality becomes actual, the determinate potentiality and specific preparedness cease, while matter remains as it was: the potentiality for possible forms.

Thus, if by saying that preparedness ceases when the possible thing for which something is prepared becomes actual, the objector means the unrestricted preparedness belonging to matter, the claim is denied. If he means the specific preparedness that is an accident subsisting in matter, it is

conceded; but its cessation does not entail the cessation of matter.

It should not be objected: The argument—that is, establishing matter by the difference between potentiality and actuality—is undermined by the human soul. The soul is simple and immaterial, yet has potential effects, such as the occurrence of volitions and conceptions, and so on. It is actual in its immaterial essence and potential with respect to its secondary perfections. If, despite its simplicity, it can be both actual and potential, then body too should be able to possess actuality and potentiality without being composed of matter and form.

The reply is that the soul is not wholly immaterial in both essence and action. Rather, it is attached to matter in its action. It has actuality insofar as it is immaterial and potentiality insofar as it is attached to matter.

It should not be objected: The argument is undermined by the human soul in another respect. They have stated—and rightly so—that the human intellectual soul is matter for immaterial intelligibles. Although it is immaterial, whenever it intellects an intelligible it becomes that intelligible.

We reply that the immaterial soul's emergence from potentiality into actuality through union with one intellect after another is not a case of motion in the familiar sense of the first perfection of what is potential insofar as it is potential. Otherwise it would entail potentiality, preparedness, change, and time, all of which contradict immateriality, which is complete actuality devoid of potentiality. Rather, calling the soul matter for intelligible forms means that its immaterial existence intensifies, without change or time, through union with an intellectual degree above its own degree of existence, through the bestowal of the higher degree. This is the condition for the bestowal of the degree above that higher degree.

In general, the soul's being matter for immaterial intelligible forms differs in kind from materiality as it is found in the world of bodies. Sufficient evidence is the absence there of the properties of corporeal matter.

It should not be objected: The argument is undermined by matter itself. In itself it is an actually existing substance, and it has the potentiality to receive things. It must therefore be composed of a form through which it is actual and a matter through which it is potential. We transfer the argument to the matter of matter, and so on, producing an infinite regress. This shows that containing potentiality and actuality does not entail composition in body.

The reply, as the Master answered, is that matter contains potentiality and actuality, but its potentiality is identical with its actuality and its actuality identical with its potentiality. In its own nature it is the pure potentiality for things. It has no actuality except the actuality of being the potentiality for things.

It should not be objected: The argument is undermined by intellect. It acts upon what is beneath it and is affected by what is above it. It therefore has two aspects, action and being acted upon. On your account it must consequently be composed of matter and form, acting through form and being acted upon through matter.

The reply is that being acted upon and reception there differ from the being acted upon and reception under discussion in bodies. An intellect’s being acted upon and receiving existence from what is above it amount to nothing but its existence being bestowed upon it, without a preceding potentiality and preparedness bringing its subject closer to actuality. It is only the intellect that posits for an intellect a quiddity and considers that quiddity receptive to existence and nonexistence, thereby considering its investiture with existence to be reception and being acted upon. “Reception,” like “being acted upon,” is thus shared by the two meanings. What entails composition is reception in the sense of preceding preparedness and potentiality, not reception in the sense of the bestowal of existence. An intellect acts through precisely that through which it receives and is acted upon.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 126–130 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=126&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

Matter does not exist apart from corporeal form, nor corporeal form apart from matter

الفصل السادس — في أنّ المادّة لا تفارق الجسميّة والجسميّة لا تفارق — المادّة أي أنّ كلّ واحدة منهما لا تفارق صاحبتها

Matter cannot be stripped of form because, in its very essence and substance, it is the potentiality for things. Its only share of actuality is the actuality of having no actuality. Existence necessarily accompanies actuality as opposed to potentiality. In its existence, therefore, matter needs an actual existent with determinate existence, with which it unites and through whose determinacy it becomes determinate. This is what is called “form.”

Furthermore, were matter to exist apart from form, it would possess actuality in its existence, although it is sheer potentiality for things. Two incompatible features would thus be combined in a single essence, which is impossible.

Since matter's existence is constituted by the existence of form, form has an aspect of agency in relation to it. Its agency is not complete, however, because forms succeed one another in matter, whereas a single effect can have only a single cause. Matter consequently has an agent higher in

existence than matter and material things, which produces matter and preserves its existence through the union with it of one form after another. Form is thus a partner in the cause of matter.

One should not object: “According to them, matter is numerically one, whereas some form or other is one universally. What is numerically one is stronger in existence than what is universally one. If some form or other causes matter, what is stronger in existence must therefore be an effect of what is weaker, which is impossible.”

The reply is that, although matter is numerically one, its unity is indeterminate and weak because its existence is indeterminate and it is sheer potentiality. The unity of form, which is a partner in the cause that is the separate existent, is supported by the unity of that separate existent.

The separate existent's sustaining and preserving matter by means of some form or other is like preserving a roof from collapse by erecting one support after another.

In the discussions of substantial motion, God willing, what reveals the true situation concerning the multiplicity of these forms succeeding one another in matter will be presented.

What has preceded shows that every actuality and determinacy that occurs to matter comes through the actuality of form, since matter's determinacy comes through the determinacy of form. It also shows that form is a partner in the cause of matter, and that form is prior to matter in existence, although matter is prior to form in time.

As for corporeal form's not being stripped of matter: any body whatsoever has separable accidents that successively occur to it—various motions, quantities, qualities, places, positions, and so forth—and specific forms that succeed one another in it. All these depend on a prior possibility and preparedness whose bearer can only be matter. No body, therefore, exists except in matter.

Furthermore, body, insofar as it is a substance admitting the three dimensions, is a single, complete specific nature, even though there are species beneath it. It is unlike the concept of substance, which has only the status of a generic quiddity and has no determination other than the determinations of the species subsumed beneath it.

Since body is a specific nature, it must by its nature and in itself either be independent of matter and have no need of it, or need it. If it were independent in itself, it could not inhere in matter, because inherence is identical with dependence. Yet we find some bodies inhering in matter; hence body is not independent of it. If it depends on matter in itself, the dependence—which is inherence—is established for every body.

One should not object: “Why may it not be independent of matter in itself, while association with matter occurs to some of its individuals through a cause external to its essence, as separable accidents occur to specific natures?”

The reply is that, as indicated, body's association with matter consists in its inherence in matter. In other words, its existence comes to be for matter and to qualify it. Dependence occurring to it through an external cause after it was in itself independent of matter would therefore mean that its existence came to be for another after being for itself. This is necessarily impossible.

Know that although the question is framed in terms of corporeal form's separation from matter, the proof applies to every form to which further perfections can possibly accrue.

The discussion of substantial motion will explain that material substance moves through its forms until it attains sheer actuality with no potentiality. This occurs by putting on one form after another, rather than by stripping off one and putting on another. Accordingly, the impossibility of material form's separation from matter is restricted to the condition of motion; it does not apply once motion has been completed and its goal attained.

This is supported by what the Shaykh and Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn have stated: matter does not enter the definition of body as genera enter the definitions of their species.

The quiddity of body—substance admitting the three dimensions—contains no mention of matter, which is substance in which the potentiality for things resides. By contrast, body, for example, is included in the definition of growing body, growing body in the definition of animal, and animal in the definition of human being.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn explains this by saying that, if matter entered the quiddity of body, its belonging to body would be self-evident, as is characteristic of an essential constituent. Yet initially we doubt whether matter belongs to body, and then establish it by demonstration; there is no demonstration of an essential constituent.

There is no conflict between saying that matter lies outside the quiddity of body and saying that it is united with corporeal form, as necessarily follows from the conjunction of what is potential with what is actual. The unity asserted is a unity in existence, not in quiddity.

It follows that, were some material species to become separate from matter, this would not entail a transformation through a change in definition. Matter is a necessary accompaniment of its existence, not a part of its quiddity.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 130–134 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=130&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Establishing specific forms: the substantial forms that differentiate the substance of body in general into species

الفصل السابع — في إثبات الصور النوعيّة وهي الصور الجوهريّة — المنوِّعة لجوهر الجسم المطلق

We find differences among bodies in respect of concepts that apply to them, whose belonging to them is self-evident and which cannot be separated from them. We cannot conceive a body without conceiving it, for example, as an element, a mineral compound, a tree, an animal, and so on. Body's qualification by these concepts in this manner indicates that they are among its constituents. Since each is more particular than body, they constitute the substance of its essence, and a species of body results through the addition of each to it. Only a substance can constitute a substance. These, therefore, are substantial forms that differentiate body into species.

One should not object: “We do not grant that only a substance can constitute a substance. Frequently something exists and ‘substance’ is predicated of it in answer to ‘What is it?’; then some accident is added, and the answer to the question ‘What is it?’ changes. Iron is a substance, for example, but when a sword is fashioned from it through the addition of accidental configurations, the answer to ‘What is it?’ differs from the answer given when it is iron. Likewise, clay and stone are substances, but when a building is constructed from them, the answer to ‘What is it?’ is ‘a house,’ although only accidental configurations have been added.”

The reply is that this confuses real species, which are real composites whose composition produces a single identity beyond their parts, with effects beyond those of their parts—as with elements and generated natural beings—with composites constituted by consideration, whose combination produces neither anything beyond their parts nor any effect beyond the effects of their parts, such as swords, houses, and other artificial things.

In general, nothing beyond the parts themselves results from a composite constituted by consideration. A composite of substance and accident is neither a substance nor an accident, and so has no quiddity that could answer “What is it?” This is because the categories differ through the entirety of their simple essences; a quiddity cannot be constituted from more than one of them.

Nor should one object: “The claim that specific forms are substances conflicts with their statement that ‘the differentiae of substances are not subsumed under the genus substance.’”

The reply is that this was discussed in the stage on quiddity. It became clear there that the substantiality of the differentiae of substances—which are specific forms taken with the condition of exclusion—means that the genus substance applies to them as a general accident applies to a property. They constitute the species and are accidental to the genus.

Another argument: We find that bodies differ in the effects present in them, including both inseparable and separable accidents. Each body's exclusive possession of its particular effects necessarily requires something that determines that specificity.

This determining factor cannot be their shared corporeality, since it is common to all bodies. Nor can it be their shared matter, whose function is reception and preparedness rather than action and entailment. Nor can it be a separate existent, whose relation to all bodies is equal.

The determining factor also cannot be one of the subsequent accidents, such that one effect is made specific by a preceding effect. For we would transfer the discussion to the preceding effect, producing an infinite regress, a circle, or an endpoint in something not external to the substance of the body possessing the effect. The first two are impossible, leaving the third: the effects depend on something not external to the substance of the body. This must be a constituent of it, and a constituent of substance is a substance.

Since this substantial constituent is more particular than body in general, it is a substantial form that differentiates body into species.

Bodies in their diversity thus possess substantial specific forms that are the principles of effects differing with the differences among species.

One should not object: “The individuals of each corporeal species possess distinctive effects and individuating accidents, such that what belongs to one individual is not found in another. Your argument applies to these as well. Why, then, do you not establish, beyond the forms you have called specific forms, individual forms constituting the species' quiddity?”

The reply is that the accidents called ‘individuating accidents’ are necessary accompaniments of individuation, not what individuates. Individuation comes through existence, as explained in the stage on quiddity. Accidents are individuated through the individuation of their subjects, for there is no sense in an accident being universal while it inheres in an individuated subject. The principle of the actual accidents subsequently attaching to an individual is the specific nature in that individual, which entails a broad range of quantity, quality, position, and other accidents.

External, coincident causes and conditions then specify what the specific nature entails. As these causes and conditions change, the individual passes from one accident with which it is qualified to another of the same species or genus.

Conclusion of the chapter: Since specific form constitutes its secondary matter, namely the body composed of matter and corporeal form, it is an efficient cause of body and prior to it, just as corporeal form is a partner in the cause of prime matter.

Two consequences follow. First, existence belongs primarily to specific form; through its existence corporeal form exists, and then prime matter exists with its actual existence.

Second, specific forms do not preserve a single corporeality until its replacement. Rather, corporeality exists through their existence. When a specific form is replaced by another that differs from it in species, the body ceases with the cessation of that form, and another corporeality then comes to be with the coming-to-be of the subsequent form.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 134–137 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=134&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Quantity, one of the accidental categories

الفصل الثامن — في الكم وهو من المقولات العرضيّة

It has already been explained that an accident is a quiddity which, when it exists in concrete things, exists in a subject independent of it. Accidentality is like a general accident belonging to nine categories, which are highest genera with no genus above them. Accordingly, the definition given for each is a description through a property, rather than a real definition possessing a genus and differentia.

The two masters, al-Fārābī and Ibn Sīnā, defined quantity as “the accident in which, through itself, there can be found one thing that measures it by repetition.” This is the best of the definitions given for it.

The definition “the accident that admits division in itself” has been criticized as defining something through what is more particular than it: susceptibility to division belongs specifically to continuous quantity, whereas discrete quantity already possesses actual parts.

Likewise, the definition “the accident that admits equality” has been criticized as circular, since equality is unity in quantity.

In any case, these definitions contain three properties of quantity: being measured by repetition, divisibility, and equality.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 137–139 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=137&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The divisions of quantity

الفصل التاسع — في انقسامات الكم

Quantity is divided in its primary division into continuous and discrete.

Continuous quantity is quantity in which parts can be supposed that meet at common limits. A common limit is that which can be made the beginning of one part just as it can be made the end of another. Thus, if a line is supposed to be divided into three parts, the middle section can be made the beginning or end of either of the two sides. The two sections then constitute a single section, and the line has two sections. Continuous quantity has also been defined as that which admits division without end.

Discrete quantity is the opposite of continuous quantity. It is number, which results from the repetition of the unit. It is actually divided into parts, with no common limit between them. If five, for example, is divided into two and three, then, were there a common limit belonging to their parts, the result would be four; were the limit additional to them, the result would be six.

Continuous quantity is divided into two: stable and nonstable. Stable quantity is that which is fixed and whose parts are actually present together, as in a surface. Nonstable quantity is that whose supposed parts are not actually present together, as in time. Every actual part of time is a potentiality for the following part, and the two are therefore not actual together, since a thing's actuality does not coexist with its potentiality.

Stable quantity is divided into mathematical body, which admits division in its three directions—breadth, length, and depth; surface, which admits division in two directions—breadth and length; and line, which admits division in one direction.

Discrete quantity, namely number, necessarily exists externally. The existence of nonstable continuous quantity, namely time, will be established in the discussions of potentiality and actuality. As for stable continuous quantity, mathematical body and surface exist externally: there are determinate, finite natural bodies separate from one another. Their determinateness entails mathematical body, and their finitude entails surface. Line exists externally if the existence of bodies with intersecting surfaces, such as the cube, cone, pyramid, and the like, is established.

Every rank in the endless series of numbers is a particular species of number distinct from the others, since each has numerical properties that do not extend beyond it to another. Time is one species, even though the subjects in which it occurs are the several species of substantial and accidental motions, because there is a common measure among its instances.

Mathematical bodies with no common measure, such as the sphere, cone, cube, and the like, are distinct species. The same holds for surfaces with no common measure, such as the plane surface and the kinds of convex and concave surfaces; and likewise for lines with no common measure, if they exist, such as the straight line and the kinds of arcs. Irregular bodies, surfaces, and lines are not species, but composites of various species.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 139–141 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=139&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

Various judgments concerning quantity

الفصل العاشر — في أحكام مختلفة للكم

It was indicated earlier that among the properties of quantity are equality and inequality; division, externally as in number or in the imagination as in other quantities; and the presence within it of a measure that measures it. They have also set out other judgments.

First: discrete quantity, namely number, exists in both material and immaterial things. Nonstable continuous quantity, namely time, exists only in material things. Stable continuous quantity—mathematical body, surface, and line—does not exist in immaterial things except according to those who establish an immaterial realm of magnitude that possesses the effects of matter without matter itself.

Second: there is no contrariety in number. A condition of contrariety is the utmost difference between the contraries, and no two numbers have the utmost difference. For any two supposed ranks of number, adding one to the greater increases its distance from the smaller.

As for the argument that every rank of number is constituted by what lies below it, whereas a contrary is not constituted by its contrary: its difficulty is that, if a rank of number were composed of the lower ranks, those lower ranks would have equal eligibility to constitute it. Ten, for example, can be supposed composed of nine and one, eight and two, seven and three, six and four, or five and five. The determination of some rather than others as its parts would be a preponderance without a determining ground, which is impossible. When mathematicians say that

ten is the sum of eight and two, they mean that one rank of number equals two ranks. They do not mean that the one rank, which is a single species, is identical with the two ranks, which are two species. An analogous argument applies to continuous quantity in general.

Nor is mathematical body contrary to a surface or a line, or a surface contrary to a line. There is no single subject here upon which the two succeed one another, and no utmost difference can be conceived between them.

Third: quantity admits no gradation in intensity and weakness. This is self-evident, or nearly so. It does, however, admit gradation in increase and decrease: one line may be longer than another when compared with it in existence, though not in its possessing the quiddity of line. A surface likewise exceeds or falls short of another surface of its species, as does a mathematical body.

Fourth: they say that dimensions are finite, and offer several arguments. One of the clearest is this. Suppose an infinite line and a sphere from whose center a line extends parallel to that infinite line. If the sphere rotates, the two lines will meet, according to Euclid's postulate. The line extending from the center will thus intersect the supposed infinite line after having been parallel to it. There must, therefore, be a point on the infinite line that is the first point of intersection. But this is impossible, since no point of intersection can be supposed on the line without there being a point farther along it that the rotating line intersects first. Other demonstrations of the impossibility of an infinite dimension have been offered, including the proof by correspondence, the ladder proof, and others.

Fifth: a void is impossible, for it would entail dimension subsisting through itself, without a subject in which it subsists. Discussion of this will come in the inquiry into place.

Sixth: number is not finite. This means that no rank of number exists without a greater one being conceivable, and a still greater one beyond that; the series does not stop until the act of consideration ceases. This infinite is called the indefinitely continuable. At any time, only a finite quantity of the series actually exists, while what exceeds it remains potential.

As for the series actually proceeding to infinity, with infinity understood as an affirmative qualification rather than as a simple negation of a limit, this is unintelligible. There is consequently no whole or totality of the infinite in this sense, and no fractional relation such as a half, a third, or a quarter is realized in it; otherwise it would become finite.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 141–144 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=141&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Quality and its primary division

الفصل الحادي عشر — في الكيف وإنقسامه الأوّلي

They define quality as an accident that, through itself, admits neither division nor relation. “Accident” excludes that which is necessary through itself and excludes substance. The qualification “does not admit division” excludes quantity, while “does not admit relation” excludes the seven relational categories. “Through itself” includes that to which division or relation belongs incidentally.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn says: “Since the categories are highest genera with no genus above them, it is impossible to give them an essential definition. Their proposed definitions are therefore incomplete descriptions, in which mention of properties suffices to distinguish them. No necessary and comprehensive property of quality has been found apart from the combination of its being an accident and its differing from quantity and the relational accidents. It was consequently defined in terms amounting to: ‘An accident different from quantity and the relational accidents.’

“But this defines something through things equal to it in being known or unknown, since none of the highest genera is clearer than another. If this were permissible, its like would be permissible for the other categories—and indeed would be more appropriate there, since relational things are known only after their subjects, namely qualities. They therefore replaced mention of quantity and the relational accidents with mention of the property that is clearer.” This ends the passage in abridgment.

Quality is divided in its primary division into four general classes: sensible qualities, psychic qualities, qualities peculiar to quantities, and dispositional qualities. Their reliance in restricting them to these four is on induction.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 144–146 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=144&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Sensible qualities

الفصل الثاني عشر — في الكيفيّات المحسوسة

One of the properties of sensible qualities is that they act by assimilation—that is, by making another thing resemble themselves. Heat makes what adjoins it hot, and blackness, for example, casts its image, that is, its likeness, upon the eye.

Sensible qualities are divided into visible, audible, gustatory, olfactory, and tangible qualities.

Among visible qualities are colors. The prevalent view is that they are objective qualities existing outside sensation; that their simple kinds are white and black; and that the other colors result from various combinations of these two. It is also said: “The simple colors that are the fundamental ones are five: black, white, red, yellow, and green. The remaining colors are compounded from them.” Another view is: “Color is an imaginative quality with no existence beyond sensation, like the halo, rainbow, and the like. It results from kinds of mixture of air with transparent bodies, or from reflection from them.”

Light is another visible quality. It needs no definition. It is sometimes defined as “that which is manifest through itself and makes other things manifest.” What should be meant here is its making bodies manifest to sight. If making manifest were taken without qualification, that would be a property of existence.

In any case, their familiar doctrine is that light is a visible quality found in bodies luminous through themselves or in a body facing a luminous thing, without its being transferred from the luminous thing to the illuminated one. Darkness is opposed to it as privation is opposed to possession. It has also been said that light is a corporeal substance, and that it is the manifestation of color.

Audible qualities are sounds. Sound is a quality resulting from a forceful striking or a forceful pulling apart, followed by undulation of the air that carries sounds. When the undulation reaches the air adjoining the auditory canal, sound is perceived. Sound is neither the undulation nor the pulling apart or striking itself. Nor is perceived sound an image in sensation with no existence outside sensation.

Gustatory qualities are the tastes apprehended by taste. They have counted nine simple kinds: pungency, saltiness, bitterness, fattiness, sweetness, blandness, acridity, astringency, and sourness. Other tastes are compounded from these.

Olfactory qualities are the kinds of odors perceived by smell. We have no names for the kinds of odors we apprehend by which to identify them, except by relating them to their subjects, as when we say ‘the odor of musk’ or ‘the odor of roses’; by their agreeableness or disagreeableness to our constitution, as when we say ‘a pleasant odor’ or ‘a foul odor’; or by relating them to taste, as when we say ‘a sweet odor’ or ‘a sour odor.’ All this indicates the weakness of human beings in the sense of smell, as the Shaykh mentions.

Tangible qualities are the kinds of qualities perceived by touch. They have counted twelve simple kinds: heat, cold, moisture, dryness, subtlety, density, viscosity, friability, desiccation, wetness, heaviness, and lightness. Some have added roughness, smoothness, hardness, and softness, though

the familiar view is that these are composite.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 146–149 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=146&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

Qualities peculiar to quantities

الفصل الثالث عشر — في الكيفيّات المختصّة بالكميّات

These are qualities that occur in a body through its quantity: quantity is characterized by them first, and the body is then characterized by them on account of its quantity. Examples are circularity in a line and evenness in a number.

Induction yields three divisions: first, shape and angle; second, qualities other than shape and angle, such as circularity and straightness, which occur in lines, surfaces, and mathematical bodies; and third, qualities that occur in number, such as evenness, oddness, being square, being a root, and so forth.

Some have added bodily configuration to these three, intending by it the combination of color and shape. This is refuted by the fact that it does not possess a real unity with a real quiddity; it is instead a composite constituted by consideration. Were it possessed of a quiddity, it would have to fall under both visible qualities and qualities peculiar to quantities. These are two mutually exclusive genera, so that would be impossible.

As for the first division, shape is a configuration that quantity acquires through being completely enclosed by one boundary or several boundaries. Examples are the shape of a circle enclosed by a single line; the shapes of a triangle, square, and polygon enclosed by several boundaries; a sphere enclosed by a single surface; and a cone, cylinder, and cube enclosed by more than one surface.

Shape belongs to qualities because the definition of quality applies to it. It is neither the surface or body, nor the boundaries enclosing it, nor their totality. It is, rather, the configuration arising from a surface or body enclosed by particular boundaries.

An angle is the configuration that arises from incomplete enclosure by two boundaries, or by several boundaries meeting at a boundary. Examples are a plane angle, formed by the enclosure of two lines meeting at a point; a solid angle, formed by the enclosure of the surface of a cone terminating at its vertex; and an angle of a cube, enclosed by three surfaces.

The argument that an angle is a quality rather than a quantity is analogous to the foregoing argument that shape belongs to the category of quality.

The Shaykh allowed that the configuration formed by the enclosure of two surfaces—for example, two surfaces of a cube—meeting at a line is an angle, because the properties of an angle apply to it.

As for the second division, straightness in a line, and circularity which is opposed to it, belong to the category of quality rather than quantity. They differ specifically from one another.

They belong to the category of quality because we apprehend the concepts of straightness and circularity, both of which are self-evident concepts, without finding in them the meaning of divisibility. Divisibility is indeed inseparable from them in existence, since they occur in quantity. Yet if divisibility were part of their definitions, or one of their best-known properties, our apprehension of them would not be devoid of it.

They are two differing and mutually distinct species because, if they were one species, the difference found between them would be accidental, neither part of the essence nor a necessary concomitant of it. It would then be intellectually possible for the characteristic of straightness to cease in a straight line while the line itself remained, and for it subsequently to become characterized by circularity. But that is impossible. A line is the boundary of a surface, just as a surface is the boundary of a body; the condition of a boundary cannot change until the condition of that which it bounds changes. If the condition of the surface with respect to its unfolding and extension did not change, the condition of the line with respect to its straightness would not change. And if the condition of the body with respect to its unfolding and extension did not change, the condition of its surface in this respect would not change. Through such a change the mathematical body perishes and another comes into existence, and likewise the surface that bounds it and the line that bounds that surface. When the subject of an attribute perishes and a numerically different subject comes into existence, the attribute is likewise numerically different.

Since a straight line cannot remain when its straightness ceases, we know that straightness is either its differentia or a necessary concomitant of its differentia. A straight line therefore differs specifically from a circular one. The same is true of a plane surface in relation to other surfaces, and of each of those other surfaces in relation to a surface that differs from it; it is also true of mathematical bodies in relation to those that differ from them.

Two consequences follow. First, there is no contrariety between straightness and circularity: they do not succeed one another in a single subject, nor is there between them the utmost opposition. The same applies between a line and a surface, between a surface and a mathematical body, among surfaces themselves, and among mathematical bodies themselves.

Second, there is no intensification or weakening between straightness and circularity. Gradation requires the more intense to contain the less intense together with something additional, whereas it has become clear that the straight does not contain the circular, or conversely.

As for the third division, it includes the evenness and oddness that occur in number, and likewise being square, being a root, being a cube, and the like.

These are qualities rather than quantities, since the definition of quality applies to them. This is evident when we consider that every rank of number is a species whose specific character is independent and distinct from the others, while sharing divisibility with all the other ranks. Being divisible into two equal parts, or not being so divisible, is an attribute of division that is not itself divisible and is not itself relational. It is therefore neither quantity nor any of the relational accidents. Evenness and oddness can consequently be nothing but qualities occurring in quantity.

A similar explanation applies to the remaining attributes of numbers, such as being square, being a root, and so forth.

Reflection on what has preceded makes three points clear. First, there is no contrariety between these numerical attributes. Evenness and oddness have no shared subject in which they succeed one another, as is required for contrariety.

Second, these numerical attributes admit no gradation by intensity and weakness or by increase and decrease. Just as curvature or circularity does not change into another curvature or circularity unless its subject perishes and a numerically different subject comes into existence, so evenness, for example, does not change into the evenness of an evenly even number unless its subject—the thing numbered—perishes and a numerically different subject comes into existence. In this event the evenness, which is an accident, perishes and a numerically different evenness comes into existence. This has nothing to do with gradation.

Third, recalling what has preceded, we know that qualities peculiar to quantities exist both in material things and in immaterial imaginal beings, on the assumption that the imaginal is immaterial.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 150–153 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=150&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

Dispositional qualities

الفصل الرابع عشر — في الكيفيّات الاستعداديّة

These are also called capacity and incapacity.

The meaning common to them—which has the standing of a species in relation to quality in general and of a genus in relation to their particular species—is an intense bodily preparedness directed toward something external: that is, a preparedness by which the occurrence of something from outside is favored.

They have two species. The first is an intense preparedness to be affected, such as susceptibility to illness and softness. The second is an intense preparedness not to be affected, such as resistance to illness and hardness.

Some have added to these a third species: an intense preparedness for acting, such as aptitude for wrestling.

The Shaykh rejected this, and Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn followed him. He says in the Asfār:

“There is no disagreement that the capacity to be affected and the capacity to resist fall under this kind. As for whether the capacity to act falls under it, the well-known view is that it does. The Shaykh excluded it, and his is the correct position, as the reason for it will become clear to you.

“If one wishes to formulate a meaning common to the two divisions while excluding the third, one should say: it is a quality through which one of the two sides, receptivity and nonreceptivity, is favored in that which receives the quality.

“To show that the capacity to act cannot properly be included under this kind, as the Shaykh maintained, we must first recognize a universal principle: the grounds of action are always necessary concomitants of the essence. Every essence possessing a reality has a demand for an effect: when left to its own nature, with no impediment, it produces that effect. It therefore needs no capacity additional to itself in order to act. If another capacity is supposed to be added to it, then in relation to that capacity the essence is its recipient, rather than its agent. If the essence and the capacity are considered together, their totality is another thing; if it has an action, its action necessarily follows, without a delayed preparedness in it for the occurrence of that action. If such preparedness for agency is posited for it, this would first entail a passive capacity to receive that through which its being an agent becomes complete. The supposed preparedness would thus in reality be for its being affected, rather than for its agency. There is consequently no preparedness for agency: preparedness belongs primarily and intrinsically to being affected, and incidentally to agency.

“From what we have demonstrated it is therefore established that there is intrinsically no capacity or preparedness for a thing's being an agent. Capacity and preparedness are only for being affected, and for a thing to become receptive to something after it had not been so.” End of quotation.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 153–155 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=153&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 15

Psychic qualities

الفصل الخامس عشر — في الكيفيات النفسانية

As for preparedness itself, it has been said: “It belongs to relation, since it is intelligible only between two things, something prepared and that for which it is prepared. Thus it is not a species of quality.” From some writers it appears that it is a quality entailing a relation, like knowledge, which is one of the psychic qualities and entails a relation between its subject …

A psychic quality is, as the Shaykh says, “that which is not connected with bodies in general.” If it is not firmly established, it is called a “state”; if it is firmly established, it is called a “habit.” Since the relation between a state and a habit is that of weakness and intensity, and since they count the two degrees of weakness and intensity as two different species, their position entails counting a state as different from a habit both in species and in existence.

Psychic qualities are numerous. In this discussion they have mentioned only some of those whose investigation is especially relevant.

Among them is will. It is said in the Asfār: “It would appear that its meaning is clear to the intellect and is not confused with anything else, although it is difficult to express it in a way that conveys a conception of its true nature. It differs from appetite, just as its opposite, aversion, differs from repugnance. Hence a person may will something for which he has no appetite, such as drinking an unpleasant medicine that benefits him; and he may have an appetite for something that he does not will, such as eating a delicious food that harms him.” End of quotation. A similar explanation makes it clear that will also differs from the intensified desire by which some have defined it.

A summary that clarifies the will upon which the act of an agent who chooses depends is as follows. Rational principles require that every species of substance be an efficient principle of the acts whose production is attributed to it. These acts are secondary perfections of the species. Thus the human soul, which is an immaterial substantial form whose activity is connected with matter, is the efficient cause of the acts proceeding from a human being. But it is a cognitive principle: nothing proceeds from it unless it has distinguished it, as one of its secondary perfections, from other things. Before acting, therefore, it needs a conception of the act and assent to its being a perfection for it. If this assent is necessary or a firmly established habit, it judges that the act is a perfection and does not undertake deliberation. An example is a speaker who utters one letter after

another without deliberating. If he deliberated over some of them, he would become bewildered and hesitant and would stop speaking. If, however, the assent is not necessary and already settled, the soul resorts to deliberation and to investigating the considerations that favor one course. If it finds something that establishes the act as a perfection, it judges accordingly.

Then, as has been said, this cognitive form is followed by desire for the act, since the act is a secondary perfection caused by the soul. Desire is then followed by will. Although no expression conveys a conception of will's true nature, evidence for its existence after desire is supplied by what we find in someone who wills an act but is unable to perform it and is unaware of his inability: he cannot perform the act, although he has willed it. Will is then followed by the operative power that moves the muscles; it moves the muscles, and this is the act.

The principles of voluntary action in us are therefore knowledge, desire, will, and the operative motive power. This is what we find in ourselves in our voluntary acts. Close consideration of the condition of other animals shows that, in their voluntary acts, they are like human beings.

The following points have thus become clear. First, the efficient principle of a human being's voluntary acts, insofar as they are his secondary perfections, is the human being insofar as he is a cognitive agent. Knowledge completes his agency: by it a perfection is distinguished from other things. Desire follows this knowledge without depending upon another desire or a will; and will necessarily follows desire without depending upon another will, for otherwise wills would regress infinitely. Counting will as the efficient cause of the act is therefore misplaced. Will, and the desire preceding it, are instead concomitants of the knowledge that completes the agent's agency.

Second, those human acts in whose production knowledge has a role are never devoid of the agent's will, even an act performed under coercion. The discussion of the divisions of agent will provide further material useful here.

Third, the criterion of an act's being chosen is that the human being stands in an equal relation to performing it and refraining from it, even though, when considered as complete in agency, he necessarily acts.

Another psychic quality is power. It is a condition in an animal through which an act can proceed from it if it wills, and does not proceed from it if it does not will. Its opposite is inability.

As for the power attributed to the Necessary Existent, exalted is He: since what is necessarily existent through itself is necessarily existent in every respect, His power is His actual being, through His essence, the principle of everything. Since it is identical with the essence, it has no quiddity; rather, it is sheer existence.

Knowledge too is counted, as has been said, among psychic qualities. What is meant is acquired mental knowledge insofar as it inheres in the soul as an accident inheres in its subject, for the definition of quality applies to it. Knowledge by presence, however, is the presence of the known, in its external existence, to the knower; and existence is neither substance nor accident.

The knowledge that belongs to quality is restricted to beings endowed with souls. As for separate immaterial beings, it has already been established that their knowledge is by presence, not acquired. Nevertheless, the acquired cognitions that exist in their effects are present to them, although these cognitions too, insofar as they are their products, are present to them.

Character also belongs here. It is the psychic habit from which acts proceed easily, without deliberation. It is called character only when it constitutes a practical intellect that is a principle of voluntary acts. It is not the power to act, for power bears an equal relation to acting and refraining, whereas character is related only to the act. Nor does “character” mean the act itself, even though the term is sometimes applied to it: character is the firmly established condition upon which the act is based.

Character has many branches, and the subdivisions resulting from them are almost innumerable. But the roots of human character, considered in relation to the powers that impel a human being to act, are three. These are the appetitive powers, which impel him to attract the good and beneficial that suit him; the irascible powers, which impel him to repel the evil and harmful; and the intellect, which guides him toward goodness and happiness and restrains him from evil and misery.

If the habit operative in matters of appetite maintains moderation, by doing what ought to be done in the way it ought to be done, it is called “temperance.” If it deviates toward excess, it is called “voracity”; and if it falls into deficiency, it is called “apathy.” Likewise, the habit associated with anger has a moderate condition called “courage,” an excessive extreme called “recklessness,” and a deficient extreme called “cowardice.” Likewise, if the habit that judges good and evil, benefit and harm, maintains the moderate mean and occupies itself with what ought to be done in the way it ought to be done, it is called “wisdom.” If it moves to the extreme of excess, it is called “cunning,” and if to the extreme of deficiency, “stupidity.”

The disposition resulting from the conjunction of these three habits stands to them as a temperament stands to the things blended to produce it. Its effect is to give each power its due. When this disposition is balanced, it is called “justice”; when it passes to the extreme of excess, it is called “injustice”; and when it passes to the extreme of deficiency, “submission to injustice.”

The moderate mean in these fundamental habits, and in the branches that derive from them, is a praiseworthy virtue. The two extremes, those of excess and deficiency, are blameworthy vices. Investigation of these virtues and vices is entrusted to a discipline other than the present one.

From the foregoing it is clear, first, that character exists only in the human world and among other beings endowed with souls that attain perfection through voluntary acts in a way appropriate to the perfection of their existence. There is no character in separate immaterial beings, since they have neither practical intellect nor voluntary acquisition of perfection.

Second, each of these traits of character, which are psychic qualities, has, insofar as it is a firmly established habit, a corresponding state of the same quality. Examples are appetite, anger, fear, alarm, sorrow, anxiety, shame, joy, happiness, distress, and others. Their natural causes are investigated in medicine; their correction and management in a way consonant with human happiness are investigated in the discipline of ethics.

Among psychic qualities are pleasure and pain. Pleasure, according to their definition, is apprehension of what is agreeable insofar as it is agreeable. Pain is apprehension of what is contrary insofar as it is contrary. They therefore belong to quality insofar as they are forms of apprehension.

They divide as apprehension divides: some are sensory, some imaginal, and some intellectual. Sensory pleasure is exemplified by the soul’s apprehension of sweetness through taste and of a pleasant fragrance through smell. Imaginal pleasure is its apprehension of an imaginal form of some sensory pleasure. Intellectual pleasure is its apprehension of some of the true intellectual perfections it has attained. Intellectual pleasure is the most intense and powerful of pleasures because of its immateriality and stability. Sensory, imaginal, and intellectual pain are the opposites of pleasure in each of these domains.

Pleasure is in every case existential, whereas pain is privative; it stands opposed to pleasure as privation is opposed to possession.

It should not be objected: “There is no doubt that pain is intrinsically evil. Since it is apprehension of what is contrary insofar as it is contrary, it is something existential, for apprehension is existential. This overturns their assertion that evil is nothing but privation.” The reply is that the existence of each thing, whether mental or external, is that thing itself. The presence of any privative thing to the apprehender is therefore that privative thing itself, because existence and quiddity, and knowledge and the known, are united. Thus the pain existing within the sphere of apprehension is an instance of pain, and is precisely that privative pain which is intrinsically evil.

Notice. The foregoing account of quality, its judgments, and its properties is what has been transmitted from the earlier philosophers. Modern natural scientists have investigated deeply what the earlier philosophers classified as quality, and have discovered many judgments and effects concerning it. A reflective investigator ought to consult these findings and give them due consideration in the inquiry.

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1. **translation:** The supplied transcription opens with the end of the preceding discussion of preparedness, then runs into this chapter's heading. Its comparison with knowledge breaks off after "between its subject"; the ellipsis marks that textual break, and no missing counterpart has been supplied.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 155–162 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=155&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 16

Relation

الفصل السادس عشر — في الإضافة

First discussion: the meaning of the relational character of the categories

You have learned that seven of the categories are relational accidents: relation, where, when, position, possession, acting, and being acted upon. Their being relational means that they are configurations subsisting in their subjects on account of relations present in them. It does not mean that these categories are identical with those existential relations. For you learned in the discussion of dependent and independent existence that a relation is a bond existing in another, with no independence whatever: it is neither predicated of anything nor has anything predicated of it. It therefore has no quiddity, since a quiddity is what is said of a thing in answer to "What is it?" Categories are generic quiddities. Thus a relation is neither a category nor something falling under a category.

Moreover, in some of these categories the relation is reciprocal and multiple, whereas the repetition of a quiddity has no meaning. This is so in the category of relation, in which reciprocity is necessary, and in the category of position, which involves the relation of some of a thing's parts to others and the relation of the whole to what is outside it; the latter may rest upon a very large number of relations.

It has thus become clear that a relational category is a configuration acquired by a thing on account of a certain relation or relations subsisting in it.

Second discussion: the definition of relation

Relation is a configuration acquired through a thing's relation to another thing which is itself related to the first thing, to which it is referred. An example is the relational configuration in a brother: it involves this brother's relation of brotherhood to his brother, who is in turn related by

brotherhood to this brother to whom he is referred.

The difference between it and relation in the unrestricted sense

The relation involved in the category of relation is thus reciprocal. This is the difference between the relation within this category and relation in the unrestricted sense. The existence of an unrestricted relation is one existence subsisting in its two terms, whatever they may be. The case is different in the category of relation: the relation is reciprocal, and each of the two relatives has a relation distinct from that in the other, although the two necessarily accompany one another and cannot be separated either in the mind or externally.

The definition of relation that we have supplied is not a logical definition by genus and differentia, as was previously indicated in analogous cases. It is a description, if it is better known than what it describes.

Perhaps what the intellect understands by the word “relation,” together with some examples, is better known to it than the description we have provided. There is therefore little benefit in prolonging the discussion of its qualifications, whether in criticism or in defense. The same applies to the other definitions they have supplied for it.

The difference between the relative in the strict and in the ordinary senses

Sometimes “relative” is used to mean the category itself, which they call “the relative in the strict sense.” Sometimes it means the subject of the category. Sometimes it means the subject and the accident together, which they call “the relative in the ordinary sense.” For ordinary people think that what is related to a son, for example, is the human being characterized by sonship, whereas the connection on both sides belongs in truth to the relation itself.

Third discussion: relation exists externally

Relation exists externally, and sense perception supports this. The senses apprehend various external relations whose objective effects cannot be doubted, such as the relation of father and son, above and below, near and far, and others.

As for its manner of existence, the intellect abstracts from the two subjects possessing the mutually concomitant reciprocal relation a qualification characterizing them, without adding anything to them. Relation therefore exists through the existence of its subject, without there being a separate, independent existence corresponding to it.

After discussing this point, the author of the Asfār says: “In general, the relative, insofar as it is relative, is simple. It has no independent, separate existence externally. Its existence consists in its attaching to things whose condition is such that they admit comparison with something else. The heaven’s existence in itself is the existence of substances, while its existence in such a manner that, when it is compared with the earth, being above is understood, is the existence of relations.” End of quotation.

Fourth discussion: some judgments concerning relation

Among the judgments concerning relation is that the two relatives are equivalent with respect to existence and nonexistence, potentiality and actuality. If one exists, the other exists, and likewise on the side of nonexistence. If one is potential, the other is potential, and likewise on the side of actuality.

An objection has been raised: this is contradicted by priority and posteriority among the parts of time. Its earlier and later parts are relatives, yet the existence of one necessarily accompanies the nonexistence of the other.

It is also contradicted by our knowledge of certain future things. Knowledge exists at present, while the known thing is nonexistent and has not yet come to exist, although knowledge and the known are relatives.

The reply to the first counterexample is that the togetherness of the parts of time is not instantaneous, such that the two parts exist in a single instant. Rather, their togetherness is their continuity within the single gradual existence in which their togetherness is identical with priority and posteriority, just as the unity of number is identical with its multiplicity.

The reply to the second counterexample is that the relation is between knowledge and the form of the known that is present to the knower. This is what is known intrinsically, as opposed to what is known incidentally, which is an external entity. Future things are present to the knower through their form, which is known intrinsically, even though they are absent in their external reality, which is known incidentally. Furthermore, the truth is that knowledge is identical with the known, as will be explained in the stage concerning the intellective subject and the intelligible.

Just as the two relatives are equivalent with respect to existence and nonexistence, potentiality and actuality, they are also equivalent with respect to universality and particularity. Universal fatherhood is correlated with universal sonship, and individual fatherhood with individual sonship.

Among the properties of relation is that it occurs in all the categories, including itself. In substance there are father and son; in continuous quantity, greater and smaller; in discrete quantity, more and less; in quality, hotter and colder; in relation, nearer and farther; in where, higher and lower; in when, earlier and later; in position, more upright and more bent; in possession, more clothed and more bare; in acting, cutting and severing more forcefully; and in being acted upon, being heated more intensely and more weakly.

Fifth discussion

Relation is divided into that whose terms are alike, in which there is no difference between its terms, such as one neighbor and another, one brother and another, and one nearby thing and another; and that whose terms differ, such as father and son, higher and lower.

It is also divided into external relation, such as father and son, and mental relation, such as universal and individual, and more general and more specific.

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1. **translation:** In the example explaining the relative in ordinary usage, the supplied transcription reads “the human being characterized by sonship” as what is related to a son. This apparent textual inconsistency has been retained; “fatherhood” may have been intended.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 162–167 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=162&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 17

Where

الفصل السابع عشر — في الأين

First discussion: the definition of where

Where is a configuration acquired by a body through its relation to place.

The existence of place, with the characteristics familiar to us, is self-evident. It is that from which and to which a body can move, and in which it can remain at rest; that which has position, meaning that it can be indicated as here or there; that which is measurable and has a half, a third, and a quarter; and that which is such that two bodies cannot occupy one and the same instance of it.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—says: “These are four marks upon which the disputants have agreed, so that their disagreement will not be merely verbal.”

They have disagreed about its reality, offering five views. First, it is the prime matter of body. Second, it is form. Third, it is a surface of a body that meets the body occupying the place, whether the former contains the latter or is contained by it. Fourth, it is the inner surface of the containing body that touches the outer surface of the contained body. This is the view of the First Teacher,

followed by the two masters al-Fārābī and Ibn Sīnā. Fifth, it is an extension equal to the dimensions of the body occupying the place, and is therefore a substantial extension separate from matter. This is the view of Plato and the Stoics, and was adopted by the investigator al-Ṭūsī—may his secret be sanctified—and Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn. These are five views. A sixth is the denial of place by some thinkers.

Since the four marks just mentioned are self-evident and beyond doubt, those who deny place must reduce it to the category of position: substance and the remaining accidents certainly do not fit it.

The objection to this is that a body may move from place to place without any change in its substance or in its other accidents apart from where; conversely, a change in position may occur without locomotion. Place is therefore distinct from all of them, including position.

The view that place is prime matter or form does not fit the preceding marks. Place is sought through motion and left through motion, whereas neither prime matter nor form is sought or left through motion. Furthermore, a composite is attributed to its prime matter, as when one says “a wooden door” or “a door made of iron,” but it is not attributed in this way to its place.

The views upon which one can rely are therefore that place is a surface, or that it is a substantial extension separate from matter.

The two parties have lengthy arguments and disputes, set out in the more extensive works.

Among the strongest objections to the view that place is a surface is that it entails a thing’s being at rest and in motion at the same time. A bird remaining stationary in the air and a fish remaining stationary in water must, when air and water flow past them, be in motion, because the surface of air or water surrounding them changes; yet they are necessarily at rest.

Furthermore, place is characterized as empty or full, and this characterizes an extension, not a surface.

Among the strongest objections to the view that place is a substantial extension separate from matter is that it entails the interpenetration of two magnitudes, which is impossible. For it involves a body, with its individual magnitude extending in three dimensions, occupying a place that is an individual magnitude equal to it, and the two becoming one individual magnitude. There is no doubt about the impossibility of this—unless it is denied on the ground that what prevents interpenetration may be prime matter together with magnitude, or form together with magnitude, or both together with it.

Second discussion: the point at issue

You have learned that where is a configuration acquired by a thing through its relation to place. The discussion concerns its being a configuration acquired through a relation, rather than the existence of the relation itself, just as in the preceding discussion of relation.

Third discussion: the divisions of where

Where is sometimes divided into primary and real, and secondary and nonreal. The first is a thing’s being in the place proper to it, which cannot accommodate anything else together with it, as when water is in a jug. The second is exemplified by saying, “So-and-so is in the room.” The room is not occupied by him alone, but accommodates him and others. More remote still are his being in the house, then in the town, and so on. This is not a real division; what is divided is where as understood in the extended usage of ordinary speech.

Closely related is its division into generic where, which is being in place; specific where, such as being in the air; and individual where, such as this individual’s being at this time in his real place.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 167–170 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=167&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 18

When

الفصل الثامن عشر — في المتى

When is the configuration acquired by a thing through its relation to time.

It will be explained, God willing, that every motion, by virtue of its flowing, gradual existence, has a nonstable measure proper to it and different from the nonstable extension belonging to any other motion. Every particular motion that is numerically one therefore has a particular time that is numerically one. Some of these times, however, admit coincidence with others. The continuous general time by which we measure motions is the time of the daily motion, adopted as a standard by which we measure times and motions. Through it, their relations to one another in priority and posteriority, length and shortness, are determined. Events acquire, in accordance with their relation to time, a configuration that is when.

The discussion of when closely resembles that of where. There is a when proper to a motion which does not accommodate another together with it: this is primary and real when. There is also a when that encompasses this motion and others, such as this motion’s occurring in such-and-such an hour, day, month, year, century, and so on.

The difference between where and when in this respect is that many things share one particular time by coinciding with it, whereas one particular where accommodates only one body.

When admits a division corresponding to the division of temporal events. Some have gradual existence and coincide with time itself. Others have instantaneous existence and are related to a limit of time, such as arrivals, contacts, and separations.

As has also been said, when is divided into intrinsic and incidental. Intrinsic when belongs to motions, which coincide with time through themselves. Incidental when belongs to moving things, which coincide with it through their motions; in respect of the substance of their own essence, they have no when. This is based on the denial of substantial motion. If substantial motion is affirmed, however—as will be explained, God willing—there is no difference between motion and the moving thing in this respect.

When is also divided in accordance with the division of the categories in which motions occur.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 170–172 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=170&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 19

Position

الفصل التاسع عشر — في الوضع

Position is the configuration that a thing acquires from the relation of some of its parts to others and of the whole to what is external, as in the configurations of standing, sitting, lying on one’s back, and lying face down.

Position is divided into what is natural and what is not natural. An example of natural position is a tree’s resting upon its root and trunk; an example of what is not natural is the situation of the inhabitant of a house in relation to the house.

It is also divided into actual and potential position.

It has been said that position admits contrariety, intensity, and weakness. An example of contrariety is the position of a human being with the head toward the sky and the feet toward the ground, as contrary to that person’s position when inverted. These two positions are positive attributes that succeed one another in a single subject, cannot coexist in it, and stand at the utmost opposition to one another. The same applies to lying on one’s back and lying face down. Examples of intensity are being more upright or more bent.

There is some obscurity in conceiving utmost opposition in position. Let this be considered.

Notice

“Position” has two other meanings besides its categorical meaning.

The first is a thing’s being susceptible to sensible indication. Indication, as reported from the Healing, is the determination of the direction belonging to a thing among the directions of this world. Accordingly, every body and bodily thing admits position in this sense. Thus a point has position, whereas a unit does not.

The second is a meaning more restricted than the first: a quantity’s being susceptible to sensible indication, such that one may ask, “Where is it among the directions, and where are some of its continuous parts in relation to others?”

This has been disputed on the ground that a line and a surface, and indeed a mathematical body, have no “where” apart from their attachment to corporeal matter. Mere quantitative continuity, therefore, does not suffice to make something susceptible to sensible indication unless it is joined to matter.

An imaginal form of quantity that is immaterial does, however, admit imaginal indication; an intelligible form likewise admits an indication appropriate to it.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 172–173 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=172&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 20

Possession

الفصل العشرون — في الجِدَة

This is also called “ownership.” It is the configuration arising from one thing’s encompassing another in such a way that the encompassing thing moves when the encompassed thing moves.

The subject is the encompassed thing. Complete encompassing is exemplified by an animal’s skin encompassing it; incomplete encompassing is exemplified by wearing a shirt, shoes, or a ring, and similar cases.

Possession is divided into natural possession, as in the first example, and nonnatural possession, as in the other examples.

In the Asfār it is said: “Ownership is sometimes expressed as the category of ‘having.’ Some of it is natural, as the faculties’ belonging to the soul, and some is an external consideration, as a horse’s belonging to Zayd. Ownership in fact differs from the present technical usage, for it belongs solely to the category of relation.” End of quotation.

The truth is that real ownership, as in the faculties' belonging to the soul, is an existential aspect: the existence of one thing subsists through another in such a way that it belongs exclusively to the latter, which disposes of it however it wishes. It is therefore not a categorical meaning. Conventional ownership, as in a horse's belonging to Zayd, is an intellectually instituted counterpart of real ownership, rather than the category of relation. God willing, we shall refer to this discussion in the stage concerning the intellective subject and the intelligible.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 173–174 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=173&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 21

The two categories of acting and being acted upon

الفصل الحادي والعشرون — في مقولتي أن يفعل وأن ينفعل

The first is a nonstable configuration arising in an agent from its producing an effect for as long as it produces that effect, as in the heating performed by what heats for as long as it heats, or the cooling performed by what cools for as long as it cools.

The second is a nonstable configuration arising in the recipient of an effect for as long as it is affected, as in the becoming hot of what is heated for as long as it becomes hot, or the becoming cold of what is cooled for as long as it becomes cold.

Among the distinctive features of these two categories is, first, that, as the examples show, they occur in other categories, such as quality, quantity, position, and others.

Second, their subject, insofar as it is their subject, is never devoid of motion. For this reason they are expressed by "acting" and "being acted upon," which suggest motion and gradual occurrence, rather than by "action" and "affection," which are sometimes applied to instantaneous, nongradual influence and reception of influence.

In general, the two categories are configurations that occur in their subject as aspects of the motion it possesses.

In the Asfār it is said: "Know that the external existence of either of them does not consist in the very progression toward a degree, for that is precisely what motion means. Nor is the existence of either of them the existence of the categories through which causing motion and undergoing motion occur: quality, such as blackness; quantity, such as the magnitude of a growing body; position, such as sitting and standing upright; or anything else of this sort.

“Rather, their existence consists in the existence of something belonging to these categories for as long as it produces or receives an effect. The existence of blackness or heat, for example, insofar as it is blackness, belongs to the category of quality. The existence of either of them insofar as it occurs gradually and produces something else that occurs gradually, or arises from something else that occurs gradually, belongs to the category of acting or being acted upon.

“As for its gradual progression itself—that is, its passage from potentiality to actuality—whether on the side of the agent or on the side of the recipient, it is precisely motion and nothing else. Thus the manner of their external existence, and their being accidents, have been established.” End of quotation.

An objection to the existence of these two categories runs as follows. The influence exerted by an agent cannot be a positive attribute additional to the agent itself. Otherwise it would require a further influence upon that influence; transferring the argument to this further influence yields a regress extending without end, although it is enclosed between two limits: the agent and the recipient.

A parallel objection applies if the recipient’s reception of an effect is additional to the recipient itself. If receiving the effect were additional to the recipient itself, it would require another reception. Transferring the argument to this further reception produces a regress, again enclosed between two limits. Producing and receiving an effect, whether instantaneous or gradual, must therefore be privative attributes that do not exist externally.

The answer is that this argument succeeds only if the positive effect hypothesized has a separate existence requiring a new, separate influence peculiar to it.

If, however, it is established through the establishment of another thing, it is produced by the very production that concerns the thing it follows. Gradual influence and the gradual reception of influence exist through the very bringing into existence of the quality—for example, blackness in what blackens and what becomes black. No proof of a thing’s existence is stronger than the truth of its concept of an external entity in an external proposition.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 174–176 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=174&type=c_fbook

STAGE VII

Unity and Multiplicity

المرحلة السابعة — في الواحد والكثير

CHAPTER 1

The concepts of unity and multiplicity are self-evident and need no definition

الفصل الأوّل — في أنّ مفهوم الوحدة والكثرة بديهيٌّ غنيٌّ عن التعريف

An existent is divided into the one and the many: every existent is either one or many. The truth is that unity and multiplicity are among the general concepts whose conception is self-evident and which need no definition, like necessity and possibility. This is why the definitions offered for them involve either circularity or defining a thing through itself. Thus the one is defined as “that which is not divided in the respect in which it is said to be one.” This includes division, which is multiplicity, in the definition of the one, besides defining the one through the one. The many is then defined as “that which is assembled from units.” This includes unity in the definition of the many, although multiplicity had already been included in the definition of the one, and so is circular. It also defines the many through an assemblage, which is precisely the many.

The truth, then, is that the definitions given for them are verbal definitions, intended to draw attention to their meanings and distinguish them from among the meanings already stored in the soul.

The one is “that which is not divided, insofar as it is not divided.” The qualification “insofar as” allows this to include the non-genuine one, which is divisible in some respects. The many is “that which is divided, insofar as it is divided.”

It has thus become clear that an existent is divided into the one and the many, and that these are two distinct meanings, distinct as one member of a division is from the other.

Notice

They say, “Unity is coextensive with existence.” Every existent is therefore one insofar as it is existent. Even an existent multiplicity, insofar as it exists, is one multiplicity. The fact that number is predicated of it bears witness to this, since number is composed of units. We say one

multiplicity, two multiplicities, and three multiplicities; one ten, two tens, and three tens; and so on.

It might be imagined that dividing an existent into the one and the many conflicts with the one's being coextensive with an existent. For the many, insofar as it is many, is existent, given the division just mentioned; and the many, insofar as it is many, is not one. This yields the conclusion that some existent is not one, contradicting their statement that every existent is one.

The answer is that the one can be considered in two ways. It can be considered in itself, without comparing some of its instances with others; in this consideration it is coextensive with an existent and embraces its instances, both one and many. Or it can be considered by comparing some of its instances with others. There are then instances that do not possess the meaning of indivisibility found in other instances. Ten, for example, does not possess the indivisibility found in one, although it does possess it when compared with tens.

The many that is not one is therefore that which is compared, insofar as it is compared, and what stands opposite it is the one in the second consideration. The one in the first consideration, however, embraces both the one and the many that are the two members of the division.

A parallel is the division of an existent without qualification into the potential and the actual, although the actual is coextensive with an existent without qualification. Another is the division of existence into mental existence and external existence to which effects attach, although external existence to which effects attach is coextensive with existence without qualification.

All of these arise from the differences of gradation belonging to the graded reality of existence.

Similar to the preceding misconception is the thought that unity is one of the meanings abstracted by the intellect: if it were an external reality, it would have a unity, and its unity would have another unity, and so on without end.

The answer is that its unity is identical with its essence. It is one through itself, just as was explained earlier concerning existence: it exists through itself, without needing an existence additional to its essence.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 179–181 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=179&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The divisions of the one

The one is either genuine or non-genuine. The genuine one is that which is characterized by unity through itself, without an intermediary in the attribution, such as one human being. The non-genuine one is the opposite, such as a human being and a horse, which are united in animality. It necessarily terminates in a genuine one.

The genuine one is either an essence identical with unity or an essence characterized by unity.

The former is a thing in its sheer purity, which admits neither a second nor repetition. Its unity is called “true unity.” Here the one and unity are a single thing. The latter is exemplified by “one human being.”

That whose unity is other than true unity is either one in particular or one in general.

The former is the numerically one, whose repetition produces number. The latter is exemplified by one species and one genus.

The one in particular either is indivisible also with respect to the nature to which unity is attributed, just as it is indivisible with respect to its attribute of unity, or is divisible with respect to that nature.

The former is either the very concept of unity and indivisibility or something other than it. Something other than it is either positional, such as one point, or non-positional, such as an immaterial being. An immaterial being either has some connection with matter, such as the soul, which is connected with matter in its activity, or has no connection with matter at all, such as an intellect.

The latter—what admits division with respect to the nature to which unity is attributed—either admits it intrinsically, as does one magnitude, or incidentally, as does one natural body on account of its magnitude.

The one in general is either one through conceptual generality or one through generality in the sense of existential comprehensiveness. The first is either specifically one, such as human being, generically one, such as animal, or accidentally one, such as walking and laughing. The one through generality in the sense of existential comprehensiveness is exemplified by all-pervading existence.

The non-genuine one is that which is characterized by unity incidentally through something else, because it has some manner of union with it. Examples are Zayd and ʿAmr, united in humanity, and a human being and a horse, united in animality.

The names of the non-genuine one differ according to the respect of unity. Union in the meaning of a species is called “likeness”; in the meaning of a genus, “generic sameness”; in quality, “similarity”; in quantity, “equality”; and in position, “parallelism” and “coincidence.”

The existence of each of these divisions is evident. So too is the fact that unity applies to its divisions as a graded meaning applies to its different instances. This is how they have set out the matter.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 182–183 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=182&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Identity is a consequence of unity, and otherness a consequence of multiplicity

الفصل الثالث — في أنّ من لوازم الوحدة الهوهويّة ومن لوازم الكثرة الغيريّة

Identity is among the concomitants of unity, just as otherness is among the concomitants of multiplicity.

By identity is meant unity in some respect together with difference in some respect. It follows that predication is valid between any two different things that possess some unity, although customary usage restricts predication to certain kinds of unity.

An objection has been raised: if predication is valid wherever two different things possess some unity, it should be valid in the case of a single continuous magnitude, which has many potential parts existing through one actual existence. Some of its parts could then be predicated of others, and some of its parts of the whole, and conversely. We could say, “This half of the cubit is the other half,” “This half is the whole,” or “Its whole is its half.” The invalidity of these statements is self-evident.

The answer, as Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—explained, is that so long as a single continuum has not been divided in any manner, externally or mentally, no multiplicity whatsoever has been realized in it. The condition of predication, namely some unity together with some multiplicity, is therefore absent, and there is no predication. Once it has been divided in some manner, its single identity is abolished, and the continuity constituting its unity ceases. The condition of predication, namely some multiplicity together with some unity, is again absent, and there is no predication.

It has thus become clear that predication obtains between any two things that differ in one respect and are united in another, provided that the unity coexists with the difference. Ordinary usage, however, as we have indicated, confines predication to two cases of unity together with difference.

The first is where subject and predicate are united in concept while differing through some consideration. An example is the difference between what is undifferentiated and what is detailed in our statement, “The human being is a rational animal.” A definition is conceptually identical with what it defines; they differ only in being undifferentiated and detailed. Another is the difference between indeterminacy and its absence in our statement, “The human being is an animal,” for the genus is the species in an indeterminate condition. Another is the difference between determination and its absence in our statement, “The human being is rational,” for the differentia is the species as determined, as was explained in the discussions of quiddity. There is also the difference introduced by supposing a thing to be denied of itself, so that its self differs from its self, and then predicating it of itself to dispel the imagined difference. Thus one says, for example, “The human being is a human being.”

Since this predication is sometimes considered in external existence, it is more appropriate to define it as the unity of subject and predicate in essence. This predication is called “primary essential predication.”

The second is where subject and predicate differ in concept but are united in existence, as in our statements, “Zayd is a human being,” “Cotton is white,” and “One who laughs is one who wonders.”

This predication is called “common predication.”

There is a point here to which attention must be drawn. It was explained in earlier discussions that existence is divided into existence in itself and existence in another. It is also divided into existence for itself and existence for another, the latter being attributive existence. It was also explained that two quiddities cannot exist through one existence in itself: one existence cannot exclude nonexistence from the very selves of two distinct quiddities. That would be the unity of a multiplicity, which reason judges impossible.

It follows that predication, which is the unity in some respect of two different things, is not realized in their respective existences in themselves. It is realized only in attributive existence, when one of the two, through its existence, qualifies the other, and the other is qualified by it.

In other words, one of the two different things is the subject in its existence in itself, and the other is the attribute in its existence in itself. Their unity lies in the attributive existence that the attribute bestows upon the subject.

This is what the logicians mean when they say, “A proposition resolves into two nexuses: the subject nexus, in which only the subject itself is considered, while any attribute contained in it is merely a designation pointing to that subject; and the predicate nexus, in which only the attribute is considered.”

There is a third kind of predication employed by the philosopher, called “the predication of reality and its attenuated manifestation.” It rests on the unity of subject and predicate in the root of existence and their difference in perfection and deficiency. It signifies that the deficient exists in the perfect in a higher and nobler manner, and that a higher degree of existence contains the perfection of the degrees beneath it.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 183–185 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=183&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Predication as “is it” and as “has it”

الفصل الرابع — في انقسام الحمل إلى هو هو وذي هو

Predication is divided into predication as “is it” and predication as “has it.”

The first is that in which the predicate is established of the subject without any need to consider an additional factor, as when we say, “The human being is one who laughs.” It is also called “predication by agreement.”

The second is that in which establishing the predicate of the subject requires considering an additional factor, such as supplying the word “possessor” or using a derivative expression. An example is our saying, “Zayd is justice,” meaning “possesses justice” or “is just.”

Predication is also divided into definitive and non-definitive.

The first is that whose subject has actual individuals to which its designation applies, as in our statements, “The human being is a writer,” and “The writer is one who moves his fingers.”

The second is that whose subject has supposed rather than actual individuals, as in our statements, “The absolutely nonexistent cannot be spoken of,” and “The conjunction of contradictories is impossible.”

Predication is also divided into simple and compound, called respectively the “simple existential proposition” and the “compound existential proposition.”

A simple existential proposition is one whose predicate is the existence of the subject, as when we say, “The human being exists.”

A compound existential proposition is one whose predicate is one of the subject’s effects or accidental attributes, as when we say, “The human being is one who laughs.” It signifies the establishment of something for something, whereas a simple existential proposition signifies the establishment of the thing itself.

This removes an objection some have raised against the universality of the principle of presupposition, which states that “the establishment of something for something presupposes the establishment of that for which it is established.” They maintain that the principle is contradicted by a statement such as “Quiddity exists.” According to the principle of presupposition, the establishment of existence for quiddity presupposes the establishment of quiddity. We then transfer the discussion to that establishment: it in turn presupposes the prior establishment of quiddity, and so on without end, yielding an infinite regress.

The answer, on the basis of what has been established, is that the proposition is a simple existential proposition. A simple existential proposition signifies only the establishment of the thing, not the establishment of something for something, such that it would require quiddity to exist before its existence.

Some have answered the objection by replacing presupposition with entailment. They say that the correct principle is that the establishment of something for something entails the establishment of that for which it is established, even if through this very establishment; thus the establishment of existence for quiddity entails the establishment of quiddity through this very establishment. This, however, concedes the objection.

Still less satisfactory is the statement of some that the principle admits an exception in the case of the establishment of existence for quiddity.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 185–187 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=185&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Otherness and its divisions

الفصل الخامس — في الغيريّة وأقسامها

It was explained that otherness is among the concomitants of multiplicity. Otherness is divided into essential and nonessential.

Essential otherness occurs when one of two things excludes the other through its very essence, so that the two cannot coexist because of their essences. An example is the otherness of existence and nonexistence. It is called “opposition.”

Opposition has been defined as “the impossibility of two things’ coexistence in one substrate, in one respect, at one time.” The impossibility of coexistence is attributed to the two things to indicate that it is due to their very essences. By “one substrate” is meant a subject in the broadest sense, even if merely supposed by reason, so that the definition includes the opposition of affirmation and negation: the content of a proposition serves as a subject for them. The qualification “in one respect” excludes cases in which the two coexist in one thing in two different respects, as when Zayd is a father to ʿAmr and a son to Bakr. The qualification concerning one time accommodates opposition involving time. The occurrence of two contraries in one subject at two different times therefore does not invalidate the definition.

The definition is not contradicted by two like things, whose coexistence is rationally impossible. One of two like things does not exclude the other through its essence, namely the specific quiddity common to them. Their coexistence is impossible only because one existence cannot be repeated, as was explained in the discussions of existence.

Nor is the definition contradicted by the contradictory of a consequent together with the antecedent itself. The contradictory of the consequent opposes the antecedent itself only because it opposes the consequent, which is its contradictory. Its coexistence with the antecedent is therefore impossible incidentally, through its contradictory, and not through itself.

Nonessential otherness occurs when two things do not coexist for reasons other than their very essences, as in the separation of sweetness and blackness in sugar and charcoal. This is called “difference.”

“Other” is also said with regard to individuation and number.

Opposition is divided into four kinds: the opposition of contradiction, of privation and possession, of correlation, and of contrariety.

The more accurate way to establish these divisions is to say: either one of the two opposites is the absence of the other, or it is not. In the first case, either there is a receptive subject, as with sight and blindness, in which case the opposition is that of privation and possession; or there is none, as with affirmation and negation, in which case the opposition is that of contradiction. In the second case, where both are positive, either one can be conceived only together with the other and in relation to it, as with higher and lower, in which case the opposition is that of correlation; or this is not so, in which case the opposition is that of contrariety.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 187–189 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=187&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

الفصل السادس — في تقابل التناقض

This is the opposition of affirmation and negation, as in our statements “Zayd is white” and “Zayd is not white,” or of simple expressions that have the meaning of affirmation and negation, such as “human being” and “non-human-being,” “blindness” and “non-blindness,” and “nonexistent” and “non-nonexistent.”

Two contradictories cannot both be true and cannot both be false. Or, if you prefer: they cannot both obtain and cannot both fail to obtain. Contradictory opposition thus comes down to a genuine disjunctive proposition: “Either the affirmation is true or the negation is true.” In reality, then, contradiction is between affirmation and negation.

This does not conflict with contradiction occurring between simple expressions. Whenever we take a concept in itself and then add to it the meaning of negation, as with human being and non-human-being, or horse and non-horse, contradiction arises between the two concepts. For when we take two contradictory concepts, such as human being and non-human-being, we have no doubt that the opposition belongs equally to both concepts: human being intrinsically excludes non-human-being, just as non-human-being intrinsically excludes human being. It is self-evident that if establishment and existence were not considered on the side of human being, it would neither exclude nor contradict non-human-being. Human being and non-human-being contradict one another only because they have the meaning of the existence of the human being and the nonexistence of the human being. This is possible only by considering existence as belonging to the human being, and likewise nonexistence. Human being and non-human-being therefore contradict one another because they resolve into two simple existential propositions: “The human being exists” and “The human being does not exist.”

A parallel account applies to the contradictories “Zayd’s standing” and “Zayd’s not standing.” They have the meaning of the existence of standing for Zayd and the nonexistence of standing for Zayd, and resolve into two compound existential propositions: “Zayd is standing” and “Zayd is not standing.” Contradictory opposition is therefore in reality between affirmation and negation, or, if you prefer, between existence and nonexistence. It will nevertheless be explained in the discussions of the intellective subject and the intelligible object, God willing, that the intellect first apprehends the concept of existence as a dependent meaning within propositions. It then forms an independent nominal meaning from this by transforming it and taking independently what was

previously a connective. It conceives of nonexistence on the model of what it has done with existence. Contradictory opposition thus belongs primarily and intrinsically to affirmation and negation, and to other things incidentally through them.

Accordingly, statements that attribute contradiction to propositions—for example, the statement in the Tajrīd, “The opposition of negation and affirmation refers to utterance and judgment”—mean negation and affirmation insofar as they bear upon one and the same propositional content.

It has also become clear that in their statement, “The contradictory of each thing is its removal,” removal means intrinsic exclusion: affirmation and negation each intrinsically exclude what opposes it. Some, however, interpret removal as negation and denial, explicitly maintaining that the contradictory of human being is non-human-being, and that the contradictory of non-human-being is non-non-human-being, while human being is a necessary concomitant of the contradictory rather than the contradictory itself. Their interpretation would entail that contradictory opposition is invariably one-sided, which is self-evidently false.

One judgment concerning contradictory opposition is that the opposition between two contradictories occurs in the mind, or, by a kind of figurative usage, in language. Opposition is a relation subsisting in two terms, whereas one term of a contradictory pair is nonexistence, and nonexistence is an intellectual consideration with no external instance. This differs from the opposition of privation and possession. As will be explained, God willing, the nonexistence in the latter is nonexistence referred to something existent, and therefore has a share in existence. The opposition there genuinely subsists in two existent terms.

Another judgment concerning this opposition is that there can be no intermediate between things opposed in this way. Nothing is without one or the other of the two contradictories being true of it. Anything posited is either Zayd, for example, or is not Zayd; it is either white or is not white; and so forth. Any two contradictories taken together thus encompass all things.

Another judgment is that the two contradictories cannot both be true or both be false. As already indicated, this takes the form of the genuine disjunctive proposition, “Either the affirmation is true or the negation is true.” This is a primary, self-evident proposition upon which the truth of every proposition depends, whether that proposition is immediately evident or requires investigation. For example, “Four is even” is true only if “Four is not even” is false. “The world has come to be” is true only if “The world has not come to be” is false. For this reason the proposition asserting the impossibility of two contradictories both obtaining or both failing to obtain is called “the first of first principles.”

For this same reason, doubt about the truth of this genuine disjunctive proposition destroys knowledge of any proposition whatsoever. Knowledge that a proposition is true occurs only when its contradictory is known to be false. Doubt about this genuine disjunction entails doubt about the falsity of the contradictory, and hence doubt about the truth of the other contradictory. Doubt about it therefore annihilates all knowledge and undermines it at its root. Human nature itself rejects this. The sophist’s professed doubt is a claim that never goes beyond words. A detailed discussion of this will follow.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 189–192 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=189&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The opposition of privation and possession

الفصل السابع — في تقابل العدم والملكة

This is also called the opposition of privation and having. Its terms are an existent feature that occurs in a subject naturally capable of possessing it, and the absence of that existent feature in that subject. An example is sight and blindness, the latter being the lack of sight in a subject naturally capable of seeing.

Whether the subject of the possession is taken as an individual nature, a specific nature, or a generic nature makes no difference to the occurrence of this opposition. A generic nature, and likewise a specific nature, is a subject of an individual’s attribute just as the individual itself is its subject. Thus the lack of sight in a scorpion—as has been said—is blindness and a privation, since its genus, animal, is naturally capable of seeing, even if the specific nature of scorpion is not characterized by sight. Likewise, a human being’s beardlessness and lack of facial hair before puberty is a privation, since the specific nature of the human being has that capacity, even though the class of those who have not reached puberty does not possess a beard. The opposition of privation and possession in this unrestricted sense is called “genuine.”

It is sometimes restricted by time, with the requirement that the privation occur at the time appropriate to the possession. In that case the opposition is called “commonly recognized.” On this usage, a human being’s beardlessness before puberty is not a privation at all, and likewise the scorpion’s lack of sight is not blindness.

This is closer to a terminological convention. There is therefore no difficulty if cases whose subject is the genus or species fall outside privation and possession on this usage without falling under any of the other three oppositions, although the kinds of opposition are confined to four.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 192–193 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=192&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Correlative opposition

الفصل الثامن — في تقابل التضايف

As the division has shown, two correlatives are two existent features, one of which cannot be conceived without conceiving the other. They stand in a reciprocal relation: one cannot be conceived without conceiving the other, which is itself conceived through the first. For this reason they cannot occur together in one thing in the same respect, since a relation cannot run between a thing and itself.

An objection has been raised against treating correlation as one of the four kinds of opposition: opposition in general is itself a kind of correlation, since two opposites, insofar as they are opposites, are correlatives. Counting correlation as a kind of opposition would therefore amount to making something a coordinate division alongside one of its own subdivisions.

The reply is that the concept of opposition is an instance of correlation, whereas an instance of correlation is one of the kinds and instances of opposition. What falls under correlation is the concept of opposition; what stands alongside correlation as a coordinate division is an instance of opposition. A mental concept is often an individual instance of that to which it is opposed. The concept of the particular, for example, is in one respect an instance of the universal and in another respect opposed to it. There is therefore no difficulty.

One judgment concerning correlation is that the two correlatives are coextensive in existence and nonexistence, and in potentiality and actuality. If one exists, the other necessarily exists; if one does not exist, the other necessarily does not exist; and if one is potential or actual, the other necessarily is so as well. It follows that they are simultaneous: neither precedes the other, whether in the mind or externally.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 193–194 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=193&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

Contrary opposition

الفصل التاسع — في تقابل التضاد

You have learned that the result of the preceding division is that contraries are two existent things that are not correlatives and that do not coexist in one locus, at one time, and in one respect.

It is reported that the ancients were content with this much in defining contrariety. They therefore allowed contrariety to occur between substances and allowed its terms to number more than two.

The Peripatetics, however, added further qualifications to what follows from the division. They described contraries as “two existent things that are not correlatives, that succeed one another in a single subject, that fall under a proximate genus, and between which there is the utmost difference.”

For them, therefore, contrariety is confined to two ultimate species of accidents falling under one proximate genus and differing to the utmost. Contrariety between more than two terms is impossible.

To explain: every quiddity—indeed, every concept—is in itself separate from any other concept whatsoever. This has nothing to do with contrariety, although the negation of the other concept is true of it. Likewise, every complete species, with its external existence and external effects, is distinct from other complete species, with their own external existence and that of their effects. They do not coincide in such a way that the existence peculiar to one species, in excluding its own nonexistence, excludes the nonexistence of some particular other species. This, too, has nothing to do with opposition or contrariety.

Contrariety, which is opposition between two existent things, requires instead that each thing exclude the other through its quiddity, be directed toward it, and resist coexistence with it.

This entails, first, a third thing for which both exist and with which both are united. That for which an existent thing exists and with which it is united is a subject in the unrestricted sense, encompassing both the substrate of a substance and the subject of an accident. Yet contrariety does not occur among substances, as will be explained. The two things must therefore be two accidents possessing a single subject.

Second, because each of the two species is directed toward the other, they must mutually exclude one another, each excluding the other through its differentia, which constitutes the completeness of its specific nature. A differentia excludes another differentia only if both divide one genus; that is, the two species must fall under one proximate genus. Understand this point.

The objection cannot be raised that, since the differentia is part of the quiddity, it has no independent judgment and that the judgment belongs to the species. The differentia is the very species in its determination, and its judgment is precisely the judgment of the species. Moreover, contrariety does not occur between the highest genera constituted by the ten categories, since more than one of them can coexist in a single locus. Quantity, quality, and the other accidents, for example, coexist in one corporeal substance. The same applies to some intermediate genera falling under one category in relation to others falling under another, and likewise to ultimate species under one category in relation to certain ultimate species under another.

Induction thus shows that contrariety occurs only between two species falling under a proximate genus of the accidental categories: blackness and whiteness, for example, which they count among visible qualities, and rashness and cowardice among psychic qualities.

As for the requirement of the utmost difference between contraries, they initially judged certain things to be contraries and subsequently encountered things intermediate between them whose character was relative. Between the contraries blackness and whiteness, for example, lie yellow, red, and green. In relation to blackness these belong to whiteness, and in relation to whiteness they belong to blackness. Similarly, courage lies between rashness and cowardice. They therefore required a contrary to differ to the utmost and to stand at the greatest distance from its contrary.

This is why they denied contrariety among substances. Among substantial species there is no relative species measured against two extremes, nor are there two extreme species differing to the utmost.

One judgment concerning contrariety is that it cannot occur between more than two terms. It is an opposition, and opposition is a relation; a single relation cannot obtain between more than two terms. This judgment applies generally to all kinds of opposition.

It is said in the Asfār: “Among the judgments concerning contrariety, given our requirement of the utmost distance, is that one thing has only one contrary. On this account, a contrary is that whose existence entails the nonexistence of the other contrary. If a thing is unitary and has several contraries, their opposition to it must be either in one respect or in several respects. If they oppose it in one respect, what is contrary to that thing is in reality a single thing and a single contrary, although several contraries were posited. If they oppose it in several respects, the thing does not possess a simple reality. It is instead like a human being, who is contrary to the hot insofar as he is cold, contrary to the cold insofar as he is hot, and contrary to many things because he contains their contraries.

“Real contrariety is therefore only between heat and coldness, or blackness and whiteness, and each term has one contrary. As for a hot thing and a cold thing, the contrariety between them is incidental.” End of quotation.

Another judgment is that contraries succeed one another in the subject, owing to the requirement of the utmost difference between them, whether or not there is an intermediate or several intermediates that, in relation to either side, belong to the other side. Its consequence is that the subject is not devoid of both together, whether they alternate in it one after the other or one contrary necessarily accompanies its existence, as whiteness accompanies snow and blackness accompanies pitch.

Another judgment is that the subject in which they succeed one another must be one in a particular sense, rather than one in a general sense. There is no impossibility in two contraries existing in two subjects, even when those subjects are one in species or genus.

Conclusion

They have disagreed over the mutual incompatibility of the one and the many, which cannot coexist in one thing in one respect. Is it an intrinsic opposition? If so, is it one of the four kinds of opposition, or a fifth kind beyond the four mentioned? If it belongs to the four, is it correlative opposition or contrary opposition? Each of these possibilities has its adherents, as detailed in the longer works.

The truth is that it does not belong to opposition in the technical sense at all. The basis of such opposition is essential otherness: the two opposing things exclude and repel one another through their very essences. Essential difference and incompatibility cannot possibly resolve into unity and concord. The one and the many are not like this. They are two divisions of the existent insofar as it is existent, and it has already been established that unity is coextensive with existence. Every existent, insofar as it is existent, is one, just as every one, insofar as it is one, is existent.

The one and the many are thus each an instance of the one. In other words, that by which the one and the many differ resolves into that by which they are united. This is characteristic of gradation, rather than opposition.

Unity and multiplicity accordingly belong to the gradation of existence. Through them existence divides into one and many, while the one remains coextensive with the existent without qualification. In the same way, existence divides into external and mental existence, while external existence is coextensive with existence without qualification; and it divides into what is actual and what is potential, while what is actual is coextensive with existence without qualification.

Furthermore, none of the four kinds of opposition, with their respective properties, applies to the one and the many. In contradiction and in privation and possession, one opposing term is the nonexistence of the other, whereas both the one and the many are existent. Correlatives are coextensive in existence, nonexistence, potentiality, and actuality, but the one and the many do not have this character. Contraries differ to the utmost, but the one and the many do not. Whatever numerical multiplicity is set against numerical unity, there is a greater multiplicity, more distant from unity, since number is infinite. There is therefore none of the four oppositions between the one and the many. Since the division is exhaustive, there is no opposition between them at all.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 194–198 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=194&type=c_fbook

STAGE VIII

Cause and Effect

المرحلة الثامنة — في العلّة والمعلول

CHAPTER 1

Establishing causality and being an effect, and that they concern existence

الفصل الأوّل — في إثبات العلّيّة والمعلوليّة وأنّهما في الوجود

It was established earlier that quiddity, considered in itself, is neither existent nor nonexistent. Its relation to existence and nonexistence is therefore equal. For either side to prevail for it, it needs something other than itself, external to its essence. Sound reason declares it impossible that either side should prevail without a determinant, whether from its own essence or from something else. You also learned earlier that saying that it needs something else for its nonexistence involves a certain figurative usage. What this really means is that the absence of the other thing needed for its existence is inseparable from the absence of its existence, because its existence depends on the existence of that other thing. Plainly, this dependence is upon the existence of the other thing, since what is nonexistent has no reality as a thing. We call this existence upon which something depends a “cause,” and the thing that depends upon the cause its “effect.”

Now what the cause produces, the influence it places in the effect, must be either the effect’s existence, its quiddity, or its quiddity’s becoming existent. But what is produced cannot be the quiddity, because, as established earlier, quiddity is intellectually considered, whereas what the effect receives from its cause is something fundamental. Moreover, causality and being an effect constitute a particular objective connection between the effect and its cause. Otherwise, everything would be the cause of everything, and everything the effect of everything. Quiddity, in its own essence, has no connection with anything else.

Nor can what is produced be the becoming, for in that case the fundamental objective influence would be the becoming, which is a relational affair subsisting in two terms, while the quiddity and its existence would, on the hypothesis, both be intellectually considered. It is impossible for something fundamental and objective to subsist in two intellectually considered terms.

Since what is produced cannot be either the quiddity or the becoming, it must be existence. This is what was to be demonstrated.

The foregoing establishes, first, that there are cause and effect. Second, every contingent thing is an effect. Third, causality and being an effect are an existential connection between an effect and its cause, and this connection obtains between the effect’s existence and the cause’s existence. Although dependence, need, and poverty are sometimes attributed to quiddity, the primary locus of need and poverty is the effect’s existence; its quiddity is needy in consequence of that existence.

Fourth, since need and poverty belong primarily to the existence that is an effect, and this existence is needy in its very essence—otherwise need would be accidental to it and it would be independent in its essence, whereas being an effect is incompatible with independence—the very essence of the effect’s existence is need itself. That is, it is not independent in itself but subsists through its cause, which bestows it.

It follows that the effect’s existence, when measured against its cause, is relational existence, existing in another. When considered in relation to its quiddity, from which it excludes nonexistence, it is existence in itself, substantial or accidental according to what the character of its quiddity requires.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 201–203 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=201&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The divisions of cause

الفصل الثاني — في انقسامات العلّة

Cause is divided into complete and incomplete. A complete cause comprises everything upon which the effect depends, so that, with it, nothing remains for the effect but to be realized. An incomplete cause comprises some, but not all, of what the effect depends upon for its realization.

They differ in that the existence of a complete cause entails the existence of the effect, as will be explained, and its nonexistence entails the effect’s nonexistence. The existence of an incomplete cause does not entail the effect’s existence, but its nonexistence does entail the effect’s nonexistence, because the effect depends upon it as well as upon something else. It should be understood that the nonexistence of the cause, whether complete or incomplete, is a complete cause of the effect’s nonexistence.

Cause is also divided into one and many, because the effect is among the concomitants of the cause’s existence, and a concomitant may be more general.

It is also divided into simple and composite. A simple cause has no parts, and a composite cause is the opposite. A cause may be simple in external reality, as are an intellect and accidents, or simple in intellectual analysis, having neither an external composition of matter and form nor an intellectual composition of genus and differentia. The simplest of simple beings is that which has no composition of existence and quiddity: the Necessary Existent, exalted is He.

Cause is also divided into proximate and remote. A proximate cause has no intermediary between itself and its effect; a remote cause has an intermediary between itself and its effect, as does the cause of a cause.

It is also divided into internal and external. The internal causes are matter in relation to what is composed of it and form—matter being that through which the thing is potential—and form in relation to the composite—form being that through which the thing is actual. They are called the "two causes of constitution." The external causes are the agent, from which the effect proceeds, and the end, for the sake of which the effect proceeds. They are called the "two causes of existence." Their explanation will follow.

Cause is also divided into genuine causes and preparatory causes. Preparatory causes bring matter closer to the agent's bestowal by preparing it to receive that bestowal, as the passing of temporal intervals brings matter closer to the occurrence of the events that occur in it.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 204–205 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=204&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The necessity of the effect's existence when its complete cause exists, and of the cause's existence when its effect exists

الفصل الثالث — في وجوب وجود المعلول عند وجود علّته التامّة — ووجوب وجود العلّة عند وجود معلولها

This is necessity relative to another, distinct from the necessity through another discussed earlier in the proposition, "A thing does not exist unless it becomes necessary."

As for the necessity of the effect's existence when its complete cause exists: if its existence were not necessary when its complete cause exists, its nonexistence would be admissible. If its nonexistence were supposed together with the existence of the complete cause, either the cause of its nonexistence—namely, the nonexistence of its cause—would be realized while the cause of its

existence existed, or it would not. In the first case, two contradictories would coexist: the cause of existence and its nonexistence. In the second, the effect's nonexistence would be realized without a cause. This is impossible.

Likewise, if the effect's nonexistence were not necessary when its cause did not exist, its existence would be admissible. Suppose it existed while the cause of its nonexistence—namely, the nonexistence of the cause of existence—was realized. If the cause of existence existed, two contradictories would coexist: the cause of existence and its nonexistence, which is the cause of nonexistence. If the cause of existence did not exist, the effect would exist while its cause did not.

Another demonstration: the effect's existence depending upon the cause's existence entails the impossibility of the effect's existing without the cause. In other words, the nonexistence of the cause is a cause necessitating the nonexistence of the effect. This effect, namely the effect's nonexistence, depends upon its cause, namely the cause's nonexistence. It must therefore be impossible when that cause is absent. This means that the effect's existence is necessary when its cause exists. Understand this.

You may object: what the contingent thing's need for a determinant and its existence's dependence upon a complete cause require is that the existence of the complete cause, in whatever domain it may be, entails the existence of the effect, in whatever domain it may be. They do not require that effect and cause be together in existence without separation in their domain.

Why, then, could the cause not exist, entailing the effect's existence although the effect did not yet exist, and then cease to exist, with the effect existing some time afterward when no cause existed? Or why could the complete cause not exist while the effect did not yet exist, and then happen to bring the effect into existence and do so? This is especially clear where the complete cause is an agent acting by choice.

I reply: there is no meaning to the intervention of nonexistence between the complete cause's existence and its effect's existence, however this is supposed. It was established above that the dependence of the effect's existence upon the cause's existence is accomplished only through an objective existential connection. Through this connection, the effect's existence is relational existence, subsisting in its very essence through the independent existence of the complete cause. Supposing the effect to exist in a domain in which its complete cause is nonexistent therefore supposes relational existence to be realized without an independent existent accompanying and sustaining it. This is an evident contradiction.

Supposing the complete cause to exist while its effect does not yet exist supposes an independent existent that actually sustains another, but has as yet no relational existent to sustain. This is an evident contradiction.

As for choice, some have supposed that an agent acting by choice, such as a human being in relation to voluntary acts, is a cause whose relation to acting and refraining is equal. It can therefore give preponderance to whichever of the two it wishes without necessitating it, because its relation to them is equal.

This is mistaken. The human being acting by choice is not a complete cause of the act, but an incomplete cause. The act has other incomplete causes, such as matter, its presence, the coincidence of the time of its presence with the time of the act, the soundness and responsiveness of the active organs, the motive for the act, the will, and many other things. When these come together, they constitute a complete cause with which the act is necessary. The human being himself is one part of the complete cause. The act's relation to him is one of possibility, not necessity. The discussion concerns the necessitation exercised by the complete cause, not by cause without qualification.

Moreover, to admit that an agent acting by choice stands in an equal relation to the act and its nonexistence is to deny the causal connection. This entails admitting that everything could be the cause of everything, and everything the effect of everything.

You may object: grant that the human being acting by choice is not a complete cause. The Necessary—exalted is His name—is nevertheless an agent acting by choice, and He is the complete cause of everything other than Himself. The world's being necessary in relation to Him is incompatible with its temporal origination. For this reason, some have maintained that the act of an agent acting by choice needs no determinant. Others have maintained that will is intrinsically a determinant, with no need for any further determinant. Another group has maintained that the Necessary—exalted is He—knows everything knowable: what He knows to be possible and about to occur, He does; what He knows to be impossible and not to occur, He does not do. Others have maintained that His acts—exalted is He—follow benefits, even though we do not know them: whatever act has a benefit at a particular time, which would be lost if He did not perform it at that time, He performs at that time and no other.

I reply: His being an agent acting by choice—exalted is He—means that there is nothing beyond Him that compels Him to act or refrain and thereby makes this necessary for Him. The thing supposed to compel Him would either be His effect or not be His effect. The latter is impossible, because it would be another necessary existent, or the act of another necessary existent, and the

proofs of oneness refute this. The former is also impossible, because it entails that an effect, whose existence subsists through the cause and is posterior to it, influences the existence of its cause, from which it receives existence.

The Necessary's acting by choice therefore does not conflict with His necessitating the act that proceeds from Himself. Nor does His necessitating the act conflict with His acting by choice in it.

As for the temporal origination of the world, meaning everything other than the Necessary: for the world to be temporally originated would mean that it is preceded by a stretch of time devoid of the world, with nothing accompanying it but the Necessary—exalted is He—and as yet no trace of the world. But the nature of time is a quantitative, contingent nature, existent and caused by the Necessary—exalted is He—and one of His acts. It is therefore part of the world.

There is no meaning to the world, which includes time, being temporally originated and preceded by temporal nonexistence. There is no temporal "before" outside time.

Some have sensed this difficulty and sought to remove it by claiming that time is an intellectually considered, imaginary affair that does not exist.

This is rejected because claiming that time is intellectually considered and imaginary amounts to admitting that there is no real temporal origination.

Others have sought to remove the difficulty by saying that time is a reality abstracted from the essence of the Necessary—exalted is He—in respect of His enduring.

The objection is that this entails change in the essence of the Necessary—exalted and sanctified is He—because what is abstracted is identical with that from which it is abstracted, and time's being intrinsically changing is self-evident.

It has been answered that what is abstracted could differ from that from which it is abstracted by failing to correspond to it.

This is rejected because allowing a disparity between what is abstracted and that from which it is abstracted is sophistry, and knowledge would thereby be abolished altogether. It also admits the falsity of the original claim.

As for the statement that an agent acting by choice may choose one of two equal alternatives rather than the other without a determinant giving it preponderance: they have illustrated this by someone fleeing a beast of prey who encounters two equal paths and chooses one without a determinant.

This is a claim without proof. The argument has already been given that, when a contingent thing has two equal alternatives, a determinant is needed for either alternative to prevail.

If it is said that the determinant is the agent, for example through his will, as in the preceding example of someone fleeing a beast of prey, the answer is that this returns to the following position, whose falsity will be explained.

As for the example of someone fleeing a beast of prey, it is not conceded. On the supposition that the alternatives are equal in every respect, the person in question would remain where he was and would not move at all.

Moreover, allowing a contingent thing to acquire preponderance without a determinant closes the path to establishing the Maker—exalted is He.

As for the statement that "will is intrinsically a determinant, through which one of several equal acts is determined without any further determinant": if will gives preponderance to an act, it does so only by being directed toward it. But its being directed in the first place toward one of several things equal in every respect is impossible.

The claim that giving preponderance to one of several equal acts is a distinctive property of will has no substance. Will is a psychic, cognitive quality that is realized only in relation to its object, to which the knowledge preceding it has given preponderance.

Unless the prior knowledge gives preponderance to the object of will, will is not realized, so that an act could acquire preponderance through it.

As for the statement that "He—exalted is He—knows everything knowable: what He knows will occur, He does; what He knows will not occur, He does not do"—or, in other words, "He does what He knows to be possible, but not what is impossible"—possibility is a necessary concomitant of quiddity. The abstraction of quiddity depends upon the realization of existence, and the thing's existence depends upon a determinant's giving it preponderance. Knowledge of possibility is therefore posterior to the determinant by several degrees and cannot be the determinant.

As for the statement that "His acts—exalted is He—are not devoid of benefits, even though we do not know them; whatever act has a benefit at a particular time, which would be lost if He did not perform it then, He delays until that time": besides being subject to the objection raised against the preceding position, the benefit supposed to be connected with the particular time of any of His acts, however it is conceived, has a contingent quiddity, neither necessary nor impossible. Like the acts possessing those benefits, it is therefore His act—exalted is He.

Everything other than Him—exalted is He—comprising both benefits and the things possessing benefits, is His act. It does not transcend the level of possibility and cannot dispense with a determining cause that is a complete cause. Beyond the contingent there is only the Necessary—

exalted is He. He is therefore the complete cause necessitating the totality of His act, which has no determinant other than Him.

Since the world is composite and has parts standing in existential relations to one another, the existence of some of its parts may indeed serve to give preponderance to the existence of others. Yet all end in the one cause besides which there is no cause and other than which there is no determinant: the Necessary—exalted is His name.

The conclusion from everything preceding is that the effect's existence is necessary when the complete cause exists.

Some who found no escape from the complete cause's necessitating its effect have said that "the cause of the world is the will of the Necessary, not His essence—exalted is He."

This is the most untenable statement made on this question. If what is meant by His will is essential will, it is identical with the essence. Saying that will is the cause would then be the same as saying that the essence is the cause, whereas the proponent distinguishes the two, accepting one and rejecting the other.

If what is meant is will as an attribute of act, which is among the attributes of act outside the essence, it would be one of the contingent things beyond the world, and from it we would infer the existence of one of the contingent things. So much for this.

As for the necessity of the cause's existence when the effect exists: if the cause's existence were not necessary when the effect existed, it would be possible, since the supposition of its impossibility is dispelled by the slightest attention. If it were possible, its nonexistence would be admissible while the effect existed with its existence subsisting through it. This would entail the effect's existing without a cause.

You may object: the effect needs its cause for origination, not for persistence. The cause could therefore cease to exist after the effect originated, while the effect remained as it was.

I reply: this rests upon the view of some that the effect needs its cause in origination but not in persistence. Once the effect originates through the cause's bringing it into existence, its need for the cause ends. They illustrate this by a building and its builder: the builder is a cause of the building, but when he has built it and the building stands, its need for the builder ceases, and the builder's nonexistence does it no harm.

This is rejected because need for a cause is an inseparable property of quiddity, owing to its possibility in becoming qualified by existence or nonexistence. Quiddity together with its possibility is preserved in persistence just as it is preserved in origination. The cause must

therefore exist in the state of persistence just as it must exist in the state of origination.

Moreover, it was established above that the effect's existence in relation to the cause is relational existence, subsisting through it and not independent of it. If the effect became independent of the cause in its persistence, it would be independent of it and would not subsist through it. This is a contradiction.

Another demonstration: it is said in the Asfār:

"This too—meaning that origination is the reason for needing a cause—is false. If we analyze origination into prior nonexistence, subsequent existence, and that existence's being after nonexistence, and then inquire into the reason for dependence upon an agent—whether it is one of these three things or a fourth thing distinct from them—none of the alternatives remains except the fourth. Prior nonexistence cannot be the reason, because it is sheer negation and is unfit for causality. Existence cannot be the reason, because it needs to be brought into existence, and this is preceded by the need for existence, which depends upon the reason for needing it. If we made existence the reason, a thing would depend upon itself through several degrees.

"As for origination, it depends upon existence, because it is a manner and an attribute of existence. You have learned that existence depends upon the reason for dependence through several degrees.

"If origination were the reason for need, it would precede itself through several degrees. The reason for dependence is therefore something additional to what has been mentioned."

The foregoing also disposes of another mistaken notion held by some: their statement that "prior nonexistence is a condition of the possibility of an act." The priority intended is temporal priority. The statement thus amounts to saying that an effect, insofar as it is the act of its cause, must be temporally originated. They justify this by saying that the perpetual existence of a thing is incompatible with its need. This position also entails the effect's not existing when the cause exists.

The reason it is refuted is that the reason for needing a cause is possibility, which is a necessary concomitant of quiddity. Quiddity accompanies the effect however its existence is supposed, with no distinction between perpetual existence and any other.

Moreover, the effect's existence is relational in relation to the cause, subsisting through it and not independent of it. It is impossible for it to turn into something independent of the independent existent through which it subsists, whether it is perpetual or finite in duration.

Moreover, this position entails that time falls outside the domain of contingent things, and the ways in which this is false have already been explained.

1. **translation:** “Necessity relative to another” (al-wujūb bi-l-qiyās) is kept distinct from “necessity through another” (al-wujūb al-ghayrī), following Stage IV, Chapter 2. The first concerns the necessary relation between the terms; the second concerns necessity conferred by a cause.
2. **translation:** “Domain” renders wiʿāʾ in the objection about the cause and effect. It denotes their context or mode of existence and should not be restricted to a spatial container.
3. **textual:** The final reply concerning will as an attribute of act retains the compressed wording, “one of the contingent things beyond the world, and from it we would infer the existence of one of the contingent things.” This reading was visually checked against the NYU/Princeton 1404 AH witness, printed pp. 163–164 (PDF pp. 167–168), and agrees with the later transcription. No explanatory premise has been inserted into the authorial text.
4. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 205–214 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=205&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

From the one, only one proceeds

الفصل الرابع — في أنّ الواحد لا يصدر عنه إلاّ الواحد

By “one” is meant a simple thing whose essence contains no compositional aspect that produces multiplicity.

The one cause is therefore a simple cause that is a cause through its simple essence. The one effect is a simple effect that is an effect through its simple essence. “One” thus means what is opposed to a many possessing parts or distinct units that cannot be referred back to one aspect.

To explain: the principle from which the effect’s existence proceeds is the cause’s existence, which is the very essence of the cause. The cause is the very existence from which the effect’s existence proceeds, even when everything else is disregarded. There must be an intrinsic affinity between an effect and its cause that specifically determines its proceeding from that cause. Otherwise, everything would be the cause of everything, and everything the effect of everything.

If many effects, insofar as they are many, distinct, and not reducible to one aspect, proceeded from one cause whose essence possessed only one aspect, many distinct and mutually opposed aspects would be established in the cause’s essence. Yet it was supposed simple and possessed of one aspect. This is a contradiction.

From the one, therefore, only one proceeds. This is what was sought.

An objection has been raised against this by appeal to a contrary consideration: it entails that the Necessary—exalted is He—cannot bring more than one thing into existence. This restricts His power, whereas it has been demonstrated that His power is unrestricted and identical with His transcendent essence.

The answer is that the supposition has been demonstrated impossible. Power does not relate to the impossible, because it is sheer nullity with no reality as a thing.

Unrestricted power therefore retains its unrestrictedness. Every existent is either His effect—exalted is He—without an intermediary, or an effect of His effect. The effect of an effect is truly an effect.

The following consequences follow from this.

First, one does not proceed from many.

If one should proceed from many, either it is one in species, possessing many individuals, each of which depends upon a particular cause, as with heat proceeding from fire, light, motion, and other things; or its unity is a weak numerical unity, like specific unity, so that its existence depends upon many. An example is numerically one prime matter whose existence depends upon an immaterial being that sustains it through forms coming successively to it, one after another, as the philosophers have said. The discussion of this has already been given.

Alternatively, the many possess an aspect of unity upon which the effect depends; or the many constitute a composite possessing parts that produces the one through one of those parts, so that the production is attributed to the composite itself.

Second, many causes do not act upon one effect, whether they act jointly at the same level or successively, with one cause taking over from another. The first entails a contradiction in the essence of the one by making it many. The second entails the same impossibility just mentioned.

Third, if many proceed from one, it must contain an aspect of multiplicity and composition upon which the many depend, besides the supposed aspect of unity. An example is a single human being who performs many acts belonging to many categories distinct in their entire essences.

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1. **translation:** The “one” in this principle is explicitly defined as what is simple in the respect from which it acts. The chapter separately treats specific unity, weak numerical unity, and composite agents; these qualifications belong to the author’s formulation.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 214–216 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=214&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The impossibility of circularity and infinite regress in causes

الفصل الخامس — في استحالة الدور والتسلسل في العلل

Circularity is a thing’s existence depending upon something whose existence depends upon it. It may occur without an intermediary, as when A depends upon B and B depends upon A; this is called “explicit circularity.” Or it may occur through an intermediary, as when A depends upon B, B upon C, and C upon A; this is called “implicit circularity.”

Its impossibility is close to self-evident, because it entails a thing's preceding itself in existence, which is necessarily impossible.

Infinite regress is an existent thing's being ordered after another thing actually existing together with it, the second being similarly ordered after a third, the third after a fourth, and so on without end.

The series may extend in this way in both directions, with something prior before every prior and something posterior after every posterior, or in one direction only.

In every case, however, the conditions are that the members of the series actually exist, that they coexist in existence, and that there be an ordering among them.

Infinite regress in causes is an effect's being ordered after a cause, its cause after another cause, and its cause's cause after another cause, and so on without end.

Infinite regress in causes is impossible.

The demonstration is that the effect's existence is relational in relation to its cause and subsists only through its cause. The cause is the independent existent that sustains it, as established above.

If its cause is the effect of a third, and so on, that cause is not independent in relation to what is above it. If the series went on without end and did not terminate in an uncaused cause that was independent and not relational, none of the series' members would be realized. Relational existence is impossible except together with an independent existent.

Another demonstration is known as the demonstration of the intermediate and the extremity. The Shaykh set it out in the Shifāʾ, where he says:

"If we suppose an effect, a cause of that effect, and a cause of its cause, it is impossible for every cause to have a cause without end. For if the effect, its cause, and its cause's cause are considered as a whole with respect to their relations to one another, the cause of the cause is an unqualified first cause of the other two. Both of the others stand to it as effects, though they differ in that one is an effect through an intermediary and the other an effect without an intermediary. Neither the final term nor the intermediate is such a cause: the intermediate, which is the cause immediately adjoining the effect, is a cause of only one thing, and the effect is not a cause of anything.

"Each of the three has a distinctive property. The property of the extremity that is an effect is that it is not a cause of anything. The property of the other extremity is that it is a cause of everything other than itself. The property of the intermediate is that it is a cause of one extremity and an effect of the other, whether the intermediate is one or more than one.

“If it is more than one, it makes no difference whether its ordering is finite or infinite. If it is ordered in a finite multiplicity, the total number of terms between the two extremities is like a single intermediary, sharing the property of a single intermediary in relation to the two extremities. Each extremity will then have its own distinctive property. Likewise, if it is ordered in an infinite multiplicity so that no extremity is present, the whole of the infinite has the property of an intermediary. For whatever aggregate you take is a cause of the final effect’s existence and is itself an effect: each of its members is an effect, and the aggregate’s existence depends upon them. Whatever depends for its existence upon an effect is an effect. Yet that aggregate is a condition of the final effect’s existence and a cause of it. However much you increase what you delimit and take together, this judgment remains, without end.

“It is therefore impossible for an aggregate of causes to exist without there being among them an uncaused, first cause. For the whole of the infinite would be like an intermediary without an extremity, and this is impossible.”

Another demonstration, known as “the firmest and shortest,” is due to al-Fārābī. Each member of a series actually extending in order without end is like every other in that it does not exist unless another beyond it exists beforehand. It is therefore true of all the infinite members taken together that they do not enter existence unless something beyond them already exists beforehand.

The self-evident judgment of reason is then: from where could anything in that series come to exist, so that anything after it could exist?

Other arguments have been offered for the impossibility of infinite regress, most of which are open to objections.

A clarification

Some have said:

“The criterion for judging impossibility in every demonstration offered against infinite regress is the joint fulfillment, in the direction of infinity, of the two conditions of ordering and actual coexistence in existence. These entail the impossibility of infinite regress among causes in the ascending direction, where causes are ordered without end, but not in the descending direction, where an effect is ordered after its cause, then the effect’s effect after the effect, and so on without end.

“The difference is that causes are together at the degree of the effect’s existence and encompass it. Their priority over it is discerned only through a kind of analysis. Effects, by contrast, are not at the degree of their causes. The series’ ascending therefore entails the ordered causes’ coming

together with their actual existences at the degree of the effect from which the series begins, for example. In a descending series, by contrast, the ordered descending effects do not come together upon the first cause from which the series begins, for example."

This concludes the summary of that statement.

You will recognize that the two preceding demonstrations, transmitted from the Shaykh and al-Fārābī, apply to both ascending and descending series when the series consists of complete causes.

As for incomplete causes, the two demonstrations apply when the series ascends, because the incomplete cause must exist when the effect exists and together with it. This differs from a descending series, because the effect need not exist when the incomplete cause exists.

The claim that the criterion of impossibility is the infinite's coming together in one member of the series, and that this occurs in ascent but not in descent, is therefore not conceded.

Another clarification

It was established above that infinite regress is impossible only when the members of the series actually exist, coexist in existence, and are ordered one after another.

If some members exist potentially, as with some degrees of number, it is not impossible, because what actually exists of it is always finite. Likewise, if the members actually exist but do not coexist in existence, as with temporal events, some of which are nonexistent when others exist, it is not impossible, because what exists of them is always finite. Likewise, it is not impossible if they actually exist together but lack an ordering among them, meaning that some do not depend upon others in existence: for example, an infinite number of existents among which there is neither causality nor being caused.

The reason is that, when any of these three conditions is absent, there is no single existent infinite series to which the demonstrations of impossibility could apply.

Another clarification

The preceding demonstration entails the impossibility of infinite regress in all the kinds of causes: efficient, final, material, and formal. It also entails its impossibility among complete causes, because the ground of impossibility is existential dependence extending without end, which occurs in every kind of cause.

This also establishes the impossibility of infinite regress among the parts of a quiddity: for example, a genus having a genus without end, or a differentia having a differentia without end. For genus and differentia are matter and form taken without condition. Moreover, if a single quiddity

were composed of infinitely many parts, its intellection would be impossible, which is false.

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1. **translation:** The chapter requires actual existence, coexistence, and existential ordering for the regress it rules out. It expressly distinguishes this from potential infinity, succession of temporal events, and an infinity lacking causal ordering. “Beforehand” in the al-Fārābī argument expresses the priority at issue in the causal series; it need not mean an earlier time.
2. **translation:** “Taken without condition” renders lā bi-sharṭ, the logical consideration under which matter and form are genus and differentia. The phrase does not mean that their existence is unconditioned.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 216–221 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=216&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The efficient cause

الفصل السادس — في العلّة الفاعليّة

It was established above that a contingent quiddity, in becoming qualified by existence, needs a determinant of its existence. Reason has no doubt that the determinant of existence has a role in relation to existence different from the role that quiddity has in relation to it.

The determinant, or some of its parts, has a role in relation to existence resembling giving, which we call “action” or something conveying that meaning. Quiddity has a role resembling taking, which we call “reception” or something conveying that meaning.

It is impossible for quiddity to possess the role of the determinant, for then it would not need a determinant. Nor can the determinant possess the role of quiddity, for this would contradict the supposition.

It is also impossible for the two roles to be identical. The role that is reception necessarily accompanies lack, while the role that is action necessarily accompanies possession.

This meaning is clear in the actual events we observe in the material realm. They involve causes moving matter toward forms that it lacks, so that it receives those forms and takes shape through them. Had it possessed them, it would not receive them while possessing them. Reception therefore necessarily accompanies lack. What belongs to the causes is action appropriate to their essences, necessarily accompanying possession.

A material event therefore depends for its existence upon a cause that produces it, which we call an “efficient cause,” and upon a cause that receives it, which we call a “material cause.” It will be established that there exist contingent quiddities immaterial and free of matter. Because of their possibility, they need a determining cause; because of their immateriality, they have no need for a material cause. They therefore also have an efficient cause.

No contingent existence, whether material or immaterial, can dispense with an efficient cause. Whoever seeks to restrict causes to the material cause and deny the efficient cause seeks to establish an act without an agent: he has mistaken swelling for fatness.

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1. **translation:** The closing Arabic proverb, fa-stasmana dhā waram, literally describes taking a swollen creature for a fat one. It conveys mistaking an unsound appearance for a substantial result.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 221–222 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=221&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The divisions of the efficient cause

الفصل السابع — في أقسام العلّة الفاعليّة

They have distinguished several kinds of agent, which some have counted as eight. Their classification proceeds as follows. An agent either possesses knowledge of its act that contributes to the act, or it does not. In the second case, either its act agrees with its nature, and it is an “agent by nature,” or its act does not agree with its nature, and it is an “agent by constraint.” In the first case, namely where it possesses knowledge of its act that contributes to it, either the act is not by its will, and it is an “agent by coercion,” or the act is by its will. In the latter case, either its knowledge of its act is at the degree of the act—indeed, identical with the act—and it is an “agent by consent,” or its knowledge of its act precedes the act. In this latter case, either its knowledge of the act is accompanied by a motive additional to its essence, and it is an “agent by intention,” or it is not accompanied by any additional motive and the knowledge itself is the principle from which the effect proceeds. In this last case, either its knowledge is additional to its essence, and it is an “agent by providence,” or it is not additional, and it is an “agent by manifestation.” An agent, however conceived, is an “agent by subordination” if both it and the act attributed to it are the act of another agent.

The efficient cause thus has eight divisions.

First: the agent by nature. This is an agent with no knowledge of its act, whose act nevertheless agrees with its nature. An example is the soul at the degree of the natural bodily faculties: it performs their acts by nature.

Second: the agent by constraint. This is an agent with no knowledge of its act, whose act does not agree with its nature. An example is the soul at the degree of the natural bodily faculties when they deviate through illness. Their acts then deviate from the course of health because of constraining factors.

Third: the agent by coercion. This is an agent that knows its act, which is not performed by its will, as when a human being is coerced into doing something he does not will.

Fourth: the agent by consent. This is an agent that wills its act through knowledge, whose detailed knowledge of the act is identical with the act itself. Before the act, it has only comprehensive knowledge of it through its knowledge of its own essence, which entails comprehensive knowledge of its effect. An example is a human being who produces imaginal forms: his detailed knowledge of them is identical with those forms. Before they exist, he has comprehensive knowledge of them through knowing his own essence as their producer. Another example is the Necessary's agency in relation to things—exalted is He—according to the Illuminationists.

Fifth: the agent by intention. This is an agent possessing knowledge and will, whose detailed knowledge of its act precedes the act, with an additional motive. An example is a human being in voluntary acts; another is the Necessary according to the majority of the theologians.

Sixth: the agent by providence. This is an agent possessing knowledge prior to its act and additional to its essence, where the cognitive form itself is the principle from which the act proceeds, without an additional motive. An example is a human being on a high tree trunk who falls to the ground merely by imagining that he will fall. Another example is the Necessary—exalted is He—in bringing things into existence, according to the Peripatetics.

Seventh: the agent by manifestation. This is an agent that performs an act and possesses detailed knowledge of it identical with its comprehensive knowledge of its own essence. An example is the immaterial human soul. Since it is the ultimate form of its species, it is, despite its simplicity, the principle of all its secondary perfections. Because it is their cause, it possesses them in its own essence. Its knowledge of its essence by presence is knowledge of the details of its perfections, even though these are not distinguished from one another. Another example is the Necessary—exalted is He—on the basis of what will be explained, God willing: He has comprehensive knowledge of things in the very act of detailed disclosure.

Eighth: the agent by subordination. This is an agent that, together with its act, belongs to another agent; it is therefore an agent subordinated in its act. Examples are the natural, vegetative, and animal faculties subordinated to the human soul in their acts, and the cosmic causes subordinated to the Necessary—exalted is He.

There is a difficulty in counting the agent by coercion and the agent by providence as two distinct kinds, each separate from the agent by intention. To explain: we attribute the operations accompanying every observed species—that is, its secondary perfections—to that species itself. Every species is thus an efficient cause of its secondary perfections. Species are of two kinds in

this respect. Some produce their acts through their nature without the mediation of knowledge, as with the elements. Others produce acts in which knowledge plays a part, as with human beings. The second kind is equipped with knowledge, and there is no doubt that it is equipped with it only to distinguish acts that are its perfection from those that are not, so that it may perform what contains its perfection and refrain from what does not. For example, a child puts what he picks up into his mouth. If he finds it suitable for nourishment, such as fruit, he eats it; if not, he leaves it and throws it away. Knowledge thus mediates to identify the act containing perfection and distinguish it from others. If the knowledge and assent that mediate are present to the agent and require no deliberative thought for assent—as with knowledge arising from established dispositions and the like—he immediately wills and performs the act. If the matter is doubtful and requires assent, he begins applying descriptions and attributes of perfection to the act. If this ends in assent that it is a perfection, he performs it; if it ends in the contrary, he refrains. This inclination and turning toward one of the alternatives is what we call “choice,” and we count the act proceeding from it as a voluntary act.

It is therefore clear that the act of this kind of knowing agent depends upon the presence of assent to the necessity of the act: that is, to its being a perfection and to the opposite alternative, refraining, being otherwise. If assent to this is present in the soul without any need for intellectual effort, the agent immediately performs the act. If it is not present, deliberation and thought are needed until necessity and preponderance are applied to the act to be performed, and impossibility and lack of preponderance to refraining from it. It makes no difference whether the act’s preponderance and the lack of preponderance in refraining arise from the nature of the situation or from a coercer’s coercion. An example of the first is someone seated beneath a wall on the point of collapsing upon him, who stands up for fear that it will fall on him. An example of the second is someone seated in the shade of a wall, whom a tyrant threatens that, unless he stands up, he will bring the wall down upon him. He too stands up for fear of its falling upon him. In both cases, the act is willed, and the assent is of the same kind.

It follows that a coerced act is not distinct from a voluntary act, nor does it differ from it in external existence in a way that makes the agent by coercion a separate division alongside the agent by intention.

The most the coercer does is to make the act have only one alternative. The coerced agent then confronts an act with only one alternative, which he can only perform, just as if the act were such by its own nature.

Rational people have, indeed, distinguished the two acts in their social practices, to preserve the good of society and uphold their prevailing laws, which entail praise and blame, reward and punishment. The division of acts into voluntary and coerced is therefore an intellectually considered division, not a real division.

It also follows that the agent by providence is a kind of agent by intention. The conception of falling entertained by someone standing on a high tree trunk, for example, is the same knowledge present both in the frightened person whom the conception of falling overwhelms, so that he falls, and in someone accustomed to standing there through repeated practice, who neither fears nor falls. An example of the latter is a builder on very high buildings and walls.

Someone who climbs onto a high wall and stands there knows that he may remain in place and be safe, or fall from it and perish. If fear and severe alarm overwhelm him and draw his soul into attending exclusively to the conception of falling, he falls. This differs from the person accustomed to it, in whom both forms are present without fear or alarm. He chooses to remain in place and therefore does not fall.

This providential act’s lack of a proper rational end does not entail its being devoid of any motive whatever. Motive is more general than such an end, as will be explained in the discussion of play and futile activity.

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1. **translation:** The eight labels render bi-l-ṭabʿ, bi-l-qasr, bi-l-jabr, bi-l-riḍā, bi-l-qaṣd, bi-l-ʿināya, bi-l-tajallī, and bi-l-taskhīr. “Constraint” is reserved here for qasr and “coercion” for jabr, maintaining the distinction drawn in the initial classification.
2. **translation:** “Providence” renders ʿināya in a technical classification of agency. Here the immediate principle of action is a cognitive form without an additional motive; the term is also applied to the human example of imagining a fall. The author subsequently challenges the separation of this class from intentional agency.
3. **translation:** “Comprehensive” knowledge renders ijmālī in contrast to tafṣīlī, “detailed.” In agency by manifestation the author explicitly identifies comprehensive knowledge with detailed disclosure; “comprehensive” should therefore not be read as merely vague or incomplete knowledge.
4. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 222–226 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=222&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

None exercises efficacy in existence, in the true sense of the word, except God—glorified is He

الفصل الثامن — في أنّه لا مؤثِّر في الوجود بحقيقة معنى الكلمة إلاّ الله سبحانه

It was established above that causality and being caused pervade existents. Every existent is either a cause that is not an effect, an effect that is not a cause, or a cause of something and an effect of something. It was established that the series of causes terminates in an uncaused cause, the Necessary—exalted is He. It was established that He—exalted is He—is one with true oneness,

admitting neither a second nor repetition, and that every supposed existent other than Him is necessary through Him and possible in itself. It was established that the effect cannot dispense with its efficient cause, just as it cannot dispense with its complete cause. He—exalted is He—is therefore the complete cause of all precisely while being an efficient cause. It was established that causality concerns existence, which is the effect of the maker, and that the effect's existence is relational in relation to its cause and subsists through it. Likewise, the cause's existence is independent in relation to the effect and sustains it. No determination belongs to the effect except one that belongs to the cause's existence and exists through it.

He—exalted is He—is therefore the agent absolutely independent in being a principle, subsisting through Himself in His bestowal of existence and His causality. He exercises efficacy in the true sense of the word. None exercises efficacy in existence except Him. Nothing other than Him possesses more than relative independence, whereas independence is the ground of causality and the bestowal of existence. Efficient causes within existence are therefore preparatory causes bringing effects nearer to the bestowal of the first principle and the agent of all—exalted is He.

This is with regard to the fundamental reality of existence realized through its degrees in concrete things. With regard to the substantial and accidental quiddities considered by the intellect, qualified by existence and independent in this respect, He—exalted is He—is the cause in which all causes terminate. Whatever things terminate in Him without an intermediary have Him as their cause; whatever terminate in Him through an intermediary have Him as the cause of their cause. The cause of a thing's cause is a cause of that thing. He—exalted is He—is therefore the agent of everything, and all causes are subordinated to Him.

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1. **translation:** The chapter distinguishes two standpoints: existence as fundamental, and the intellect's consideration of substantial and accidental quiddities. Its description of intermediate efficient causes as preparatory belongs to the first standpoint; the final paragraph retains their causal ordering under the second.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 226–227 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=226&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

An agent complete in its agency is stronger than its act and prior to it

الفصل التاسع — في أنّ الفاعل التامّ الفاعليّة أقوى من فعله وأقدم

That the agent is stronger and more intense in existence follows from the fact that the act, which is its effect, is relational in relation to it and subsists through it in its very identity. The agent is the independent being that sustains and encompasses it. This is all that we mean by greater intensity of existence. This applies to the complete cause just as it applies to the efficient agent.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may God have mercy on him—counted this question as self-evident, saying: “Self-evidence judges that the efficient cause is intrinsically stronger than its effect in that through which it exercises causality. In anything else, this cannot be affirmed with certainty at the outset.” End of quotation.

As for its being prior in existence to its act, this belongs to the innately evident propositions, because the existence of the act depends upon the existence of its agent. This too applies not only to the agent but also to the complete cause and the other causes.

It has been said: “The complete cause is together with the effect, because its parts include matter and form, which are together with the effect—indeed, identical with it. It therefore does not precede the effect, since this would entail a thing’s preceding itself.”

The answer is that matter, as established above, is a material cause of the aggregate of matter and form, namely the composite thing. Likewise, form is a formal cause of the aggregate of the two. The aggregate produced from them, however, is not a cause of anything. Each of the two is a prior cause, while the aggregate is a posterior effect. There is therefore no difficulty.

This is the meaning of the statement: “What is prior is all the individual components; what is posterior is the aggregate on condition of their being combined.”

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 227–228 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=227&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

A simple thing cannot be both agent and recipient

الفصل العاشر — في أنّ البسيط يمتنع أن يكون فاعلا وقابل

The prevalent position among the philosophers is that one thing, insofar as it is one, cannot be both agent and recipient under any circumstances. The qualification “in one respect” excludes material species, which act through their forms and receive through their matters, as fire produces heat through its form and receives it through its matter. Later thinkers have maintained that this is permissible without qualification.

The truth is to distinguish two cases. Where reception means affection and external acquisition of perfection, reception and action cannot coexist in one thing insofar as it is one. Where reception means being characterized by something and its being abstracted from the thing’s essence, without external affection or being affected, as with the necessary concomitants of quiddities, the two can coexist.

The argument is that reception in the sense of affection and being affected necessarily accompanies lack, whereas action necessarily accompanies possession. These are two distinct, mutually opposed aspects that cannot coexist in one thing insofar as it is one. As for the necessary concomitants of quiddities, such as the evenness of four, the complete essence cannot be conceived as devoid of its necessary concomitant, so that lack could be conceived in it. Reception here means only being characterized by something, and there is no difficulty in this.

The proponents of the prevalent view have offered two arguments for impossibility without qualification.

The first is that action and reception are two distinct effects and therefore cannot proceed from one thing insofar as it is one.

The second is that the relation of the recipient to what it receives is one of possibility, whereas the relation of the agent complete in its agency to its act is one of necessity. If one thing were both agent and recipient of something, its relation to that thing would be both possibility and necessity. These are incompatible, and incompatibility between necessary consequences entails incompatibility between that of which they are consequences.

Even if these two arguments were complete, they would establish no more than the impossibility of action and reception—in the sense of affection and being affected—coexisting in one thing insofar as it is one. Reception in the sense of being characterized by something, as quiddities are characterized by their necessary concomitants, is not an effect proceeding from the essence and preceded by possibility.

Moreover, neither argument is free of difficulty.

As for the first, making reception an effect proceeding from the recipient entails that the recipient is an efficient cause of reception. The difficulty would then arise in a simple recipient’s receiving form, since it produces reception and becomes a part of the composite. These are two effects that do not proceed from one.

As for the second, the relation of the efficient cause, insofar as it is one of the four causes, to the act is not a relation of necessity. The mere existence of the efficient cause does not require the effect’s existence unless the other causes join it—unless, of course, the agent alone is a complete cause. Merely supposing the agent complete in its agency, meaning that it is an actual agent through the remaining causes joining it, does not change its own relation to the act from possibility to necessity.

Later thinkers have argued for the permissibility of one thing's being both agent and recipient, insofar as it is one, by appealing to the necessary concomitants of quiddities, especially simple quiddities. Every such quiddity has a concomitant or concomitants, such as contingency and its being a quiddity and a concept. The same applies to concepts abstracted from the essence of the Necessary—exalted is He—such as necessity of existence and oneness. The essence is both their agent and their recipient.

As you have learned, this argument is complete only where reception means being characterized by something. Reception and action are then one.

Where reception is affection, being affected, and acquiring perfection, however, reception necessarily accompanies lack and action necessarily accompanies possession. These are incompatible and do not coexist in one thing.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 228–230 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=228&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

The final cause and the proof of its existence

الفصل الحادي عشر — في العلّة الغائيّة وإثباتها

It will be explained, God willing, that motion is the first perfection of what is potential insofar as it is potential. There is therefore a second perfection toward which the moving thing directs itself through the motion that terminates in it. This is the final perfection that the moving thing attains through its motion. It is sought for its own sake, whereas motion is sought for its sake. Hence the saying: "Motion is not sought for its own sake, nor is it something that a thing's essence requires."

This second perfection is what is called "the end of motion." Through it the moving thing acquires perfection. Its relation to motion is that of completeness to deficiency. No motion is without it; otherwise, motion would turn into rest.

Because of the connection and fixed relation between the end and motion, there is a kind of unity between them. Through this, the end is related to the mover just as motion is, and is related to the moving thing just as motion is.

When the mover is nature and it moves a body through one of the accidental motions—in position, quality, quantity, or place—through which the body acquires perfection, the end is the completeness toward which the moving thing directs itself through its motion and which the moving nature seeks through its causing motion. Without the end, there would be neither the mover's causing motion nor the moving thing's motion.

A body moving, for example, from one position to another seeks the second position. It directs itself toward it by leaving the first position for a flowing position, in which it exchanges one instantaneous instance for another like it, until it settles into a fixed, unchanging position and remains there. This is the completeness sought for its own sake, and the mover also seeks it.

If the mover is a knowing agent whose knowledge contributes to its act, as with animal and human souls, the motion together with its end, which is completeness, is willed by it. But the end is willed for its own sake, and motion follows it, since motion is for the sake of the end, as established above. A knowing agent may, however, imagine something that necessarily accompanies the end or happens alongside it to be the end of the motion. It then takes this as that in which the motion terminates, sets up an imagined association between the two, and directs the motion toward it. Examples are someone who moves to a place to meet a friend, walks to a watering place to drink water, or goes to the market to buy and sell.

All this concerns an act that is an accidental motion, whether natural or voluntary.

When the act is substantial, as with substantial species, the case is as follows. If it belongs to the substances that have some connection with matter, it will be shown, God willing, that all of these undergo substantial motion. Their existences are flowing, terminating in fixed, nonflowing existences in which they come to rest. They therefore have a completeness that is the direction toward which they turn. Their efficient, moving causes will this completeness for its own sake, and their substantial motions are willed for its sake. If the act belongs to the substances immaterial in both essence and action, then, because its existence is actual and free of potentiality, it is not divided into completeness and deficiency as other things are. Rather, it is complete in itself, willed for its own sake and intended for its own sake. Act and end are one here: the act, in its reality at the level of the agent’s existence, is an end for that same act in its attenuated reality. This does not mean that the act is its own final cause, prior to itself, for a thing’s being its own cause is impossible.

It has thus become clear that every agent has an end in its act, and this is the act’s final cause. This was what was sought.

Several points follow from the foregoing.

First: the end of an act—that to which the agent’s exigency is directed primarily and for its own sake—may be one with the act. This means that the end is the reality of the act established at the level of the agent’s existence, and amounts to the unity of the agent and the end. This is the case when the agent’s act is an existent immaterial in essence and action, fully actual in itself and willed for its own sake. The end may also not be one with the act, the two being distinct. This is the case

when the act is an accidental motion, or belongs to the substances that have some connection with matter, such as souls and forms impressed in matters. The agent attains ends of this kind through causing motion, and motion is not sought for its own sake. Motion is therefore realized, and the end follows it. The end may return to the agent, as when someone is saddened by an afflicted person's suffering and removes it in quest of joy; or to the matter, as when someone moves into a position that improves his condition; or to something other than either, as when someone honours an orphan to make the orphan happy.

Second: knowing agents know the end before the act, even if the end is realized after the act and follows upon it. Agents of this kind will their acts, and will, whatever its character, is preceded by knowledge. If there is a causing of motion, the motion is willed for the sake of the end. The end is thus willed by the agent before the act. If there is no causing of motion and the act itself is the end, willing and knowing the act are willing and knowing the end.

The saying that "the end is before the act in conception and after it in existence" holds only for ends other than those of natures, since natures lack knowledge.

The saying that "the final cause is an efficient cause of the agent's agency" is not without looseness of expression. Natural agents have no knowledge, so their ends cannot be cognitively present to them in a manner that gives the agent its agency. As for external existence, the end's existence follows that of the act, and the act is posterior in existence to the agent insofar as it is an agent. It is therefore impossible for the end to be a cause of the agent's agency.

As for knowing agents that are not natural agents, either their end is identical with their act, in which case the act is an effect of its agent and an effect cannot be a cause of its cause; or their end's existence follows that of their act and is posterior to it, in which case it cannot be a cause of that act's prior agent. The end's cognitive presence to the agent before the act is a mental existence, too weak to be a cause of an external thing, namely the agent insofar as it is an agent.

The truth, as will be explained in detail, is that knowing agents, through their specific existences, are efficient causes of the acts connected with them and belonging to them as consequences of their specific natures. Similarly, every natural species is an efficient principle of the acts occurring about it and proceeding from it. Since these are knowing agents, however, the presence in them of the cognitive form of the act is a condition completing their agency, upon which their actual exercise of causality depends.

This is what is meant by the final cause's being a cause of the efficient cause's agency. Otherwise, the agent, through its specific nature, is an efficient cause of the acts proceeding from it and subsisting in it. These are its secondary perfections, through which it acquires perfection.

Third: although at first sight the end sometimes returns to the agent, sometimes to the matter, and sometimes to something other than either, closer consideration shows that it always returns to the agent. Someone who does good to a poor person to make that person happy suffers at the sight of the wretched condition he sees him in; through his beneficence, he wishes to remove that suffering from himself. Likewise, someone who travels to a place to rest there really wishes to relieve himself of the awareness of the fatigue he experiences in his body.

In general, an act is always of a kind with its agent, suited to it and pleasing to it; the same holds for the end that follows the act. It is therefore a good and a perfection for the agent.

It has been said: “The higher does not acquire perfection through the lower and does not will it, because it is a cause, and a cause is stronger in existence and higher in rank than its effect.”

The answer, as has been said, is that the agent wills the lower only insofar as it is one of its own effects. In reality, will is directed primarily to the agent itself, and derivatively to the end that follows the act.

When an agent conceives the perfective end, it sees itself in respect of its exigency and causality for that end. A hungry person who wishes to eat in order to become satiated, for example, sees himself in respect of his exigency for this act upon which the end follows. That is, he sees himself as possessing satiety in respect of that exigency, and wishes to become such in actual external existence.

If the agent has some connection with matter, it acquires perfection through the actuality of the end, which is its own essence insofar as it is an agent. As for the end outside its essence whose existence follows the act, it acquires perfection through this derivatively.

If the agent is immaterial in both essence and action, it is complete in itself and does not acquire perfection through its end, which is its fully actual essence and, in reality, its complete essence.

The foregoing therefore shows, first, that the agent’s end in its act is its own acting essence insofar as it acts. The end of the act that follows upon it is an end willed only derivatively.

Second, the end is always a perfection for the agent. If the agent has some connection with matter, it acquires perfection through the end that is its own acting essence insofar as it acts. If it is entirely immaterial, the end is identical with its essence, which is the perfection of its essence, without being perfection after deficiency or actuality after potentiality.

It is thus clear that the saying, “Every agent that has an end in its act acquires perfection through its end and benefits from it,” is not without looseness of expression. It holds universally only for agents that have some connection with matter.

Notice. Some theologians have maintained that the Necessary—exalted is He—has no end in His acts, because He is intrinsically independent of everything else. This is what they mean when they say: “God’s acts are not explained by purposes.” Other theologians have maintained that He—exalted is He—has ends and benefits in His acts that return to others and from which His creation benefits.

The first view is refuted by what has already been established: an agent’s act must either be a good sought by it for its own sake or terminate in a good sought for its own sake. The existence of an end does not entail the agent’s need for it, since the end may be identical with the agent, as established above.

The second view does not entail His—exalted is He—need for another, His acquiring perfection through the ends that follow His acts, or His benefiting from them. Nevertheless, it still entails the higher’s willing the lower and the nobler’s seeking the less noble. If the end that called Him to act, and upon which His act and indeed His agency depended, were the good and benefit following upon the act, something other than Him would exercise some influence upon Him. Yet He is a first agent, complete in agency, whose agency does not depend upon anything.

Rather, the truth, as established above, is that an agent insofar as it is an agent has, in reality, no end for its act other than its own acting essence insofar as it acts. Nothing impels it toward the act except itself, and the end that follows the act is an end only derivatively. He—exalted is He—is an agent complete in agency and a first cause in which every cause terminates. His essence—exalted is He—insofar as it is identical with knowledge of the order of good, is the end of His essence that acts to produce every good other than Him and is the principle of every perfection other than Himself.

Our statement that “the agent’s agency depends upon the final cause,” which appears to distinguish what depends from that upon which it depends, does not contradict our statement that “the end of the necessary essence is identical with the transcendent essence.” What is meant here by dependence and exigency is the more general sense of inseparability.

As Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn indicated, this belongs to those instances of verbal looseness in which reliance is placed upon the understanding of someone trained in the sciences. An example is their explanation of the intrinsically Necessary as “that which, through its essence, requires existence,” or as “an existent necessary through its essence.” The wording appears to make the essence a cause of its existence, although its existence is identical with it.

In general, His—exalted is He—knowledge in His essence of the order of good is the end of His agency, which is identical with His essence. Indeed, deeper investigation shows that He—exalted is He—is the end of ends.

You have learned that the existence of every effect, insofar as it is an effect, is relational in relation to its cause and has no independence apart from it. It is clear that dependence cannot have its complete meaning without being related to something depended upon in its own right; otherwise, there would be an infinite regress. Likewise, seeking, intending, willing, directing oneself, and the like cannot be realized in their proper meanings without terminating in something sought for its own sake, intended for its own sake, willed for its own sake, and approached for its own sake.

Since He—exalted is He—is the first cause in which the existence of everything other than Him terminates, He is the independence of every independent thing and the support of everything that relies upon another. No seeker seeks and no willing being wills anything but Him; no being turns toward anything but Him, whether without an intermediary or through one. He—exalted is He—is therefore the end of everything that has an end.

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1. **translation:** “Exigency” renders iqtiḍāʾ: what the agent’s nature calls for or requires. In the example of hunger, the text distinguishes satiety as required by the agent’s nature from satiety actually realized externally; it does not say the hungry person is already actually satiated.
2. **translation:** The identity of act and end in an immaterial act is stated through the distinction between its higher reality (ḥaqīqa) in the agent and its attenuated reality (raqīqa) as effect. The translation retains this qualification, which prevents the claim from becoming an assertion that a thing causes itself.
3. **textual:** The phrase rendered “sets up an imagined association between the two” is the terse wa-yūjidu baynahumā takhayyulan (ويوجد بينهما تخيلا). It is retained without emendation: the wording also appears in the 1404 AH NYU/Princeton scan, printed p.181 (PDF p.185). The translation takes this to describe an imagined association by which something accompanying the proper end is adopted as the end of the motion.
4. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 230–237 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=230&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Unpremeditated action, necessary intention, habit, and similar acts are not without an end

الفصل الثاني عشر — في أنّ الجزاف والقصد الضروري والعادة وما يناظرهامن — الأفعال لا تخلو عن غاية

It may be imagined that some voluntary acts have no end: children’s games, breathing, a sick person’s turning from side to side while asleep, playing with one’s beard, and the like. Such cases would invalidate the universality of the proposition that “every act has an end.”

This is answered by reflecting on the principles of our voluntary acts and the way their ends follow upon them.

We say: the philosophers have stated that our voluntary acts and movements by choice have a proximate principle that directly produces the movements called acts. This is the motive power distributed through the muscles, which moves them. Before the motive power there is another principle, the appetitive faculty, which culminates in will and resolve. Before the appetitive faculty there is yet another principle, the cognitive form arising from thinking or imagining that calls for the act for the sake of its end. These are three principles apart from the volitional principle.

The motive power is a natural principle with no awareness of the act. Its end is therefore that in which the motion terminates, as is the case with natural agents.

As for the other two principles—the appetitive faculty and the cognitive form—their end may be the same as that of the motive power, namely that in which the motion terminates. The three principles then share one end. An example is someone who imagines settling in a place other than his present one, longs for it, moves toward it, and settles there. Their end may also differ from that of the motive power, as when someone conceives a place other than his present one and moves there to meet a friend.

The remote principle, namely the cognitive form, may be merely imaginative, the form of the act being present in imagination without thinking. It may also be a form of thought, necessarily accompanied by a particular imagining of the act.

Furthermore, this form may alone be a principle of the appetitive faculty; or it may be its principle with assistance from nature, as in breathing; from bodily temperament, as in a sick person's turning from side to side while asleep; or from disposition and habit, as in playing with one's beard.

If the three principles agree in their end—as when someone imagines the form of a place, longs for it, and moves toward it, this being called "unpremeditated action"—the act, together with its principles, has its end.

If the cognitive principle gives rise to appetite with assistance from nature, as in breathing, or from bodily temperament, as when a sick person turns from a side on which remaining has become wearisome to another side, this is called "necessary intention." If it does so with assistance from disposition, as in playing with one's beard, the act is called "habit." Each of the act's principles has its end in these cases.

There is no difficulty in the agent's being inattentive and failing to attend to the imaginative form of the end present to it in some or all of these cases. Imagining the end is different from knowing that one imagines the end, and knowledge is different from knowledge of knowledge.

In all these cases that are called “idle play,” the end is not an end of thought. There is no difficulty in this, since the cognitive principle in them is an imaginative form rather than a form of thought. There is no principle of thought in them such that they would have an end of thought.

Alternatively, you may say that they contain a conjectural principle of thought considered in a general way, toward which the appetite arising from imagining the form of the act points. A child, for example, conceives settling in a place other than his present one. From this arises an appetite that points toward the act’s being preferable and something that should be done. He then judges its preferability in a general way; his appetite intensifies, he wills, and he acts. The act is not preceded by a detailed cognition completed by a judgement of preferability. This is like someone speaking from an acquired disposition, who utters one letter after another without detailed conception and assent. The act nevertheless proceeds from knowledge and choice.

Likewise, there is no difficulty in the absence of the end in some natural or voluntary motions that are interrupted before reaching it. In that case the act is called “abortive.” An act’s having no end is one thing; the failure of its end to occur because the motion is interrupted and comes to nothing is another. What is claimed to be impossible is the first, not the second. This is clear.

It should be known that the principles of our voluntary action are ordered as explained above. There is a motive power upon which the act follows. This power follows upon will, and will follows upon the appetitive faculty without a further will intervening between them. The appetitive faculty follows upon the cognitive form, whether a form of thought or of imagination, without a will being directed to it. Rather, knowledge itself produces appetite. This is what they have said.

Their attributing appetite to certain psychic qualities is not incompatible with this, since psychic qualities necessarily accompany knowledge.

The Shaykh says in the Shifāʾ:

“The arousal of this appetite must have some cause: either habit, or weariness with one condition and a wish to pass into another, or eagerness on the part of the motive and sensory powers to renew an act of causing motion or of sensation.

“Habit is pleasant; passing from what has become wearisome is pleasant; and eagerness for a new act is pleasant—I mean with respect to the animal and imaginative power.

“Pleasure is, in truth, the sensory, animal, and imaginative good. It is what is supposed to be good when considered in relation to the human good.

“If the principle is imaginative and animal, its good must also be imaginative and animal. This act, then, is not devoid of a good relative to it, even if this is not a true good—that is, a good with respect to intellect.” End of quotation.

Since appetite is directed only to a perfection that is lacking and does not yet exist, it belongs exclusively to a knowing agent that has some connection with matter. An immaterial agent therefore has, among the principles of voluntary action, only knowledge and will. This differs from the knowing agent that has some connection with matter: it possesses knowledge, appetite, will, and the material power that directly performs the act, as explained above. This is what they have said.

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1. **translation:** Juzāf is rendered “unpremeditated action,” not action without any end. The chapter’s argument is precisely that such action has an imaginative end even without a detailed deliberative judgement. “Necessary intention” (qaṣd ḍarūrī), “idle play” (ʿabath), and “abortive” (bāṭil) retain the distinct categories used here.
2. **textual:** The phrase ghayr al-irādiyya (غير الإرادية) is rendered “apart from the volitional principle.” The concluding paragraph expressly distinguishes knowledge, appetite, will, and the material motive power. The three principles first listed are thus counted apart from will. The same wording is visible in the 1404 AH NYU/Princeton scan, printed p.186 (PDF p.190); no Arabic emendation is made.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 237–240 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=237&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

The rejection of chance as the absence of a connection between agent and end

الفصل الثالث عشر — في نفي الاتّفاق وهو انتفاء الرابطة بين الفاعل والغاية

It may be imagined that some ends following upon acts are not intended by their agents, and therefore that not every agent has an end in its act.

Examples given are someone who digs a well to reach water and comes upon a treasure: finding the treasure is an end following upon the act, yet it is neither connected with the digger nor intended by him; and someone who enters a house to shelter in its shade, whereupon it collapses upon him and he dies: death is not an end intended by the person entering.

The first kind of chance is called “good fortune,” and the second “ill fortune.”

The truth is that there is no chance in existence. The demonstration is that possible events, with respect to their occurrence, fall into four divisions: what always occurs; what occurs for the most part; what occurs and fails to occur equally often; and what occurs only in a minority of cases.

The intellect necessarily judges that what always occurs and what occurs for the most part each have a cause. The difference between them is that what occurs for the most part is sometimes opposed by an obstacle that prevents it from occurring. What always occurs, by contrast, has no

such obstacle. Since the occasional failure of what occurs for the most part is due to an assumed obstacle, it necessarily always occurs on condition that the obstacle is absent. For example, a human child is usually born with five fingers; occasionally this fails, and a child is born with an additional finger, because an obstacle opposes the formative power in the act that it requires. On condition that the obstacle is absent, the formative power always produces five fingers.

A similar account applies to what occurs in a minority of cases. Given the particular obstacle opposing the cause that operates for the most part, it necessarily always occurs. In the example of the additional finger, whenever the formative power encounters in the receptacle surplus matter suitable for the form of a finger under its particular conditions, it always forms a finger.

An account similar to that concerning what occurs for the most part and what occurs in a minority of cases applies to what occurs and fails to occur equally often, such as Zayd’s standing and sitting.

Real causes therefore always exercise their efficacy, without failing either in their act or in their end. The assertion of chance arises from ignorance of the real causes and from attributing an end to something other than that to which it belongs.

A well-digger’s finding a treasure, when attributed to its essential cause—digging the well on condition that it is aligned with the treasure buried beneath it—is an essential end that invariably follows, and has nothing to do with chance. When attributed to digging a well without qualification and without any further condition, however, it is a chance occurrence and an accidental end attributed to something other than its invariably operative essential cause.

Similarly, the death of someone upon whom a house collapses after he has entered it for shade, when attributed to its essential cause—entering a house on the point of collapse and remaining in it until it collapses—is an essential end that invariably follows. When attributed to entering a house for shade without qualification, however, it is a chance occurrence and an accidental end attributed to something other than its essential cause.

Other particular examples of chance are to be understood on the model of these two examples. Proponents of chance have appealed to particular examples of this sort, whose character you now know.

Democritus is reported to have held that the world came to be by chance. Bodies, on this account, are composed of small, solid corpuscles dispersed in an infinite void. Their natures are alike, their shapes differ, and they are perpetually in motion. A number of them happened to collide and come together in a particular arrangement, and this world came to be. He nevertheless maintained that animals and plants do not come to be by chance.

Empedocles is reported to have held that the coming-to-be of elemental bodies occurs by chance: those that happened to combine in a manner suited to survival and reproduction survived, whereas those that happened not to do so did not survive but disintegrated.

Several arguments have been offered for this position.

The first argument: nature does not deliberate, so how can it perform its act for the sake of an end?

The answer is that deliberation does not give the act an end. It merely distinguishes the act from other acts and determines it. The end then follows upon the act in its own right, not through being made so by a maker. It is the difference between motives and deterrents that necessitates the exercise of determining deliberation. Without this, there would be no need for it. This is how acts proceeding from acquired dispositions occur. A speaker produces one letter after another in their different configurations without deliberating; if he deliberated, he would become hesitant and cease speaking. Likewise, if a craftsperson deliberated in the course of practising the craft, he would become hesitant and stop.

The second argument: in the order of nature there are kinds of corruption and death, and varieties of evil and harm, occurring in an unchanging order through causes that do not fail. These are not intended by nature but arise from the necessity of matter. Let us therefore judge that the kinds of good and benefit following nature's act likewise arise in this manner, without nature's intending them or having a motive that calls it to them.

The answer is as follows. Some of these evils consist in natural agents' failure to reach their ends because their motions are interrupted. Nature's being directed toward an end does not require that it reach it; abortive action has already been discussed. Other evils are themselves ends occurring in a constant order, in things whose good predominates over their evil. These are ends intended secondarily. The ends intended primarily are the predominant goods inseparably connected with these evils. This will be explained in detail in the discussion of divine decree. Nature, in its acts terminating in these evils, is like a carpenter who wishes to make a door from timber. He begins to carve and saw, then assembles and constructs it. A necessary consequence is the waste of some of the timber through sawing and carving. This is intended by him secondarily, as a consequence of his intention to make the door.

The third argument: one nature performs different acts. Heat, for example, melts wax, hardens salt, darkens the fuller's face, and whitens the surface of the cloth.

The answer is that one nature performs only one act having one end. The different effects following upon its act are necessary concomitants of its conjunction with diverse and different factors and impediments.

The foregoing establishes that the ends following upon agents' acts are essential ends that invariably follow their real causes and explanatory principles. Rare effects called chance occurrences are accidental ends attributed to something other than their real causes. Those very same effects invariably follow when related to their real causes.

There is therefore no avoiding the affirmation of an existential connection between them and their real efficient cause. If we could doubt the connection of these ends with their agents despite the stated invariability with which they follow, we could also doubt the connection of an act with its agent. For this reason, many proponents of chance have denied the efficient cause just as they have denied the final cause, and have confined causation to the material cause. The efficient cause has already been discussed.

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1. **translation:** "Always" and "invariably" render dāʾimī in the argument about events under their complete causal conditions. The point is not that a treasure is found whenever anyone digs any well; the text expressly adds the conditions under which the outcome follows.
2. **translation:** The accounts of Democritus and Empedocles are translated as historical attributions made in the Arabic text, including "elemental bodies" (al-ajrām al-usṭuqusiyya). They have not been replaced with a modern reconstruction of either philosopher's doctrines.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 240–243 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=240&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

The material and formal causes

الفصل الرابع عشر — في العلّة الماديّة والصوريّة

You have learned that species possessing perfection potentially cannot lack, within their essential substance, a substance that receives the actuality of their primary and secondary perfections, namely forms and accidents. If its aspect is one of potentiality in one respect and actuality in another—as with a body, which is actual with respect to its corporeality and potential with respect to the forms and accidents that supervene upon its corporeality—it is called "secondary matter." If its aspect is purely that of potentiality, it is what the analysis of secondary matter ultimately reaches: that which is potential in every respect except the respect of its being potential in every respect. It is called "hyle" and "prime matter."

Matter has causality in relation to the material species composed of it and form, because that species' existence necessarily depends upon it. Insofar as matter is a part of the composite, it is a cause of it. In relation to the other part that it receives, namely form, however, it is its matter and its effect, since, as established above, form is a co-cause of matter.

A group of naturalists has confined causality to matter alone, denying the other three causes.

This is refuted, first, by the fact that matter’s essential aspect is potentiality and reception, necessarily accompanying lack. It is evident that this does not suffice to bestow and produce actuality, which necessarily accompanies possession. The only alternative would be for actuality to come to exist without a cause, which is impossible.

Second, it has been established that a thing does not exist until it becomes necessary. Since matter’s character is possibility and reception, it cannot be the ground of this necessity abstracted from the effect’s existence, whose reality is necessity, entailment, and inseparability. There must therefore be something beyond matter that grounds the effect’s necessity and existence. This is the efficient cause that bestows the effect’s existence.

Third, matter has one nature and, if it produces an effect, produces only one uniform effect. They have conceded this. It follows that all the differences among things would have to be reduced to matter’s unity in essence and attribute. This amounts to every thing’s being identical with every other thing, which the intellect necessarily rejects.

As for the formal cause, it is form—in the sense of that through which a thing is actually what it is—in relation to the thing composed of it and matter. The composite necessarily depends upon it.

Form in relation to matter, however, is not its formal cause. Matter is not composed of form and something else, with an intrinsic need for form. Rather, it needs form for its determinate realization, which lies outside its essence. For this reason, form is a co-cause in relation to matter and gives it determinate realization, as explained above.

Know that the form giving matter determinate realization may become part of the matter in relation to a subsequent form. Consequently, the acts and effects that belonged to it when considered as the form giving matter determinate realization are attributed to the form in relation to which it has become part of the matter. Consider a plant, for example. The vegetal form gives determinate realization to the secondary matter that is the body. It has actual effects, namely the effects of corporeality and vegetative life.

When an animal form subsequently supervenes upon it, the vegetal form becomes part of its matter, and the animal form possesses the distinctive acts and effects that previously belonged to the vegetal form. Thus, whenever a new form supervenes upon a composite, the preceding forms become parts of the secondary matter, and the new form possesses the acts and effects that belonged to those preceding forms. It has already been established that the final form is the entire reality of the species.

Know also that the composition of matter and form is not a composition by juxtaposition, as is attributed to the majority. Rather, it is a unitive composition, as is required by the coming together of the indeterminate and that which gives it determinate realization, and of potentiality and actuality. Otherwise, the composition would not be real, and no new species with its own distinctive effects would result.

1. **translation:** “Co-cause” renders sharīkat al-ʿilla. Form helps cause matter’s determinate external realization; the text distinguishes this from being a formal cause of matter itself. A formal cause is here the form in relation to the composite of matter and form.
2. **translation:** “The final form is the entire reality of the species” retains the claim that the latest constitutive form encompasses the powers of the preceding forms, rather than treating the composite as a mere aggregate of independent forms.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 244–246 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=244&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 15

The corporeal cause

الفصل الخامس عشر — في العلّة الجسمانيّة

Corporeal causes are finite in their effects with respect to number, duration, and intensity, because corporeal species undergo motion in their substances and accidents. The natures and active powers they possess are therefore resolved and divided into parts, each surrounded by a preceding and a succeeding nonexistence, and limited in both essence and effect.

Moreover, corporeal causes act only when there is a particular spatial disposition between them and the matter that is affected.

The philosophers say: “Because corporeal causes need matter for their existence, they also need it for their production of existence, which follows from their own existence. Their need for matter in producing existence consists in their acquiring, through matter, a particular spatial disposition in relation to their effect.

“For this reason, proximity, distance, and particular spatial dispositions contribute to the manner in which corporeal causes exercise their efficacy.”

1. **translation:** Waḍʿ here is the spatial disposition of a corporeal cause relative to the matter on which it acts, as the following examples of proximity and distance indicate. It is not a claim about merely conventional or posited relations.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 246–246 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=246&type=c_fbook

STAGE IX

Potentiality and Actuality

المرحلة التاسعة — في القوّة والفعل

CHAPTER 0

Introduction: Potentiality and Actuality

مدخل المرحلة

The existence of a thing among concrete entities, such that the effects sought from it follow upon it, is called “actuality,” and one says that its existence is actual. Its possibility before it is realized is called “potentiality,” and one says that its existence is potential. A sperm-drop, for example, is potentially a human being so long as it remains a sperm-drop. When it becomes a human being, it becomes a human being actually, possessing the effects of humanity sought from a human being.

It is most likely that “power” originally signified the principle of arduous, forceful actions: that is, a thing's being such that forceful actions proceed from it. Its meaning was then extended to the principle of resistance to being affected—that is, a thing's being such that it is difficult to affect—on the assumption that being affected is an effect present in its principle, just as acting and exerting an influence are effects present in the agent. They then extended “power” to the principle of being affected even where this was not difficult, because they supposed that difficulty and ease in being affected constituted a single graduated kind. Thus they said, “Such-and-such a thing has the potential to become such-and-such,” and “Such-and-such is in it potentially.” This is the usage of ordinary people.

When the philosophers observed that temporally originated forms and accidents possess, before their existence, a possibility corresponding to the receptivity that ordinary people call potentiality, they called the existence that a thing has in possibility “potentiality.” They also called the principle of action “power,” applying this term to efficient causes and speaking of natural powers and powers of the soul.

They called the existence opposed to it—the existence upon which the effects sought from the thing follow—“actual existence.” Accordingly, they divided the existent without qualification into that whose existence is actual and that whose existence is potential.

These two divisions are the subject of investigation in this stage, which contains fourteen chapters.

1. **translation:** The Arabic quwwa covers both “power” and “potentiality.” The introductory discussion traces the extension of the former sense into the latter.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 249–250 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=249&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 1

Every Temporally Originated Thing Is Preceded by the Potentiality for Its Existence

الفصل الأوّل — كلّ حادث زمانيّ فإنّه مسبوقٌ بقوّة الوجود

This is because, before its existence is realized, it must be possible for it to exist: it must be admissible both that it be characterized by existence and that it not be so characterized. If it were not possible before its origination, it would be either impossible or necessary. If impossible, its realization would be impossible, although it has been assumed to originate in time; this is a contradiction. If necessary, it would exist and its nonexistence would be impossible; yet it may fail to occur and not exist.

This possibility is something existent externally, and is not an intellectual consideration attaching to the quiddity of a possible thing, because it is characterized by intensity and weakness, proximity and remoteness. A sperm-drop containing the possibility of becoming a human being, for example, is nearer to the possible human being than is food that can become a sperm-drop and then a human being. Likewise, the possibility in the sperm-drop is more intense than that in the food.

Moreover, this possibility existent externally is not a substance subsisting by itself, as is evident. Rather, it is an accident subsisting in a subject that bears it. Let us call it “potentiality,” and call the subject that bears it “matter.” Every temporally originated thing, therefore, has matter preceding it and bearing the potentiality for its existence.

Matter must not be incapable of uniting with the actuality whose possibility it bears; otherwise it would not bear that possibility. In itself, therefore, it is the potentiality for the actuality whose possibility it bears. If it possessed an actuality of its own, it would be incapable of receiving another actuality. Rather, it is a substance whose actuality of existence consists in being the potentiality for things. Yet, because it is a potential substance, it subsists through another actuality. When the possible thing arises—namely, the actuality whose possibility matter bore—the previous actuality ceases, and the subsequent actuality takes its place. The matter of water, for example, bears the potentiality for air while still subsisting through the form of water. When it becomes air, the form of water ceases, the form of air takes its place, and matter subsists through it.

The matter of the newly originated actuality and of the previous, vanishing actuality is one and the same. Otherwise, matter would originate with the origination of the new actuality, and would require another possibility and another matter. We would transfer the discussion to those two, with

the result that a single originated thing would have infinitely many possibilities and matters; this is impossible.

A similar difficulty follows if matter is supposed to have a temporal origination.

What has preceded makes three points clear.

First, the relation between matter and the potentiality it bears is like the relation between natural body and mathematical body: the potentiality for a particular thing determines matter's indeterminate potentiality.

Second, the origination of things that originate in time is inseparable from a change in forms, if they are substances, or in states, if they are accidents.

Third, potentiality always subsists through an actuality, and matter always subsists through a form that preserves it. When one form originates after another, the new form takes the place of the old and sustains matter.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 250–251 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=250&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Further Discussion of Potential and Actual Existence, and the Division of Existence into Them

الفصل الثاني — في استيناف القول في معنى وجود الشيء بالقوّة

The substantial species before us admit of change, becoming other than they were at first. A substance that does not grow can change into a growing substance, and a growing substance can change and become an animal, with both the recipient and what is received being determinate. This entails that an existent, established relation obtains between them.

Moreover, we find that this relation varies in proximity and remoteness, intensity and weakness. A sperm-drop is nearer to an animal than food is, although both share the possibility of becoming an animal.

Proximity, remoteness, intensity, and weakness are positive attributes that can characterize only something existent. The relation in question therefore necessarily exists.

Every existent relation requires both of its terms to exist within the domain in which it exists. It necessarily subsists through them; its existence does not fall outside theirs; and one term of the relation exists for the other. All this has already been explained in the stage concerning the division

of existence into existence in itself and existence in another.

Since what is received does not exist in the recipient with the external existence that is the source of its effects, it exists in the recipient with a weak existence upon which not all its effects follow.

Since each of its two existences, weak and intense, is the very same thing, they are one. What is received thus has one existence with two degrees: a weak degree upon which not all its effects follow, and an intense degree that is otherwise. Let us call the weak degree “potential existence,” and the strong degree “actual existence.”

Furthermore, what is received in its potential existence and in its actual existence is one continuous existent. Otherwise, the relation would cease, although it has been assumed to be established and existent; this is a contradiction.

Likewise, what is received in its potential existence and the recipient exist through one existence. Otherwise, one term would not exist for the other, the relation would cease, and the same contradiction would follow. Thus the existence of the recipient, the potential existence of what is received, and its actual existence are all one existence possessing different degrees. In it, that by which the degrees differ returns to that in which they agree. This is gradation.

This applies when we assume a single recipient and a single thing received. Suppose instead a chain of recipients and received things extending in both directions, finite or infinite. Each link contains the possibility of the actuality following it and the actuality of the possibility preceding it, as is the case with the chain of occurrences in external reality. All the limits would then have one existence, continuous with the continuity of the chain and possessing different degrees. If this single existence were divided into two portions, the earlier portion would contain the potentiality for the later, and the later would contain the actuality of the earlier.

If, for example, the earlier portion were itself divided into two, the first would contain the potentiality for the second, and the second the actuality of the first. However far one pursued division and subdivision of this single continuous existence, the situation would remain the same. Potentiality and actuality are therefore mingled and interwoven in it.

Every limit of this single continuous existence is a perfection in relation to the preceding limit, and an imperfection and potentiality in relation to the following limit, until it ends in a perfection without imperfection—that is, an actuality without potentiality—just as it began from a potentiality without actuality.

The definition of motion therefore applies to it: motion is the first perfection of what is potential insofar as it is potential.

This single continuous existence is a gradual, flowing existence that passes over matter bearing potentiality. The differing determinations are the limits of motion and the forms of matter.

All this concerns substantial species. The account of accidents is analogous to that of substances, and a detailed discussion of them will follow.

It is now clear that a thing's potentiality is a certain establishment of it upon which not all the effects of its actual existence follow; that existence divides into the actual and the potential; and that it divides into the stable and the flowing.

It is also clear that anything whose existence has a potentiality possesses a flowing, gradual existence, and that motion is present there. Whatever does not have a flowing, gradual existence—that is, whatever is stable—has no potentiality for its existence, and thus has no matter. Whatever has motion has matter; whatever has no matter has no motion. Accidents, insofar as their existences are for their subjects, have motion consequent upon the motion of their subjects, as will be explained in detail.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 251–253 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=251&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Further Clarification of the Definition of Motion and What It Depends Upon

الفصل الثالث — في زيادة توضيح لحدّ الحركة وما تتوقّف عليه

It has been established that motion is a mode of existence through which a thing passes gradually from potentiality to actuality, such that the parts supposed for its existence do not coexist. In other words, every limit of its existence is an actuality for the supposed preceding part and a potentiality for the supposed following part. Motion is therefore a thing's gradual passage from potentiality to actuality.

The First Teacher defined it as “the first perfection of what is potential insofar as it is potential.” To explain: when a body occupying one place, for example, aims to occupy another, it leaves the first place by beginning to traverse the distance to the second, until it occupies it. While in the first place, the body has two perfections in relation to which it is potential: the traversal, which is a first perfection, and occupying the second place, which is a second perfection. Motion—the traversal—is a first perfection of the body that is potential in relation to both perfections. This is not without qualification, however, but insofar as the body is potential in relation to the second perfection, because the existence of the traversal depends upon it.

This makes clear that the existence of motion depends upon six things. First is the starting point: that from which the motion proceeds. Second is the endpoint: that toward which it proceeds. On one side, motion terminates in potentiality without actuality, either in reality or by consideration; on the other, it terminates in actuality without potentiality, either in reality or by consideration, as will become clear, God willing. Third is the course within which motion occurs: the category. Fourth is the subject to which motion belongs: the moving thing. Fifth is the agent through which motion occurs: the mover. Sixth is the magnitude by which motion is measured: time.

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1. **translation:** “The First Teacher” is Aristotle. “Course” translates masāfa: here it includes the category in which change occurs and is not restricted to spatial distance.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 254–255 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=254&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The Division of Change

الفصل الرابع — في إنقسام التغيّر

You have learned that a thing's passage from potentiality to actuality necessarily involves change, either in its essence or in the states of its essence. Alternatively, one may say: either in what is essential to it, as when one substantial species changes into another, or in what is accidental to it, as when a thing changes in its accidental states.

Change is either gradual or, in contrast, instantaneous. Gradual change—which entails divisibility into parts that neither endure nor coexist—is motion.

Instantaneous change, insofar as it requires a subject that receives the change and a potentiality preceding the occurrence of the change, is realized only through motion. You have learned that passage from potentiality to actuality, however it is supposed, takes place only through motion. Yet, because it is an instantaneous change, it belongs among the meanings applicable to the instantaneous parts of motion, such as arriving, leaving, coming into contact, and separating. Change, however it is supposed, therefore takes place only through motion.

Motion is sometimes considered as the moving thing's being between its starting point and endpoint in such a way that, at whatever limit of the course is supposed, it is not at that limit before or afterward. This is a simple, stable, undivided state, called “intermediate motion.” At other times, motion is considered as the thing's being between the starting point and endpoint in such a way that it has a relation to the supposed limits of the course, each of which is an actuality for the preceding potentiality and a potentiality for the following actuality: a limit that it leaves and a limit that it approaches. This entails division into parts, gradual lapse and passage, and the non-coexistence of the parts. It is called “traversal motion.”

Both considerations exist externally, because both apply to external reality. That is to say, motion has a relation to its starting point and endpoint that entails neither division nor flow; and it has a relation to its starting point, endpoint, and the limits of the course that entails the flow of existence and division.

As for the image of motion that imagination obtains by taking one limit after another and gathering them into a continuous image whose parts coexist, this is a mental thing that does not exist externally. The parts of motion, if parts are supposed for it, cannot coexist. Otherwise, motion would be stable rather than flowing, which is a contradiction.

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1. **translation:** Intermediate motion (al-ḥaraka al-tawassuṭiyya) considers the moving thing's state of being between endpoints; traversal motion (al-ḥaraka al-qaṭʿiyya) considers its successive passage through the course. The distinction is between two considerations of motion, not two kinds of moving object.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 255–256 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=255&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The Starting Point and Endpoint of Motion

الفصل الخامس — في مبدأ الحركة ومنتهاها

It was established that motion is divisible in itself. It should be understood that its division is potential, not actual, as is the case with stable continuous quantity: line, surface, and mathematical body. If motion were actually divided, with its parts separated from one another, division would end in parts occurring instantaneously, and motion would cease to be motion.

Nor does its divisibility stop at a limit beyond which it cannot proceed. If it stopped at a limit that division could not pass, motion would be composed of indivisible parts, whose impossibility has already been established.

From this it is clear that motion has neither a starting point nor an endpoint in the sense of a first part indivisible in the direction of motion and a last part likewise indivisible. A part in this sense, as has been shown, occurs instantaneously, and the definition of motion as the flow and gradual unfolding of existence does not apply to it.

The earlier statement that motion terminates on its two sides in a starting point and an endpoint defines its limits through what lies outside motion itself.

At its beginning, substantial motion terminates in potentiality without actuality, except for the actuality of being potentiality without actuality. This is prime matter. At its conclusion, it terminates in actuality without potentiality, which is immateriality. We shall clarify this further, God willing.

Accidental motions terminate, on the side of their beginning, in the matter of their subject, which receives the motion. On the side of their conclusion, natural motion terminates in the rest required by nature; forced motion terminates in a configuration at which the effect of the compulsion is exhausted; and voluntary motion terminates in what the moving thing regards as a perfection for itself in which it ought to settle.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 256–257 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=256&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The Course of Motion

الفصل السادس — في المسافة

This is the category in which motion occurs, as when a body moves in its quantity through growth or in its quality through alteration.

It is necessary that what is essential does not change. The categories, being the highest genera of the quiddities beneath them, are essential to those quiddities. Motion changes the moving thing in the respect in which it moves. If motion occurring in quality, for example, were a change of the moving thing in the quiddity of quality, this would be a change in what is essential, and that is impossible.

There is therefore no motion in a category in the sense of change in its existence in itself—the existence that excludes nonexistence from it—for a quiddity's existence in itself is the quiddity itself.

If there is motion and change in a category, it occurs in its qualifying existence insofar as that existence qualifies. A thing has a quiddity in consideration of its existence in itself. As regards its existence as qualifying another, as in accidents, or as qualifying itself, as in substance, it has no quiddity. There is therefore no impossibility in motion occurring in a category.

A body moving in its quantity or quality, for example, undergoes no change in its quiddity, nor is there any change in the quiddity of the quantity or quality in which it moves. The change occurs only in the quantified or qualified character applying to the body.

This is the meaning of their statement that gradation pertains to accidental predicates, not to the accidents themselves.

Although qualifying existence has no quiddity, its unity with existence in itself allows the quiddity belonging to existence in itself to be attributed to it. This entails that motion in a category means that, at every instant of the motion, a species of that category comes upon the moving thing,

without any species remaining upon it for more than one instant. Otherwise, there would be change in a quiddity, which is impossible.

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1. **translation:** “Qualifying existence” renders al-wujūd al-nāʿit. The argument distinguishes an accident considered in itself from its character as qualifying a subject; “accidental predicates” renders ʿaraḍiyyāt, distinguished here from aʿrāḍ, the accidents themselves.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 257–258 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=257&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The Categories in Which Motion Occurs

الفصل السابع — في المقولات التي تقع فيها الحركة

The well-known position among the ancient philosophers is that motion occurs in four categories: quality, quantity, place, and position.

As for quality, the occurrence of motion in it in general is evident, particularly in qualities specific to quantities, such as straightness, flatness, and curvature. A body moving in its quantity necessarily moves in the qualities subsisting in that quantity.

As for quantity, motion in it is a body's continuous, ordered, gradual change in its quantity. Growth, for example, is a continuous increase of the body's volume, gradually and in an ordered proportion.

An objection has been raised: growth occurs only through the addition of external parts to the body's parts. The later, larger volume is a quantity belonging to the combination of the original and added parts, whereas the earlier, smaller volume is the quantity belonging to the original parts alone. These two quantities are distinct and discontinuous because their subjects are distinct. Growth is therefore the disappearance of one quantity and the origination of another, not motion.

The reply is that the addition of further parts is beyond doubt, but nature transforms the added parts into the form of the original parts and thereby increases the quantity of the original parts continuously, in an ordered and gradual manner. This is motion, as is evident.

As for place, motion in it is evident, as in bodies' passage from one place to another. Whether place constitutes an independent category in itself, however, is not free from doubt.

As for position, motion in it is also evident, as in a sphere's rotation about its axis. Its position changes through a continuous, gradual change in the relations of the points supposed on its surface to what is outside it.

They said that motion does not occur in the remaining categories: acting, being affected, when, relation, possession, and substance.

As for acting and being affected, gradualness is included in their concepts. They therefore have no instance existing in an instant. Motion in them would require division into parts existing in an instant, which they do not possess. It would also entail motion within motion.

The same applies to “when.” Since it is a configuration resulting from a thing's relation to time, and is gradual with time's gradual passage, it has no instance existing in an instant in which motion divisible into instantaneous determinations could occur.

As for relation, it is abstracted from and dependent upon its two terms, and has no independent attribute such as motion.

Likewise, change in possession follows change in its subject: for example, a change in the shoe or foot from its previous condition in the case of being shod.

As for substance, motion in it would entail motion occurring without a stable subject persisting as long as the motion persists. This would entail motion without anything moving.

The arguments they have advanced can be challenged.

Their account of acting, being affected, and “when” can be challenged because motion within motion is possible, as we shall explain, God willing.

Relation and possession are relational categories, like position. Their dependence upon their terms in respect of motion does not conflict with motion genuinely occurring in them. Possessing an attribute consequently is different from possessing it incidentally.

As for their claim concerning substance, the absence of a subject in substantial motion is denied. Its subject is matter, as has already been explained and will be clarified further, God willing.

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1. **translation:** The categorical terms “place,” “when,” and “possession” render ayn, matā, and jida. “Consequently” renders bi-l-tabaʿ: a dependent but real attribution, distinguished here from an incidental attribution, bi-l-ʿaraḍ.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 258–260 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=258&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Clarifying Motion in a Category and the Fundamental Questions That Follow from It

الفصل الثامن — في تنقيح القول بوقوع الحركة في مقولة والإشارة — الى ما يتفرّع عليه من اُصول المسائل

Although the restriction of motion to the four accidental categories is the well-known position transmitted from the ancients, their reported statements contain indications of motion occurring in the category of substance, even though they did not state it explicitly.

The first to adopt this position and discuss its proof fully was Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may God have mercy on him. It is the truth, as we demonstrated in the second chapter. He advanced various arguments for his position. Among the clearest is that accidental motions are flowing and changing in their existence, and are effects of the natures and specific forms belonging to their subjects. The cause of what changes must itself change. Otherwise, the effect, through its change, would diverge from its cause, which is impossible.

The natures and substantial forms that are the proximate causes of the attached accidents in which motion occurs therefore change in their existence and renew themselves in their substance, although they are stable in their quiddity and fixed in their essence, because what is essential does not change.

They explained the change and renewal affecting these accidents, despite the stability of their cause—nature or something else—by circumstances externally added to them. These include the occurrence of degrees of remoteness from and proximity to the end in natural motions; encounters with stronger and weaker obstacles and preparatory factors in forced motions; and renewed particular volitions arising at every limit of the course in voluntary motions.

The difficulty is that we transfer the discussion to the renewal of these circumstances that bring about the changing motion: whence does it arise? It must ultimately terminate in what is renewed intrinsically.

If it is said: “We explain the production of renewed motion by a stable cause in precisely the way you do, without needing to make nature intrinsically renewed. Motion is intrinsically renewed, and there is no difficulty in something renewed proceeding from something stable if renewal is essential to it. Bringing its essence into existence is identical with bringing its renewal into existence, as you yourself have acknowledged.”

The reply is that the renewal present in accidental motion is not a renewal of motion itself. An accidental category does not have an existence in itself that is for itself, such that it could be qualified by itself and be something renewed just as it is renewal. Its existence is for another: the substantial subject. A body's motion in its colour, for example, is the body's change and renewal in the colour belonging to it, not the renewal of its colour.

Substance is otherwise. Its existence in itself is for itself; thus it is both renewal and something intrinsically renewed. Bringing this substance into existence is the very bringing into existence of something renewed, and bringing something renewed into existence is the bringing into existence of this substance. It is not bringing a substance into existence so that it may then become renewed. Understand this.

Another argument: accidents are degrees of the existence of substances, since, as previously established, their existence in themselves is identical with their existence for their subjects. Their change and renewal therefore occur only together with the change and renewal of their substantial subjects. Accidental motions are thus evidence of substantial motion.

What has preceded makes several matters clear.

First, the changing substantial forms that come upon matter one after another are, in reality, a single flowing substantial form passing over matter. Its subject is matter preserved through some form, as established in the stage on substances and accidents. From each limit of this form we abstract a concept different from that abstracted from another limit. We call it a “specific quiddity,” differing from other quiddities in its effects.

Motion in general is never without an element of gradation, because it is passage from potentiality to actuality and a journey from imperfection to perfection. Nevertheless, in substance there is also another intensifying motion: the motion of prime matter toward nature, then plant, then animal, then human being. Each of these motions has particular effects following upon it, until motion terminates in actuality without potentiality.

Second, whatever accidents attach to substances possess motion consequent upon the substances that are their subjects. Stable attributes in changing, renewed subjects would make no sense. Moreover, accidents inseparable from existence, like the concomitants of quiddity, are produced through the simple production of their subjects, without any act of production intervening between them and their subjects. This concerns the inseparable accidents that we regard as stable and unchanging.

As for separable accidents that come upon their subjects through motion—as in motions occurring in the four categories of place, quantity, quality, and position—the appropriate account is to regard their motion as motion within motion. These should be called “second motions,” and the first kind “first motions.”

An objection to the possibility of motion within motion is that motion must be potentially divisible into parts existing in an instant. Motion within motion, however, is assumed to consist of gradual, divisible parts, from which motion therefore cannot be composed. Furthermore, motion would require the moving thing's arrival at each of its limits to be a further penetration into that limit, rather than a departure from it; motion would consequently fail to occur.

The response is that what we accept is that motion can be divided into parts through which its continuity and extension are cut, and that this ends in instantaneous parts. We do not accept that it must reach such parts without an intermediary. Motion may be divided into instantaneous parts

that are not gradual in the manner characteristic of that motion, and those parts may then be divided into ultimate instantaneous parts.

The division of motion and the termination of its division in instantaneous parts resemble an accident's subsistence in a substance. Sometimes this subsistence is without an intermediary; sometimes it occurs through an intermediary and terminates in substance through one or more intermediaries. Thus a line subsists in a surface, a surface in a mathematical body, and a mathematical body in a natural body.

As for penetrating further into the limits, this requires only the occurrence of slowness in motion. The cause of slowness may be the composition of motion, as we shall indicate later, God willing.

Third, prime matter, insofar as it is pure potentiality, has absolutely no actuality except the actuality of being pure potentiality. In whatever actuality comes upon it, it therefore follows the form that sustains it. It is distinguished through the distinction of the form with which it unites, individuated through that form's individuation, and dependent upon it in unity and multiplicity. It does, however, possess an indeterminate unity resembling the unity of a generic quiddity.

Since prime matter is the subject of universal substantial motion, the material world in its entirety is a single flowing reality directed from the stage of pure potentiality toward actuality without potentiality.

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1. **translation:** Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn is Mullā Ṣadrā. “Simple production” renders jaʿl basīṭ: bringing something into existence, distinguished from making an already posited thing possess an additional determination.
2. **textual:** The difficult wording about “instantaneous parts” followed by further division is present in both the transcription and the Qum 1404 scan, printed p. 210 (PDF p. 214). The rendering treats “not gradual” as relative to the motion under consideration; the following analogy with line, surface, and body is the author’s explanation.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 261–264 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=261&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The Subject of Motion

الفصل التاسع — في موضوع الحركة

It has become clear that the subject of these motions is matter. This is the account in outline.

In detail, you have learned that wherever motion occurs there are matter and form, potentiality and actuality. You have also learned, in the discussions of quiddity, that genus and differentia are matter and form considered without a condition of exclusion. Specific quiddities may be ordered in descending levels: a higher species, an intermediate species, and a lowest species. Alternatively, many species may fall under one proximate genus in a parallel order rather than a hierarchical one.

This entails that, in the first kind of substantial species, prime matter is determined through a first form; the two together then constitute a second matter for a second form; and the two together in turn constitute matter—also called second matter—for a subsequent form. In the second kind, there is matter with multiple forms succeeding one another in it: whenever one of them comes to reside in it, it is incapable of receiving another form.

When these hierarchical and parallel substantial differentiations into species are referred to motion, then, in the second kind, the matter that is the subject of motion at its beginning remains the very same subject as the forms succeed one another until motion ends. This holds whether it is prime matter or second matter. The same judgment applies to accidental motions.

In the first kind, hierarchical motion, prime matter is the subject of the first form, and the two together are the subject of the second form. This occurs through putting on a further form after putting on a form, rather than through stripping off and putting on, as in the former case.

This entails that the motion is intensifying rather than uniform. It also entails that the matter of the first form is no longer, by itself, the subject of the second form. Rather, the subject of the latter is prime matter together with the first form, while prime matter alone is an accompanying factor.

At this degree, the second form is the actuality of the species, and the resulting effects belong to it. Only actuality exercises determination, and there is only one actuality: that of the second form.

This is the meaning of their statement that the final differentia encompasses all the perfections of the preceding differentiae and is the basis for abstracting them; and that, if it were to become detached from matter and established on its own, the reality of the species would not thereby cease. The same applies to every form following another form.

From this, three points become clear.

First, motion in the second kind is simple. In the first kind it is composite, because the subject changes at every limit. This change, however, does not occur through the destruction of the preceding subject and the origination of a subsequent one, but through perfecting. At every limit, the actuality of that limit and the potentiality for the following limit together become a potentiality for the actuality of the following limit.

Second, descending motion, in which the subject proceeds from intensity to weakness and from perfection to imperfection, is unintelligible. It would entail some actuality's becoming a potentiality for its own potentiality—as if a human being were to move from humanity to animality, from animality to vegetative being, and so forth.

What appears to be weakening motion is therefore incidental motion following another, intensifying motion that conflicts with the supposed descending motion. Withering is an example.

Third, every motion, whatever it may be, is bounded by a beginning and an end. Each of its limits terminates on its two sides in potentiality without actuality and in actuality without potentiality; the whole has the same judgment as its parts. This does not conflict with the earlier statement that motion has neither a first nor a last part. What was denied there was its beginning with an actually indivisible part and its ending with such a part.

A part in this sense never passes from potentiality to actuality, nor does the specific quiddity abstracted from such a limit ever pass from potentiality to actuality.

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1. **translation:** The Arabic distinguishes parallel species (ʿarḍī, with a quiescent rā᾽) from accidental motions (ʿaraḍī, with a vowel on the rā᾽). “Putting on after putting on” preserves the author’s metaphor for cumulative substantial perfection.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 265–266 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=265&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

The Agent of Motion: The Mover

الفصل العاشر — في فاعل الحركة وهو المحرّك

It should be understood that, however motion is supposed, its mover is other than the moving thing.

If the motion is substantial, occurring in the essence of the thing that is truly moving, as previously explained, to suppose that the moving thing is itself the mover would be to suppose that a thing is the agent bringing itself into existence. The impossibility of this is necessary. The agent bringing motion into existence is therefore the agent bringing the moving thing into existence. It is a substance separate from matter, which brings the substantial form into existence and sustains matter through it. The form is a co-principle with the agent, as previously established.

If the motion is accidental and the accident inseparable from existence, the agent bringing the motion into existence is the agent of the moving subject, through the very production of that subject. No further production intervenes between the subject and the motion. If a production intervened, and the moving thing—which is material—were itself the agent of motion within itself, it would be an agent acting without the mediation of matter. But it was established in the discussion of cause and effect that material causes act only through the mediation of matter and the intervention of a positional relation between themselves and their effects. They act only upon what is outside themselves.

The agent of an inseparable concomitant of existence is thus the agent of that which entails it: a substance separate from matter that produces the form and the concomitant of its existence through a single production, and sustains matter through the form.

If the motion is accidental and the accident separable, the proximate agent of motion is nature, on the basis that the actions arising in each substantial species are ascribed to that species' nature.

To explain in detail: the subject either performs its actions uniformly or does not. The first is nature, defined as the principle of motion and rest in that in which it resides. The second is soul, which commands several natures and powers and employs them to obtain the action it wishes. In either case, its action may be congenial to it, such that, left to itself, it would perform it; this is natural motion. Alternatively, its action may be otherwise, as required by an opposing obstacle; this is forced motion.

On all these assumptions, the agent of motion is nature. In natural motion, nature initiates motion only when a congenial form has disappeared or an uncongenial configuration has arisen, so that it lacks a perfection it requires. It seeks that perfection and proceeds toward it through motion. Form is the agent of this motion, and matter its recipient.

In forced motion, the external coercer may cease while the forced motion persists. Since nature's ordinary agency has in fact been suspended, the agent can only be nature under compulsion.

As for motion belonging to the soul, the soul's commanding the different natures and powers in order to perfect itself through their actions is excellent evidence that the proximate agents in such motions are the natures and powers implanted in the organs.

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1. **translation:** “Ordinary” clarifies the contrast between nature acting congenially to itself and nature under compulsion. Both the transcription and the Qum 1404 scan, printed pp. 213–214, read “the agency of nature” here, not “the agency of the coercer.”
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 266–268 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=266&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Time

الفصل الحادي عشر — في الزمان

Among the events before us, we find some realized after other events that precede them. Those that come afterward have a certain dependence upon those that come before: a dependence in which the earlier and the later do not coexist. This differs from other kinds of priority and posteriority, such as the priority of a cause or part of a cause over an effect. This is a necessary premise about which we have no doubt.

What we have supposed to be earlier is itself divisible into an earlier and a later in this same sense —that is, such that they do not coexist. Likewise, everything obtained through division and possessing the character of being earlier is divisible into an earlier and a later, without division coming to a halt.

There is therefore a continuous, non-stable quantity here. If it were not a quantity, there would be no division. If it were not continuous, the later would not be realized within what is earlier, or conversely; the two would instead be separate. In other words, the two parts of this quantity would have no common limit. If it were not non-stable, the earlier and the later would actually coexist.

Since quantity is an accident, it has a subject in which it resides. Yet whenever we remove motion from the case in question, this magnitude disappears, and whenever we posit motion, it is established. This is what we call “time.” Time therefore exists, and its quiddity is that of a continuous, non-stable magnitude occurring as an accident of motion.

Several matters become clear from what has preceded.

First, whenever we posit a motion or substitute one motion for another, this quantity called time is established. Every motion, whatever it may be, therefore has its own time, individuated through the individuation of that motion and measuring it. Nevertheless, we take the time of certain motions as a measure by which we measure other motions. Thus we take the time of daily motion as a measure for the other motions contained in universal and particular cosmic events, correlating them with the divisions we assign to this time: centuries, years, months, weeks, days, hours, minutes, seconds, and so forth.

Second, the relation of time to motion is like the relation of mathematical body to natural body: the relation of the determinate to the indeterminate.

Third, just as motion is divided into portions possessing common limits, with boundaries between them that exist only potentially—instantaneous determinations—so time is divided into portions possessing common limits, with boundaries between them that exist only potentially: instants. An instant is the limit of time, like a point, which is the limit of a line. It is something privative whose share in existence consists in its relation to that of which it is the limit.

From this it is clear that instants cannot follow immediately upon one another. An instant is only a privative boundary between two portions of time. Two things of this kind cannot occur unless a portion of time lies between them.

Fourth, things differ in their correspondence to time. Traversal motion corresponds to time immediately, and the parts of this motion are characterized by priority, posteriority, and the like consequently upon the parts of time being so characterized.

Every event existing in an instant, such as arrival, departure, contact, and separation, corresponds to an instant. Intermediate motion corresponds to time through traversal motion.

It is also clear that imagining an intermediate counterpart in time—the so-called flowing instant that traces temporal extension—is an imaginative, figurative conception. How could it be otherwise, when time is a quantity divisible in itself?

The comparison with a flowing unit that traces number through its repetition, or with a flowing point that traces a line, is misplaced. A unit is not a number: it traces number through its repetition, not through itself. A point is a privative limit, and a line's being composed of points is imaginary.

Fifth, time has no actually existent extremity in the sense of a part constituting its beginning or end that is indivisible along temporal extension. Otherwise, a magnitude would be composed of parts with no magnitude—the indivisible part—which is impossible. Time comes to an end on either side only through the ending of the motion in which it resides.

Sixth, nothing precedes time except through a non-temporal priority, such as the priority of the cause of existence, the cause of motion, and motion's subject over time.

Seventh, temporal earlierness and laterness do not obtain between two things unless there is a common time to which both correspond. Thus, if something temporally earlier is established in relation to a motion or a moving thing, this requires a common time between them. That entails a common motion, which in turn entails common matter between them.

Observation

Considering time together with motions—time being a changing magnitude—provides their measurement and the priority and posteriority that follow from it. Stable existents may also be considered together with changing things. This gives the coexistence of the stable with the changing, called “dahr.” The stable existent may be considered together with stable things, giving the coexistence of the stable with stable things and the coexistence of the universal stable existent with the stable things beneath it. This is called “sarmad.” Neither dahr nor sarmad contains priority or posteriority, because neither contains change or division.

It is said in the Asfār: “Existents that are neither motion nor in motion are not in time. Rather, their stability is considered together with changing things, and this coexistence is called dahr. Likewise, the coexistence of changing things with changing things, considered not with respect to their

change but with respect to their stability—for nothing lacks some mode of stability, even if it is the stability of change—is also a coexistence in dahr. If stable things are considered together with stable things, this coexistence is sarmad. Neither this coexistence nor the preceding one has a corresponding priority and posteriority. There is nothing impossible in this, for neither priority nor posteriority is a correlative of coexistence such that coexistence would entail it.” End of quotation.

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1. **translation:** Dahr and sarmad are retained as technical terms for atemporal modes of coexistence; translating both simply as “eternity” would obscure the distinction made here.
2. **translation:** In the sentence on intermediate motion, the pronoun in “corresponds to it” is understood as referring back to time. The following discussion explicitly rejects treating the “flowing instant” as an independently real constituent of time.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 268–271 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=268&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

The Meaning of Speed and Slowness

الفصل الثاني عشر — في معنى السرعة والبطؤ

We know speed and slowness by comparing motions with one another. Suppose two motions, one swift and one slow, along a course. If the course is the same, they differ in time: the time of the swift motion is shorter and that of the slow motion longer. If the time is the same, the course traversed by the swift motion is greater and that traversed by the slow motion less.

They are relational meanings realized through comparison. A slow motion becomes swift when compared with one slower than itself, and a swift motion becomes slow when compared with one swifter than itself.

If we suppose a sequence of motions successively increasing in speed, each intermediate motion, excluding the two extremes, is characterized by both speed and slowness: swift in comparison with one side and slow in comparison with the other. The two are thus relational attributes that do not stand in opposition, like length and shortness, or largeness and smallness.

The claim that slowness in motion results from intervening periods of rest is refuted by what has already been established: motion is continuous and admits division only potentially.

It has sometimes been said that speed and slowness are contraries. It is said in the Asfār: “The opposition between speed and slowness is not that of correlatives, since correlatives are mutually inseparable in both modes of existence, whereas these two are not mutually inseparable in either. Nor is their opposition one of affirmation and negation. If the two motions are equal in time, the swift traverses a distance that the slow does not; if equal in distance, the time of the slow is longer.

One therefore has a deficiency in distance and the other a deficiency in time. There is no better reason to make one privative than to make the other so. Consequently, the only remaining opposition between them is contrariety.” End of quotation.

The difficulty is that they stipulate, for contrariety, the greatest possible difference between its two terms. This is not realized between speed and slowness: no motion is so swift that a swifter one cannot be supposed, and none so slow that a slower one cannot be supposed.

This concerns relational speed and slowness. Speed in the sense of running and flowing, however, is a property of motion without qualification, opposed to no slowness.

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1. **translation:** The “two modes of existence” in the quotation are mental and external existence. The final sentence uses “speed” in an extended sense of flow, distinct from comparative rate of motion.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 271–273 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=271&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

Rest

الفصل الثالث عشر — في السكون

Motion and rest cannot coexist in a body in the same respect at the same time. There is therefore an opposition between them. Motion is positive, for it has been established that it is the mode of flowing existence. Rest, however, is not a positive thing. If it were, it would be stable existence, which is actual in every respect. Yet stable existences—immaterial beings—are neither rest nor possessors of rest.

Motion is therefore positive and rest privative. Their opposition is consequently neither that of correlatives nor that of contraries. Nor are they contradictories, for then rest would apply to everything that is not motion, such as separate intellects, which are actual in every respect, and their acts. Rest is thus the absence of motion in what is capable of motion. Their opposition is that of privation and possession.

It should nevertheless be understood that rest has no instance in any material substance, because, as established, their existence flows. Nor does it have an instance in any of their accidents, which follow their substantial subjects in motion because they subsist through them.

There is, however, a relative rest with which material subjects may be characterized in relation to the second motions occurring in the four accidental categories: quantity, quality, place, and position.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 273–274 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=273&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

The Divisions of Motion

الفصل الرابع عشر — في إنقسامات الحركة

Motion is divided according to the division of the six things upon which its essence depends.

It is divided according to the starting point and endpoint: motion from one place to another, from sitting to standing, from one colour to another, or a body's motion from one magnitude to another.

It is divided according to the category: motion in quality, quantity, place, or position.

It is divided according to the subject: the motion of a plant, an animal, or a human being.

It is divided according to time: motion by night or by day, in summer or in winter.

It is divided according to the agent: natural motion, forced motion, and motion belonging to the soul.

They said that the proximate agent in all these cases is nature, and that the soul's production of motion takes place by commanding natural powers, as previously indicated.

They also said that what intervenes between nature and motion is the principle of inclination that nature produces in the moving thing. The detailed account belongs to natural philosophy.

Just as “power” is applied to the principle of receptivity, so it is applied to the principle of action, especially when that principle is strong and intense. Thus “natural powers” denotes the principles of natural effects, and “powers of the soul” the principles of the soul's effects, such as sight, hearing, imagination, and others. When this active power is accompanied by knowledge and volition, it is called an animal's capacity to act. It is an efficient cause whose causality becomes complete—such that the act necessarily follows—only through external conditions: the presence of receptive matter, the establishment of a position appropriate to the act, the fitness of the instruments of action, and so forth. When these come together, the causality is complete and the act becomes necessary.

This shows the error in some people's defining capacity without qualification as “that together with which both acting and refraining are admissible.” The relation of acting and refraining to an agent is one of admissibility and possibility only when the agent is part of a complete cause. Taken alone, as an incomplete cause, the act ascribed to it does not become necessary through it. As for an agent complete in its agency, which is alone a complete cause—such as the Necessary Existent, exalted is He—there is no meaning to its relation to acting and refraining being one of possibility, that is, to the two relations being equal.

An objection is that the necessity of His act would entail His being necessitated and compelled to act, which conflicts with capacity.

The response is that this necessity attaches to the act from Him, exalted is He, and is His effect. It is unintelligible that a thing's effect, dependent upon it in existence, should influence the essence of the thing acting. Nor is there another agent influencing Him and making Him compelled to act.

Likewise, the claim that “an act's admissibility depends upon its being preceded by temporal nonexistence, so that an act not preceded by temporal nonexistence is impossible” is false. Its error is that it rests upon making origination, rather than contingency, the reason for needing a cause. This was refuted in the discussions of cause and effect. Moreover, it is contradicted by time itself: making the production of time precedable by its temporal nonexistence establishes time before itself, which is necessarily impossible.

Likewise, the claim that capacity arises only together with the act, and that there is no capacity for an act before it, is false. Its error is that its proponents regard capacity as the admissibility of acting and refraining. If someone refrains from an act for a time and then acts, it was true before the act that both acting and refraining were admissible for him; this is capacity. Moreover, their claim contradicts their admission that the act depends upon capacity, because the accompaniment of capacity and act conflicts with one depending upon the other.

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1. **translation:** Quwwa is rendered “power” here; qudra is rendered “capacity to act” or “capacity.” The chapter extends the account of motion to the relation between capacity, a complete cause, and the necessity of its effect.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 274–276 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=274&type=c_fbook

STAGE X

Priority, Posteriority, Beginninglessness, and Origination

المرحلة العاشرة — في السبق واللحوق والقدم والحدوث

CHAPTER 1

Priority and Posteriority

الفصل الأوّل — في السبق واللحوق وهما التقدّم والتأخّر

It appears that the first meaning of priority and posteriority to become known was their sensible meaning. A starting point is supposed to which two things share a relation: one possesses whatever relation the other possesses, but not conversely. The attribute belonging to the former is called priority, and that belonging to the latter posteriority. For example, take the prayer niche of a mosque as the starting point. The prayer leader and the follower share a relation to it: whatever proximity to the niche the follower possesses, the leader possesses, but not conversely. The leader is therefore prior and the follower posterior.

It is evident that the attributes of priority and posteriority differ with the supposed starting point. In this example, the leader is prior and the follower posterior if the niche is the starting point. If the doorway is taken as the starting point, the reverse obtains: the follower is prior and the leader posterior. Nor does it matter whether the ordering is conventional and instituted, as in the example above, or natural. Suppose, for example, body, then plant, then animal, then human being. If body is the starting point, plant is prior and animal posterior; if human being is the starting point, animal is prior and plant posterior. This is called priority and posteriority according to order.

They then generalized this meaning, applying it to nobility, excellence, baseness, and similar cases of superiority in non-sensible respects, as in the priority of the knowledgeable over the ignorant or the brave over the cowardly. If, for example, the species with the effects of its perfection is taken as the starting point, the knowledgeable and the ignorant, or the brave and the cowardly, differ in their relation to it. These are called priority and posteriority in nobility.

They also moved to temporal priority and posteriority. Two portions of time, such as today and yesterday, share in bearing the potentiality for later portions. But whatever potentiality one of them —today—bears, the other—yesterday—also bears, and not conversely. Yesterday bears the

potentiality for today, whereas today bears its own actuality; actuality does not coexist with potentiality. Hence the two portions of time do not coexist in actual existence.

There is therefore priority and posteriority among the parts of time such that the prior does not coexist with the posterior, unlike other kinds of priority and posteriority.

Likewise, events that are motions corresponding to time possess temporal priority and posteriority through the mediation of time, which is their determination, just as a natural body possesses the three dimensions through the mediation of mathematical body, which is its determination.

This alerted them to further kinds of real priority and posteriority in existence. They investigated them and enumerated nine kinds, including both those constituted by consideration and those that are real.

The first, second, and third are priority and posteriority according to order, nobility, and time, already discussed.

The fourth is priority and posteriority by nature: the priority of an incomplete cause over its effect, where removing the cause removes the effect but the cause's existence does not necessitate the effect; and the posteriority of the effect to it.

The fifth is priority and posteriority by causality: the priority of a complete cause, through whose existence the effect becomes necessary, over its effect; and the effect's posteriority to it.

The sixth is priority and posteriority in quiddative constitution: the priority of the parts of a quiddity—genus and differentia—over the quiddity, and its posteriority to them, on the assumption of the primacy of quiddity.

These last three—priority and posteriority by nature, by causality, and in quiddative constitution—are called intrinsic priority and posteriority.

The seventh is priority and posteriority in dahr: the priority of a complete cause over its effect and the posteriority of its effect to it, considered not with respect to the cause's necessitating and bestowing the effect's existence, as in causal priority and posteriority, but with respect to its existence being distinct and separate from the effect's existence, and the effect's nonexistence being established at the level of the cause's existence. An example is the priority of the realm of intellectual immateriality over the realm of matter. This division was added by the verifying master al-Dāmād.

The eighth is priority and posteriority in literal and figurative attribution: two things share in being characterized by an attribute, but one possesses it intrinsically and the other incidentally. What possesses it intrinsically is prior, in this sense, to what possesses it incidentally, and the latter is posterior. An example is the priority of existence over the quiddity existent through it, on the view that existence is primary in being existent and realized, while quiddity exists through it incidentally. This division was added by Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified.

The ninth is priority and posteriority by existential reality: the priority of the existence of a complete cause over the existence of its effect, and the effect's posteriority to it. This differs from priority and posteriority by causality. It too was added by Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified.

It is said in the Asfār: “In general, the existence of every necessitating cause precedes the existence of its intrinsic effect with this kind of priority. The philosophers defined the efficient cause as that which acts upon something other than the agent. Thus the priority of the agent's essence over the effect's essence is priority by causality. But the priority of existence over existence is another priority, distinct from causal priority, for between them there is neither influencing and being influenced nor agency and being acted upon. Their condition is instead that of a single thing possessing modes and phases, undergoing development from one phase to another.” End of quotation.

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1. **translation:** “Quiddative constitution” renders tajawhur in this classification; its example is the relation of genus and differentia to the constituted quiddity. “By existential reality” renders bi-l-ḥaqq, distinguished from bi-l-ḥaqīqa wa-l-majāz, literal and figurative attribution.
2. **translation:** Al-Dāmād is Mīr Dāmād; Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn is Mullā Ṣadrā. Dahr is the technical atemporal relation discussed at IX.11.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 279–282 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=279&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The Criterion of Priority and Posteriority in Each Division

الفصل الثاني — في ملاك السبق واللحوق في كلّ واحد من الأقسام

As indicated in the preceding chapter, the criterion is that which the prior and the posterior share, of which the prior possesses something that the posterior does not, while the posterior possesses nothing that the prior does not also possess.

The criterion of priority and posteriority according to order is the relation to a specified starting point. In sensible order, the prayer leader and follower share a relation to the supposed starting point, whether the niche or the doorway. The leader is prior if the niche is the starting point, and

the follower prior if it is the doorway. Likewise, in an ordering of genera and species, each genus is prior to its species if the highest genus is the supposed starting point, and each species prior to its genus if the reverse is assumed.

The criterion of priority and posteriority in nobility is that two things share a meaning capable of being characterized by excellence and distinction, or by vice. The brave and the cowardly, for example, share humanity, which is capable of possessing the virtue of courage. The brave possesses what the cowardly possesses, but not conversely. The priority of the baser over another in baseness is analogous.

The criterion of temporal priority and posteriority is that two supposed parts of time share a lapsing, passing existence in which potentiality and actuality are interwoven, such that the actuality of one depends upon its potentiality being present together with the other. The part accompanied by the potentiality for the other part is prior; the part for which this is otherwise is posterior. Today and tomorrow, for example, share a non-stable quantitative existence in which tomorrow's actuality depends upon its potentiality being realized together with today. When tomorrow actually exists, its potentiality has ceased and today has passed. Today is therefore temporally prior and tomorrow temporally posterior.

Through this same criterion, priority and posteriority obtain among temporal events through the mediation of time, since those events are motions possessing times.

The criterion of priority and posteriority by nature is existence. The prior is distinguished by the later's existence depending upon it, such that, if the prior were not realized, the posterior would not be realized, but not conversely. This is the case with the priority of an incomplete cause: removing it removes the effect, although its existence does not entail the effect's existence.

The Master of Illumination is reported to have said that temporal priority and posteriority belong to priority and posteriority by nature, since they ultimately amount to the later part's existence depending upon the earlier part's existence, such that it ceases if the latter is removed.

It was objected that the two are different kinds. In natural priority the prior and posterior may coexist, whereas in temporal priority they cannot. Moreover, priority and posteriority belong intrinsically to the parts of time.

The truth is that there is no way to deny that temporal priority and posteriority rest upon existential dependence between the two parts. Yet because this existence is non-stable, with every part accompanied by the potentiality for the following part, the two cannot coexist: a thing's

potentiality cannot coexist with its actuality. What can be accepted of the assertion that priority and posteriority are intrinsic to time is that they are inseparable from its lapsing, non-stable existence, in which potentiality and actuality differ.

Whoever wishes to reduce temporal priority to natural priority must therefore explain natural priority as that in which existential dependence is found, and then divide it into cases allowing the prior and posterior to coexist—as with an incomplete cause and its effect—and cases not allowing this—as with some parts of time preceding others.

The criterion of priority and posteriority by causality is the complete cause's and its effect's sharing necessity of existence, with the necessity of the cause—the prior—being intrinsic, and the necessity of the effect—the posterior—being through another.

The criterion of priority and posteriority in quiddative constitution is their sharing in the establishment of quiddity. The posterior depends upon the prior for its establishment, as a complete quiddity depends upon its parts.

The criterion of priority and posteriority in dahr is that a universal level of existence shares, with what is above or below it, occurrence in concrete reality, while concretely depending upon what is above it, or having what is below it depend upon it, in such a way that the two do not coexist. Non-dependence is included at the level of that upon which the other depends. Examples are the priority of the world of separate intellects over the imaginal world, and the priority of the imaginal world over the material world.

The criterion of priority and posteriority in literal attribution is their sharing establishment in a sense broad enough to include both literal and figurative establishment. Literal establishment belongs to the prior, figurative to the posterior—as in existence's priority over quiddity through its primacy.

The criterion of priority and posteriority by existential reality is their sharing existence in a sense broad enough to include both independent and linking existence. The cause's existence is prior through its independence, and the effect's existence is posterior through its being linking existence.

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1. **translation:** The Master of Illumination is Shihāb al-Dīn al-Suhrawardī. The imaginal world (ʿālam al-mithāl) is an ontological realm of immaterial forms, not simply private imagination.
2. **textual:** The paragraph on dahr reads ʿadam al-tawaqquf (“non-dependence”) in both the transcription and the Qum 1404 scan, printed p. 228. The wording is retained. Compare X.8, where the effect’s nonexistence at the level of its cause is stated explicitly.
3. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 282–285 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=282&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

Coexistence

Coexistence is two things' sharing a meaning without differing in the perfection and deficiency constituted by priority and posteriority. Yet not every pair lacking a certain kind of priority and posteriority coexists in that kind. Separate substances have neither temporal priority and posteriority nor temporal coexistence. Things coexisting in time must be temporal things capable of temporal priority and posteriority. If they share a temporal meaning without priority and posteriority within it, they coexist in it.

This makes clear that the opposition of coexistence to priority and posteriority is that of privation and possession. Coexistence is two things' sharing a meaning without differing in priority and posteriority, while being capable of priority and posteriority in that meaning. Priority and posteriority are positive determinations, and coexistence is privative.

Coexistence in order is exemplified, in sensible order, by two followers standing behind the prayer leader in relation to the supposed starting point in the mosque. In an ordering of species and genera, it is exemplified by two species or two genera under a genus, in relation to the species or genus in question.

Coexistence in nobility is exemplified by two brave people equal in their disposition.

Coexistence in time is exemplified by two motions occurring in the very same time. There is no coexistence among the parts of time itself, since any two of its parts necessarily have priority and posteriority.

Coexistence by nature is exemplified by two equal parts in relation to the whole.

Coexistence by causality is exemplified by two effects of one complete cause. There is no coexistence between two complete causes in this respect, because they cannot combine upon a single effect. Coexistence in literal and figurative attribution, and coexistence by existential reality, follow the same pattern as coexistence by causality.

Coexistence in dahr is exemplified by two parts of a level of concrete reality, if multiplicity is supposed within that level.

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1. **translation:** Maʿiyya is rendered “coexistence,” but the classification extends beyond simultaneity: it includes parity in order, nobility, causality, and other respects.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 285–286 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=285&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The Meaning and Divisions of Beginninglessness and Origination

الفصل الرابع — في معنى القدم والحدوث وأقسامهما

When the elapsed duration of one thing's existence is greater than the elapsed duration of another's—as when fifty years of Zayd's life have passed and forty years of ʿAmr's—ordinary people call the one with the longer duration “old” and the one with the shorter duration “recent.” The meaning obtained from this is that the old thing existed during a time when the recent thing did not yet exist. In other words, the recent thing's existence is preceded by nonexistence during a time when the old thing existed, whereas the old thing is otherwise.

When these two meanings are generalized and taken in a real sense, they become essential attributes of the existent insofar as it is existent. The existent without qualification is divided into them, and their investigation becomes philosophical.

The existent is therefore divided into the beginningless and the originated. The beginningless is that whose existence is not preceded by nonexistence; the originated is that whose existence is preceded by nonexistence.

Of the previously mentioned meanings and kinds of precedence, four can properly be included in the definitions of origination and beginninglessness: temporal precedence, causal precedence, precedence in dahr, and precedence by existential reality.

There are consequently four divisions of beginninglessness and origination: temporal beginninglessness and origination; causal beginninglessness and origination, commonly called intrinsic; beginninglessness and origination by existential reality; and beginninglessness and origination in dahr. We shall discuss each in detail.

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1. **translation:** Qidam and ḥudūth begin here with ordinary “oldness” and “recentness,” then acquire technical senses. “Beginninglessness” must therefore be read according to the specified kind of precedence, not invariably as infinite elapsed time.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 286–287 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=286&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

Temporal Beginninglessness and Origination

الفصل الخامس — في القدم والحدوث الزمانيّين

Temporal origination is a thing's existence being preceded by temporal nonexistence: its occurring after it was not, with a posteriority that does not coexist with priority. Nonexistence is temporal only if the existence opposed to it is temporal. This means that the thing's existence is gradual, corresponding to a portion of time preceded by another portion to which its nonexistence corresponds.

Opposed to origination in this sense is temporal beginninglessness: a thing's existence not being preceded by temporal nonexistence. This entails that the thing exists in, and corresponds to, every portion of time supposed before a given portion.

These meanings apply only to temporal things contained in and corresponding to time: motions and moving things. Time itself is not characterized by temporal origination or beginninglessness, because time has no other time to which its existence could correspond and in which it could be either preceded or not preceded by nonexistence.

Nevertheless, since time is intrinsically characterized by mutually non-coexistent earlierness and laterness, every part of it has its existence preceded by its nonexistence, whose instance is every preceding part. Every part of time is therefore temporally originated in this sense, and so is the whole. Time is the non-stable magnitude of motion, which is a thing's gradual passage from potentiality to actuality. The actuality of time's existence is accordingly preceded by the potentiality for its existence; this is temporal origination.

Origination in the sense of time's existence being preceded by a nonexistence outside its existence, with a precedence in which the before does not coexist with the after, would suppose temporal earlierness being realized without time being realized.

This is what is indicated by the saying attributed to the First Teacher: “Whoever asserts the origination of time has asserted its beginninglessness without being aware of it.”

Observation

It was established in the discussions of potentiality and actuality that every individual motion has its own individual time, specific to it and measuring it. Among these is universal time, which belongs to the universal substantial motion through which the matter of the material world moves in its forms. There are also the distinct times belonging to and measuring distinct accidental motions.

The time by which ordinary people measure the world's events is the time of daily motion. Applying events to it is intended to establish their relations to one another in priority and posteriority, length and shortness, and the like.

Remembering this, know that the account we have given of temporal origination and beginninglessness applies to every time, of whatever kind. Do not overlook this.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 287–288 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=287&type=c_fbook

Intrinsic Origination and Beginninglessness

الفصل السادس — في الحدوث والقدم الذاتيّين

Intrinsic origination is a thing's existence being preceded by the nonexistence established at the level of its essence. Intrinsic beginninglessness is its contrary.

They said that everything possessing a quiddity is intrinsically originated. Their argument is that every contingent thing deserves nonexistence through itself and existence through another. What belongs through itself is prior to what belongs through another; its existence is therefore preceded by nonexistence through itself.

It was objected that, if a contingent thing intrinsically required nonexistence, it would be impossible. Rather, because it is contingent, it is true of it in itself neither that it exists nor that it does not exist. Just as it deserves existence through an external cause, so it deserves nonexistence through an external cause. Neither existence nor nonexistence is therefore prior to the other in relation to it, and its existence through another is not preceded by its nonexistence through itself.

The reply is that what is intended is its not deserving existence through itself, as a straightforward negation, not as the affirmation of a negative predicate. This meaning belongs to it in itself before the existence coming from another.

Another argument: every contingent thing has a quiddity different from its existence; otherwise it would be necessary, not contingent. Whatever has a quiddity different from its existence cannot receive its existence from its quiddity. Otherwise, the quiddity would exist before obtaining its existence, which is impossible. Its existence is therefore received from another, and is intrinsically preceded by another. Everything of this kind is intrinsically originated.

It follows that what is intrinsically beginningless is intrinsically necessary in existence, and also that what is intrinsically beginningless has no quiddity.

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1. **translation:** The reply distinguishes denying that a quiddity deserves existence by itself from affirming that it positively deserves nonexistence. This is the logical distinction between a negative proposition and an affirmative proposition with a negative predicate.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 288–289 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=288&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

Origination and Beginninglessness by Existential Reality

الفصل السابع — في الحدوث والقدم بالحق

Origination by existential reality is the existence of an effect being preceded by the existence of its complete cause, considering the relation of priority and posteriority between the two existences, rather than between the existent quiddity of the effect and the cause, as in intrinsic origination.

This is because genuine establishment and realization in concrete reality belong to existence, not to quiddity. To the cause—and especially to the unrestricted Necessary Cause in which the matter ultimately terminates—belong only independence and self-sufficiency. To the effect's existence belong only intrinsic dependence upon the cause's existence, intrinsic poverty in relation to it, and subsistence through it.

It is necessary that what is independent, self-sufficient, and subsistent through itself precedes what is dependent, poor, and subsistent through another. The effect's existence is therefore originated in this sense, preceded by the existence of its cause; the cause's existence is beginningless relative to it and prior to it.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 289–290 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=289&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

Origination and Beginninglessness in Dahr

الفصل الثامن — في الحدوث والقدم الدهريّين

Origination in dahr is an existent, caused quiddity being preceded by its nonexistence established at the level of its cause. Its nonexistence, with its delimitation, is abstracted in relation to its cause, even though the cause possesses the perfection of its existence in a higher and nobler manner. Its cause is therefore prior to it with a priority that does not coexist with the effect's posteriority, insofar as a thing's nonexistence does not coexist with its existence.

Beginninglessness in dahr is the cause's not being preceded by the effect with this kind of precedence.

Our explanation makes clear that the establishment of the effect's nonexistence at the level of the cause does not conflict with the established principle that the cause is the fullness and perfection of its effect's existence. What is denied at the level of the cause's existence is the effect with its delimitation, not its existence insofar as it is existence received from the cause. The effect with its delimitation must differ from its cause. This entails that negating the delimited effect of the cause is true; otherwise, the two would be identical.

There nevertheless remains the question of the claim that the priority and posteriority in this origination and beginninglessness cannot coexist.

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1. **textual:** “Its cause is therefore prior to it” follows the causal sense of fa-ʿillatuhā qablahā, visible in the Qum 1404 scan, printed p. 234. The online transcription’s vocalization of this phrase is irregular.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 290–290 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=290&type=c_fbook

STAGE XI

Intellect, the Knower, and the Intelligible

المرحلة الحادية عشرة — في العقل والعاقل والمعقول

CHAPTER 0

Introduction to Stage XI: Intellection, the Intellect, and the Intelligible

مدخل المرحلة

Although the heading employs the term “intellection,” which in technical usage refers to universal apprehension rather than particular apprehension, the discussion embraces both.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 291–291 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=291&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 1

The definition of knowledge, its primary division, and some of its properties

الفصل الأوّل — في تعريف العلم وانقسامه الأوّلي وبعض خواصّه

The existence of knowledge is immediately certain to us through our own awareness, and its concept is likewise self-evident to us. What we seek in the discussion of this chapter is only to identify its most distinctive properties.

We say: it was established in the discussion of mental existence that we have some knowledge of things outside us, in the sense that they are present to us through their very quiddities, rather than through their external existences upon which their external effects follow. This is one division of knowledge, called “acquired knowledge.”

Another instance of knowledge is the knowledge each of us has of his own self, to which he points and which he expresses by “I.” He is never distracted from himself or unaware of witnessing his own self, even if we suppose that he is unaware of his body, its parts, and its organs.

His knowledge of himself does not consist in the quiddity of his self being present to him conceptually, as acquired knowledge. For a concept present in the mind, however it is supposed, does not in itself exclude being true of many things; it becomes individuated only through external existence. But what he witnesses of himself and expresses by “I” is intrinsically an individual

thing, incapable of being shared by many. It has already been established that individuation is through existence. Our knowledge of ourselves therefore consists in our selves being present to us through their external existence, which is identical with our individual existence upon which effects follow.

Furthermore, if what was present to our selves when we knew them was the quiddity of our selves rather than their existence, while our existence already has a quiddity subsisting through it, one existence would have two quiddities existing through it. This would be the coincidence of two identicals, which is impossible. Thus our knowledge of ourselves consists in their presence to us and their not being absent from us through their external existence, rather than through their quiddity alone. This is another division of knowledge, called “knowledge by presence.”

The division of knowledge into these two divisions is exhaustive. The known is present to the knower either through its quiddity, which is acquired knowledge, or through its existence, which is knowledge by presence.

This is the division into acquired knowledge and knowledge by presence to which an initial consideration leads. Deeper consideration, however, shows that acquired knowledge too ultimately rests upon knowledge by presence.

To explain: a cognitive form, however it is supposed, is immaterial and devoid of potentiality. It is evident that, insofar as it is known, it is actual and contains absolutely no potentiality for anything. If any change in it were supposed, the new form would be distinct from the form previously known. Were the cognitive form material, it would not exclude change.

Moreover, were it material, it would not lack matter’s inseparable properties: divisibility, time, and place.

Knowledge, insofar as it is knowledge, does not admit of being halved or divided into thirds, for example. If it were impressed in corporeal matter, it would divide with the division of that matter. Nor is it restricted to a time. If it were material—and every material thing is in motion—it would change as time changed. Nor can it be pointed out in a place. If it were material, it would occupy a place.

You may object: the cognitive form’s indivisibility insofar as it is knowledge does not conflict with its being impressed in a body, such as a part of the brain, and being divisible incidentally, through its substrate. A quality, such as a color occurring on the surface of a body, likewise excludes division insofar as it is a quality, yet is divisible incidentally through its substrate. Why, then, may the cognitive form not be material, impressed in a substrate, and divisible incidentally through the division of that substrate—especially given the familiar view that knowledge is a psychic quality?

Moreover, the correspondence of knowledge to time, particularly in sensory and imaginative knowledge, should not be doubted: consider the sensation of material activities at the time of their existence.

Moreover, there is no doubt that certain parts of the brain are specially associated with knowledge, which functions properly when they do and is impaired when they are impaired, as is accepted in medicine. The cognitive form therefore has a place, just as it has a time.

We reply: there is no doubt, as stated, that the cognitive form excludes and does not admit division insofar as it is knowledge.

But there is likewise no doubt that its being divided incidentally through the division of a substrate, such as a neural part, is false. We sense and imagine forms vastly greater than the neural part supposed to be their substrate: the sky in all its reaches, the earth in all its regions, lofty mountains, broad deserts, and swelling seas. It is impossible for the large to be impressed in the small.

The claim that “the apprehension of largeness and smallness in a cognitive form occurs only by comparing the parts of the cognitive form with one another” is of no help. What is witnessed is the large thing in its largeness, rather than the universal quantitative ratio between the large and the small—for example, that the ratio between them is one hundred to one.

The sensed or imagined cognitive form, with its magnitude, therefore subsists in its own right in the realm of the soul, without being impressed in a neural part or in some other material thing, and without being divided incidentally through the division of such a thing. Mentally pointing to some parts of what is known and separating them from the other parts is like pointing to some parts of the sensed or imagined Zayd and then to some other parts. This is not division at all. It is turning away from the original cognitive form and bringing about two other forms.

Since the cognitive form is not impressed in a neural part and is not divided incidentally through its division, the connection of the cognitive form to the neural part and to the activity it performs during apprehension is a preparatory connection. That is, the activity performed by the neural part prepares the soul for the presence and manifestation, within its own realm, of the particular cognitive form with the particular characteristics of the known.

Likewise, the temporal concurrence that appears between our apprehensions and time is really between time and the preparatory material activity performed by the soul in the organ of apprehension, rather than between time and the cognitive form insofar as it is knowledge.

Evidence for this is that we often apprehend something known, retain it, and then recall that very same thing after many years have passed, without any alteration. Had it been restricted to time, it would have changed as time changed.

What has been established is that the cognitive form, whatever it may be, is immaterial and devoid of potentiality. Being such, its existence is stronger than that of the material object upon which sense falls and at which imagination and intellection terminate, and it possesses the effects of its immaterial existence. As for the effects of its external material existence, which we suppose to be the object of apprehension, they are not effects of what is truly known and present to the apprehender, such that they should or should not follow upon it. Rather, a misapprehension leads the apprehender to suppose that what is present to him during apprehension is the form externally attached to matter. He therefore seeks its external effects, fails to find them accompanying it, and judges that what is known is the quiddity without the external effects following upon it.

Accordingly, what is known in acquired knowledge of something with a certain attachment to matter is an immaterial existent that is an efficient principle of that thing and possesses its perfection. It is present to the apprehender through its external existence, and this is knowledge by presence. This is followed by the apprehender's transition to the quiddity of that thing and to the effects that follow upon it externally. In other words, acquired knowledge is an intellectual consideration to which the intellect is compelled. It is taken from an object known by presence: an immaterial existent, imaginal or intellectual, present to the apprehender through its external existence, even though apprehended from afar.

Let us return to our discussion of the definition of knowledge. We say: there is no doubt that knowledge occurs and exists for the knower.

This is not just any sort of occurrence. It is the occurrence of something actual with pure actuality, containing absolutely no potentiality for anything. We find through immediate awareness that the cognitive form, considered as such, has no potentiality for another form and does not admit change from the actuality it possesses. It is therefore the occurrence of something immaterial, free of the deficiencies of potentiality. We call this "presence."

The presence of one thing to another is its occurrence for that other in such a way that it is fully actual, without an attachment to matter that would leave it deficient with respect to some of its perfections that remain potential.

The presence of knowledge to the knower requires that the knower too be complete and actual in itself, without deficiency in respect of some of the perfections possible for it. This means that it is immaterial and devoid of potentiality. Knowledge is thus the occurrence of something immaterial

for something immaterial. Or, if you wish, you may say: it is the presence of one thing to another.

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1. **translation:** In the paragraph beginning “What has been established,” wahm is rendered “misapprehension” in the context of mistakenly identifying the form present to cognition with the externally material form. It is distinguished here from takhayyul, rendered “imagination” earlier in the same paragraph.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 293–297 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=293&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

The union of the knower with the known, termed the union of the intellect with the intelligible

الفصل الثاني — في إتّحاد العالم بالمعلوم ، وهو المعنون عنه باتّحاد العاقل بالمعقول

One thing’s knowledge of another is the occurrence of the known—that is, the cognitive form—for the knower, as explained above. A thing’s occurrence is its existence, and its existence is the thing itself. Knowledge is therefore identical with what is known per se. A necessary consequence of the known’s occurrence for the knower and presence to it is that the knower is united with it, whether it is known by presence or through acquired knowledge. If the object of acquired knowledge subsists in its own right, its existence is for itself. Yet it is also for the knower. The knower must therefore be united with the known, since it is necessarily impossible for a thing to exist both for itself and for another. If it is something whose existence is for another—namely, its subject—and is also for the knower, then the knower is united with its subject. What exists for another is united with that other, and is therefore united with whatever that other is united with.

The same reasoning applies to what is known by presence and the one who knows it.

You may object: it was established in the discussions of mental existence that to say knowledge belongs to the category of the known means that the concept of that category is included in the knowledge. That is, the category is predicated of it by primary predication, rather than by common predication, which is the criterion for a quiddity’s falling under a category and for effects to follow upon it, including the existence’s being for itself or for another. A mental substance, insofar as it is mental, is therefore not a substance by common predication existing for itself; nor is a mental accident, insofar as it is mental, an accident by common predication existing for another.

In brief, there is no sense in the union of the intellect, which is an external existent upon which effects follow, with the mental intelligible, which is a mental concept upon which those effects do not follow.

As for knowledge by presence, either what is known is the knower itself, as in our knowledge of ourselves, or it is not. In the latter case, what is known is either a cause of the knower, an effect of the knower, or, together with the knower, an effect of a third thing. In a thing's knowledge of itself, what is known is identical with the knower; there is no multiplicity there for union to apply. This is evident. In a cause's knowledge of its effect, or an effect's knowledge of its cause, however, there is no doubt that cause and effect must be distinct. Otherwise a thing would precede itself in existence and be posterior to itself in existence, which is self-evidently impossible.

As for one of the two effects of a third cause knowing the other, their necessary distinction in individuality excludes union. Moreover, union would entail that all immaterial beings—each of them knowing all and known by all—were a single individual.

We reply: the objection concerning acquired knowledge is answered by what was established above, that all acquired knowledge ultimately rests upon knowledge by presence. What is then present to the knower as its object is an immaterial existent through its external existence, which is either for itself or for another.

As for the objection concerning knowledge by presence, recall that an existent which is an effect can be considered in two ways. First, it may be considered in itself, disregarding its cause. It then has a contingent quiddity and exists in itself, excluding nonexistence from its quiddity; predicates may be predicated of it, and it may be predicated of something. Second, it may be considered by comparing its existence with the existence of its cause. It was established in the discussions of cause and effect that the existence of an effect, insofar as it is intrinsically dependent, is a relational existence in relation to its cause, with no independent selfhood. It has nothing but its subsistence through the existence of its cause, without anything being predicated of it or it being predicated of anything.

With this established, when the knower is the cause and the known is the effect, the relation between them is that of the relational to the independently existent in itself. It is evident that a relational existent excludes existence for something, since this presupposes existence in itself, whereas the relational existent exists in another. A condition of something's being known is that it exist for the knower. The effect, however, is relational and subsists through the existence of the cause, in the sense that it is neither outside nor absent from it. Its existence for the cause is therefore fulfilled only through what sustains it, namely, the cause's existence. What the cause knows is thus itself insofar as it sustains the effect's existence. The cause intellects its own essence, and the effect is not outside it—not in the sense of being a part or of composition. The predication between them is the predication of the effect, as sustained by the cause, of the cause. This is a kind of predication of a reality and its attenuated reality.

Similar reasoning applies to knowledge of the relational: everything relational that is known is known through knowledge of the independent being through which that relation subsists.

When the knower is the effect and the known is the cause, the known must exist for the knower, while it is impossible for anything to exist for a relational existence. The cause's existence for the effect is therefore fulfilled only through the effect's subsistence through the cause. The cause itself exists for itself, while the effect is not outside it. The cause knows itself, and this knowledge is ascribed to the effect insofar as the effect is not outside it. The effect attains only as much knowledge of the cause as its own existence can encompass. The predication between them is the predication of the cause of the effect, as sustained by the cause. This too is a kind of predication of a reality and its attenuated reality.

Thus an effect's knowledge of its cause ultimately amounts to the cause's knowledge—considered together with its effect—of itself considered alone. And a cause's knowledge of its effect ultimately amounts to the cause's knowledge—considered in itself—of itself considered together with its effect.

When the knower and the known are two effects of a third cause, union of the knower and the known does not mean that the two individuals turn into a single individual. It means, rather, that the quiddities of both the knower and the known are abstracted from the knower.

As for counting a thing's knowledge of itself as a union of the knower and the known, this is in consideration of the abstraction from it of the two concepts of knower and known, which are distinct concepts. It is therefore called "union," although in itself it is one.

What has been said also shows the invalidity of the objection that all immaterial beings would have to be a single individual. It has become clear that the individuality of the knower or the known is not abolished by the union in question.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 298–301 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=298&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The division of acquired knowledge into universal and particular, and related matters

الفصل الثالث — في انقسام العلم الحصوليّ إلى كلّيّ وجزئيّ وما يتّصل به

Acquired knowledge divides into universal and particular.

The universal is that which the intellect does not refuse to suppose true of many, such as the intelligible human, which the intellect allows to be true of many things externally.

The particular is that which the intellect refuses to allow to be true of many. One example is knowledge of this human obtained through a kind of connection with his present matter; this is called “sensory knowledge” or “sensation.” Another is knowledge of an individual human without his matter being present; this is called “imaginative knowledge.”

These two divisions of knowledge are counted as particular, incapable of being true of many, only because the organs of sense are connected to the matter of the external known in sensory knowledge, and because imaginative knowledge depends upon prior sensory knowledge. Otherwise the cognitive form, whether sensory, imaginative, or of another kind, does not in itself exclude being true of many.

Corollaries

First: it is clear from the foregoing that the connection of the organs of sense with external matter, and the material action and affection involved in this, serve to prepare the soul to apprehend the form of the known, whether particular or universal.

It follows that the following account is offered as an illustrative comparison to facilitate understanding: “Intellection consists in stripping the known of matter and of the other individuating accidents surrounding it until only the quiddity remains, stripped of these coverings. This differs from sensation, which requires matter to be present and the individuating accidents to surround it; and from imagination, which requires the accidents and individuating configurations to remain, but does not require matter to be present.”

The truth is that what is sensed per se is an immaterial cognitive form. The presence of matter and the surrounding individuating accidents are required to produce the soul’s preparedness for sensory apprehension. Likewise, the requirement that individuating features accompany a form in imagination, and the requirement of stripping in intellection, indicate the conditions of preparedness. In the latter case, apprehending more than one individual is required to prepare the soul to intellect the universal quiddity, which is expressed as abstracting the universal from the individuals.

Second: taking a concept and abstracting it from its instance depends upon some connection with that instance and contact with external reality. This may be unmediated, as when the organs of sense connect with external reality in sensory knowledge; or mediated, as when imagination connects with external reality through sensation in imaginative knowledge, and as when the intellect connects with external reality in intellectual knowledge through the sensory and imaginative apprehension of particulars.

If, in apprehending a concept, the apprehensive faculty did not draw upon external reality, but instead produced the apprehension itself without any connection to external reality, the apprehended form would stand in the same relation to its own instance as to anything else. It would therefore have to be true of everything or of nothing at all. Yet it is true of its own instance rather than anything else. This is a contradiction.

You may object: there is no doubt that most acquired knowledge ultimately derives from sensation. But not all acquired knowledge is obtained through the external senses. Love, hatred, willing, aversion, and other things apprehended through the internal senses are examples; their mental forms are apprehended without connection to external reality. Moreover, the senses apprehend only accidental quiddities. No sense reaches substance insofar as it is substance. Its mental form is therefore obtained without sensation and its connection to external reality.

I reply: as for mental forms obtained through internal sensations, such as love, hatred, and the like, the soul takes them from its apprehension of those attributes through their external existence in the soul. Connection with external reality is therefore preserved in their case.

As for substance, it is undoubtedly true that no external or internal sense knows or reaches substance. But at the outset the soul has knowledge of itself by presence, through which it reaches and witnesses its own external existence. From what it knows by presence it takes a mental form, just as it takes other mental forms from things known by presence, as explained above. It then senses the attributes and accidents that subsist in it and witnesses their intrinsic need for the soul as their subject, and the soul's subsistence in itself without need of anything in which to subsist. It subsequently finds accidental attributes that assail and befall it from outside, by which it is affected. It sees that these are like the accidents that are effects of the soul and subsist in it, and like things have the same ruling. It therefore judges that they have a subject in which they subsist, just as the soul is the subject of its accidental attributes. In this way the concept of substance is obtained: a quiddity which, when it exists, exists not in a subject.

Third: the foregoing establishes that existence divides, according to whether or not it is free of matter, into three universal realms. The first is the realm of matter and potentiality.

The second is the realm free of matter but not of its effects, such as shape, magnitude, position, and the like. It contains corporeal forms, their accidents, and their configurations of perfection, without matter bearing potentiality. It is called the "imaginal realm" and the "intermediate realm," because it lies between the realms of matter and intellectual immateriality.

They have divided the imaginal realm into the greater imaginal realm, which subsists in its own right, and the lesser imaginal realm, which subsists in the soul. In the latter, the soul acts as it wishes according to different motives, sometimes producing true and sound forms, and sometimes arbitrary forms with which it plays.

The third is the realm free of matter and of its effects, called the “realm of intellect.”

These three realms form a vertical order. The highest in rank, strongest in manifestation, prior in existence, and nearest to the First Principle—exalted and holy—is the realm of immaterial intellects, because they are fully actual and their existence is free from any admixture of matter and potentiality. Next comes the imaginal realm, free of matter but not of its effects. Then comes the realm of matter, the abode of deficiency, evil, and possibility. Knowledge is connected to what is in this realm only through what corresponds to it in the imaginal and intellectual realms, as was indicated above.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 301–304 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=301&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

Another sense in which acquired knowledge divides into universal and particular

الفصل الرابع — ينقسم العلم الحصوليّ إلى كلّيّ وجزئيّ بمعنى آخر

In this sense, universal knowledge is knowledge that does not change when the external known changes. An example is the form of a building that a builder conceives and according to which he builds. It remains as it is before the building, while the building exists, and after it, even if the building ceases to exist. This is called “knowledge prior to multiplicity.”

Knowledge through causes is universal in this sense. An example is an astronomer’s knowledge that the moon will be eclipsed on a particular day, from a particular hour to another, when the celestial configuration returns to a position that requires the earth to intervene between the moon and the sun. His knowledge of this remains the same before, during, and after the eclipse.

The reason is that a complete cause does not change from what it is in its causality. Since knowledge of it corresponds to what is known, its cognitive form does not change. Likewise, knowledge of its effect does not change. It is therefore universal and constant.

This makes clear that sensory knowledge cannot be universal, because sensible things change.

Particular knowledge is knowledge that changes when the external known changes. An example is our knowledge through vision of Zayd’s motion while he is moving. When he stops moving, the knowledge changes. This is called “knowledge subsequent to multiplicity.”

It may be objected: the change of knowledge, which you have acknowledged in the second division, proves that it is material. For change is a transition from one state to another; it entails potentiality, which in turn entails matter. Yet you have said that knowledge in all its divisions is immaterial.

We reply: knowledge of change is different from a change of knowledge. Change is constant in its changing, rather than itself changing. Knowledge's connection to what changes—that is, its presence to the knower—is only in respect of its constancy, not its change. Otherwise it would not be present, and there would be no presence of one thing to another. This is a contradiction.

A clarification

The division can be generalized to include knowledge by presence. Universal knowledge would then be exemplified by a cause's knowledge of its effect through its own essence, which possesses the effect's perfection within itself in a higher and nobler manner. This knowledge does not change if the effect passes away, supposing that it can pass away. Particular knowledge would be exemplified by a cause's knowledge of its perishing effect that is identical with the effect itself. Such knowledge passes away with the passing away of the effect.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 304–305 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=304&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The kinds of intellection

الفصل الخامس — في أنواع التعقّل

They have stated that intellect is of three kinds.

The first is intellect in potentiality: it is not actually any of the intelligibles, nor does it actually possess any of the intelligibles, since it is devoid of all intelligibles.

The second is for it actually to intellect one intelligible or many intelligibles, distinguishing them from one another and arranging them. This is detailed intellection.

The third is for it actually to intellect many intelligibles without distinguishing them from one another. This is a simple, comprehensive intellection containing all the details. They illustrate it by the case in which someone asks you several questions about matters you know, and the answer immediately comes to you. At the very first moment when you begin to answer, you actually know them all with certain knowledge, yet without distinguishing some from others or setting out their

details. Distinction and detail arise only in the answer, as though the simple knowledge you possess were a spring from which the details issue and flow. This is called “comprehensive intellection.”

They presented this division as a division of acquired knowledge.

But since you have learned above that every acquired knowledge ultimately rests upon knowledge by presence, you must understand the discussion in a manner that also applies to knowledge by presence. Do not overlook this.

The same applies to the discussions of acquired knowledge that follow this one.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 305–306 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=305&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The degrees of intellect

الفصل السادس — في مراتب العقل

They have stated that intellect has four degrees.

The first is the material intellect: the degree at which the soul is devoid of all intelligibles. It is called “material intellect” because it resembles prime matter in being devoid of all actualities.

The second is intellect in habitu: the degree at which the soul intellects self-evident matters, whether conceptions or assents. Self-evident knowledge precedes all other knowledge, because theoretical knowledge depends upon it.

The third is actual intellect: the degree at which the soul intellects theoretical matters by deducing them from self-evident matters.

The fourth is the soul’s intellection of all the self-evident and theoretical intelligibles it has acquired that correspond to the realities of the higher and lower worlds. It brings them all to presence and attends to them without any material distraction. It thus becomes a world of knowledge corresponding to the world of concrete reality. This is called “acquired intellect.”

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 306–307 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=306&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

That which bestows these cognitive forms

The bestower of universal intellectual forms is an intellectual substance separate from matter, possessing all universal intellectual forms.

For, as established above, these cognitive forms are immaterial and are bestowed upon the soul. They therefore have a bestower. Their bestower is either the soul, which both produces and receives them, or something outside it, whether material or immaterial. That the soul should itself bestow and produce them is impossible, because this would require one and the same thing to be both agent and recipient; its falsity was established above. That the bestower should be material is refuted by the fact that a material thing is weaker in existence than an immaterial one. It is therefore impossible for it to be their agent, since an agent is stronger in existence than its act. Moreover, the action of material causes is conditional upon position, whereas an immaterial thing has no position. It is therefore established that the bestower of these intellectual forms is an immaterial intellectual substance, the nearest of the immaterial intellects to the substance receiving the bestowal. It contains all intellectual forms, intellected through comprehensive intellection. The soul prepared for intellection is united with it to the extent of its preparedness, and receives from it those intellectual forms for which it is prepared.

You may object: let us grant that universal cognitive forms are bestowed by a separate substance, on the basis of the demonstration already given. But why are all of them attributed to a single individual intellect? Why not ascribe them to many intellects of different quiddities, attributing each form to a separate substance different from the one to which another is attributed, or attributing each group of forms to an intellect different from the one to which another group is attributed?

I reply: the reason is what was established in earlier discussions: every immaterial species is confined to a single individual. It follows that each link in the chain of intellects, which demonstration establishes and to which it establishes that the existence of material things and material effects is attributable, is a species confined to a single individual. Their multiplicity is a vertical multiplicity, ordered and arranged as efficient causes, beginning with the first of them to issue from the First Principle and ending with the intellect nearest to material things and material effects. Material things and material effects must therefore be ascribed to the intellect nearest to them, which the Peripatetics call the “Agent Intellect.”

The Illuminationists, to be sure, also establish horizontal intellects beyond and below the vertical intellects: these are the lords of material species. They hold, however, that the existence of each species, with its material individuals and their perfections, is attributable to that species’ lord and

archetype.

Reasoning similar to that given for universal cognitive forms applies to particular cognitive forms. It establishes that the bestower of particular cognitive forms is a separate imaginal substance, containing all particular forms in the manner of comprehensive knowledge. The soul is united with it to the extent of its preparedness, and it bestows the appropriate forms upon the soul.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 307–308 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=307&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

The division of acquired knowledge into conception and assent

الفصل الثامن — ينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى تصوّر وتصديق

Acquired knowledge is either a mental form obtained from a single known, without affirmation or negation, such as knowledge of a human or of the antecedent of a conditional proposition; this is called “conception.” Or it is a mental form consisting of items of knowledge accompanied by affirmation or negation, as in categorical and conditional propositions; this is called “assent.”

Since a proposition contains affirmation or negation, it is composed of more than one part.

The prevalent view is that an affirmative categorical proposition consists of the subject, the predicate, the predicative relation—which is the relation of the predicate to the subject—and the judgment that the subject is united with the predicate. This applies to compound existential propositions, whose predicates are other than the subject’s existence, as when we say, “The human is capable of laughter.” Simple existential propositions, whose predicate is the subject’s existence, as when we say, “The human exists,” consist of three parts: the subject, the predicate, and the judgment. For it makes no sense for a relation, which is a relational existence, to intervene between a thing and its existence, which is the thing itself.

The prevalent view also holds that a negative categorical proposition consists of the subject, the predicate, and the negative predicative relation. It contains no judgment; it is not that it contains a negative judgment. For judgment is making something to be something, while the negation of judgment is not making it so, rather than making its nonexistence.

The truth is that a proposition requires the conception of a predicative relation only on account of judgment insofar as it is an act of the soul, rather than insofar as it is a part of the proposition. The predicative relation, assuming it is realized, is therefore external to the proposition. In other words, the proposition is the subject, the predicate, and the judgment. But the soul reaches the judgment—which consists in making the subject be the predicate—by first conceiving the predicate as related

to the subject, so that it can make the judgment. The evidence for this is that simple existential propositions lack a predicative relation, yet are propositions, as stated above. A proposition, insofar as it is a proposition, therefore does not require a predicative relation for its realization.

As for judgment's being an act of the soul within mental apprehension, its reality in our statement "Zayd is standing," for example, is as follows. Through sensation the soul reaches one thing, namely, the standing Zayd. It then reaches the standing ʿAmr and the nonstanding Zayd. This prepares it to separate the standing Zayd into the two concepts "Zayd" and "standing." It makes this separation and retains both concepts. Then, when it wishes to represent what it found externally, it takes the retained Zayd and standing, which are two, and makes them one. This is the judgment that we have described as an act: a making and bringing about by the soul, through which it represents external reality.

Judgment is therefore an act of the soul, while also being one of the mental forms that represent what lies beyond them. If it were a conception taken from external reality, the proposition would not convey a complete meaning on which one could stop, just as either component of a conditional proposition does not. If it were a conception produced by the soul on its own, without assistance or support from external reality, it would not represent external reality. Some further matters related to this will come to you later.

The foregoing establishes that every assent depends upon more than one conception. There is thus no assent without conception.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 308–310 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=308&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The division of acquired knowledge into self-evident and theoretical

الفصل التاسع — ينقسم العلم الحصولي إلى بديهيّ ونظري

Self-evident knowledge, also called necessary knowledge, is that whose acquisition requires no learning or reflection. Examples include conceiving the concepts of existence, thing, and unity, and assenting that the whole is greater than its part and that four is even.

Theoretical knowledge is that which requires learning and reflection for its conception, if it is conceptual knowledge, or for assent to it, if it is knowledge by assent. Examples include conceiving the quiddity of a human or a horse, and assenting that the three angles of a triangle equal two right angles and that the human has an immaterial soul.

They have reduced self-evident propositions to six divisions: sensible propositions, propositions established through recurrent testimony, experiential propositions, innate propositions, introspectively known propositions, and primary propositions, as they have explained in logic.

The self-evident propositions most worthy of acceptance are the primary propositions. These are propositions for assent to which it suffices merely to conceive the subject and the predicate, as when we say, “The whole is greater than its part” and “A thing is established for itself”; or the antecedent and consequent, as when we say, “A number is either even or odd.”

The primary proposition most worthy of acceptance is the proposition that contradictories cannot both obtain or both be absent. This is expressed by our saying, “Either the affirmation is true and the negation false, or the negation is true and the affirmation false.”

This is a genuine disjunctive proposition. No theoretical or self-evident proposition, even among the primary propositions, can dispense with it in yielding knowledge. Our saying “The whole is greater than its part,” for example, yields knowledge only if it excludes its contradictory and that contradictory is false.

It is therefore the first proposition to which assent attaches, and all theoretical and self-evident knowledge ultimately rests upon it in an exceptive syllogism through which the knowledge is completed.

If doubt about it were supposed, this would spread to every proposition and invalidate knowledge at its very root.

The following consequences ensue.

First: for every proposition supposed, we have a true proposition, either that proposition itself or its contradictory.

Second: the contradictory of one proposition is one, and there is no intermediary between contradictories.

Third: contradiction between two conceptions ultimately amounts to contradiction between two assents. Thus the contradiction between human and nonhuman amounts to the existence and nonexistence of the human, which in turn amount to our saying, “The human exists” and “The human does not exist.”

A clarification

The sophist, who denies the existence of knowledge altogether, does not concede the first of first principles. If he conceded it, this would be his acknowledgment that of every two contradictory propositions, one is true and correct; and this would acknowledge the existence of some knowledge.

Now the sophist, in displaying doubt about every judgment, either acknowledges that he knows he is doubting, or does not acknowledge this.

If he acknowledges that he knows he is doubting, he has acknowledged some knowledge. To this is added his concession of the first of first principles, followed by knowledge that of every two contradictory propositions one is true and correct. Further items of knowledge follow upon this.

If he does not acknowledge that he knows he is doubting, but instead declares that he doubts everything and doubts his own doubt, without being certain of anything, then arguing with him is futile and no demonstration will succeed with him. Such a person is either afflicted by a disorder that has impaired his apprehension, in which case he should consult a physician; or he obstinately opposes the truth and displays what he does in order to refute the truth and escape its consequences. In that case, let him be beaten and tormented, deprived of what he loves, and compelled to undergo what he hates, since for him everything and its contradictory are equal.

Some of those who display doubt, however, have turned to the rational sciences without being equipped with logical principles or trained in the art of demonstration. They have witnessed investigators disagreeing on questions through affirmation and denial, and have seen the arguments they offer for the two sides of a contradiction. Because of their limited resources, they have been unable to distinguish truth from falsehood, and so have accepted contradictory positions in question after question. They have consequently come to distrust logic, supposing that there is no path to attaining reality that secures thought against error, and no way to know anything as it is. As you see, however, this is itself a decisive judgment about many things: that the investigators' ideas and arguments diverge without any having a preponderance over others, and that this entails the incapacity of argument as such to attain reality. Such a person may therefore abandon his supposition when alerted to this. He should be treated by explaining the laws of logic and showing him self-evident propositions that admit no doubt under any circumstances, such as the necessity that a thing be established for itself and the impossibility of its being denied of itself. Every effort should be made to explain the meanings of the parts of propositions to him, and he should be instructed to learn the mathematical sciences.

There are two groups of doubters short of those just mentioned. One group concedes the human being and his apprehensions while expressing doubt about everything beyond that. Another group has noticed that saying "we and our apprehensions" acknowledges that each of them knows the

existence of other human beings and their apprehensions. There is no difference between this knowledge and other apprehensions in their property of disclosing what is external. They have therefore changed the formulation to “I and my apprehensions.”

The answer is that a human sometimes errs in his apprehensions, as in errors of sight and touch and other errors of thought. Unless there were external realities that apprehension either corresponds to or fails to correspond to, this would not be coherent. Moreover, to classify apprehension of the self and of its apprehensions as knowledge, while classifying apprehensions beyond this as doubts, is plainly arbitrary.

Another form of sophistry is the claim: “Empirical investigation shows that sensible things, in their external existence, do not correspond to their forms in sensation. Since knowledge ultimately derives from sensation, nothing known corresponds to external reality in a way that discloses a truth.”

The answer is that if sensation does not disclose the reality of the sensible thing as it is externally, and all other knowledge ultimately derives from sensation and shares its ruling, then from where has it become evident that external realities differ from what sensation reaches? The supposition is that every apprehension is sensory or ultimately derives from sensation, and that sensation has no access to external reality. The claim thus ends in sophistry, just as the claim that mental forms are mere likenesses of external things ends in sophistry.

Another form of sophistry is the claim: “What we count as knowledge consists of opinions, having nothing of knowledge that excludes its contradictory.”

The answer is that this very statement, “What we count as knowledge consists of opinions,” is itself a proposition claiming knowledge. If it were a matter of opinion, it would not establish that knowledge consists of opinions. It would establish only the opinion that it consists of opinions. Reflect upon this and take heed.

The same applies to the claim: “Our knowledge is relative, varying with the conditions of existence. There is knowledge relative to each condition, but no absolute knowledge, no permanent knowledge, no universal knowledge, and no necessary knowledge.”

These statements refute themselves. If “knowledge is relative” is itself a relative statement, it establishes that there is an absolute statement and thus refutes itself. If it is an absolute statement, an absolute statement is thereby established, and it again refutes itself. The same holds for “there is no absolute knowledge.” As for “there is no universal knowledge,” if it is itself universal, it refutes

itself; if it is not universal, it establishes a universal statement and thus refutes itself. Likewise, “there is no permanent knowledge” and “there is no necessary knowledge” refute themselves however they are supposed.

There is, to be sure, an admixture of relativity in practical knowledge, to which reference will be made later, God willing.

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1. **translation:** “Innate propositions” renders fiṭriyyāt, the logical class of propositions whose supporting inference is immediately available to the mind when their terms are conceived.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 310–314 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=310&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

The division of acquired knowledge into real concepts and concepts formed by intellectual consideration

الفصل العاشر — ينقسم العلم الحصوليّ إلى حقيقيّ وإعتباريّ

A real concept is a concept that sometimes exists externally, where its effects follow upon it, and sometimes exists in the mind, where its external effects do not follow upon it: the concept of human, for example. It follows that it stands in an equal relation to existence and nonexistence. This is the quiddity predicated of a thing in answer to “What is it?”

A concept formed by intellectual consideration is the opposite of a real concept. It is either one of those concepts whose instance is characterized precisely by being external, with its effects following upon it, and therefore cannot enter the mind, whose character is that external effects do not follow there. Otherwise it would be transformed from what it is. Existence and its real attributes, such as unity, necessity, and the like, are examples. Or its instance is characterized precisely by not being external, as with nonexistence. This too cannot enter the mind; otherwise it would be transformed into something capable of external existence, whereas there is no mental existence for that which has no external existence. Or it is one of those concepts whose instance is characterized precisely by being mental, such as the concepts of universal, genus, and differentia. Such a thing does not exist externally, since otherwise it would be transformed from what it is.

These are known mental concepts, but in respect of their instances they are either purely external and do not enter the mind, as with existence and what accompanies it; or pure nullity, as with nonexistence; or purely mental, with no access to external reality. They are therefore not abstracted from external reality, and are not quiddities that exist at one time with external existence and at another with mental existence. They are, however, abstracted from instances, as is shown by their being acquired items of knowledge upon which the effects do not follow. They must therefore be abstracted from instances in the mind.

As for meanings whose instances are characterized precisely by being mental, our minds can take something abstracted from external reality—which is a concept—as an instance and consider it. The intellect is then compelled to consider properties appropriate to it. Thus it abstracts the concept of human from several individuals, such as Zayd, ʿAmr, Bakr, and others, then takes this concept and sets it up as an instance. Examining the properties surrounding it, the intellect finds it to be the entire quiddity of the instances, in which case it is a species; or a part of their quiddity, in which case it is a genus or differentia; or something external to their quiddity, equal in extension or broader, in which case it is a proprium or common accident. It finds that the concept admits of being true of many, which is universality; and it proceeds in this manner.

As for concepts whose instances are characterized precisely by being external or not being external, they appear to be abstracted from the judgment in affirmative propositions and its absence in negative propositions.

To explain: when the soul first reaches some sensible quiddity through sensation, it takes what it has reached and stores it in imagination. When it reaches it a second time, or at the next instant, and takes it to store it, the soul finds it identical with what it reached first and corresponding to it. This is predication, which is the union of two concepts in existence. The soul then reproduces the concept repeatedly, one reproduction after another, and makes them one. This is a judgment and an act of the soul, while at the same time representing external reality. This act is an existential relation and a relational existence, considered as subsisting through its two terms.

The soul can then conceive the judgment, which is its own act, and consider it independently as ascribed to that of which it is an attribute, after it had been relational. It thereby conceives the existence of the concept. It then abstracts this and conceives existence on its own, without ascription. In this way, the concept of existence is abstracted from judgment and applies to its external instance, even though that instance is characterized precisely by being external. Such things are instances of existence, rather than individuals containing its concept in the way that a quiddity is contained in its individuals. The soul then abstracts from the instances of existence its distinctive attributes, such as necessity, unity, multiplicity, potentiality, actuality, and others.

Next, when the soul reaches a sensible quiddity and stores it, then reaches another quiddity different from it, it does not find the second to be identical with the first and corresponding to it, as it did in the previous case. When it brings both to presence after storing them, it does not perform upon them the judgment it performed in the previous case of the repeated quiddity. Yet it considers this too an act of its own: the negation of predication, as opposed to predication. It then considers this independently and with ascription, conceiving it as the negation of the predicate from the

subject. It subsequently considers it without qualification, conceiving it as negation and nonexistence. It is then compelled to consider properties belonging to it, such as the absence of distinction between nonexistences and their distinction through their ascription to existents.

The foregoing establishes the following.

First: any concept predicated of both the Necessary and the contingent, such as knowledge and life, is formed by intellectual consideration. Otherwise the Necessary would possess a quiddity—exalted is He above that.

Second: any concept predicated of more than one category, such as motion, is formed by intellectual consideration. Otherwise it would fall under more than one genus, which is impossible.

Third: concepts formed by intellectual consideration have no essential definition and are not included as a genus in the essential definition of a quiddity. The same applies to other properties distinctive of quiddities, such as universality, except by a certain extension of usage.

A clarification

In technical usage, “considered” has other meanings besides the preceding one, which lie outside our present discussion.

The first is that which stands opposed to primacy, in the sense of being intrinsically the source of effects, as discussed in the investigation of the primacy of existence and quiddity.

The second is “considered” in the sense of having no existence distinct from another, as opposed to the “real,” which has a distinct existence. An example is the considered character of the category of relation, which exists through the existence of its two terms, unlike substance, which exists in itself.

The third is a conceptual or assertoric meaning that has no realization beyond the sphere of action.

Consideration in this sense ultimately consists in borrowing objectively real concepts, with their definitions, for kinds of actions—which are different motions—and their objects, in order to attain sought-after vital ends. An example is considering the chief of a people to possess headship, so that he stands to the group as the head stands to the body in managing its affairs and directing its members toward the action required. Another is considering Zayd, for example, to possess ownership in relation to the property he has taken possession of, so that he alone may dispose of it as he wishes, as is the case with a real owner in relation to what he owns, such as the human soul

that owns its faculties. Another is considering the relation between a man and a woman as a pairing, so that the two spouses share in what follows upon the pair together, as is the case with a numerical pair. Other cases follow the same pattern.

From this it is clear that these conventional meanings have neither essential definitions nor demonstrations.

They have no essential definitions because they have no quiddity falling under any category. They therefore have no genus, hence no differentia, and hence no essential definition. They do, however, have definitions borrowed from the realities whose concepts are borrowed for them.

They have no demonstrations because the premises of a demonstration must be necessary, permanent, and universal. These features are realized only in true propositions corresponding to objective reality. How could conventional premises possess them, when they do not go beyond the bounds of a claim?

It also becomes clear that reasoning about them is dialectical, composed of widely accepted propositions and conceded premises. What is accepted among them is that which has a beneficial effect in relation to the ends; what is rejected is the futile, which has no effect.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 314–317 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=314&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

Knowledge by presence is not confined to a thing’s knowledge of itself

الفصل الحادي عشر — في العلم الحضوريّ وأنّه لا يختصّ بعلم الشيء بنفسه

It was established above that every immaterial substance, because of the completeness of its essence, is present to itself through itself and its external identity. It therefore knows itself by presence.

Is knowledge by presence confined to a thing’s knowledge of itself, or does it include this together with a cause’s knowledge of its effect and an effect’s knowledge of its cause? The Peripatetics adopted the first view and the Illuminationists the second, which is the truth. For the existence of the effect is a relational existence in relation to the existence of its cause, subsisting through it and in no way independent of it. The effect is therefore present to its cause with its entire existence, without being veiled from it. Through its very existence it is known by its cause through knowledge by presence, if both are immaterial. Likewise, the cause is present through its existence

to its effect, which is related to it, subsists through it, and is independent through its independence. The cause is therefore known to its effect through knowledge by presence if both are immaterial. This is what was sought.

It was also established above that all acquired knowledge ultimately rests upon knowledge by presence. Some acquired knowledge is such that neither knower nor known is the cause or effect of the other; rather, both are effects of a third cause.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 318–318 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=318&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Every immaterial being is intellect, intellective subject, and intelligible

الفصل الثاني عشر — كلّ مجرّد فإنّه عقل وعاقل ومعقول

As for its being intellect: because its essence is complete and it is pure actuality unaccompanied by potentiality, it is possible for it to exist and be present to something. Whatever is possible for an immaterial being belongs to it actually. It is therefore actually intelligible. Since intellect is united with the intelligible, it is intellect. And since its essence exists for its own essence, it intellects its own essence. Every immaterial being is therefore intellect, intellective subject, and intelligible. Or, if you wish, say: “Intellect, intellective subject, and intelligible are three concepts abstracted from one existence.”

The demonstration just given applies not only to every immaterial being’s being intellect, intellective subject, and intelligible for itself, but also to its being intellect and intelligible for another.

It may be objected: this requires that the human soul, because it is immaterial, should intellect itself and every immaterial being supposed. But this is contrary to what is immediately evident.

We reply: this would be so if the immaterial soul were completely immaterial in both essence and act. It is, however, immaterial in essence and material in act. Because it is immaterial in essence, it actually intellects its own essence.

Its intellection of other things, however, depends upon its gradual passage from potentiality to actuality according to the different dispositions it acquires. If it became completely immaterial and the governance of the body no longer occupied it, all intellections would actually belong to it through comprehensive intellect, and it would become acquired intellect.

Note that this account applies only to immaterial essences whose existence is in itself and for itself. As for accidents, whose existence is in itself but for another, the intellective subject to which their intelligible forms occur is their subject, rather than the accidents themselves. The same ruling applies to relations and connections, whose existences are in another.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 318–319 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=318&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

Knowledge of what has a cause is obtained only through knowledge of its cause, and related matters

الفصل الثالث عشر — في أنّ العلم بذي السبب لايحصل إلاّ من طريق العلم بسببه وما يتّصل بذلك السبب

By cause here we mean the cause that necessitates the effect through the specific character of its causality, whether it is a cause through its quiddity, as four is the cause of evenness, or a cause through its external existence. It is that to which the existence of the effect is attributable, while its being attributable to anything else is impossible; otherwise a single effect would have two independent causes. Since knowledge corresponds exactly to what is known, the relation between knowledge of the effect and knowledge of the cause is the relation between the effect itself and the cause itself. It follows that knowledge of the effect depends upon and follows from knowledge of its cause. If it followed from something other than its cause, one thing would have more than one cause, which is impossible.

It is evident from this account that the ruling concerns knowledge of the caused thing itself together with knowledge of the cause itself, rather than knowledge of the two correlative attributes of causality and being caused. The latter would be of no use here, because it applies to any two correlatives supposed, without being peculiar to knowledge. Moreover, it establishes only concomitance, rather than the dependence of knowledge of the effect upon knowledge of the cause, since correlatives are together in potentiality and actuality, in the mind and externally.

You may object: we often apprehend things through sensation, judge that they are externally realized, and assent to their existence while remaining ignorant of their cause. There is thus knowledge of the effect despite ignorance of the cause. Admittedly, this does reveal in a general way that its cause exists.

We reply: what sensation reaches is the forms of external accidents, without assenting to their establishment or to the establishment of their effects. Assent belongs to the intellect. The intellect sees that what the human reaches through sensation, and which has effects outside him, is something he has not made; and whatever is such exists outside the human soul. This is a passage in knowledge from one of two concomitants to the other.

What was established above is that knowledge of what has a cause depends upon its cause. As for what has no cause, its establishment is known only through general concomitances, as has been demonstrated in the art of demonstration.

A thing's being independent of another thing, which has no part in making it, and its being distinct from and outside that other thing are two general, mutually concomitant attributes that have no cause. Their concomitance is intrinsic, like the other subjects of divine philosophy. The existence of the sensible thing outside the soul is an instance of these two concomitants, and the intellect passes from one to the other. This is just like the intrinsic concomitance between a thing and its being established for itself. This particular thing's being established for itself is one instance of that concomitance, and knowledge of it does not depend upon a cause.

It is therefore clear from the foregoing that investigating a conclusion sought yields knowledge of it only by proceeding to it through its cause, if it has a cause, or through general concomitances, if it has no cause. Proceeding to a cause through its effect, however, yields no knowledge at all.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 320–321 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=320&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 14

Items of knowledge are not intrinsic to the soul

الفصل الرابع عشر — في أنّ العلوم ليست بذاتيّة للنفس

It has been said: "The items of knowledge the soul attains are intrinsic to it and actually present in it from the beginning of its being."

When it was objected that this conflicts with the human's observed ignorance of some items of knowledge and with their need for acquisition in order to become actual, they answered that these items are intrinsic and innate to the soul, but that its occupation with governing the body makes it heedless of its knowledge and distracts it from attending to it.

The objection is that the soul's mode of existence, insofar as it is a soul, is that of a form governing a body. Governing the body is therefore intrinsic to it wherever it is supposed to be a soul. Combining the intrinsic character of its knowledge with the claim that governing the body distracts

it from that knowledge amounts to nothing but contradiction.

This account would, to be sure, make sense on the basis of the view attributed to Plato: souls are temporally eternal, their knowledge is intrinsic to them, and their subsequent governing attachment to bodies causes this governance to make them forget the knowledge rooted in their essences.

But this is false in light of what has been established in psychology: souls originate with the origination of bodies, according to the prevalent view, or through the motion of the substances of bodies after the bodies have originated.

The claim of their eternity has sometimes been interpreted as referring to the eternity of their intellectual mode of being, which precedes their psychic mode of being. Even this, however, does not establish that knowledge is obtained by recollection rather than by the passage of thought from causes to effects, or from some general concomitants to others, as explained above.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 321–322 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=321&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 15

Other divisions of knowledge

الفصل الخامس عشر — في انقسامات أُخر للعلم

The author of the Asfār says, in summary:

“In our view, knowledge is immaterial existence itself. Existence is not in itself a universal generic or specific nature such that it could be divided by differentiae into species, by individuators into individuals, or by accidental qualifications into classes. Rather, every item of knowledge is a simple individual identity that does not fall under an essential universal meaning.

“In one respect, therefore, the division of knowledge is identical with the division of the known, because it is united with the known as existence is united with quiddity. Accordingly, we say that some knowledge is necessary in existence through its own essence: this is the First’s—exalted is He—knowledge of His own essence, which is identical with His essence, without a quiddity. Some knowledge is contingent in existence through its own essence: this is the knowledge of everything other than Him. This divides into what is substance, such as intellectual substances’ knowledge of their own essences, and what is accident. According to the prevalent view, the latter comprises all acquired items of knowledge, because, in their view, they subsist in the mind. In our view, accidental knowledge consists in the attributes of the known things whose forms become present

to the soul. We have explained that knowledge, whether intellectual or imaginative, does not consist in the known things inhering in the intellect or the soul. Rather, they stand before the knower and the soul is united with them.

“Another division: they have said that some knowledge is active, some passive, and some neither active nor passive. Active knowledge includes the Creator’s—exalted is He—knowledge of what is other than His essence, and the knowledge other causes have of their effects. Passive knowledge includes the knowledge beings other than the Creator—exalted is He—have of what is not their effect, when it is obtained only through some affection and change in the knower: in general, through the impression of forms arising in the essence of the soul or in its instruments. Knowledge that is neither active nor passive includes the knowledge intellective essences have of themselves and of things that are never absent from them. One and the same knowledge may be active in one respect and passive in another, as with originated items of knowledge that have external effects, such as the effects of estimative apprehensions upon external materials.”

He also says:

“Knowledge applies to its instances by gradation, as existence does. It therefore differs in intensity and weakness, firstness and priority and their opposites, anteriority, and so forth. Knowledge of the essence of the First—exalted is He—which is His knowledge of His own essence and identical with His essence, is more entitled to be knowledge than knowledge of anything else. It is prior to all other knowledge because it is the cause of all other knowledge, and it is the clearest and strongest in manifestation in its own essence. As for its hiddenness from us, this is due, as you have learned, to its utmost manifestation and to the weakness of our inward sight in apprehending it. The very respect in which it is hidden is the respect in which it is clear and manifest. The same holds for every knowledge of the reality of a cause in comparison with knowledge of the reality of its effect. Likewise, knowledge of the reality of any substance is more intense than knowledge of the reality of any accident. It is more entitled and prior than knowledge of the reality of the accident subsisting in that substance, because the substance is its cause—not than knowledge of the reality of other accidents that do not subsist in it.

“As for applying ‘knowledge’ to action, affection, and relation, as in teaching, learning, and being a knower, this is by equivocation or figurative usage.” End of quotation.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 322–323 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=322&type=c_fbook

STAGE XII

The Necessary Existent

المرحلة الثانية عشرة — في ما يتعلّق بالواجب الوجود عزّ اسمه من المباحث

CHAPTER 0

Introduction to Stage XII: Matters concerning the Necessary Existent

مدخل المرحلة

The inquiries concerning the Necessary Existent—exalted is His name—are in fact questions connected with the stage on necessity and contingency. They have been assigned a separate stage in recognition of their importance and out of regard for the nobility of their subject.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 325–325 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=325&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 1

Establishing necessary existence

الفصل الأوّل — في إثبات الوجود الواجبي

The demonstrations indicating His existence—exalted is He—are many and numerous.

The most reliable and firmest is the demonstration that proceeds to Him through existence. They have called it the “demonstration of the veracious,” because they make Him known through Himself rather than through something else. As you will see, it is a demonstration of fact, in which one proceeds from one concomitant of existence to another.

It has been formulated in more than one way. The briefest formulation is that the reality of existence is either necessary or entails necessary existence. The intrinsically Necessary therefore exists, which is what was sought.

To the same effect is a formulation based upon the primacy of existence: the reality of existence, which is the very reality of concrete things and the core of actuality, is an unrestricted reality that does not admit nonexistence, since no opposite admits its opposite. An unrestricted reality that

does not admit nonexistence is necessary in existence through its own essence. The reality of existence in question is therefore intrinsically necessary, which is what was sought.

You may object: existence's not admitting nonexistence does not require that it be intrinsically necessary. Otherwise the existence of every contingent thing would be intrinsically necessary, because it contradicts its own nonexistence. The contingent would therefore be necessary while still contingent, which is a contradiction.

I reply: this concerns contingent existences, which are delimited by quiddative limits that they do not surpass. Their nonexistence is abstracted from what lies beyond their limits. This is what is meant by their saying, "Every contingent thing is a composite pair." As for the unrestricted reality of existence, which alone is fundamental, with nothing else fundamental besides it, no limit delimits it and no qualification restricts it. It is simple and pure, intrinsically excluding and contradicting nonexistence. This is intrinsic necessity.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—formulated the demonstration in another way. He says:

"Its formulation is as follows. Existence, as stated earlier, is a single, simple, concrete reality. Its individuals differ in themselves only through perfection and deficiency, intensity and weakness, or through additional matters, as with the individuals of a specific quiddity. Its utmost perfection is that than which there is nothing more complete: that which is not dependent upon another, and than which nothing more complete can be conceived. For everything deficient is dependent upon another and needs what completes it. It was established above that completeness precedes deficiency, actuality precedes potentiality, and existence precedes nonexistence. It was also explained that the completeness of a thing is that thing together with what exceeds it.

"Existence is therefore either independent of another or intrinsically dependent upon another. The former is the Necessary Existent: pure existence, than which there is nothing more complete, unmixed with nonexistence or deficiency. The latter is everything other than Him, consisting of His acts and effects. Nothing other than Him has any subsistence except through Him, because, as explained earlier, the reality of existence has no deficiency; deficiency attaches to it only on account of being an effect. For an effect cannot equal its cause in the excellence of existence. If existence were not made, with a dominant principle bringing it into being and realizing it as that principle requires, no manner of deficiency in it could be conceived. For the reality of existence, as you have learned, is simple, possessing no limit or determination except pure actuality and realization. Otherwise it would contain composition or have a quiddity other than existentiality. It

was also established above that when existence is an effect, it is itself made through simple making; its essence is intrinsically dependent upon a maker, and it is attached to its maker in its very substance and essence.

“It is therefore established and clear that existence is either complete in reality and necessary in identity, or intrinsically dependent upon that and attached to it in its very substantiality. In either case, it is established and evident that the existence of the Necessary Existent is independent in its identity of all else. This is what we intended.” End of quotation.

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1. **translation:** “Demonstration of the veracious” renders burhān al-ṣiddīqīn. “Demonstration of fact” renders burhān innī; the next chapter distinguishes this from a demonstration of the reason why (burhān limmī).
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 327–329 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=327&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 2

Some other demonstrations offered for the existence of the Necessary—exalted is He

الفصل الثاني — في بعض آخر ممّا أُقيم على وجود الواجب (تعالى) من البراهين

One demonstration for Him is as follows. There is no doubt that something exists. If it, or anything included in it, is intrinsically necessary, the conclusion sought is established. If it is not intrinsically necessary, yet exists, it is necessarily intrinsically contingent. Its existence has therefore been given preponderance over its nonexistence by something outside its essence, namely, its cause. Otherwise its existence would have preponderance through itself, and it would be intrinsically necessary, though it was supposed contingent. This is a contradiction.

Its cause is either contingent like it or intrinsically necessary. In the latter case, the conclusion sought is established. In the former, the discussion transfers to its cause, and so on. Either the sequence circles back or continues infinitely, both of which are impossible, or it ends in an uncaused cause, which is the intrinsically Necessary. This is what was sought.

It has been objected that this is not a demonstrative account yielding certainty. A demonstration yields certainty only when it proceeds from cause to effect, which is a demonstration of the reason why. A demonstration of fact that proceeds from effect to cause does not yield certainty, as explained in logic.

Since the Necessary—exalted is He—is the cause of all else and is in no way the effect of anything, proceeding to establish His existence from anything whatsoever is a passage from effect to cause that does not yield certainty. This account proceeds from the contingent existent, which is

His effect, to establishing His existence.

The answer is that a demonstration of fact is not confined to proceeding from effect to cause, which does not yield certainty. It may instead proceed from some general concomitants of unrestricted existents to others, and this does yield certainty, as the Shaykh explained in the Book of Demonstration in the logic of the Shifāʾ.

The preceding demonstration proceeds from a condition necessarily accompanying the concept of something existent—which is coextensive with existent insofar as it is existent—to another condition necessarily accompanying it: that among its instances there exists an uncaused cause whose existence is necessary through its own essence.

The foregoing account is therefore a demonstration of fact yielding certainty, like the other demonstrations employed in philosophy to establish the properties of existent insofar as it is existent that are coextensive with existent in general.

A clarification

The substance of the preceding account is that the realization of something existent necessarily accompanies the preponderance of its existence, either through its own essence, in which case it is intrinsically necessary, or through another, in which case it ends in something whose existence has preponderance through its own essence. Otherwise there would be a circle or an infinite regress, both of which are impossible.

The preponderance of existence can be replaced by the necessity of existence, producing a demonstration of fact along another route. It is formulated as follows. There is no doubt that something exists, and every existent is necessary, because a thing does not exist until it is necessitated. If it, or anything included in it, is necessary through its own essence, the conclusion sought is established. If it is necessary through another, namely its existent and necessary cause, then either its cause is necessary through its own essence, which establishes the conclusion, or it is necessary through another. We then transfer the discussion to the cause of its cause, and so on. Either there is a circle, an infinite regress, or a termination in something necessary through its own essence. The first two alternatives are impossible, and the third is what was sought.

Another demonstration was offered by the natural philosophers through motion and change. Its formulation is as follows. It was established above, in the discussions of potentiality and actuality, that the mover is other than the moved. Every moving thing therefore has a mover other than itself. If the mover is itself moved, it too has another mover. To avoid a circle and an infinite regress, the

series of movers must end in an unmoved mover. Because it is free of matter and potentiality, exempt from change and alteration, and constant in its existence, it is either intrinsically necessary in existence or ends in such a being through the series of its causes.

Another demonstration was also offered by the natural philosophers, through the human soul. Its formulation is as follows. The human soul is intrinsically immaterial and, insofar as it is a soul, originates with the origination of the body, since differentiation without bodies and transmigration are impossible, as explained in their proper place. It is therefore contingent, dependent upon a cause that is neither a body nor corporeal. That cause is not a body, because if it were a body, every body would possess a soul, whereas this is not so. Nor is it corporeal, because if it were something corporeal—whether another soul, a corporeal form, or a corporeal accident—its influence would operate through position. Yet the soul, being immaterial, has no position. Moreover, because the soul is immaterial, it is stronger in substantiality and nobler in existence than every body and corporeal thing. There is no sense in the weaker and baser being a cause of the stronger and nobler.

The cause bringing the soul into existence is therefore something beyond the natural world. It is the Necessary—exalted is He—either without an intermediary or through an ordered series of causes ending in Him.

Another demonstration is that of the theologians through origination. Its formulation is as follows. Bodies are never devoid of motion or rest, both of which are originated; and whatever is never devoid of originated things is itself originated. All bodies are therefore originated, and everything originated needs an originator. To avoid a circle and an infinite regress, their originator is something that is neither a body nor corporeal, namely, the Necessary—exalted is He.

This argument is incomplete. The premise that whatever is never devoid of originated things is itself originated is neither evident nor demonstrated. According to their view, change in the accidents of a substance does not necessarily accompany change in the substance that is their subject. If, however, the argument is based on substantial motion, the premise is established and the argument succeeds. As you see, this argument, like the three preceding arguments, rests upon the finitude of causes and their termination in an uncaused cause, which is the Necessary—exalted is He.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 330–333 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=330&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 3

The intrinsically Necessary has no quiddity

This question was discussed in the stage on necessity and contingency. It was shown there that whatever has a quiddity is contingent. By contraposition, whatever is not contingent has no quiddity. The intrinsically Necessary therefore has no quiddity, and neither does the intrinsically impossible.

There we also presented the well-known argument they have offered to deny quiddity of the Necessary—exalted and holy. If the Necessary—exalted is He—had a quiddity beyond His existence, that quiddity would in itself be neither existent nor nonexistent. It would therefore need a cause in order to be clothed with existence. That cause would be either its own essence or something outside it, and both alternatives are impossible. Its own essence cannot be the cause of its existence, because a cause necessarily precedes its effect in existence. The quiddity would thus precede its own existence through its existence, which is impossible. Nor can something else be the cause of its existence, because this would entail that the intrinsically Necessary is the effect of that other thing and is therefore contingent, although He was supposed intrinsically necessary. This is a contradiction. It is thus impossible for the intrinsically Necessary to have a quiddity beyond His existence, which is what was sought.

This is a complete demonstrative argument, free of difficulty. It is not successfully countered by appealing to the existent quiddities of contingent things as follows: if supposing the quiddity posited for the Necessary to be the efficient cause of its own existence required that quiddity to precede the existence caused by it, the same would follow for the existent quiddities of contingent things. For the quiddity of a contingent thing receives its existence, and a recipient, like an agent, must precede what depends upon it.

This counterargument is unsound. A recipient must precede what it receives in existence only when it is a recipient that is a material cause. Such a cause precedes its effect, which is the composite of form and matter. The quiddity of a contingent thing, however, is not a material cause either of its existence or of the existent quiddity. Its receptivity is only an intellectual consideration arising from the intellect’s analysis of the contingent into quiddity and existence, and its taking quiddity as the subject and existence as its predicate. In brief, quiddity is not a receptive cause of existence. But if it were supposed an efficient cause of its existence, it would be a real cause that must really precede it. For the need for a cause of existence is a real need, entailing a real cause, unlike the need for a quiddative recipient to receive existence, which is an intellectual consideration. In reality, quiddity is incidental to existence, rather than existence being incidental to quiddity.

Another argument is as follows. If existence were additional to quiddity, the quiddity would necessarily fall under one of the categories. This must be the category of substance rather than any category of accident, whether the categories are confined to a certain number, familiar or otherwise, or exceed it. For accidents, whatever they are, subsist in another. If the supposed quiddity falls under the category of substance, it must be specified by a differentia after sharing with the other substantial species. It would therefore need a specifying principle. Moreover, there is no doubt that some substantial species need a specifying and preponderating principle. If contingency is admissible for some species under a genus, it is admissible for the genus. What is possible for some species under a genus is possible for the genus; and what is impossible or necessary for a genus is impossible or necessary for every species under it. If the Necessary Existent—exalted is He—fell under a category, He would therefore have an aspect of contingency in respect of the genus. He would then be contingent rather than necessary, which is a contradiction. Since the supposed quiddity's falling under the category of substance is impossible, the Necessary's possessing a quiddity is impossible. This is what was sought.

It is clear from the foregoing that the necessity and obligatoriness of existence in the Necessary—exalted is He—are eternal, abstracted from the very essence, which is existence without a quiddity.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 333–335 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=333&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 4

The Necessary is simple, composed of neither external nor mental parts

الفصل الرابع — في أنّ الواجب (تعالى) بسيط غير مركّب من أجزاء خارجيّة ولا ذهنيّة

It was established above that the Necessary—exalted is He—has no quiddity. He therefore has no essential definition; and having no essential definition, He has no definitional parts, genus and differentia. Having neither genus nor differentia, He has no external parts consisting of external matter and form. For matter is genus taken on condition of exclusion, and form is differentia taken on condition of exclusion. Likewise, He has no mental parts consisting of intellectual matter and form, which are genus and differentia taken on condition of exclusion in externally simple things such as accidents. In brief, He has no definitional parts consisting of genus and differentia, no external parts consisting of external matter and form, and no mental intellectual parts consisting of intellectual matter and form.

Another demonstration: if He had a part, it would precede Him in existence, and the Necessary would depend upon it for existence. For a part necessarily precedes the whole in existence, and the whole depends upon it in this respect. It is impossible for the Necessary to be preceded by and dependent upon another while being necessary in existence.

Another demonstration: if the essence of the Necessary—exalted is He—were composed of parts, either all the parts would be intrinsically necessary, some would be intrinsically necessary and others contingent, or all would be contingent. The first is impossible. If the parts were intrinsically necessary, there would be relative possibility between them, as explained above. This is incompatible with their being real parts of a real composite possessing real unity. For composition requires an intrinsic connection between the parts, through which something new arises beyond their aggregate, with an effect beyond the effects of each individual part. The second is impossible because it would require the intrinsically Necessary to depend upon the contingent. It would also require quiddity to enter into the reality of the Necessary, since, as explained in the stage on necessity and contingency, every contingent thing has a quiddity. The third is likewise impossible for reasons similar to those just given.

As they have said, these demonstrations do not suffice to deny quantitative parts, because these are potential rather than actual parts, as explained in the discussion of quantity in the stage on substances and accidents.

The following has been said in denying them: “If the Necessary had a quantitative part, that part would be either contingent or necessary. If contingent, the quantitative part would differ from its whole in reality, which is impossible. If necessary, the intrinsically Necessary would exist potentially rather than actually, which is impossible.”

Another form of composition is that arising from the negations by which a thing is characterized in its existential identity. This too is denied of the intrinsically Necessary—exalted and holy.

To explain: every identity of which something can correctly be denied, considering the limit of its existence, is constituted by affirmation and negation. The human, for example, is a human and is not a horse in the very core of its existence. Everything of this kind is composed of an affirmation, namely its own self’s being established for it, and a negation, namely another thing’s being denied of it, since these two aspects are necessarily different. Every identity of which something is denied is therefore composite. The meaning of negation’s entering into an existential identity—although existence contradicts nonexistence—is an existential deficiency in one existence compared with another. Through this are realized the degrees of gradation in the reality of existence and their specific characteristics. By contraposition, the conclusion becomes: no existential perfection is denied of any essence that is simple in reality.

The intrinsically Necessary is sheer existence, with no access for nonexistence to His essence, and no existential perfection is denied of Him. For every contingent existential perfection is an effect bestowed by a cause, and causes end in the intrinsically Necessary. The giver of a thing cannot lack it. He—exalted is He—therefore possesses every existential perfection without any admixture of nonexistence. The necessary reality is purely simple, and nothing is denied of it. This is what was sought.

It may be objected: He—exalted is He—has negative attributes established by demonstration, such as that He is neither a body nor corporeal, neither a substance nor an accident.

We reply: negative attributes amount to the negation of deficiencies and nonexistences. Negating negation is existence, and negating deficiency is a perfection of existence, as has been said.

It may be objected: the foregoing account entails that predication is valid between Him—exalted is He—and every existent and existential perfection. This entails the identity of the Necessary and the contingent—exalted is God above that—which is contrary to what is immediately evident.

We reply: not at all. If contingent existences were predicated of Him—exalted is He—by common predication, they would be true of Him in both their affirmative and negative aspects, and in both their aspects of perfection and deficiency, of which their essences are composed. The essence of the Necessary would then be composite, although it was supposed simple in reality. This is a contradiction. Rather, His possession, through His simple reality, of the perfection of every existent is possession in a higher and nobler manner. It is like a cause’s possession of the perfection of its effect, notwithstanding the distinction between them that makes predication impossible.

This is what they mean by saying, “That which is simple in reality is all things.” The predication is that of a reality and its attenuated reality, rather than common predication.

It is clear from the foregoing that the intrinsically Necessary is the completeness of every thing.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 335–338 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=335&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 5

The unity of the intrinsically Necessary: He has no associate in necessary existence

الفصل الخامس — في توحيد الواجب لذاته وأنّه لا شريك له في وجوب الوجود

It became clear in the preceding chapters that the essence of the intrinsically Necessary is existence itself, without a quiddity or any negative component. It is therefore pure existence. The pure reality of a thing is one through true unity, which cannot be doubled or repeated. For multiplicity is realized only by the distinction of its units, each possessing a meaning not present in another; and this is incompatible with purity. Whatever you suppose to be a second to it returns to being the first. The intrinsically Necessary is therefore intrinsically one, just as He exists through His own essence and is necessary through His own essence. This is what was sought. Perhaps this is what the Shaykh meant by his statement in the Taʿlīqāt: “The existence of the Necessary is identical with His identity. His being existent is therefore identical with His being Himself. Hence the existence of the intrinsically Necessary does not belong to another.” End of quotation.

Another demonstration: if the intrinsically Necessary were multiple—supposing, for example, two intrinsically necessary beings—necessity of existence would be shared by them, and their distinction would be through something beyond the meaning they share. If this were internal to the essence, composition would follow, which is incompatible with necessity of existence. If it were external to the essence, it would be accidental and caused. If it were caused by the essence, the essence would precede its own distinction in existence. But there is no essence prior to distinction, so this is impossible. If it were caused by another, the essence would depend upon another for its distinction, which is impossible. A multiplicity of necessary existents is therefore impossible under every supposition.

Against this is raised the doubt attributed to Ibn Kammūna. According to the Asfār, the first to mention it was the Illuminationist Shaykh in the Muṭāraḥāt. Ibn Kammūna, one of the commentators on his writings, then mentioned it in one of his own works, and it became known by his name. The doubt is this: why may there not be two simple quiddities, unknown in their inmost nature, distinct in the entirety of their essences, with existence predicated of them accidentally? This doubt applies both to the primacy of quiddity attributed to the Illuminationists and to the primacy of existence together with the view that existences are simple realities distinct in the entirety of their essences, attributed to the Peripatetics. The argument rests upon the primacy of existence and its being a single graded reality with different degrees.

The doubt has been answered by observing that it rests upon the abstraction of one concept from many distinct instances precisely insofar as they are many and distinct, which is impossible.

Another demonstration: if the intrinsically Necessary were multiple, so that there were, for example, two intrinsically necessary beings, there would be relative possibility between them, without an intrinsic relation of necessary implication. For such a relation is realized between two things only if one is a cause and the other an effect, or if both are effects of a third cause. Being an effect is incompatible with intrinsic necessity of existence.

Each would therefore possess a share of existence and a degree of perfection that the other did not possess. The essence of each, through its own essence, would possess something of existence and lack something of it. It has already been established that this is a composition impossible for the intrinsically Necessary.

Another demonstration is mentioned by al-Fārābī in the Fuṣūṣ: “Necessity of existence is not divided by being predicated of many things different in number; otherwise it would be caused.”

Perhaps the meaning is that, if the intrinsically Necessary were multiple, that multiplicity could not be required by its essence, since this would entail that it had no instance. For whatever was supposed to be an instance of it would be many, and the many is realized only through units. If no unit is an instance of it, there is no multiplicity; and if there is no multiplicity, it has no instance. Yet it was supposed intrinsically necessary. It remains, then, that multiplicity would be required by something else. This is impossible, because it entails dependence upon another, which cannot coexist with intrinsic necessity.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 338–340 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=338&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 6

The unity of the intrinsically Necessary in lordship: there is no lord besides Him

الفصل السادس — في توحيد الواجب لذاته في ربوبيّته وأنّه لارَبَّ سواه

Thorough investigation and precise scientific reflection show that the parts of our witnessed world —the natural world—are connected to one another: its higher and lower parts, their actions and affections, and the events resulting from these. Among them you find no existent unconnected to others in its being, influence, and being affected. What was established in the discussions of substantial motion supports this.

Every occurrence, whether a coming-to-be, an action, or an affection, therefore depends upon the world as a whole. From this we conclude that a kind of unity exists among the parts of the world, and that the comprehensive order prevailing in it is one. This is one principle.

What emerges from the preceding discussions and those to come is that this material world is the effect of a luminous realm, free of matter and exempt from potentiality. Between cause and effect there is an existential affinity through which the effect, with the existential perfection appropriate to its degree, represents the existential perfection realized in the cause in a higher and nobler manner. The same ruling applies if there are immaterial intellectual causes, one above another, until they end in the intrinsically Necessary—majestic is His remembrance.

We conclude from this that above the order prevailing in the witnessed world there is an intellectual, luminous order akin to it, which is the principle of this order. It ends in a divine order in His knowledge—exalted is He—which is the principle of the whole. This is another principle.

It is also necessary that the cause of a thing's cause is a cause of that thing, and that the effect of a thing's effect is an effect of that thing. Since causes end in the Necessary—exalted is He—every existent, however supposed, is His effect. In concrete reality there is nothing but the existence of substances, their effects, and the relations and connections between them. Nothing is independent in its existence except the intrinsically Necessary, and none bestows existence except Him.

It is therefore clear from the foregoing that the Necessary—exalted is He—is the one who brings about the order prevailing in our witnessed mode of being and governs through the universal governance encompassing the parts of the world. The same applies to the luminous intellectual orders above and corresponding to this order, in the manner appropriate to each according to its degree of existence. The intrinsically Necessary is thus the Lord of the world, governing its affairs through one bestowal of existence after another. Intermediate causes are merely subordinated to act as intermediaries, without independence. This is what was sought. It is therefore impossible for there to be any lord in the world other than Him, whether one or many.

Moreover, if a multiplicity of lords governing the world were supposed, as the idolaters maintain, impossibility would follow from another direction: the corruption of the order. To explain: multiplicity is realized only through units, and units only through the distinction of some from others. Distinction is accomplished only when each unit of the multiplicity possesses an intrinsic aspect that another unit lacks. Through this it differs from the other and they become distinct. All of this is necessary. The affinity between an agent and its act requires a difference between two acts corresponding to the difference between their agents. If there were separate lords, whether they jointly produced a single act or each aspect of the general cosmic order had a lord independent in its lordship—such as a lord of the heavens and earth, a lord of the human, and so forth—this would lead to corruption of the order and conflict among its parts. The unity of the order and the continuous mutual entailment among its parts rule this out.

It may be objected: the remarkable firmness and precision of the order prevailing among its parts testify that its governance proceeds from knowledge. The philosophical principles that establish the witnessed world’s dependence upon knowing immaterial causes support this. Let us grant, then, that the supposed lords have multiple, distinct essences, and that this naturally leads to differing and conflicting acts. Nevertheless, since they are rational, they might agree to peaceful cooperation and concord, attending to the good of the single order and preserving its continuance.

I reply: there is no doubt that the items of knowledge on which rational beings base their actions are cognitive forms and universal laws taken from the external order prevailing in the world. The external order has a kind of priority over these cognitive forms and universal laws, which follow it. But this external order, in its external existence, is the act of those supposed lords. It is impossible for an agent to be influenced in its act by cognitive forms abstracted from that act and posterior to it.

It may be objected: let us grant that the supposed lords producing the external order do not follow cognitive forms abstracted from their act, since these would be mental, acquired items of knowledge that follow what is known. But the supposed lords are knowing agents who know their act at the degree of their own essences, before the act. Why could they not agree to cooperation and concord in their knowledge prior to the act?

I reply: a knowing agent’s knowledge of its act before bringing it into being—as will be explained and has already been indicated—is knowledge by presence. Its basis is the cause’s possession of the effect’s perfection in a higher and nobler manner, and the affinity between the cause and its effect. Supposing the lords’ agreement and concord at the level of knowledge in this sense amounts to their cancelling the multiplicity and distinction in their existences. Yet their existences were supposed multiple and distinct. This is a contradiction.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 340–344 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=340&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 7

The intrinsically Necessary has no associate in any concept in respect of its instance

الفصل السابع — فيأنّ الواجب بالذات لا مشارك له فيشيء من المفاهيم من حيث المصداق

Sharing between two or more things occurs only when they are distinct and differentiated, and there is one concept by which they are characterized, as Zayd and ʿAmr are united in humanity, and the human and the horse in animality. Sharing is therefore unity in multiplicity. Multiplicity is realized only through distinct, differentiated units, each containing that by which the other units

are denied of it. Each of the things sharing is therefore composed of negation and affirmation in respect of existence. Since the existence of the intrinsically Necessary is the reality of pure, simple existence, composition has no access to Him and there is no scope for negation in Him. Nothing therefore shares any meaning with Him.

Furthermore, the shared concept is either one of the quiddities or something reducible to them. Quiddities, which are intrinsically devoid of reality, have no access to the reality of the intrinsically Necessary, which is pure truth. Thus nothing is of the same genus as the intrinsically Necessary, since He has no genus; nothing is of the same species, since He has no species; nothing resembles Him, since He has no quality; nothing equals Him, since He has no quantity; nothing is congruent with Him, since He has no position; nothing stands alongside Him, since He has no place; and nothing is proportionate to Him, since no relation belongs to His essence.

Relational attributes additional to the essence—such as creation, provision, giving life, causing death, and others—are abstracted from the station of act, as will be explained, God willing. Moreover, relational attributes all reduce to His being the Sustainer. Since none brings into existence or exercises influence other than Him, He has no associate as Sustainer.

If the shared concept is one of the concepts abstracted from existence, what belongs to the intrinsically Necessary is its highest degree, infinite in intensity, unmingled with deficiency or nonexistence. What belongs to another is one of the degrees of the graded reality, not free of deficiency and composition. There is therefore no sharing.

As for predicating some concepts of both the intrinsically Necessary and other things—for example, existence predicated of Him and others with a shared meaning, disregarding the specificity of the instance, and likewise the other attributes of the Necessary considered solely as concepts, such as knowledge, life, and mercy, disregarding contingent particularities—this has nothing to do with the sharing under discussion.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 344–345 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=344&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 8

The attributes of the intrinsically Necessary in general, and their division

الفصل الثامن — في صفات الواجب بالذات على وجه كلّي وانقسامها

It was established above that no existential perfection is ever denied of necessary existence. Whatever perfection there is in existence—such as knowledge and power—necessary existence possesses it in a higher and nobler manner. It is predicated of Him in a way appropriate to the

domain of His might and majesty. This is what is meant by His being characterized by attributes.

The primary division of attributes is into affirmative attributes, which convey a positive meaning, such as knowledge and power, and negative attributes, which convey a negative meaning. The latter can only negate the negation of a perfection, and thus return to affirming perfection, since the negation of a negation is an affirmation. Examples are our saying “one who is not ignorant” and “one who is not incapable,” which return to the knowing and the powerful. As for negating perfection, the preceding discussions have made clear that the negation of any perfection has no access to Him—exalted is He. Negative attributes therefore return in reality to affirmative attributes.

Affirmative attributes divide into real attributes, such as living, and relational attributes, such as being a knower and being powerful. Real attributes divide into purely real attributes, such as living, and real attributes involving a relation, such as creating and providing.

From another perspective, attributes divide into attributes of essence, for whose abstraction the supposition of the essence alone suffices, and attributes of act, whose abstraction depends upon supposing another. Since there is no existent other than Him—exalted is He—except His act, attributes of act are those abstracted from the station of act.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 345–346 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=345&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 9

The attributes of essence are identical with the transcendent essence

الفصل التاسع — في الصفات الذاتيّة وأنّها عين الذات المتعالية

Investigators have differed concerning the attributes of essence abstracted from the necessary essence considered apart from anything else. Their positions are as follows.

First: these attributes are identical with the transcendent essence, and each is identical with every other. This is attributed to the philosophers.

Second: they are meanings additional to the essence and necessarily accompanying it, and are therefore eternal with its eternity. This is attributed to the Ashʿarites.

Third: they are additional to the essence and originated, according to the position attributed to the Karrāmiyya.

Fourth: the essence's being characterized by these attributes means that the act issuing from it is the act of one possessing the attribute. Thus the transcendent essence's being knowing means that the act issuing from it is precise, firm, and directed toward a rational end, as is the act of a knower. Its being powerful means that the act issuing from it is like the act of one possessing power. The essence therefore takes the place of the attributes.

Some appear inclined toward another position: affirming the attributes means denying their opposites. Thus affirming life, knowledge, and power, for example, means denying death, ignorance, and incapacity.

Others appear to hold that the attributes of essence are identical with the essence, but that they all have one meaning and their expressions are synonymous.

The truth is the first position. It has been established that the intrinsically Necessary is a complete cause to which every contingent existent ultimately returns, whether without an intermediary, through one intermediary, or through several. This means that the necessary reality is itself the cause. It has also been established that every existential perfection in an effect is possessed by its cause, at the station of its causality, in a higher and nobler manner. The intrinsically Necessary therefore possesses every supposed existential perfection. Moreover, He is pure existence, unmixed with nonexistence. It has been established that His existence is pure, simple, and one through true unity. There is therefore no multiplicity of aspects or difference of respects in His essence. Every existential perfection supposed in Him is identical with His essence and with every other perfection supposed of Him. The attributes of essence belonging to the intrinsically Necessary are therefore many and different in concept, but one in concrete reality and instance. This is what was sought.

The claim made by some that "the cause of bringing into existence is the will of the intrinsically Necessary, rather than His transcendent essence" has no coherent content. If, according to its proponent, this will is an attribute of essence identical with the essence, then attributing the bestowal of existence to it is identical with attributing it to the transcendent essence. Attributing it to the will while denying it of the essence is a manifest contradiction. If the will is an attribute of act abstracted from the station of act, the act precedes it. Attributing the production of the act to it would therefore assert that the effect precedes the cause, which is impossible. Moreover, attributing causality to the will of the intrinsically Necessary while denying it of the essence requires a difference between the Necessary and His will. This will is either independent of a cause, in which case it must be necessary in existence, entailing a multiplicity of necessary beings, which is impossible; or it depends upon a cause. If its cause is the Necessary, then the will is the cause of the world and the Necessary is its cause. Since the cause of a cause is a cause, the

Necessary is the cause of the world. If its cause is something other than the Necessary and does not ultimately return to Him, it entails another necessary being in which it terminates, which is impossible.

As for the second position, attributed to the Ashʿarites: these attributes, which they enumerate as seven—life, knowledge, power, hearing, sight, will, and speech—are additional to the essence, necessarily accompany it, and are eternal with its eternity.

The objection is that, if these attributes are independent of a cause in their existence and subsist in their own right, there would be eight necessary beings: the essence and the seven attributes. The demonstrations of the Necessary's oneness invalidate this and show it to be impossible.

If they depend upon a cause for their existence, and their cause is the essence, then the essence would be a cause preceding them and bestowing them while itself lacking them. This is impossible.

If their cause is other than the essence, they are necessary through another, and their necessity through another ends in a further necessary being other than the Necessary characterized by them. The demonstrations of the oneness of the intrinsically Necessary invalidate this too. It would also entail that the intrinsically Necessary needs another in order to possess the attributes of perfection. Need in any form is incompatible with intrinsic necessity of existence. Furthermore, it would entail that the Necessary lacks the attributes of perfection in His own essence, although it was established above that He is pure existence, lacking no existential perfection.

As for the third position, attributed to the Karrāmiyya, that these attributes are additional and originated: it entails that they are contingent and need a cause. Their cause is either the essence, which would entail that the essence bestows upon itself what it lacks, whose impossibility has been established; or something other than the essence, which would entail an aspect of contingency in it and the absence of existential perfections from it, whose impossibility has likewise been established.

As for the fourth position, attributed to the Muʿtazilites, that the essence substitutes for the attributes: it entails that the essence lacks perfection while bestowing every perfection, which is impossible.

This also refutes the claim that affirmative attributes of essence mean the negation of their opposites, so that life, knowledge, and power mean the negation of death, ignorance, and incapacity.

As for the claim that these attributes are identical with the essence and synonymous in a single meaning, it seems to arise from confusing the concept with its instance. What demonstration establishes is that their instance is one. Their concepts, however, are distinct and do not become one at all. Moreover, language and ordinary usage refute the claim of synonymy.

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1. **translation:** In the discussion of the Karrāmiyya, “the essence bestows upon itself what it lacks” follows the Qum 1404 witness, printed p. 287 (PDF p. 291): an tufīḍa al-dhātu li-nafsihā mā hiya fāqidatun lahu. This corrects a transcription error in the later electronic text.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 346–349 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=346&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 10

The attributes of act are additional to the essence

الفصل العاشر — في الصفات الفعليّة وأنّها زائدة على الذات

There is no doubt that the intrinsically Necessary has attributes of act related to others, such as Creator, Provider, Giver, Generous, Forgiving, Merciful, and so forth. They are very numerous and are gathered together in the attribute of Sustainer.

Since they are related to something other than Him—exalted is He—their realization depends upon the realization of the other to which they are related. Every other thing supposed is an effect of the transcendent essence and posterior to it. The attribute depending upon that thing is therefore posterior to the essence and additional to it. It is abstracted from the station of act and ascribed to the transcendent essence.

A contingent existent, for example, has existence not through itself but through another. Considered with respect to itself, it is existence; considered with respect to another, it is a bestowal of existence by that other, of whom it is true that He brings it into existence. Under different considerations, its existence is origination without precedent, creation, making, blessing, and mercy. It is therefore true of its giver of existence that He is Originator, Creator, Maker, Benefactor, and Merciful.

Now, if the thing He brings into existence is such that its existence has some continuance, there are things available to it by which it maintains its continuance and removes its aspects of deficiency and need. When such a thing is considered in itself, the concept of provision by which it is sustained is abstracted from it. When it is considered as existing not through itself but through another, its cause that bestows it, that other is truly called its Provider. Under further different considerations, provision is truly called a gift, blessing, bestowal, generosity, and bounty; and the Provider is truly called Giver, Benefactor, Bestower, Generous, Bountiful, and so on. The other attributes of act follow the same pattern, multiplying with the multiplication of aspects of perfection in existence.

These attributes of act are truly predicated of Him—exalted is He. They are not predicated in respect of their particular characteristics of origination and posteriority to the transcendent essence, which would entail change in Him—exalted and holy—and the composition of His essence from many distinct aspects. Rather, they are predicated insofar as they have a source in the essence from which every perfection and good proceeds. He—exalted is He—is such that every possible perfection subsists through Him in its own proper locus. He is such that, when a thing is possible, it is willed by Him; when He wills a thing, He brings it into existence; when He brings it into existence, He nurtures it; when He nurtures it, He perfects it; and so forth. To the Necessary belong His necessity and eternity, and to things belong their contingency and origination.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 349–350 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=349&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 11

His knowledge—exalted is He

الفصل الحادي عشر — في علمه (تعالى)

It was established above that every immaterial being has knowledge of its own essence, because its essence, free of matter, is present to itself. Knowledge is nothing but the presence of one thing to another. The Necessary—exalted is He—is free of matter and potentiality. His essence is therefore known to His essence.

It was also established that His transcendent essence is the reality of pure, simple existence, one through true unity, into which neither deficiency nor nonexistence enters. There is therefore no existential perfection in the particulars of creation and their existential order that His essence does not possess in a higher and nobler manner. Because of its purity and simplicity, these perfections are not distinguished from one another. Everything other than Him is thus known to Him—exalted is He—at the degree of His transcendent essence, with a knowledge that is detailed in its very comprehensiveness and comprehensive in its very detail.

It was further established that all other existents are His effects, terminating in Him without an intermediary, through one intermediary, or through several. Their essences subsist through Him as the relational subsists through the independent. They are present to Him through their existences, without being veiled from Him. They are therefore known to Him at the degree of their existences through knowledge by presence: immaterial things through themselves, and material things through their immaterial forms.

The foregoing establishes that the Necessary—exalted is He—knows His essence at the degree of His essence, and that this knowledge is identical with His essence; that He knows the existents other than His essence at the degree of His essence, which is called “knowledge before bringing into existence”; that this is comprehensive knowledge in the very act of detailed disclosure; that He has detailed knowledge of the existents other than His essence at the degree of their own essences, outside the transcendent essence, which is “knowledge after bringing into existence”; and that His knowledge is knowledge by presence however it is conceived.

These are five questions.

It follows that every item of knowledge established at the degrees of contingent beings, among immaterial intellectual and imaginal causes, is knowledge belonging to Him—exalted is He.

It also follows that He is Hearing and Seeing, just as He is Knowing and Aware. For the reality of hearing and sight is knowledge of audible things and knowledge of visible things, both belonging to knowledge without qualification; and every knowledge belongs to Him—exalted is He.

Investigators have differed greatly concerning His knowledge—exalted is He—so much so that some have denied it altogether. Such a person is refuted by the demonstration establishing it.

Those who affirm it hold various positions.

First: He—exalted is He—knows His essence but not its effects, because the transcendent essence is eternal and every effect is originated.

The objection is that knowing an effect eternally does not require that it exist eternally with its own specific existence. Moreover, this position rests upon restricting knowledge by presence to a thing’s knowledge of itself and treating everything else as acquired knowledge that follows the known. This is rejected by what was established above: an immaterial cause has knowledge by presence of its immaterial effect. Demonstration has established that He—exalted is He—has knowledge by presence of His effects before bringing them into existence, at the degree of the essence, and knowledge by presence of them after bringing them into existence, at the degree of the effects.

Second: the position attributed to Plato, that His detailed knowledge—exalted is He—is the immaterial intellects and divine Forms in which the perfections of species are gathered in detail.

The objection is that this belongs to knowledge after bringing into existence, at the degree of their contingent existences. Confining His detailed knowledge of things to them entails that the transcendent essence, in itself, lacks the perfection of knowledge, whereas it is pure existence from which no existential perfection is absent.

Third: the position attributed to Porphyry, that His knowledge—exalted is He—is through union with the known.

The objection is that this suffices only to explain the realization of knowledge and that it occurs through union of the intellect with the intelligible, rather than through inherence as an accident or the like. It does not suffice to establish knowledge of things before or after bringing them into existence.

Fourth: the position attributed to the Shaykh of Illumination, followed by a group of later investigators, that things, both immaterial and material, are present to Him—exalted is He—through their concrete existence, neither absent nor veiled from Him. This is His detailed knowledge of things after bringing them into existence, while He has comprehensive knowledge of them as a consequence of His knowledge of His essence.

The first objection is that the claim that material things are present to Him—exalted is He—is rejected. Materiality does not coexist with presence, as explained in the discussions of the intellective subject and the intelligible.

The second objection is that confining detailed knowledge of things to the degree of their existences entails that the transcendent essence, which bestows every detailed perfection in things, lacks their detail. Yet it is pure existence, encompassing every existential perfection in a higher and nobler manner.

Fifth: the position attributed to al-Malaṭī, that He—exalted is He—knows the first intellect, which is the first emanated being, through its presence to Him, and knows all other things below the first intellect through the impression of their forms in the first intellect.

The objection is that this is subject to the same difficulty as the previous position: it requires that the transcendent essence lack perfection, although it possesses every perfection. Moreover, it was established in the discussions of the intellective subject and the intelligible that immaterial intellects have no acquired knowledge through impressed forms.

Sixth: the statement of some that “His transcendent essence is detailed knowledge of the first effect and comprehensive knowledge of what is below it; the essence of the first effect is detailed knowledge of the second effect and comprehensive knowledge of what is below it; and so on.”

The objection is the unacceptable consequence that the transcendent essence lacks the perfection of knowing what is below the first effect, although it is pure existence from which no perfection is denied.

Seventh: the position attributed to most later thinkers, that He—exalted is He—has detailed knowledge of His own essence, which is comprehensive knowledge of things before bringing them into existence. His detailed knowledge of things, however, comes after their existence, because knowledge follows the known and there is no known before concrete existence.

The objection is the unacceptable consequence that the transcendent essence lacks the perfection of knowledge, as in the preceding positions. Moreover, it affirms acquired knowledge through impressed forms in purely immaterial existence.

Eighth: the position attributed to the Peripatetics, that He—exalted is He—has knowledge by presence of His transcendent essence and detailed acquired knowledge of things before bringing them into existence. Their quiddities are present to His essence in the order found externally, not by entering it through identity or as parts, but by subsisting through it with mental establishment in a universal manner. “Universal” here means that the knowledge does not change when the known changes, according to the terminology of the discussions of knowledge. It is thus providential knowledge: the occurrence of the known in knowledge entails its occurrence in concrete reality.

The first objection is the same difficulty as in the preceding position: the essence would lack perfection.

The second is likewise the difficulty in the preceding position: acquired knowledge would be established in that which is immaterial both in essence and in act.

The third is that this entails the establishment of mental existence without a concrete existence to which it is compared. Consequently, it becomes another concrete existence of the quiddity before the existence proper to it, with an existence separate from Him—exalted is He. On close examination, it returns to the second position, attributed to Plato.

Know that most theologians hold this position, even though they criticize it for describing knowledge before bringing into existence as universal, supposing that “universal” means what is meant in logic’s discussion of universal and particular. For they have chosen the view that detailed knowledge before bringing into existence is acquired knowledge and remains unchanged before and after things exist.

Ninth: the Muʿtazilite position that quiddities have concrete establishment in nonexistence, and this is the object of His knowledge—exalted is He—before bringing into existence.

The objection is that the falsity of the doctrine of the establishment of nonexistent things has already been demonstrated.

Tenth: the position attributed to the Sufis, that quiddities have establishment in knowledge as a consequence of the names and attributes, and this is the object of His knowledge—exalted is He—before bringing into existence.

The objection is that the primacy of existence and the intellectually considered status of quiddity negate any supposed establishment of quiddities before their own specific concrete establishment.

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1. **translation:** “Comprehensive” renders ijmālī. In the account of divine knowledge, it denotes an undivided possession of the details, not an incomplete or merely approximate knowledge.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 350–356 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=350&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 12

Providence, decree, and measure

الفصل الثاني عشر — في العناية والقضاء والقدر

They have mentioned providence, decree, and measure among the degrees of His knowledge—exalted is He—because each, through its own specific concept, applies to a particular aspect of His knowledge.

As for providence, it consists in the cognitive form’s being a necessitating cause of the known, which is the act. His detailed knowledge of things, identical with His essence, is the cause of their existence with their known particular characteristics. He—exalted is He—therefore exercises providence over His creation.

As for decree, in its familiar meaning it is to make the relation between a subject and its predicate necessary and binding. For example, when Zayd and ʿAmr dispute some property or right, refer their dispute to a judge, and present their arguments, the judge’s statement in deciding the case, “The property belongs to Zayd, and the right belongs to ʿAmr,” establishes Zayd’s ownership and ʿAmr’s right necessarily. It thereby removes the uncertainty and hesitation produced by the dispute before the judgment and the settlement of the case. In brief, the judge’s decree makes the matter necessary in knowledge, followed by making it externally necessary in a conventional sense.

When this meaning is taken through analysis as real rather than conventional, it applies to the necessity with which contingent existents are clothed in relation to their complete causes. For a thing does not exist until it is necessitated. This necessity through another, considered in relation to the complete cause, is necessitation. There is nothing in the series of contingent existence that is not necessary, necessitated through another. Causes end in the intrinsically Necessary, who is therefore the cause necessitating them and their effects.

Since contingent existents, with their best order at the degree of their concrete existences, are active knowledge belonging to the Necessary—exalted is He—the necessitation within them is a decree from Him. Above this is His essential knowledge, through which everything is disclosed to Him in detail as it is in concrete reality, in a higher and nobler manner.

Decree is therefore of two kinds: essential decree, outside the world, and active decree, within it.

This shows the weakness of what is attributed to the prevalent view: that decree is the knowledge of contingent existents and their order possessed by the separate intellects.

The same applies to Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn's—may God have mercy on him—view that decree is essential knowledge relating to the details of creation. He says in the Asfār:

"As for decree, according to them it means the existence of the intellectual forms of all existents, bestowed by Him—exalted is He—through origination without precedent, all at once and without time. For in their view these belong to the world and to God's acts, whose essences are distinct from His essence. In our view, they are cognitive forms necessarily accompanying His essence, without making, influence, or being affected. They are not parts of the world, since they possess neither a negative aspect nor real possibilities. Divine decree, which is the form of God's knowledge, is therefore intrinsically eternal and endures through God's endurance." End of quotation.

His expression "cognitive forms necessarily accompanying His essence" should be understood as essential knowledge that is inseparable from the essence. If they necessarily accompanied it while being external to it, they would belong to the world and would not be intrinsically eternal, as he expressly states. Moreover, if they were known by presence, this would coincide with Plato's account of knowledge, which he does not accept; and if they were acquired forms, it would coincide with the Peripatetic account, which he also does not accept.

The weakness of both positions is that the applicability of the concept of decree to one of the two degrees of knowledge—essential knowledge and active knowledge—does not deny its applicability to the other. The truth is therefore that decree is of two kinds, essential and active, as explained above.

As for measure, it is the quantity or limit attaching to a thing in its attributes and effects. Determination is the specification in knowledge of the attributes and effects attaching to it, followed by action according to what the available causes and instruments allow. A tailor, for example, determines the garment he will sew upon the cloth before him, and then sews according to what he has determined. A builder determines the building he intends upon a tract of land, according to what it accommodates and what the causes and instruments available to him require.

He then constructs the building in conformity with what he has determined, owing to renewed causes that require this of him. Determination is thus to the thing determined as a mold in which a thing is cast, delimiting it by a limit or limits that it does not exceed.

When this meaning is taken as real through analysis, it applies to the limits attaching to material existents through their incomplete causes, with the cognitive forms those causes have in the mode of being above them. Each incomplete cause, with its different aspects, has an effect upon the effect that restricts its unrestricted character in its attributes and effects. When the restriction is completed through the completion of the complete cause, the thing acquires determination and individuation through the existence required by the complete cause. A human, for example, has the property of seeing, but not through his entire existence: rather, through his body. Nor through his entire body, but through an organ situated in his face. He therefore sees only what faces him; and not everything that faces him, but bodies; and not every body, but dense bodies possessing color; and not the body itself, but its surface; and not all its surfaces, but the surface facing him. Nor does he see in every position, every state, every place, or every time. If you counted the conditions surrounding a single individual act of vision, you would find an immense multitude beyond enumeration. These are nothing but limits attached to that vision by the incomplete causes that delimit it through the effect they place in it. Some of these causes are prevented by impediments from exerting their effect.

These limits are existential aspects accompanied by negations, as was just explained. They have cognitive forms in the imaginal mode of being above the material mode, through which the attributes and effects of things are determined. None of them has access to any attribute or effect except that to which determination has directed it.

You may object: this account entails that the human is compelled and has no choice in his acts.

I reply: not at all. Choice is one of the conditions through which the human act is delimited. We have discussed the refutation of this doubt in detail in the discussions of existence and of cause and effect.

You may object: why not generalize the account of measure, which is the imposition of limits upon a thing in respect of its attributes and effects in a prior knowledge followed by concrete reality, so that it also encompasses contingent quiddities? Quiddities too are limits of their subjects, through which they are distinguished from others and accompanied by negations they do not exceed. It was established above that everything possessing a quiddity is contingent, and that the essence of the contingent is composed of affirmation and negation. Measure would therefore encompass every contingent thing, whether an immaterial intellect, a suspended imaginal form, or a material nature; and the prior knowledge through which the thing is determined would be essential knowledge.

In brief, measure in concrete reality would be the determination abstracted from concrete existence, and determining would be the specification in knowledge followed by concrete reality. Likewise, what is decreed is the necessity abstracted from concrete existence, and decree is the necessitation in knowledge that entails it, whether with respect to quiddity and essence or to attributes and effects.

I reply: there is no doubt that quiddity is an intrinsic limit of the contingent. In discussing measure, however, they have attended to the apparent meaning of its concept: the limit attaching to a thing in the attributes and effects of which it is a subject, rather than in its original essence. It therefore does not encompass what lies beyond natures that have some attachment to matter.

Their purpose in undertaking this discussion is to show that the contingent is not left unrestrained in the attributes and effects attaching to it, independently of the Necessary—exalted is He—in what characterizes it or what it does. Rather, the matter belongs to Him, and nothing occurs except what He has determined. This is close in meaning to their saying, “The cause of a thing’s cause is a cause of that thing.”

Likewise, their purpose in discussing decree is to show that the contingent occurs only through a necessity through another that ends in Him—exalted is He—in prior knowledge. This is close in meaning to their saying, “A thing does not exist until it is necessitated.”

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 356–360 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=356&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 13

His power—exalted is He

الفصل الثالث عشر — في قدرته (تعالى)

Among the meanings we count as existential perfections is power. It concerns action rather than affection: we do not count a thing’s being affected by another, whether strongly or weakly, as power. Nor does it concern every action, but only an action of which the agent has knowledge. We do not call the agency of natural agents devoid of awareness their power. Nor does it concern every action known to its agent, but a knowledgeable act in which knowledge of the act impels its agent to perform it. A human’s agency in relation to his natural bodily activities, for example, is not power even if he knows them. Rather, it concerns an act that the agent knows to be good for him precisely insofar as he is this agent: he conceives it and assents that it is good for him insofar as he is this agent.

A necessary consequence of knowing that the act is good for the agent is that it is a perfection for him that he himself requires. For the good of every species is the perfection following upon it, and its specific nature is the principle that requires this perfection. If the agent is supposed to know it as a good and perfection for himself that he requires, he is impelled toward it through himself, rather than by the necessitation of another determining principle imposing it upon him. There is therefore no power together with compulsion. One possessing power chooses, in the sense that the act is determined for him through his own determination, rather than through determination by another.

When the knowledge that the act is good is complete, it is followed by the agent's desire for the act. Good is loved without qualification and desired when absent. This desire is certainly a psychic quality distinct from the preceding knowledge. It is followed by will, which is certainly a psychic quality distinct both from the preceding knowledge and from desire. With its realization, the act is realized: the movement of the muscles through the active faculty diffused within them.

These are the qualifications that investigation discloses in the power found in us: being a principle of the act; knowledge that it is good for the agent, a knowledge necessarily accompanied by choice in the act; desire for the act; and will directed toward it. It has been established that every existential perfection in existence belongs to the Necessary—exalted is He—within His own essence. He is therefore necessary power itself. Desire, however, has no access to Him, because it is a psychic quality necessarily accompanied by lack; lack necessarily accompanies deficiency, and He is free of every deficiency and nonexistence.

The same applies to will as a psychic quality distinct from knowledge and desire. It is a contingent quiddity, while the Necessary—exalted is He—is free of quiddity and contingency. Moreover, will in this sense accompanies what is willed when the latter belongs to things subject to generation and corruption: it does not exist before it or remain after it. For the Necessary to be characterized by it would therefore entail change in that which is characterized, which is impossible.

It follows that power, stripped of deficiencies and nonexistences, is a thing's being an efficient principle of an act through knowledge that it is good and through choice in giving it preponderance. The Necessary—exalted is He—is intrinsically the efficient principle of every existent. He intrinsically knows the most fitting order in things, and intrinsically chooses in His act, since no agent other than Him exercises influence upon Him. He is therefore intrinsically powerful. The account we have given applies to immaterial intellects as well.

You may object: the path you have followed to establish power for the Necessary—exalted is He—does not establish will for Him precisely as will. Their definition of power as "a thing's being such that, if it wills, it acts, and if it does not will, it does not act" includes affirming will as an

essential attribute of the Necessary constitutive of power. They have, however, explained necessary will as knowledge of the most fitting order.

I reply: their account of the meaning of power returns to the account we have given, which includes the three qualifications of being a principle, knowledge, and choice. What they say about the meaning of His power—exalted is He—is therefore true. The whole issue lies in their taking His knowledge as an instance of will. There is no way to establish this, and it is more like an act of naming.

You may object: a single existence may have different quiddities and unequal degrees according to its different modes of being. Knowledge, for example, is a psychic quality when it concerns what is outside us, but a psychic substance when it concerns our souls. An intellect's knowledge of itself is an intellectual substance; the Necessary's knowledge of His essence is intrinsically necessary, and a contingent being's knowledge of itself is intrinsically contingent. That the will in us is a psychic quality therefore does not exclude the Necessary's will for His act being His essential knowledge.

Moreover, it is conceded that a choosing agent does whatever it does only through will and volition. The Necessary—exalted is He—is a choosing agent, so He has a will for His act. But the will in us, which is a psychic quality, is not realized there. There is nothing there except knowledge and the choice necessarily accompanying it. His knowledge is therefore His will, and He is willing insofar as He is knowing through His knowledge identical with His essence.

I reply: what we concede is that a choosing animal agent does whatever it does only through knowledge of the benefit of the act and through will in the sense of a psychic quality. We also concede that the Necessary—exalted is He—does whatever He does only through knowledge of the benefit of the act. But that the knowledge found there has the existence of will and volition, even though its quiddity is not a psychic quality, is not conceded. We may, to be sure, abstract will from the station of act, like the other attributes of act, as was indicated in the discussion of attributes of act and will be explained further.

In brief, there is no proof that the concept of will applies to the Necessary's knowledge of the most fitting order. What is intended by its concept is either what we find in ourselves, in which case it is a psychic quality distinct from knowledge, or some other concept capable of applying to knowledge that the act is good. We know of no such concept of will. For this reason, we said earlier that calling the Necessary's knowledge of the best order His will is more like an act of naming.

Will should not be compared with knowledge, which is said to be a psychic quality and is then stripped of quiddity and made into a general existential aspect belonging to the Necessary—exalted is He—as an attribute of essence identical with the essence. For even if we concede that some instances of knowledge, namely acquired knowledge, are psychic qualities, other instances, namely knowledge by presence, are substance or something else. It has been established that a concept applying to more than one category is an existential attribute that falls under no category, abstracted from existence insofar as it is existence. Knowledge therefore has a common meaning to which analysis leads: the presence of one thing to another.

You may object: if will has no known meaning except the psychic quality found in animals, why is it abstracted from the station of act, where there is no psychic quality? This testifies that it has a meaning broader than a psychic quality and that it is an existential attribute like knowledge.

I reply: just as an expression may be used for its real meaning, it may also, by extension, be used for the necessary concomitants of that real meaning and the effects branching from it. Attributes abstracted from the station of act subsist through the act, originate with its origination, and are intrinsically posterior to the intrinsically eternal essence. It is therefore impossible for the intrinsically necessary essence to be characterized by them, whether by identity or by inherence as an accident, as explained above—unless what is intended, by extension, is the necessary concomitants of the real meaning and the effects branching from it. Mercy, for example, as we find it in ourselves, is a psychic response and affection upon witnessing a needy, afflicted person who requires some perfection, such as well-being, health, or survival. It is followed by the merciful person relieving his need and destitution, and is therefore a praiseworthy attribute of perfection. Response and affection are impossible for Him—exalted is He—so He is not characterized by mercy in its real meaning. But from the removal of need and the attainment of sufficiency, for example, mercy is abstracted, because these are among its necessary consequences. Since it is mercy related to Him, the attribute Merciful is derived from it as one of His attributes of act. Other cases follow the same pattern.

The will ascribed to Him—exalted is He—is abstracted from the station of act: either from the very act that exists externally, so that it is will, then necessitation, then necessity, then the bestowal of existence, then existence; or from the presence of the complete cause of the act, as we say, when we observe an agent assembling the causes of an act in order to perform it, “He intends to perform such-and-such an act.”

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 360–364 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=360&type=c_fbook

The Necessary is the principle of every contingent existent: the discussion of His will’s encompassing all acts

الفصل الرابع عشر — في أنّ الواجب (تعالى) مبدأ لكلّ ممكن موجود وهو — المبحث المعنون عنه بشمول إرادته للأفعال

The preceding principles have established that what is fundamental in every thing is its existence; that the existent divides into the intrinsically Necessary and everything else; that everything other than the intrinsically Necessary, whether substance or accident—or, in other words, essence, attribute, or act—has an intrinsically contingent quiddity equally related to existence and nonexistence; and that whatever is such needs, in becoming clothed with either existence or nonexistence, a preponderating principle that determines and necessitates that alternative, namely, a necessitating cause. Every contingent existent therefore needs, both in its origination and continuance, a cause that necessitates its existence and brings it into existence, a cause that is intrinsically necessary or ends in the intrinsically Necessary. The cause of a thing’s cause is a cause of that thing. Thus every contingent existent other than the intrinsically Necessary, even voluntary acts, is an act of the intrinsically Necessary and His effect, without an intermediary, through one intermediary, or through several.

Another route is as follows. It became clear in the discussions of cause and effect that the existence of an effect in relation to its cause is a relational, nonindependent existence, subsisting through the existence of the cause. Contingent existences, whatever they are, are therefore relations to the existence of the intrinsically Necessary, not independent of Him, and encompassed by Him in the sense of not being outside Him. In existence there is thus only one independent essence, through which these relations subsist and acquire independence. Essences, together with their attributes and acts, are His acts.

He—exalted is He—is therefore the proximate agent of every act and of its agent. The independence that appears to belong to every contingent cause in relation to its effect is the independence of the Necessary, besides which there is in reality no independence.

There is no contradiction between His being a proximate agent, as this demonstration establishes, and His being a remote agent, as established by the preceding demonstration based upon the ordered succession of causes and upon the cause of a thing’s cause being a cause of that thing. The requirement of remoteness follows from considering the existences of the quiddities of causes and effects as independently existent in themselves, according to initial consideration. Proximity is what precise consideration establishes.

It is evident that there is no conflict between attributing the act to the intrinsically necessary agent and attributing it to the agent that is its subject, such as the human. Their agency is vertical, not horizontal.

A group of theologians, namely the Muʿtazilites and their followers, have maintained that voluntary acts are created by the human and that the Necessary—exalted is He—has no part in them. His role is only to enable the human to act by creating for him the causes through which he can act, such as the faculties and limbs by which he reaches the act through his choice, which makes both acting and refraining valid for him. He can therefore refrain from the act even if the Necessary wills it, and perform the act even if the Necessary dislikes it. The Necessary has no part in producing his act. Moreover, if the act were created by the Necessary, He would be its agent rather than the human. It would then make no sense to impose obligations upon the human through command and prohibition, or to promise and threaten, or for him to deserve reward and punishment for obedience and disobedience, since no act or abstention would belong to the human. Furthermore, for Him to be the agent of voluntary acts, which include various evils and morally objectionable things such as unbelief, denial, and kinds of disobedience and sin, conflicts with the freedom of the domain of majesty and greatness from what does not befit it.

The reply is that voluntary acts are contingent things. Rational necessity judges that a contingent quiddity is equally related to existence and nonexistence and cannot leave the exact middle for either alternative without a preponderating principle necessitating it, namely a necessitating cause. The agent is one of the causes. It makes no sense for an agent whose agency is complete, accompanied by the remaining parts of the complete cause, to stand in an equal relation to acting and refraining. Rather, it necessitates the act. This necessity through another ends in the intrinsically Necessary, who is therefore the first cause of the act. The first cause is a cause of the final effect, since the cause of a thing’s cause is a cause of that thing. These are established principles demonstrated in the preceding discussions. They show that the act is related to the Necessary—exalted is He—through the bestowal of existence, and to the human, for example, as a subordinated agent who is an effect in the very act of being a cause. The Necessary’s agency is vertically ordered with the human’s agency, rather than horizontally alongside it such that they would conflict and could not coexist.

As for the necessary will’s relation to the act while the human chooses it, that will relates to the human’s performing such-and-such an act through his choice. It does not relate to the act without the qualification of choice. Choice is therefore not rendered futile, nor is the effect of human will abolished. Moreover, excluding voluntary acts from the scope of necessary power, so that He wills and it does not occur, or dislikes and it does occur, restricts the absolute power identical with the essence of the Necessary. Demonstration rejects this. Demonstration also establishes that bringing

into existence and bestowing existence are peculiar to the Necessary—exalted is He—with no associate. How well Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—said in a similar context: “There is no doubt that the doctrine of one who makes all individual human beings creators of their own acts, independent in bringing them into existence, is more reprehensible than the doctrine of one who makes idols or stars intercessors with God.” End of quotation.

As for their saying, “A voluntary act’s being created by the Necessary is incompatible with directing obligation toward the human through command and prohibition, with promise and threat regarding action and abstention, and with deserving reward and punishment, since he has no act and is not an agent”: this would hold only if attributing the act to the Necessary could not coexist with attributing it to the human. You have learned, however, that the agency is vertical. The act is related to the Necessary through acting in the sense of bringing into existence, and to the choosing human in the sense of an accident’s subsistence in its subject.

As for their saying, “The human’s voluntary acts being created by the Necessary, while including kinds of evil, disobedience, and morally objectionable things, conflicts with the purity of His domain from every deficiency and blemish”: the reply is that the evils found in the world, as will become clear, are nothing but things containing much good and little evil. Their little evil enters existence as a consequence of their much good. Evil is therefore intended by a secondary intention, while the primary intention relates only to good. Moreover, it will also become clear that existence, insofar as it is existence, is nothing but good, and evils merely attach to some existences. What the Necessary bestows of an act is its existence, intrinsically good and pure in itself. The deficiency and nonexistence accompanying it are necessary consequences of its distinction in existence. Without existential distinctions, the order of existence would be corrupted. Omitting the little evil would therefore abolish the much good found in the parts of the order.

Another group of theologians, namely the Ashʿarites and their followers, have maintained that everything existent other than the intrinsically Necessary, whether essence, attribute, or act, exists through the will of the intrinsically Necessary without an intermediary. All are His acts, and He alone is the agent.

The first consequence is the removal of causality and being caused from among things. Causes would be followed by their effects merely through custom: God’s custom would be to bring about effects after causes, without any influence of the causes upon the effects or dependence of the effects upon the causes.

The second consequence is that acts counted as voluntary would be compelled acts, in which the will and choice of their agents have no influence.

The reply is that attributing the act to the Necessary through the bestowal of existence does not conflict with attributing it to other intermediaries. The attribution is vertical rather than horizontal, as explained above. The reality of the mediation of intermediaries returns to the existence of the effect being restricted by qualifications specifying its existence. The connection of existents to one another, horizontally and vertically, makes the whole one, with some of its parts restricted by others in their existence. Bestowing one of them is therefore accomplished only by bestowing the whole. The bestowal is only one, and each receives what it has the capacity to receive.

As for denying causality and being caused among things, the demonstration given in the stage on cause and effect suffices to refute it. Moreover, if there were no relation of influence and being affected among things, and what we find of this among them were false and unreal, we would have no way to establish an agent beyond them, namely the Necessary who is the agent of all.

As for asserting compulsion and denying choice in acts on the grounds that the agency of the intrinsically Necessary and His will's relation to the act called voluntary make that act necessary in realization and occurrence, so that it makes no sense for an act necessary in existence to be voluntary for the human, who can perform it or refrain, or for his will to influence it: the reply is that His agency is vertical and does not conflict with the agency of another when that too is vertically ordered. His will relates to the act precisely as voluntary. He wills that the human perform such-and-such an act through his own choice and will. The voluntary act is therefore necessary in realization precisely as voluntary.

Some have argued for compulsion in acts by saying that an act of disobedience is known to the Necessary—exalted is He—and is therefore necessary in realization and occurrence. If it did not occur, His knowledge would be ignorance, which is impossible. The act is thus necessary, and necessary occurrence cannot coexist with the act's being voluntary.

Against this, the act of disobedience is known to the Necessary with the specific character of its occurrence: that it issues from the human through his choice. It is therefore necessary in realization and occurrence precisely as voluntary. If it did not occur, His knowledge would be ignorance, which is impossible. The act is therefore necessary in realization insofar as it is voluntary.

A clarification

Their argument for compulsion in acts from the Necessary's knowledge of them and the consequent determination of their occurrence is in reality an appeal to decree in knowledge, which makes the matters it concerns inevitable. As for will, which they regard as an affirmative attribute additional to the essence, they do not regard it as a principle of the act that necessitates it. They suppose that the necessity of the act would make the agent compelled—mūjab—whereas the

Necessary is a choosing agent. Rather, will’s function is to give the act preponderance through priority without necessity. Will may therefore specify whichever of the two alternatives of the act it concerns.

These are unsound views whose falsity is clear from the preceding principles. The necessity attaching to the effect is necessity through another, abstracted from its existence bestowed by its cause, and is an effect of that cause. If this necessity then returned to influence the cause by making it compelled in its agency, what is posterior in existence, precisely as posterior, would precede what is prior in existence, precisely as prior. This is impossible. Moreover, if a choosing agent became compelled through the necessity of the act, there would be no difference whether the effect’s necessity depended upon prior knowledge and a preceding decree or upon the agent’s necessitation of the act, which is the meaning of our saying, “A thing does not exist until it is necessitated.”

It has also become clear from the foregoing that preponderance through mere priority returns to the contingent’s not needing a preponderating principle to determine one of the alternatives of existence and nonexistence. For the less favored alternative remains possible even when the preferred alternative possesses priority, and the question “Why?” has still not been cut off.

Likewise, preponderance through will, while supposing its equal relation to acting and refraining, returns to the absence of any need for a preponderating principle.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 364–370 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=364&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 15

His life—exalted is He

الفصل الخامس عشر — في حياته (تعالى)

Life, as we find it among the kinds of animals, is a thing’s being such that it apprehends and acts.

The apprehension common to all animals is sensory apprehension additional to the essence. Their action is a limited act proceeding from knowledge and apprehension of it. Knowledge and power are therefore necessary consequences of life, rather than life itself, because we allow that knowledge may at times be absent from life, and likewise power.

The life found in an animal is thus an existential principle upon which knowledge and power follow.

Since something possessing knowledge and power additional to its essence is living, and its life is an existential perfection for it, one whose knowledge and power are identical with His essence, and who possesses every perfection and the whole of perfection, is more entitled to be called living. This is the intrinsically Necessary—exalted is He. He is therefore intrinsically living. His life is His being such that He knows and has power. His knowledge of everything proceeds from His essence, and His power is His intrinsic being a principle of everything other than Himself.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 371–371 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=371&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 16

Will and speech

الفصل السادس عشر — في الإرادة والكلام

According to the prevalent view, both are counted among the attributes of essence of the Necessary—exalted is He.

As for will, it was discussed above in the investigation of power.

As for speech, it has been said:

“In our ordinary usage, speech is an expression that signifies, through conventional designation, what is inwardly intended. It is therefore a conventional existent that signifies what is in the speaker’s mind to one who knows the designation, through conventional, posited signification. For this reason, it is considered a verbal existence of the mental meaning, just as the mental meaning is counted as a thing’s mental existence and its external instance as its external existence.

“If there were a real existent signifying something through real rather than conventional signification—such as an effect signifying that which produces it, or an effect signifying through its existential perfection the perfection present in its cause in a higher and nobler manner—it would be more entitled to be called ‘speech,’ because of the fundamentality of its existence and the strength of its signification.

“If there were an existent whose essence was simple in every respect, possessing every perfection in existence in a higher and nobler manner, and disclosing through the detail of its attributes, identical with its holy essence, the comprehensiveness of its essence—as with the Necessary—then it would be speech signifying itself through itself, with comprehensiveness identical with detail.”

I say: this analyzes speech and returns the reality of its meaning to a certain sense of power. There is therefore no necessity calling for its being set apart from power. Moreover, every existential meaning, even one deeply immersed in materiality and surrounded by nonexistences and deficiencies, can be returned through analysis and the removal of deficiencies and nonexistences to one of His attributes of essence.

You may object: this also applies to hearing and sight. They are two aspects of knowledge, yet they have been set apart from power and counted as two attributes of essence.

I reply: this is because they occur in the Book and the Sunna. As for speech, nothing of it occurs in the Noble Book except as an attribute of act.

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1. **translation:** The final objection reads “set apart from power” (ufridā min al-qudra) in both the electronic transcription and the Qum 1404 witness, printed p. 308 (PDF p. 312). This reading is retained despite the contextual difficulty created by describing hearing and sight as aspects of knowledge.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 371–373 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=371&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 17

Divine providence over creation: the cosmic order possesses the greatest possible goodness and precision

الفصل السابع عشر — في العناية الإلهيّة بخلقه وأنّ النظام الكوني في غاية ما يمكن من الحسن والإتقان

A knowing agent whose knowledge contributes to the completeness of its necessitating causality may be deficient in itself and seek completion through its act. In that case, the greater its need for the perfection it seeks through its act, the greater its concern for the act and the more thoroughly it performs it so as to include every particular feature that can be considered in perfecting its workmanship and fully realizing its benefits. This differs from the case in which the perfection sought through the act is slight and unnecessary in the agent’s view, so that its benefits may be neglected. This meaning is what is called “providence.”

The Necessary—exalted is He—is intrinsically independent and possesses every perfection in existence. He is therefore not perfected by any of His acts, and every existent is His act. He has no end in His acts outside His essence. But He has essential knowledge of everything possible that is established in it, and His knowledge, identical with His essence, is the cause of everything other than Him. His act therefore occurs as He knows it, without neglect of any of its particular features that He knows; and all are known. He thus exercises providence over His creation.

The general order witnessed throughout creation, the particular order prevailing in each species, and the arrangement and order established in the individuals of species confirm this. When we reflect upon any of these, we find benefits and advantages in its creation that fill us with wonder. The more thoroughly and deeply we examine it, the more new benefits and remarkable connections appear, astounding the intellect and revealing the precision of the matter and the perfection of the workmanship.

The foregoing account applies to the higher causes and immaterial intellects, whose essences are complete and whose existences are perfect, free of potentiality and preparedness. Their acts do not issue from them for a purpose or end returning to them from those acts that they did not possess before acting, since their essences are supposed complete. Their end in their act is therefore their own essences, which are shadows of the essence of the Necessary—exalted is He. In reality, their end in their act is the Necessary—exalted is His name.

It follows from the foregoing that the order prevailing in creation is the most precise and firmest order, because it is the attenuated reality of knowledge to which weakness and slackness have no access in any respect.

To explain: as indicated earlier, the universal realms of existence are three, with no fourth rationally possible. Existence is either marked by potentiality and preparedness, so that its possible primary and secondary perfections are not gathered together at the beginning of its being; or its possible primary and secondary perfections are gathered together at the beginning of its being, so that no perfection can be conceived as subsequently coming to it after not being. The first is the "realm of matter and potentiality." The second is either free of matter but not of its effects, such as quality, quantity, and the other accidents occurring in material bodies, or free of both matter and all its effects. The former is the "imaginal realm," and the latter is the "realm of intellect."

There are therefore three universal realms, ordered according to the intensity and weakness of existence. Their order is vertical, through causality and being caused. The degree of intellectual existence is an effect of the Necessary—exalted is He—without an intermediary, and an intermediate cause of the imaginal realm below it. The imaginal degree is an effect of intellect and a cause of the degree of matter and material things. This has already been indicated and will be explained further.

The degree of intellectual existence is therefore the highest degree of contingent existence and the nearest to the Necessary—exalted is He. An intellectual species is confined to a single individual. Intellectual existence with its order is thus a shadow of the divine order in the realm of lordship, which contains every beauty and perfection.

The intellectual order is therefore the best and most precise possible order; next comes the imaginal order, a shadow of the intellectual order; then the material order, a shadow of the imaginal. The general order of the world is thus the best and most precise possible order.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 373–375 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=373&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 18

Good and evil, and the inclusion of evil in divine decree

الفصل الثامن عشر — في الخير والشرّ ودخول الشرّ في القضاء الإلهي

Good is what every thing seeks, intends, and loves, and toward which every thing naturally turns. When a choice lies among several things, what is chosen is the best of them. Good is therefore only an existential perfection upon which a thing’s existence depends, such as a cause in relation to its effect; or a primary perfection, which is the existence of the thing itself; or a secondary perfection through which the thing is perfected and a deficiency is removed from it. Evil is its opposite: the nonexistence of an essence or the absence of a perfection of an essence.

The proof that evil is the nonexistence of an essence or the absence of a perfection of an essence is as follows. If evil were something existential, it would be evil either for itself or for another. The first is impossible, because if a thing required its own nonexistence, it would never exist at all. A thing does not require its own nonexistence or the absence of any of its secondary perfections, because of the existential connection between it and them. Divine providence also requires that every thing be brought to its perfection. The second is likewise impossible. For evil, supposed to be existential, would be evil for another either by annihilating that other’s essence, by annihilating some perfection of it, or without annihilating either its essence or any of its perfections. The first and second alternatives are inadmissible, because evil would then be the nonexistence of that thing or of some perfection of it, rather than the supposed annihilating thing. This is a contradiction. The third is also inadmissible. If it annihilates nothing, neither an essence nor a perfection of an essence, it cannot be counted as evil. We necessarily know that what causes neither the nonexistence of a thing nor the absence of its perfection cannot be evil for it, since it suffers no harm from it. Evil, however it is supposed, is therefore not existential. This is what was sought.

Thorough reflection upon occurrences of evil confirms this. Careful examination of their aspects shows that the evil occurring is the nonexistence of an essence or the absence of a perfection of an essence. If, for example, a man kills another with a sword after restraining him, the effective blow undertaken by the killer is a perfection for him and is not evil; the sword’s sharpness and cutting

capacity are a perfection for it and are not evil; the receptivity and softness of the victim's neck are a perfection of his body and are not evil; and so forth. The evil is only the departure of the spirit and the cessation of life, which is privative.

The foregoing shows that an existent counted as evil because harm is suffered through it is evil incidentally, as with the killer and the sword in this example.

You may object: the apprehension involved in pain is different from the disruption of continuity produced by cutting, for example, and immediate awareness shows it to be something existential. This refutes their claim that what is intrinsically evil is privative—unless what is meant is that the source of evilness is privative even though some evil is existential.

I reply: Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—answered that pain is the apprehension of an adverse privative condition, such as disruption of continuity and the like, through knowledge by presence. In such knowledge, what is known is present to the knower through its external existence, rather than through acquired knowledge in which the known is present by a form taken from it, not through its external existence. There are therefore not two things in pain: the disruption of continuity, for example, and a form acquired from it. Rather, the presence of that adverse condition is pain itself. Although it is a kind of apprehension, it is one of the instances of nonexistence; and although it is a kind of nonexistence, it has establishment in the manner in which privations, such as blindness, deficiency, and the like, have establishment.

In sum, because the soul is the human's final form corresponding to the ultimate differentia, it encompasses all the perfections of the species and possesses all the bodily and other faculties. When disruption of continuity occurs as an affliction affecting a sense faculty, the soul apprehends its loss of the perfection of the faculty afflicted, at the soul's comprehensive degree rather than at the body's material degree.

Now, since evil is the nonexistence of an essence or the absence of a perfection of an essence, the essence affected by nonexistence must be receptive to it. Examples are material substances, which admit nonexistence through the passing away of their form, the entirety of their specific actuality. The essence whose perfection disappears through the occurrence of evil must likewise be capable of losing that perfection. That is, the nonexistence must be something that befalls it, rather than something intrinsic to its essence, like the nonexistences and deficiencies necessarily accompanying contingent quiddities. For this latter kind of nonexistence is abstracted solely from the degree of existence and its limit.

This makes clear that there is no evil in the realm of complete immateriality. Nonexistence has no access to its essences, which are established through their principle’s establishing them. Nor can nonexistences occur that oppose the perfections these essences require, which belong to them from the beginning of their existence.

The sphere and arena of evil is therefore the material world, in which opposites contend, different causes obstruct one another, and substantial and accidental motions occur, accompanied by change from one essence to another and from one perfection to another.

Evils are necessary consequences of the existence of matter receptive to different forms and diverse, conflicting perfections. Yet whatever they may be, goods prevail over them, and they are insignificant beside goods when compared with them.

For, as reported from the First Teacher, things fall into five divisions in respect of the goods and evils attributed to them: pure good, pure evil, predominance of good, predominance of evil, and equality of good and evil.

Two of the five divisions exist. The first is pure good: the Necessary—exalted is He—whose existence is necessary, who possesses every existential perfection and is the whole of perfection. Completely immaterial beings are included with Him in this division. The third is that in which good predominates. Divine providence requires its existence, because omitting much good is much evil.

As for the remaining three divisions, pure evil is pure nonexistence, sheer nullity with no access to existence. Predominance of evil and equality of good and evil are excluded by divine providence, which arranges the order of existence in the best and most precise way possible.

If you reflect upon any part of the cosmos, you will find that, were it not to occur as it has, the cosmic order, whose sides are connected to one another, would be invalidated at its root. This suffices as a predominance of evil in omitting what is predominantly good.

Since it is clear that the few evils attaching to things are necessary consequences of their many goods, intention and will relate to the goods primarily, and to the evils necessarily accompanying them consequentially and through a secondary intention.

It follows that evils enter into divine decree through a secondary intention. Or, if you wish, say “incidentally,” considering that evils are nonexistences to which intention does not attach per se.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 375–378 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=375&type=c_fbook

The ordering of His acts, which is the order of creation

الفصل التاسع عشر — في ترتيب أفعاله وهو نظام الخلقة

The preceding discussions have made clear that contingent existence, which is His act—exalted is He—has various divisions. Among them is its division into material and immaterial, and the division of the immaterial into intellectual and imaginal immateriality. There we indicated that the universal realms of existence are three: the realm of complete intellectual immateriality, the imaginal realm, and the realm of matter and material things. The intellectual realm is completely free, in both essence and act, of matter and its effects. The imaginal realm is free of matter but not of its effects, such as shapes, dimensions, positions, and the like. In this realm there are likenesses appearing in the characteristics of the bodies in the realm of matter and nature, in an order similar to their order in the material realm. The difference from the material order is that some imaginal things follow others through existential ordering, rather than through a form or state changing into another form or state by passing from potentiality to actuality through motion, as occurs in the material world. The condition of imaginal forms in their ordering after one another is like that of the form of motion and change in imagination. Knowledge is immaterial without qualification: imagined motion is knowledge of motion, not motion in knowledge, and knowledge of change, not change in knowledge.

No existent in the material realm is devoid of some attachment to matter. Motion and change, whether substantial or accidental, encompass it.

Since existence in its fundamental reality is a graded reality with different degrees of intensity and weakness, nobility and inferiority, and each degree subsists through what is above it and depends upon it in its very identity, the following conclusions ensue.

First: the three realms are ordered in existence through priority and posteriority. The intellectual realm precedes the imaginal realm, and the imaginal realm precedes the material realm in existence. Pure actuality, untainted by potentiality and unmixed with preparedness, is stronger and more intense in existence than what is pure potentiality, such as prime matter, or what is tainted by potentiality and mixed with preparedness, such as material natures. The intellectual and imaginal realms therefore precede the material realm.

The separate intellect is then less limited, more expansive in existence, and simpler in essence than the imaginal, which is accompanied by the effects of matter even though free of matter itself. It is clear that the less limited, more expansive, and simpler existence is, the earlier, prior, and higher

its degree in the graded reality of existence, and the nearer it is to the highest degree, which is the principle of all. The intellectual realm is therefore earlier and prior in existence to the imaginal realm.

Second: this ordering of the three realms is causal, because of the priority and dependence between them. The intellectual realm is a cause of the imaginal realm, and the imaginal realm is a cause bestowing the material realm.

Third: the three realms correspond and agree in order, in a manner appropriate to the existence of each. For, as established above, every cause contains the perfection of its effect in a higher and nobler manner. The imaginal realm contains an imaginal order corresponding to the order of the material realm and nobler than it. The intellectual realm contains what corresponds to the imaginal order, but existing in a simpler, nobler, and more beautiful manner. Corresponding to it is the divine order in the knowledge of lordship.

Fourth: every contingent existent, whether material or immaterial, higher or lower, is in all respects a sign of the Necessary—exalted is He—representing through the existential perfection it possesses the perfection of the Necessary.

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1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 378–380 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=378&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 20

The intellectual realm, its order, and how multiplicity arises within it

الفصل العشرون — في العالم العقليّ ونظامه وكيفيّة حصول الكثرة فيه

It was established in the discussions of cause and effect that from one only one proceeds. Since the Necessary—exalted is He—is one and simple in every respect, admitting no aspect of multiplicity, either intellectual or external, and possessing every existential perfection in a detailed possession identical with comprehensiveness, He bestows only a single, simple existence possessing every existential perfection. This follows from the affinity between cause and effect. That existence is fully actual in every respect and free of potentiality and preparedness.

It is, however, an existence that is a shadow of necessary existence, dependent upon it, subsisting through it, and not independent apart from it. It is therefore necessarily accompanied by intrinsic deficiency and contingent limitation, through which its degree in existence is determined, and by a contingent quiddity. An existent characterized in this way is an intellect, immaterial in both essence and act, posterior in existence to the Necessary without an intermediary and prior in existential degree to all other degrees of existence.

Now a quiddity has a multiplicity of individuals only through association with matter. The reason is that multiplicity is either identical with the quiddity, a part of it, external but necessarily accompanying it, or external and separable from it. Under the first three suppositions, the quiddity would have no individual. For whenever an individual of it existed, it would have to be many. Every multiplicity is composed of units, and each unit would have to be many because it is an instance of the quiddity. This multiplicity too would be composed of units, and so on, in an infinite regress that never ends in a unit. No multiplicity would therefore be realized, and the quiddity would have no individual. Individual multiplicity must therefore be something external to the quiddity and separable from it. The attachment of a separable feature requires matter. Every quiddity with many individuals is therefore material. By contraposition, every immaterial quiddity —that is, one immaterial in existence—does not multiply through individual multiplicity. In other words, every immaterial being belongs to a species confined to a single individual. This is what was sought. Individual multiplicity in immaterial intellect is possible, to be sure, when individuals of a material species, such as the human, attain completion through intrinsic progression and substantial motion from the mode of matter and possibility to that of immateriality and pure actuality. They retain the individual distinction they possessed at the beginning of their existence in the mode of matter and potentiality.

It is therefore clear that the first emanated being proceeding from the Necessary—exalted is He—is a single intellect, the noblest contingent existent, and a species confined to a single individual. Since it is nobler and prior in existence, it is a cause of what lies below it and an intermediary in the bestowal of existence. It contains more than one aspect, so that many things can proceed from it. The many aspects in it, however, do not reach a number sufficient for the production of what lies below the intellectual mode, with its immense multiplicity. The procession of intellects must therefore be ordered in descent until a number of aspects is attained corresponding to the multiplicity in the mode that follows intellect.

This multiplicity can be conceived in one of two ways: vertically or horizontally.

The first, the occurrence of multiplicity vertically, is that an intellect exists, then another intellect, and so forth. Whenever an intellect exists, an aspect or aspects are added, until an intellect is reached through which aspects of multiplicity are realized sufficient for the procession of the mode following the intellectual mode. There are thus distinct species of intellects, each confined to a single individual, ordered in descent. Each higher intellect is more intense and nobler than the one after it and is its efficient cause, complete in its agency, because the latter’s intrinsic contingency suffices for its procession. The last of these intellects is the efficient cause of the mode following

the intellectual mode. This is the view favored by the Peripatetics in their account of the ten intellects. To the last, which they call the “Agent Intellect,” they attribute the bringing into existence of the natural world.

The second, the occurrence of multiplicity horizontally, is that the vertical intellects end in horizontal intellects among which there is neither causality nor being caused. These correspond to the material species, each governing the material species corresponding to it. Through them the species in the natural world exist and its order is arranged. These intellects are called the “lords of species” and the “Platonic Forms.” This is the view favored by the Illuminationists, adopted by the Shaykh of Illumination, and chosen by Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified. Several arguments have been offered for it.

The first is that the vegetative faculties—nutritive, augmentative, and generative—are accidents inhering in a body that is their subject. They change as it changes and dissolve as it dissolves, and lack knowledge and apprehension. It is therefore impossible for them to be the principles bringing into existence the remarkable compositions of their subjects, their different activities, and the good and beautiful shapes and designs within them, together with the precise, perfected order that bewilders intellects. There must therefore be an immaterial intellectual substance exercising providence over them, governing their affairs, and guiding them to their ends in existence.

The objection is that, even if this argument were complete, it would show only that these remarkable activities and their prevailing order ultimately depend upon an intellectual substance possessing knowledge. It does not show that they depend upon a directly acting intellectual substance with no intermediary between it and the vegetative body. What they attribute to this intellectual substance could instead be attributed to the substantial form through which the species’ specific character is realized, and above it to the Agent Intellect, the last in the series of vertical intellects.

The second is that natural material species, with the order constantly prevailing in them, do not exist by chance. What occurs by chance is neither perpetual nor predominant. These species therefore have real causes. These are not what they suppose, such as temperaments and the like, since no proof indicates this. Rather, the real cause upon which each depends is an immaterial intellectual substance and universal archetype that exercises providence over it, brings it into existence, and governs its affairs. Its universality means the equality of its relation to all the material individuals that it leads from potentiality to actuality, rather than its being capable of being true of many.

The objection is that the acts and effects of each species depend upon its specific form. Without this, one substantial species would not be distinguished from another like it. The proof of the specific form is the effects peculiar to each species, which require something through which they subsist and upon which they depend as their proximate principle.

The third is that this is required by the principle of the possibility of the nobler, which is a demonstrated principle. When a contingent being exists that is inferior in existence to another contingent being, the nobler contingent being must exist before it. There is no doubt, for example, that a human actual in all human perfections is nobler in existence than the material human, who is potential in relation to most human perfections. The existence of the material human therefore proves the prior existence of his intellectual archetype. Likewise, the existence of the material individuals of every material species proves that their species' lord exists before them. This is an individual of the species that is immaterial from the beginning of its existence, actual in all the species' perfections, bringing the other individuals from potentiality to actuality and governing them.

The objection is that the operation of the principle of the possibility of the nobler is conditional upon the inferior and the nobler falling under one specific quiddity, so that the external existence of the inferior indicates the possibility of the nobler in respect of its quiddity. A concept's merely being true of a thing does not show that the thing is really an individual of that concept. Every existent cause, for example, possesses all the perfections of its effect through which that effect is what it is, yet it does not follow that the cause of every thing must have the same quiddity as its effect. Thus the perfection through which the human is human, for example, belonging to a thing and applying to it does not, merely by that thing's possessing it, reveal that it is an individual of the human quiddity. In other words, the concept of human being true of the universal human we intellect does not show that what we intellect is an individual of the human specific quiddity. Why could it not be one of the vertical intellects in the series of the human's proximate or remote causes, because it possesses the perfection of the human and of other species? The predication would then be that of a reality and its attenuated reality, rather than common predication. If the principle's operation is not conditional upon the inferior and nobler falling under one specific quiddity, the objection is even more forceful.

A clarification

A number of philosophers have given attention to the principle of the possibility of the nobler and based several questions upon it. Its import is that the nobler contingent being must precede the inferior contingent being in the degrees of existence: the contingent being nobler than it must have existed before it.

Ṣadr al-Mutaʾallihīn—may his secret be sanctified—formulated its proof as follows. When the inferior contingent being exists from the Creator—majestic is His remembrance—the nobler contingent being must have existed before it. Otherwise, if it could exist together with it, two things would have to exist from the intrinsically Necessary at one degree, from one essence and in one respect, which is impossible. If it could exist after the inferior and through an intermediary, the effect would have to be nobler than its cause and prior to it, which is impossible. If it could exist neither before the inferior, nor together with it, nor after it, despite being possible in the sense of possibility of occurrence—that is, its supposed occurrence entailing no impossibility—then, supposing it existed without proceeding from the intrinsically Necessary or from any of His effects, while retaining its possibility, its existence would necessarily call for a determining aspect nobler than what belongs to the intrinsically Necessary. The supposed contingent being would therefore, through its possibility, call for a cause bringing it into existence that was higher and nobler than the intrinsically Necessary. This is impossible, since the intrinsically Necessary surpasses the infinite infinitely in intensity. The conclusion is therefore established.

A clearer proof is possible. The nobility and inferiority in question are attributes of existence, returning to intensity and weakness according to existential degree. They therefore return to causality and being caused, which ultimately amount to a thing's being independent and existent in itself, or relational, subsisting through another and existing in another. Every degree of existence subsists through what is above it, depends upon it, and is inferior to it, while sustaining what is below it, being independent in relation to it, and being nobler than it.

If two contingent beings are supposed, nobler and inferior in existence, the nobler must exist before the inferior with existential priority. Otherwise the inferior would be independent, neither relational nor subsisting through the nobler, although it was supposed relational and subsisting through it. This is a contradiction.

The two arguments yield the following conclusions.

First: whenever one existential perfection is inferior to another, the nobler exists before the inferior and the more intense before the weaker, as with two degrees of existence differing in intensity and weakness even if their quiddities differ, such as the first and second intellects.

If the inferior is a material individual of a quiddity, however, the principle establishes only that a perfection akin to it and more intense than it exists before it. It does not establish that this more intense perfection is an individual of the quiddity of the inferior. It might be one of the many aspects of perfection in a cause possessing many aspects. The human, for example, has a material individual with an inferior perfection, and above it a human perfection immaterial in every respect

and nobler than it. It does not follow that this is a human by common predication, because it may be one aspect of the perfection present in its efficient cause. The resulting predication is therefore that of a reality and its attenuated reality.

The principle does, to be sure, apply to the higher immaterial ends belonging to some species attached to matter, such as the human. For demonstration establishes that they belong to their subjects by common predication, provided they encounter no natural impediment.

Second: the principle operates only beyond material things and the world of motions, among immaterial beings whose determining factors encounter no competing factor or impediment.

As for material things, the mere operation of a determining factor and the possibility of the quiddity do not suffice for the possibility of their occurrence, since an obstacle may prevent them.

The following objection therefore does not arise: if the principle were true, every material individual, such as a human individual, would have to attain the utmost intellectual and imaginative perfection proper to it, because this is nobler than its potential existence, whereas most individuals are deprived of their final perfection and barred from their ultimate existence.

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1. **translation:** “The principle of the possibility of the nobler” renders qāʿidat imkān al-ashraf. The chapter distinguishes the principle itself from the stronger claim that every material species must have a separate archetype of the same specific quiddity.
2. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 380–387 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=380&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 21

The imaginal realm

الفصل الحادي والعشرون — في عالم المثال

It is also called the “intermediate realm,” because it lies between the intellectual realm and the realm of matter and nature. As became clear from the foregoing, it is a degree of existence free of matter but not of matter’s effects, such as quantity, quality, position, and similar accidents. The cause bringing it into existence is the last of the vertical intellects, called the “Agent Intellect” by the Peripatetics, or some of the horizontal intellects according to the Illuminationists.

It contains the images of substantial forms that are aspects of multiplicity in the intellect bestowing this realm. Some are presented to others in different configurations, without the differences of configuration impairing the individual unity of the substance concerned. An example is that many human individuals conceive someone from the past whom they have not seen, but whose name and something of whose life they have heard. Each represents him within himself in a configuration appropriate to what he supposes him to be, according to the attributes he knows, even if this differs from the configuration that person has for someone else.

Because of this point, they have divided the imaginal into separate imagination, subsisting in its own right independently of particular imagining souls, and connected imagination, subsisting in particular imagining souls.

Moreover, among the things imagined by souls are arbitrary forms that do not befit the act of a wise agent and bear a relation to the play of the imaginative faculty.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 387–388 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=387&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 22

The material realm

الفصل الثاني والعشرون — في العالم الماديّ

This is the sensible realm, the lowest degree of existence. It is distinguished from the other two realms—the intellectual and imaginal—by its forms being attached to matter in both essence and act, or in act, and by their dependence upon preparedness. The perfections belonging to its species are potential at the beginning of existence and then gradually become actual. An obstacle may prevent them from attaining their perfection, so causes within it compete and obstruct one another.

Down to the present day, natural and mathematical investigations have discovered much about the parts of this realm, the relations between them, and the order prevailing among them. Perhaps what remains unknown is greater than what is known.

It became clear in the preceding discussions that the material realm, through the connections and continuity among its parts, is one, flowing in its essence and moving in its substance, with accidents accompanying it in this. The end at which this universal motion terminates is immateriality, as indicated in the stage on potentiality and actuality.

Since this realm is motion and moving in its substance, flow and flowing in its existence, and since its identity is renewal and change themselves rather than something upon which renewal and change supervene, its connection to an immutable cause, free of renewal and change, is valid.

The maker whose existence is immutable makes that which is intrinsically renewed and changing; it does not make a thing become renewed and changing. In this way the difficulty of the changing depending upon the immutable, and of the originated being connected to the eternal, is removed.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 388–389 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=388&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 23

The origination of the world

الفصل الثالث والعشرون — في حدوث العالم

It was established in the preceding discussions of eternity and origination that every existent contingent quiddity is preceded in existence by intrinsic nonexistence. It is therefore intrinsically originated. The nonexistence preceding its existence in its particular limit is abstracted from its cause that brings it into existence. Its existence is thus preceded by the existence of its cause and posterior to it.

Since the first principle of every contingent existence—whether material or immaterial, intellectual or otherwise—is the intrinsically Necessary—exalted is He—every contingent existent is intrinsically originated in relation to Him. The aggregate of contingent things, called the contingent world and everything other than the Creator, is nothing beyond its parts. Its ruling is therefore the ruling of its parts. The world with all its parts is intrinsically originated, its existence preceded by the existence of the intrinsically Necessary.

If we then disregard quiddities and confine our consideration to existence as the fundamental reality, we find existence divided into what is intrinsically necessary, subsisting through itself and independent in its realization and establishment, and what is contingent, existing in another, relational, and subsisting through another, namely the Necessary. Every contingent existence is therefore preceded by necessary existence and originated through this kind of origination. The ruling of the aggregate of contingent existences is the ruling of its parts, so the aggregate is originated through their origination.

The world of matter and nature has another origination peculiar to it: temporal origination. Its account is as follows. It was established in the discussions of potentiality and actuality that the material realm moves in its substance and in the accidents accompanying it. It flows in existence, is renewed in identity, proceeds intrinsically from deficiency to perfection, and passes out of potentiality. It is divisible into limits, each of which is an actuality for what precedes it and a potentiality for what follows it. If that same limit is divided, every limit produced through the division is again an actuality for what precedes it and a potentiality for what follows it.

This universal motion traces a quantitative extension such that every segment supposed within it divides into before and after. Likewise, every before and after divides into before and after, without stopping at any limit, as described for the motion tracing it. The difference between the two extensions is that the extension belonging to motion is indeterminate, whereas this extension occurring to motion is determinate, like the difference between the natural body and the mathematical body.

This extension traced by the substance of the world through its motion is universal time, through which motions are measured and relations among natural events are determined in terms of length, shortness, priority, and posteriority. Its priority is its being potentiality for the actuality adjoining it, and its posteriority is its being actuality for the potentiality adjoining it.

Every segment we take from the segments of this extended universal motion is found to be preceded by temporal nonexistence, because it is an actuality preceded by potentiality. It is therefore temporally originated. The aggregate of these segments and parts is nothing but the segments and parts themselves. Its ruling is therefore theirs, and it is temporally originated through their temporal origination. The world of matter and nature is thus temporally originated.

As for the theologians' account of the temporal origination of the world—that is, everything other than the Creator, glorified is He—it is based upon the impossibility of temporal eternity for the contingent. Its substance is that contingent existences have a beginning beyond which they do not extend, so that before them no existent is found except the Necessary. Time stretches infinitely in both directions; its earlier portion is empty of the world, while its later portion is occupied by and serves as a receptacle for the world.

The objection is that time itself is a contingent existent created by the Necessary. It must therefore be included in the world that is His act. There is then nothing beyond the Necessary and His act, and no "before" in which the world's nonexistence could be established as something contained in a receptacle. Moreover, asserting time's infinity at both beginning and end contradicts their assertion of the impossibility of what is temporally eternal. Furthermore, time is a quantity occurring to motion subsisting in a body. Its infinity necessarily accompanies the infinity of bodies and their motions, which is the eternity of the world and contradicts their claim of its origination.

Some have attempted to escape the difficulty that time would be neither necessary nor an effect of the Necessary by saying that time is something intellectually considered, so there is no objection to saying it is neither necessary nor an effect of the Necessary.

The objection is that asserting the world's temporal origination and its temporal eternity would then be equivalent, since time would have no reality.

Others have attempted to escape it by saying that time is something abstracted from necessary existence—exalted is He above that.

It was objected that this would entail the occurrence of change in the necessary essence.

The answer offered was: "We do not concede that what is abstracted must correspond to that from which it is abstracted." You are well aware that this is a commitment to sophistry.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 389–392 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=389&type=c_fbook

CHAPTER 24

The perpetuity of emanation

الفصل الرابع والعشرون — في دوام الفيض

It became clear in the preceding discussions that His power—exalted is He—is His being a principle of bringing into existence and His causality in relation to all else, and that it is identical with the transcendent essence. This necessarily entails the perpetuity of emanation, the continuity of mercy, and the uninterrupted bestowal of gifts.

This does not require the perpetuity of the natural world, because the aggregate is nothing beyond its parts, and every part is originated and preceded by nonexistence. Nor is there repetition in the existence of the world, as held by proponents of cycles and great cycles, since there is no proof for it.

It has been said: “The celestial spheres and higher bodies endure in existence as individuals, and likewise the universals of the elements and the original material species endure in existence, because their causes are separate and do not admit change.”

The reply is that there is no proof that these causes are complete and exclusive, with their influence independent of conditions and preparatory factors unknown to us. Their effects may differ as these conditions differ, so that creation need not be alike in its cycles.

Moreover, the doctrine of celestial spheres and bodies incapable of change, and other such views, were principles taken for granted from ancient astronomy and natural philosophy. These views have now been overturned.

The book was completed, praise be to God, on the sixth of the sacred month of Muḥarram in the year one thousand three hundred and ninety-five of the Prophetic Hijra. Blessings be upon Muḥammad and his family.

1. **Source:** Arabic transcription · Qum 1417 AH · p. 392–393 https://lib.rafed.net/view.php?b_id=1642&page=392&type=c_fbook

136 original passages; 136 with working English. Not a specialist-certified critical edition.